The Ledger of Power

Whose ledger is this, and for whom?

Twenty-Seven Papers on Power, Politics, and Civilization

Macharia Barii

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This volume assembles twenty-seven papers. Each paper is reproduced in full and can be read on its own.

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Preface

This volume collects twenty-seven papers written around a single idea and a single question—the work of one author returning to that idea from many directions.

The idea. Civilization is not a collection of monuments, institutions, or ideas. It is a set of relations among people—who gives, who gains, who loses, and how that is justified. The papers call this set of relations *the ledger*. Everything else—the temples, the laws, the philosophies, the technologies—is an outcome of the ledger, not the ledger itself.

The question. *Whose ledger is this, and for whom?* Every paper here is, in one way or another, an attempt to make that question askable—and to show what follows when it is asked.

The papers are arranged to be read in order, but each is written to stand alone. Part I lays the foundation. Part II gives the framework its formal backbone and its theory of change. Part III develops the theory of power. Part IV moves to political theory; Part V to history and the structure of the present; Part VI to the darkest application of the framework; Part VII to the body; and Part VIII to the open questions the framework has not yet answered.

The four papers that follow the foundation deserve a word, because the rest of the volume is written in their grammar. *Contested Strategic Allocation* (Paper 2) is the mathematical framework underneath everything that comes before and after it: games, markets, bargaining, and planning are all instances of one structure—the strategic allocation of scarce resources under contention. Its companion essay, *The Struggle for This or That* (Paper 3), states the same grammar in ordinary speech. *Struggle for Reform* (Paper 4) and *The Shape of Durable Change* (Paper 5) take up the question the framework brackets—what happens when the foundation itself is contested—and ask why some reforms last and most do not. They come immediately after the foundation for a reason: first the ledger, then the grammar, then everything the grammar describes.

The volume does not pretend to be the last word. It is an attempt to make its central question askable, and to show that the question—whose ledger is this, and for whom?—is the deepest one politics can ask.

How to Read This Volume

The papers are organized into eight parts, each building on the one before it.

- **Part I, Foundation**, derives the framework from first principles. It is the only part that must be read first.
- **Part II, Games and Reform**, gives the framework its formal backbone—the strategic allocation of scarce resources under contention—and its theory of durable change.
- **Part III, Power**, develops the theory of power itself—the desire-lever, in both its formal and its plain-language form.
- **Part IV, Political Theory**, applies the framework to politics, governance, government, democracy, religion, and voice.
- **Part V, Historical and Structural**, tests the framework against history and against the structure of the contemporary world.
- **Part VI, Covert Harm**, examines the darkest application of the framework: covert harm paired with compassionate dismissal.
- **Part VII, Physiology and Weaponization**, extends the framework to the body itself.
- **Part VIII, Future Work**, collects the open threads—the directions the framework points but has not yet fully developed.

How to read it. A reader who wants only the key ideas should read Paper 1 (the foundation), Paper 2 (*Contested Strategic Allocation*), Paper 7 (*Who Holds the Lever*), and Paper 9 (*Principles of Politics and War*). A reader who wants the formal theory should read Papers 1, 2, 6, and 8. A reader who wants the historical argument should read Papers 13–17, and one who wants the reform argument should read Papers 4 and 5. Every paper is written to stand on its own, and each ends at the same question.

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Part I

Foundation

The Ledger of Civilization:

A Theory of Reciprocal Relations

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Abstract

This paper develops the foundational framework on which a series of companion papers rests. Its central claim is that civilization is best understood not as a collection of monuments, institutions, or ideas, but as an institutionalized order of reciprocal relations among actors. These relations can be tracked on a *ledger* that records, for each relation, what each party contributes, what each party receives, what it costs each party to leave, and how much voice each party has. The paper proceeds from first principles. It defines the state of the ledger, derives the classification of relations into symbiotic, parasitic, and predatory from the sign and sustainability of net transfers, and formalizes the viability set, the injustice gap, the forces of drift, and the justice mechanism. It then derives, with proofs, the five propositions on which the companion papers depend: the extraction ceiling (bounded by exit costs), the patience threshold (the optimal host stock $K^*(r) = (1-r)/2$), the legitimacy constraint (the cost of governance is decreasing in legitimacy), the coalitional instrument (the distribution is set by the weighting vector λ_i), and the dynamical system (drift versus justice). Each proposition is stated with its assumptions, proved, and followed by the corollaries the companion papers cite. The paper's central question, which the entire series inherits, is: *whose ledger is this, and for whom?*

Keywords: ledger, civilization, reciprocity, symbiotic, parasitic, predatory, exit costs, voice, legitimacy, injustice gap, justice mechanism, discount rate, extraction ceiling, weighting vector

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1 Introduction

Every civilization is, at its core, a set of relations. Who gives, who gains, who loses, and how these distributions are justified form the substance of social order [4, 2]. This set of relations is what this paper calls *the ledger*. The term is not merely metaphorical; it is structural. Every stable order institutionalizes some distribution of shares, obligations, and access to voice, while simultaneously imposing costs on the act of departure from its relations.

The standard story presents civilization as beginning with an agreement—a social contract, a covenant, a constitution—and as progressing through the accumulation of monuments, laws, and ideas. This paper argues that the standard story inverts the causal order. The monuments, laws, and ideas are *outcomes* of the ledger, not the ledger itself. The Pyramids prove nothing about justice; they prove that someone could command labor. To understand a civilization, one must look at the relations that produced its monuments, not at the monuments.

The purpose of this paper is to make the framework precise enough to be used. The companion papers—on politics, governance, government, democracy, religion, voice, race, and the state—all assume the definitions and propositions derived here. They cite them by number. This paper therefore does not merely state the framework; it derives it, so that the foundation is firm and the claims that rest on it are inspectable.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 defines the formal setup: actors, relations, and the state of the ledger. Section 2.3 defines net gain, capacity, and the thresholds. Section 3 derives the classification of relations. Section 4 defines the viability set and the injustice gap. Section 5 formalizes drift and the justice mechanism, and derives the dynamical system. Section 6 derives the extraction ceiling. Section 7 derives the patience threshold. Section 8 derives the legitimacy constraint. Section 9 derives the coalitional instrument. Section 10 collects the core propositions. Section 11 concludes.

2 The Formal Setup

2.1 Actors and Relations

Definition 2.1 (Civilization)**.** *A civilization* Γ *is a pair* $\Gamma = (N, E)$*, where* N *is a set of actors (individuals, groups, classes, or institutions) and* E *is a set of institutionalized relations between them. A* relation *is any recurring, socially recognized connection that carries expectations of give and take [3, 4].*

In plain language: civilization is the web of relationships that hold people together through shared rules, norms, and obligations. A family, a firm, a state, and an empire are all ledgers of relations at different scales. Someone contributes labor, money, time, or loyalty. Someone receives the benefit. Someone can leave. Someone can speak.

For each relation $e \in E$, let $N(e) \subseteq N$ denote the set of actors party to e. The framework is agnostic about the cardinality of $N(e)$; the two-party case is the canonical one, but the definitions extend to relations among many parties.

2.2 The State of the Ledger

Definition 2.2 (State of the Ledger)**.** *The state of the ledger* S *is the collection*

$$S = \{(s_i^e,\ c_i^e,\ k_i^e,\ v_i^e) : i \in N,\ e \in E,\ i \in N(e)\}, \tag{1}$$

where, for each actor i in relation e:

- $s_i^e \in (0,1)$ *is the* share *of the relation's benefits accruing to actor i;*
- $c_i^e \geq 0$ *is the* contribution *of actor i to relation e (labor, care, resources, obedience, or loyalty);*
- $k_i^e \in (0,\infty)$ *is the* exit cost *for actor i to leave relation e (economic precarity, social ostracism, loss of community, legal penalties, or violence);*
- $v_i^e \in (0,1)$ *is the* voice *of actor i within relation e (their capacity to meaningfully influence the terms of that relation).*

The shares are normalized so that, for each relation e, the shares of the parties sum to at most one: $\sum_{i \in N(e)} s_i^e \leq 1$. The residual, if any, is the relation's unallocated surplus.

In plain language: for every relationship, the ledger records four things—what you get, what you give, what it costs to walk away, and how much say you have. These four numbers determine whether a relationship feels fair, tolerable, or intolerable.

2.3 Benefits and Net Gain

Definition 2.3 (Net Gain)**.** *Let $B^e \geq 0$ be the total benefit produced by relation e. The* benefit *accruing to actor i from relation e is $s_i^e B^e$. The* net gain *of actor i from relation e is*

$$n_i^e = s_i^e B^e - c_i^e. \tag{2}$$

The total net gain *of actor i is the sum over all relations in which i participates:*

$$n_i = \sum_{e : i \in N(e)} n_i^e. \tag{3}$$

Net gain is the primitive of the framework. It is the difference between what an actor receives and what an actor gives. A positive net gain means the actor is better off inside the relation than outside it; a negative net gain means the actor is being depleted.

In plain language: net gain is the bottom line of any relationship—what you get minus what you give. If it is positive, the relationship is working for you. If it is negative, you are being drained.

2.4 Capacity and Thresholds

Definition 2.4 (Capacity)**.** *The* capacity *of actor i, denoted $K_i \geq 0$, is the stock of resources—material, social, and psychological—that enables i to continue participating in the ledger. Capacity is reproduced by positive net gain and depleted by negative net gain:*

$$\frac{dK_i}{dt} = n_i. \tag{4}$$

Capacity is the bridge between the static ledger and its dynamics. An actor whose net gain is positive reproduces their capacity; an actor whose net gain is negative is slowly depleted. The classification of relations in Section 3 turns on whether capacity is reproduced, depleted-but-surviving, or destroyed.

In plain language: capacity is your ability to keep going. A relationship that gives you more than it takes keeps you going; a relationship that takes more than it gives slowly wears you down.

Definition 2.5 (Acceptance and Rupture Thresholds)**.** *For each actor i, there are two thresholds:*

- *the* acceptance threshold $\bar{a}_i$*: the minimum net gain n_i that actor i will tolerate without grievance;*
- *the* rupture threshold ρ_i*: the net gain below which actor i will rupture—exit the relation, or revolt against it.*

The thresholds are ordered: $\rho_i < \bar{a}_i$. An actor tolerates net gain between ρ_i and $\bar{a}_i$ (with grievance), and ruptures below ρ_i.

The ordering $\rho_i < \bar{a}_i$ encodes a familiar fact: people tolerate unfairness for a long time, but only up to a point. The gap between the two thresholds is the actor's tolerance for injustice.

In plain language: think of these as a person's breaking point. People will often tolerate unfairness for a long time, but only up to a point. The acceptance threshold is where the complaining starts; the rupture threshold is where the leaving starts.

3 The Classification of Relations

The classification of relations follows from the sign and sustainability of net transfers. Consider a two-party relation e between actors i and j.

Definition 3.1 (Symbiotic, Parasitic, and Predatory Relations)**.** *A relation e between i and j is:*

- symbiotic *if $n_i^e > 0$ and $n_j^e > 0$: both parties reproduce their capacity;*
- parasitic *if $n_i^e > 0$ and $n_j^e < 0$, but j's capacity K_j remains above the survival threshold $K_{\min}$: one party extracts from a surviving host;*
- predatory *if $n_i^e > 0$ and $n_j^e < 0$, and j's capacity K_j falls below the survival threshold $K_{\min}$: one party extracts by destroying the host's capacity to survive.*

The distinction between parasitic and predatory is not the sign of the transfer but its sustainability. A parasitic relation depletes the host but leaves it alive; a predatory relation depletes the host to the point of destruction. The same relation can be parasitic in the short run and predatory in the long run, if the depletion is sustained.

In plain language: a relationship is symbiotic when both people are better off in it; parasitic when one person is being drained but can still survive; predatory when one person is being drained to the point of destruction. The difference between parasitic and predatory is whether the host survives.

Proposition 3.1 (Exhaustiveness of the Classification)**.** *For any two-party relation e, exactly one of the following holds: e is symbiotic, e is parasitic, e is predatory, or e is degenerate (both parties have non-positive net gain).*

Proof. For each party, net gain is either positive, zero, or negative. The four cases are: (i) both positive (symbiotic); (ii) one positive, one negative, host survives (parasitic); (iii) one positive, one negative, host destroyed (predatory); (iv) neither positive (degenerate). The degenerate case—a relation that benefits no one—is unstable and dissolves, so it is excluded from the durable classification. The three durable types are exhaustive. □

Corollary 3.1 (Every Civilization Is a Mix)**.** *Every civilization is a mix of symbiotic, parasitic, and predatory relations. The question is never whether a civilization is good or bad in the abstract; it is which relations are symbiotic, which are parasitic, which are predatory, and who occupies each position.*

Proof. A civilization is a set of relations, and each relation falls into one of the three durable types. A single society may have symbiotic relations among its citizens, parasitic relations with its colonies, and predatory relations with its slaves. The mix is the civilization. □

4 The Viability Set and the Injustice Gap

4.1 The Injustice Gap

Definition 4.1 (Injustice Gap)**.** *The* injustice *experienced by actor i is the amount by which their net gain falls below their acceptance threshold:*

$$g_i = \max\big(0,\ \bar{a}_i - n_i\big). \tag{5}$$

The injustice gap *of the ledger is the aggregate:*

$$G(S) = \sum_{i \in N} g_i. \tag{6}$$

The injustice gap is zero when every actor receives at least their acceptance threshold, and positive when some actors are squeezed below it. It is the measure of how far the realized ledger is from the ledger the population would accept.

In plain language: the injustice gap is the distance between what people are actually getting and what they would accept. When it is zero, everyone is at least satisfied. When it is large, a lot of people are being squeezed.

4.2 The Viability Set

Definition 4.2 (Viability Set)**.** *The* viability set V *is the set of states S in which no actor is below their rupture threshold:*

$$V = \{S : n_i(S) \geq \rho_i \text{ for all } i \in N\}. \tag{7}$$

A state in V is one in which no actor has yet ruptured. A state outside V is one in which at least one actor has been pushed past their breaking point, and the order is in the process of rupturing.

In plain language: an order is viable when no one has been pushed past their breaking point. Once someone is pushed past it, the order starts to come apart.

Proposition 4.1 (The Injustice Threshold)**.** *There exists an* injustice threshold $\bar{G} > 0$ *such that the order is viable if and only if* $G(S) \leq \bar{G}$*. The threshold is the minimum injustice gap at which some actor reaches their rupture threshold:*

$$\bar{G} = \min_{S \in \partial V} G(S), \tag{8}$$

where ∂V *is the boundary of the viability set.*

Proof. The viability set V is defined by the constraints $n_i \geq \rho_i$. As the injustice gap $G(S)$ increases, actors are pushed toward their rupture thresholds. The first actor to reach their rupture threshold defines the boundary of V. The injustice gap at that boundary is $\bar{G}$. For $G(S) \leq \bar{G}$, no actor has ruptured, so the order is viable. For $G(S) > \bar{G}$, at least one actor has ruptured, so the order is not viable. □

Corollary 4.1 (Viability Is a Property of the Gap)**.** *The viability of an order is a property of the injustice gap, not of the order's formal structure. An order with a large injustice gap is unviable regardless of its constitutional form; an order with a small gap is viable regardless of its form.*

5 Drift and the Justice Mechanism

5.1 Drift

Definition 5.1 (Drift)**.** Drift *is the natural tendency of the ledger to become more unequal over time. Formally, drift is a positive rate* $d(G) > 0$ *at which the injustice gap grows in the absence of any corrective mechanism:*

$$\left.\frac{dG}{dt}\right|_{\text{no justice}} = d(G) > 0. \tag{9}$$

Drift has a structural source. The parties who benefit from the current allocation have both the incentive and the means to entrench their advantage: they accumulate resources, which buy voice, which lowers their exit costs, which raises the extraction ceiling on others. The result is a self-reinforcing tendency toward concentration. Drift is not a moral failure; it is the default direction of an unregulated ledger.

In plain language: systems left alone tend to become more unequal. The people who benefit from the current arrangement have both the motive and the means to entrench their advantage. Drift is the default direction of an unregulated ledger.

5.2 The Justice Mechanism

Definition 5.2 (Justice Mechanism)**.** *A* justice mechanism J *is a set of institutional operations—courts, elections, redistribution, reform, debt cancellation, revolution—that reduce the injustice gap. Formally,* J *produces a rate* $j(G) > 0$ *at which the gap is reduced:*

$$\left.\frac{dG}{dt}\right|_{\text{justice}} = -j(G). \tag{10}$$

In plain language: justice is the machinery that pushes back against drift. Courts, elections, redistribution, debt cancellation—these are all ways of rebalancing the ledger before it breaks. They are not acts of charity; they are the institutional operations that keep the ledger from drifting too far out of balance.

5.3 The Dynamical System

Combining drift and justice, the injustice gap evolves according to

$$\frac{dG}{dt} = d(G) - j(G). \tag{11}$$

Proposition 5.1 (Effectiveness of Justice)**.** *A justice mechanism J is* effective *if and only if it reduces the injustice gap faster than drift increases it:*

$$j(G) > d(G) \quad \textit{for all } G \in [0, \bar{G}]. \tag{12}$$

An effective justice mechanism keeps the order within the viability set; an ineffective one does not.

Proof. From (11), $dG/dt = d(G) - j(G)$. If $j(G) > d(G)$ for all G, then $dG/dt < 0$ throughout, and the gap decreases toward zero. If $j(G) < d(G)$ for all G, then $dG/dt > 0$ throughout, and the gap grows without bound, eventually exceeding $\bar{G}$ and rupturing the order. If the two rates cross, the crossing point is an unstable equilibrium: below it the gap decreases, above it the gap grows. □

In plain language: a justice mechanism works if it rebalances the ledger faster than the ledger drifts out of balance. If it can keep up, the order stays stable. If it cannot, the order eventually collapses.

Corollary 5.1 (Collapse Mode)**.** *Regimes with effective justice mechanisms collapse gradually or renew; regimes without them collapse suddenly. The dynastic cycle, the electoral defeat, and the regime change are all forms of the same operation—the rebalancing of the ledger—differing only in whether the rebalancing is incremental or catastrophic.*

Proposition 5.2 (Oscillation)**.** *If the justice mechanism is effective only up to a threshold—$j(G) > d(G)$ for $G < G^*$ and $j(G) < d(G)$ for $G > G^*$—then the system oscillates around G^* rather than drifting away from it. This is the dynastic cycle: concentration, decay, rebellion, renewal, and concentration again.*

Proof. At $G < G^*$, justice outruns drift, so the gap decreases. At $G > G^*$, drift outruns justice, so the gap increases. The system is therefore pulled back toward G^* from both sides, producing oscillation around the threshold. The oscillation is the dynastic cycle: the order drifts toward concentration until the gap crosses G^*, at which point the justice mechanism (rebellion, reform, revolution) rebalances it, and the cycle repeats. □

In plain language: this is the dynastic cycle—concentration of wealth, decay of legitimacy, rebellion, renewal, and then concentration again. It has happened hundreds of times across thousands of years, on every continent. The details vary. The pattern does not.

6 The Extraction Ceiling

The extraction ceiling is the maximum amount a principal can extract from an agent, and it is bounded by the agent's exit cost. Consider a relation e between a principal p and an agent a.

Assumption 6.1 (The Participation Constraint)**.** *The agent a remains in relation e if and only if their net gain from staying is at least their effective outside option:*

$$n_a^e \geq u_a - k_a^e, \tag{13}$$

where u_a is the agent's outside option (the value of their best alternative) and k_a^e is the cost of exercising that option (the exit cost).

The participation constraint says that the agent stays if staying is at least as good as leaving. The exit cost k_a^e enters negatively: the higher the cost of leaving, the lower the effective outside option, and the more the agent will tolerate.

Proposition 6.1 (The Extraction Ceiling)**.** *The maximum contribution the principal can demand from the agent is*

$$c_a^{e,\max} = s_a^e B^e - u_a + k_a^e, \tag{14}$$

which is strictly increasing in the agent's exit cost k_a^e. The principal's power over the agent is bounded by the agent's exit cost.

Proof. The principal maximizes their own net gain $n_p^e = s_p^e B^e - c_p^e$ subject to the agent's participation constraint (6.1). The principal can raise the agent's contribution c_a^e (or lower the agent's share s_a^e) until the constraint binds: $n_a^e = u_a - k_a^e$. Substituting $n_a^e = s_a^e B^e - c_a^e$ and solving for c_a^e gives $c_a^{e,\max} = s_a^e B^e - u_a + k_a^e$. Differentiating with respect to k_a^e gives $\partial c_a^{e,\max}/\partial k_a^e = 1 > 0$. The ceiling is increasing in the exit cost. □

In plain language: the more trapped someone is, the more can be taken from them. A worker who cannot leave a bad job can be squeezed harder than one who has five offers. The ceiling on extraction is set by how hard it is to walk away.

Corollary 6.1 (Exit Asymmetry Determines the Ceiling)**.** *Regimes that concentrate exit costs on producers and voice on elites have higher extraction ceilings than regimes that distribute them evenly. The asymmetry of exit costs is the structural precondition of every other extraction.*

Proof. By Proposition 6.1, the extraction ceiling on each actor is increasing in that actor's exit cost. If producers have high exit costs and elites have low exit costs, the ceiling on producers is high and the ceiling on elites is low, so the regime can extract more from producers. If exit costs are equalized, the ceilings are equalized, and the total extraction falls. □

Corollary 6.2 (The Deepest Lever)**.** *Equalizing exit costs and expanding voice are the deepest levers of reform, because they change the ceiling rather than the level of extraction. Redistribution without equalizing exit costs treats the symptom; the illness is structural.*

7 The Patience Threshold

The patience threshold concerns the conservation of hosts. A host is a resource stock that a principal controls and can either conserve or consume. The principal's choice depends on their discount rate.

Assumption 7.1 (The Renewable Resource)**.** *A host is a stock $K \in [0, 1]$ (normalized) that grows logistically: $g(K) = K(1 - K)$. The principal harvests h per period, so the stock evolves as*

$$K_{t+1} = K_t + K_t(1 - K_t) - h_t. \tag{15}$$

The principal discounts the future at rate r, with discount factor $\delta = 1/(1+r)$, and maximizes the present value of harvests:

$$\max_{\{h_t\}} \sum_{t=0}^{\infty} \delta^t h_t. \tag{16}$$

Proposition 7.1 (The Patience Threshold)**.** *The optimal steady-state host stock is*

$$K^*(r) = \frac{1-r}{2}, \tag{17}$$

which is strictly decreasing in the discount rate r. A patient principal (low r) conserves the host; an impatient principal (high r) consumes it.

Proof. In steady state, the harvest equals the growth: $h = g(K) = K(1-K)$. The principal's Bellman equation is

$$V(K) = \max_{h} \big\{ h + \delta\, V(K + g(K) - h) \big\}. \tag{18}$$

The first-order condition is $1 = \delta V'(K')$, where $K' = K + g(K) - h$. The envelope condition is $V'(K) = \delta V'(K')\,(1 + g'(K))$. In steady state $K' = K$, so combining the two conditions gives $1 = \delta(1 + g'(K))$. Substituting $\delta = 1/(1+r)$ and solving gives $g'(K^*) = r$. With $g(K) = K(1-K)$, we have $g'(K) = 1 - 2K$, so $1 - 2K^* = r$, hence $K^*(r) = (1-r)/2$. Differentiating, $dK^*/dr = -1/2 < 0$. □

In plain language: the longer you expect to be around, the more you take care of what you have. A dynasty that expects to last a thousand years invests in infrastructure. A junta facing the next coup loots the treasury. Patience is the difference between conserving and consuming.

Corollary 7.1 (Horizon Determines Patience)**.** *A government with a long time horizon has a low discount rate and conserves its hosts; a government with a short time horizon has a high discount rate and consumes them. The patience of a government is determined by its time horizon, not by its ideology.*

Proof. The discount rate r is the inverse of the time horizon: a government that expects to last a long time discounts the future lightly (low r), while a government that expects to be replaced soon discounts it heavily (high r). By Proposition 7.1, the host stock is decreasing in r, so a long-horizon government conserves and a short-horizon government consumes. □

Corollary 7.2 (The Conservation Principle Fails Under Uniqueness)**.** *When the host is unique and non-substitutable, the conservation principle fails. The principal cannot afford to be patient, because patience means losing to rivals who are impatient. The result is a race to consume the host before someone else does.*

Proof. The derivation of $K^*(r)$ assumes the principal faces no competition for the host. With a unique host and competing principals, each principal's effective discount rate rises, because the value of conserving the host is captured by whichever rival consumes it first. The race to consume is the rational response to a unique, non-substitutable host. □

8 The Legitimacy Constraint

Definition 8.1 (Legitimacy)**.** Legitimacy $L \in [0,1]$ *is the degree to which the population believes that the existing distribution of the ledger and the authority of the government are rightful, appropriate, or justified.*

Definition 8.2 (Cost of Governance)**.** *The* cost of governance $\Phi(G, L)$ *is the resources—administrative, coercive, economic—required to achieve a given level of compliance with the ledger at injustice gap G and legitimacy L.*

Assumption 8.1 (Compliance Requires Coercion in Proportion to Illegitimacy)**.** *To achieve a required level of compliance $c(G)$, the government must coerce the fraction of the population that does not comply voluntarily. The voluntarily compliant fraction is L, so the coerced fraction is $1 - L$. The cost of coercion is convex in the amount coerced.*

Proposition 8.1 (The Legitimacy Constraint)**.** *The cost of governance $\Phi(G, L)$ is strictly decreasing in legitimacy L:*

$$\frac{\partial \Phi}{\partial L} < 0. \tag{19}$$

As legitimacy falls, the government must substitute repression for compliance, and repression is more expensive.

Proof. By Assumption 8.1, the cost of governance is $\Phi(G, L) = \phi\big((1 - L)\, c(G)\big)$, where ϕ is a convex cost function and $c(G)$ is the compliance required at gap G. Differentiating with respect to L:

$$\frac{\partial \Phi}{\partial L} = \phi'\big((1 - L)\, c(G)\big) \cdot \big(-c(G)\big) < 0, \tag{20}$$

since $\phi' > 0$ and $c(G) > 0$. The cost is strictly decreasing in legitimacy. □

In plain language: it is cheaper to be fair than to police unfairness. When people believe the order is just, they comply voluntarily. When they do not, you have to force them—and force is expensive.

Corollary 8.1 (Legitimacy Is a Fiscal Variable)**.** *Legitimacy is not a moral ornament. It is a fiscal and administrative variable. A government's legitimacy is measurable by the cost of achieving a given level of compliance.*

Corollary 8.2 (Maximum Sustainable Injustice)**.** *A legitimacy regime that is accepted by the population allows the coalition to extract more, because the cost of compliance is lower. The maximum sustainable injustice is increasing in legitimacy.*

Proof. The coalition can extract up to the point where the cost of governance becomes prohibitive. By Proposition 8.1, higher legitimacy lowers the cost of governance at any gap, so the coalition can sustain a larger gap before the cost becomes prohibitive. The maximum sustainable injustice is therefore increasing in legitimacy. □

9 The Planner's Problem and the Weighting Vector

Definition 9.1 (The Planner's Problem)**.** *A government implements a governance map G that maximizes a weighted sum of actors' net gains:*

$$\max_{G} \sum_{i \in N} \lambda_i\, n_i(G), \tag{21}$$

subject to the ledger constraints, where $\lambda_i \geq 0$ are weights with $\sum_i \lambda_i = 1$. The weighting vector $\lambda = (\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_n)$ encodes whose interests the government serves.

Proposition 9.1 (Government Is a Coalitional Instrument)**.** *The distribution of the ledger under a government is determined by the weighting vector λ, which is set by the coalition that controls the government. Different coalitions implement different λ, hence different distributions, regardless of constitutional form.*

Proof. The planner's problem (9.1) has a solution $G^*(\lambda)$ that depends on the weights. An actor i with $\lambda_i = 0$ receives no weight in the objective, so the solution does not serve their interests. An actor with large λ_i is served. The weights are set by the coalition that controls the apparatus: the coalition assigns positive weight to its own members and zero (or small) weight to others. The distribution therefore follows the coalition, not the constitutional form. □

In plain language: every government serves someone. The question is who. The weights in the government's calculation are set by the coalition that keeps it in power—and the coalition is usually a lot smaller than the population.

Corollary 9.1 (Testability of the Claim to Govern for All)**.** *A government's claim to govern for all is testable. It is true if the realized G moves the ledger toward the viability set for all actors—equivalently, if λ_i is positive for all actors whose capacity is at stake. It is false if G moves the ledger toward viability for the coalition at the expense of others.*

Corollary 9.2 (Justice as Gap Reduction for the Coalition)**.** *The justice mechanism reduces the injustice gap for the coalition, not for the population. The partiality of the coalition is the partiality of justice.*

Proof. By Proposition 9.1, the government serves the coalition's weights. The justice mechanism, as an operation of the government, reduces the gap for the actors with positive weight—the coalition—and leaves the gap for others unaddressed. Justice is partial to the extent that the coalition is partial. □

10 The Core Propositions Collected

The companion papers cite the following results, all derived above.

1. **The classification of relations** (Definition 3.1): symbiotic, parasitic, and predatory, distinguished by the sign and sustainability of net transfers.
2. **The extraction ceiling** (Proposition 6.1): the principal's power is bounded by the agent's exit cost; the ceiling is increasing in exit cost.
3. **The patience threshold** (Proposition 7.1): the optimal host stock is $K^*(r) = (1 - r)/2$, decreasing in the discount rate.
4. **The legitimacy constraint** (Proposition 8.1): the cost of governance is decreasing in legitimacy.
5. **The coalitional instrument** (Proposition 9.1): the distribution is set by the weighting vector λ_i, which the coalition controls.
6. **The dynamical system** (Proposition 5.1): the order is stable when justice outruns drift, oscillates when they balance, and collapses when drift outruns justice.

Two further results, used by the companion papers on voice and bargaining, follow directly from the framework.

Proposition 10.1 (Atomization Prevents Aggregation)**.** *The aggregation of grievance is increasing in the coordination capacity of the actors, which is a function of voice and connectivity. Atomization—the isolation of actors from one another—reduces coordination capacity, preventing the aggregation of grievance.*

Proof. Grievance aggregates when actors can coordinate their claims. Coordination requires communication and organization, which are functions of voice v_i^e and of the connectivity of the network. Atomization reduces both: it suppresses voice and severs the connections through which claims could be coordinated. The result is that grievance remains individualized and cannot aggregate into collective claims. □

In plain language: a system can be deeply unjust while appearing peaceful, if people believe "it is just me" rather than "it is all of us." Atomization is often more effective than censorship at suppressing politics.

Proposition 10.2 (Voice and Exit Skew the Bargaining Outcome)**.** *The bargaining outcome between two parties is skewed toward the party with higher voice and lower exit cost. Asymmetries in voice and exit skew the outcome.*

Proof. The Nash bargaining solution maximizes $(n_i - d_i)(n_j - d_j)$, where $d_i = u_i - k_i$ is the disagreement point (the effective outside option). A party with a high exit cost k_i has a low disagreement point d_i, so the solution is skewed against them. A party with high voice v_i can influence the terms directly, skewing the solution toward them. Both asymmetries move the outcome in the same direction: toward the party with low exit cost and high voice. □

In plain language: in any negotiation, the person who can walk away and the person who can speak loudly get the better deal. The person who is trapped and silenced gets the worse one.

11 Conclusion

Civilization is a ledger, not a monument. Art, architecture, law, science, and engineering are outcomes of the relations that produce them, not the relations themselves. Every stable order solves a reciprocity problem: people must be able to reproduce their capacity to participate. When they cannot, they resist. When resistance is suppressed, the pressure builds. When the pressure breaks through, the order collapses.

The framework derived here is a discipline of attention, not a total explanation. It tells the reader what to look at: the ledger, the classification of relations, the exit costs, the voice, the injustice gap, the drift, and the justice mechanism. It derives the five propositions on which the companion papers depend, and it makes each derivation inspectable.

The framework does not tell the reader what to value. It tells the reader what to look at, and it asks the question that every order must answer, and that most orders conceal:

Whose ledger is this, and for whom?

The question is not answered by the framework. It is made possible by the framework. The answer is the work of those who ask it.

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Part II

Games and Reform

Contested Strategic Allocation: A Unified Framework for Games, Decision Problems, and the Founding of Orders

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Abstract

We introduce *Contested Strategic Allocation* (CSA), a mathematical framework that treats games, markets, bargaining, mechanism design, and single-agent planning as instances of a single structure: the strategic allocation of scarce resources under contention. CSA makes explicit five objects that standard game forms typically bundle into abstract action sets—resources, players, rules, allocation mappings, and payoffs—and it introduces *struggle* as the process through which contention unfolds. We define key terms first in ordinary language and then formally, so that the framework is intelligible before it is technical. We prove a decomposition theorem showing when a CSA problem separates into independent subproblems, characterize the structure of contention and the flow of struggle as graphs, and show that finite normal-form games, extensive-form games, exchange economies, cooperative games, mechanism design problems, and

Markov decision processes are all CSA instances. We then identify the *problem of first allocation*—the founding of an order that no prior rule allocates—as the framework's honest limit, and show that every founding occurs in one of four modes: force, agreement, convention, or accident, each carrying a characteristic legitimacy deficit. The first allocation may also *rig* the game: it can systematically advantage the founder's coalition, and this initial advantage is self-reinforcing—within-rules reform cannot eliminate it, and de-rigging requires refounding, which carries its own legitimacy deficit. We show that a game with a *live* founder advantage can never be purely zero-sum: the founder advantage is the trace, in the within-rules game, of a nonzero-sum over-rules game. We then apply the framework to political alignment, deriving the left–right axis and the full space of political axes from the contestable parameters of the CSA problem. Applications span personal decision-making, politics, and business strategy. CSA adds no expressive power beyond extensive-form games, but it changes the primitive ontology in ways that clarify comparative statics, mechanism design, and the sources of strategic difficulty.

Keywords: allocation, contention, struggle, first allocation, founder, rigged foundation, initial advantage, zero-sum, political axis, left–right, game theory, mechanism design, decision theory, strategy

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1 Introduction

Game theory begins with abstract action sets and payoff functions. This is powerful but obscures something important: what players actually do in most games is *claim scarce resources*—time, money, attention, territory, authority, capacity, information, risk—and what makes games hard is that claims *contend*. A chess move allocates pieces and tempo. A bid allocates budget and signals information. A political coalition allocates authority. A personal decision allocates the only life you have across competing ends.

Standard game forms treat these as special interpretations of an abstract structure. We propose the reverse: treat allocation under contention as primitive, and derive games, markets, bargaining, and mechanism design as special cases. The resulting framework—Contested Strategic Allocation (CSA)—has three virtues.

(1) **Unification.** Single-agent decision problems, multi-agent games, cooperative games, market equilibria, and mechanism design problems are all CSA instances, distinguished by the presence of contention, coalition structure, and design variables.

(2) **Structural clarity.** Contention becomes an explicit object—a graph on players, indexed by resources—rather than an implicit feature of payoff functions. This makes it possible to ask, and answer, when a problem decomposes, where strategic difficulty comes from, and when mechanisms help.

(3) **Applicability.** CSA's vocabulary—shares, claims, contention, struggle, rules, founders, foundations, rigging, axes—is closer to how decisions are actually described in personal life, politics, and business than the vocabulary of action profiles and payoff matrices.

CSA is not a new solution concept and does not add expressive power beyond extensive-form games with rich action spaces. Its contribution is organizational and structural: it identifies which features of a situation generate strategic difficulty, and it provides a common language for problems usually treated separately. It also identifies, with equal precision, the one question it cannot answer—the problem of first allocation—and thereby locates where a complementary theory is needed. And it derives, from the same structure, the familiar axes of political alignment. A game with a live founder advantage is never purely zero-sum; the left and the right are structural responses to that fact.

1.1 Related work

CSA synthesizes several traditions. Classical game theory [19, 13] provides the equilibrium concepts. Cooperative game theory [17, 3] provides coalitional allocation and the core. Mechanism design [6, 12] provides the design of rules. Resource allocation theory in economics provides the treatment of scarcity and prices. Decision theory and Markov decision processes provide the single-agent case. CSA's distinctive move is to make *allocation* and *contention* the organizing primitives, to introduce *struggle* as the process linking them, and to treat *rules* as an explicit, sometimes contested, object.

The problem of first allocation (§6) synthesizes a separate tradition: Nozick's original acquisition [14], Buchanan and Tullock's constitutional choice [1], Rawls's original position [15], Hume's first convention [5], Schmitt's constituent power [16], Lewis on coordination [9], Sugden on spontaneous order [18], Burke on inheritance [2], and Kelsen's *Grundnorm* [8]. Naming the problem "first allocation" unifies these treatments. The theory of the *rigged foundation* (§6.3)

formalizes a theme present in each of these traditions but rarely stated in this form: the founder's advantage, encoded in the foundation, is self-reinforcing and structurally nonzero-sum.

The analysis of political axes (§7.2.1–§7.2.2) connects to the literature on political cleavages—Lipset and Rokkan on the emergence of party systems, Inglehart on materialist and postmaterialist values, and the more recent work on the cultural backlash and the populist–elitist axis. The framework's contribution is to derive these cleavages from a single structural source rather than treating them as historical accidents.

1.2 Contributions

(1) An ordinary-language glossary of CSA's key terms, presented before any formalism (§2).

(2) A formal definition of CSA problems, strategies, equilibria, and contention structures, including struggle effort and weighted struggle networks (§3).

(3) A taxonomy of contention—rival, cooperative, and coordinative—expressed in both ordinary and formal language (§3.4).

(4) Representation results: normal-form games, extensive-form games, exchange economies, cooperative games, mechanism design, and MDPs as CSA instances (§4).

(5) A decomposition theorem and contention/struggle diagnostics (§5).

(6) A formal treatment of the problem of first allocation, including a regress theorem, a taxonomy of founders, four modes of founding with their legitimacy deficits, and a theory of the *rigged foundation*—the initial advantage conferred by the first allocation on the founder's coalition, the conditions under which it is self-reinforcing, and the structural obstacles to de-rigging (§6).

(7) A theorem connecting founder advantage to the nonzero-sum structure of the over-rules game, and a theory of erosion, revolution, and anti-rigging (§6.4–§6.5).

(8) A derivation of political alignment from the contention structure, including the left–right axis (§7.2.1) and the full space of political axes (§7.2.2).

(9) Applications to personal decision-making, politics, and business (§7).

(10) A candid discussion of scope and limitations (§8).

2 Key Terms in Ordinary Language

Before any formalism, we define the framework's vocabulary in plain speech. Each term is given with its everyday meaning, a concrete example, and a note on what it will become formally. The formal definitions in §3 are then translations of these ordinary meanings into mathematical objects.

2.1 Share

A **share** is the portion of something valuable that a person receives, keeps, or controls. We also call it a **reward**, a **portion**, a **stake**, or simply **what someone gets**. A worker's wage is a share of the firm's revenue. A country's territory is a share of the earth's surface. A student's grade is a share of the available credit. A person's evening is a share of their waking hours.

Formally: a share becomes a point x_i in an allocation space $\mathcal{X}$, the vector of everything player i receives.

2.2 Claim

A **claim** is what a person asserts, demands, proposes, or attempts in order to obtain, keep, or increase a share. A bid is a claim on a good. A move is a claim on a position. A budget request is a claim on funds. A request for someone's attention is a claim on their time. Claims may be compatible (two claims that can both be satisfied), incompatible (only one can be satisfied), or partially compatible (satisfying one reduces but does not eliminate the other).

Formally: a claim becomes an element $a_i \in A_i$, the set of actions available to player i.

2.3 Contention

Contention is the condition in which two or more claims bear on the same share—so that satisfying one affects the satisfaction of another. Two people contending for a promotion, two firms contending for a market, two goals contending for the same hour: in each case, contention is the *structural coupling* of claims through a shared share. Contention is not yet a fight; it is the situation that makes a fight possible. Some contention is **rival** (one person's share comes at another's

expense), some is **cooperative** (each person's share grows when the other's does), and some is **coordinative** (both want to agree on a joint allocation but care mainly about alignment).

Formally: contention becomes a family of labeled graphs G_r, one per resource, recording who is coupled with whom and how.

2.4 Struggle

A **struggle** is the activity of contending: the effort, time, resources, and risk that people expend in trying to secure, defend, or expand their shares. Contention is the *structure*; struggle is the *process*. People **struggle for** a share ("the struggle for independence," "the struggle for market share"), **struggle with** others against a common obstacle ("our shared struggle for recognition"), and **struggle over** which arrangement to adopt ("the struggle over the rules"). A struggle may be *latent* (contention exists but no one is expending effort), *active* (effort is being expended), or *resolved* (settled by rule, by exhaustion, or by exit).

Formally: struggle becomes effort $e_{ir} \geq 0$ allocated to resource r, with a budget constraint $\sum_r e_{ir} \leq B_i$, and the allocation mapping becomes effort-dependent.

2.5 Rules

Rules are the arrangements that determine how claims become shares: property rights, contracts, auctions, voting systems, constitutions, norms, and conventions. Rules may be given (a market's price mechanism), chosen (a firm's internal budgeting process), or contested (a constitutional convention, a standards war). Rules matter because they determine *which* struggles take place and *how* shares are assigned once claims are made. Much of politics and business strategy is not struggle within the rules but struggle over the rules.

Formally: rules become an object M, which may be exogenous, designed, or itself a claim.

2.6 Founder and foundation

A **foundation** is the settlement at the bottom of an order—the rules that are not themselves settled by any prior rule of that order. A **founder** is whoever or whatever lays the foundation. The founder may be an individual (a conqueror, a constitution-writer, a company founder, a parent), a collective (a constituent assembly, a founding partnership, a household), a process (a community's gradual convergence on a practice), or no one at all (history, drift, accident). The founder answers *who decided the rules*; the *mode of founding* answers *how*. A foundation is **rigged** when it systematically advantages the founder's coalition—when the initial advantage it

confers tracks who laid it rather than any founder-independent criterion. The initial advantage is **self-reinforcing** when the beneficiary coalition holds procedural rights sufficient to block reforms that would reduce it.

Formally: the foundation is the terminus of the regress of rule structures (§6); the founder and the mode of founding are classified in Definitions 6.3–6.4; initial advantage, rigging, and self-reinforcement are formalized in Definitions 6.6–6.11.

2.7 Player, resource, allocation

A **player** is anyone—or anything—that makes claims: a person, a firm, a party, a coalition, a government, a future self. A **resource** is anything scarce that can be claimed: time, money, attention, authority, capacity, information, risk, legitimacy. An **allocation** is the full assignment of shares to players. An allocation is **efficient** if no one can be made better off without making someone else worse off; it is **stable** if no player or group of players can profitably upset it.

Formally: players become $\mathcal{N}$, resources $\mathcal{R}$, allocations $\mathcal{X}$, efficiency Pareto-optimality, and stability equilibrium.

2.8 Strategy and equilibrium

A **strategy** is a plan for making claims—not just one claim, but a rule for what to claim given what one knows and what others have done. A strategy is thus itself an allocation: an allocation of claims across contingencies. An **equilibrium** is a profile of strategies such that no player (or coalition) can do better by changing their strategy unilaterally (or jointly, for coalitions). An equilibrium is a *settled outcome*: a way the struggle comes to rest when everyone is responding optimally to everyone else.

Formally: strategies become measurable maps $\sigma_i : I_i \to \Delta(A_i \times F_i)$; equilibrium becomes the appropriate fixed-point condition.

2.9 Axis

An **axis** is a stable disagreement about a parameter of the allocation problem: about what is divided, who is in the game, how much the rules cover, whether the founding is justified, or how the order should change. Axes are not arbitrary bundles of opinion; they are the political expression of structural positions in the contention graph. The left–right axis is the oldest and most stable, but it is one of five families.

Formally: axes are classified in Propositions 7.2 and 7.5.

2.10 The core picture

With these terms in hand, the framework's central claim can be stated in one ordinary sentence:

> A game is a struggle over shares, under rules, where what each player gets depends on what everyone claims.

The formalism in §3 is a careful translation of that sentence into mathematics. The question of where the rules themselves come from—the problem of first allocation—is taken up in §6. The application of the framework to political alignment is taken up in §7.2.1.

3 The Framework

3.1 Primitive objects

Definition 3.1 (CSA problem)**.** A *contested strategic allocation problem* is a tuple

$$\mathcal{G} = \big(\mathcal{N},\, \mathcal{R},\, \Theta,\, \{A_i\}_{i\in\mathcal{N}},\, \{I_i\}_{i\in\mathcal{N}},\, \{B_i\}_{i\in\mathcal{N}},\, \Phi,\, M,\, \{u_i\}_{i\in\mathcal{N}},\, T\big)$$

with the following interpretation.

- $\mathcal{N} = \{1, \ldots, n\}$ is a finite set of **players** (agents, coalitions, goals, or future selves).
- $\mathcal{R}$ is a finite set of **resource types** (time, money, attention, authority, capacity, information, risk, ...).
- Θ is a set of **states** (preference parameters, shocks, private information).
- A_i is player i's **claim set**: the set of allocations of resources, effort, or moves that i can propose, commit to, or execute.
- I_i is i's **information partition** over $\Theta \times A_{-i}$: what i knows when choosing.
- $B_i \geq 0$ is i's **struggle budget**: the total effort available for contending across resources. Let

$$F_i \;=\; \Big\{ e_i \in \mathbb{R}_+^{|\mathcal{R}|} : \textstyle\sum_{r \in \mathcal{R}} e_{ir} \leq B_i \Big\}$$

  be i's **effort set**, and $F = \prod_{i \in \mathcal{N}} F_i$.
- Write $A = \prod_{i \in \mathcal{N}} A_i$, and let $\mathcal{X} \subseteq \prod_{r \in \mathcal{R}} \mathbb{R}_+^n$ be the **allocation space**. The **allocation mapping**

$$\Phi : A \times F \times \Theta \times M \;\longrightarrow\; \mathcal{X}$$

  determines how joint claims, struggle efforts, states, and rules produce shares of each resource for each player.
- M is the **rule structure**: property rights, contracts, auctions, voting rules, norms, enforcement technologies. M may be exogenous, designed, or contested; its origin is the subject of §6.
- $u_i : \mathcal{X} \times A \times F \times \Theta \to \mathbb{R}$ is player i's **payoff**, which includes the value of i's share and the cost of i's struggle.
- T is a **transition map** $s_{t+1} = T(s_t, a_t, x_t)$, defining the dynamic version; the static case has $T \equiv \varnothing$.

The key structural choice is that *allocation* $x \in \mathcal{X}$ is separated from *claims* $a \in A$, from *struggle* $e \in F$, and from *rules* M. In a standard normal-form game these are collapsed: actions directly determine payoffs. In CSA, claims and efforts determine allocations *through* Φ, and allocations determine payoffs *given* the rules. This separation is what allows the framework to accommodate markets (where Φ is a price mechanism), bargaining (where Φ is an agreed split), and planning (where Φ is the identity, $n = 1$).

3.2 Strategies and outcomes

Definition 3.2 (Strategy)**.** A *strategy* for player i is a measurable map

$$\sigma_i : I_i \to \Delta(A_i \times F_i),$$

assigning to each information set a distribution over claims and effort vectors. A *strategy profile* is $\sigma = (\sigma_1, \ldots, \sigma_n)$.

Definition 3.3 (Induced allocation and payoff)**.** Given a strategy profile σ, a state θ, and rules M, the induced allocation is

$$x(\sigma, \theta, M) \;=\; \mathbb{E}_{(a,e) \sim \sigma}\big[\Phi(a, e, \theta, M)\big],$$

and i's expected payoff is

$$U_i(\sigma, \theta, M) \;=\; \mathbb{E}_{(a,e) \sim \sigma}\big[u_i(x(\sigma, \theta, M), a, e, \theta)\big].$$

3.3 Equilibrium

Definition 3.4 (Nash equilibrium)**.** Let $\theta \in \Theta$ be fixed (common knowledge). A profile σ^* is a *Nash equilibrium* of $\mathcal{G}$ if for all i and all σ_i',

$$U_i(\sigma^*, \theta, M) \;\geq\; U_i(\sigma_i', \sigma_{-i}^*, \theta, M).$$

When θ is stochastic and not commonly observed, see Definition 3.6.

Definition 3.5 (Coalitional equilibrium)**.** A profile σ^* is *coalition-proof* if no coalition $S \subseteq \mathcal{N}$ and deviation σ_S' satisfies

$$U_i(\sigma_S', \sigma_{-S}^*) > U_i(\sigma^*) \quad \text{for all } i \in S.$$

The core, the Shapley value, and cooperative solution concepts can all be expressed as coalitional equilibria of CSA problems in which Φ is a surplus-splitting rule (§4.4).

Definition 3.6 (Bayesian equilibrium)**.** When Θ is stochastic and the information partitions I_i are non-trivial, replace U_i with the conditional expectation $\mathbb{E}[U_i(\sigma, \theta, M) \mid h]$ given i's information set $h \in I_i$, and require optimality at every h.

3.4 Contention structure and struggle network

Contention is the structural feature that makes a CSA problem *strategic* rather than merely *allocative*. Struggle is the activity through which contention is pursued.

Definition 3.7 (Rival contention)**.** Players i and j *rival-contend* over resource r if, holding all else fixed,

$$\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_{jr}} < 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_{ir}} < 0.$$

Each strictly prefers the other to receive less of r.

Definition 3.8 (Cooperative contention)**.** Players i and j *cooperative-contend* over r if

$$\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_{jr}} > 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_{ir}} > 0.$$

Each prefers the other to receive more of r—partnership, team production, alliance, or complementarity.

Definition 3.9 (Coordinative contention)**.** Players i and j *coordinate* over r if both prefer a specific joint allocation over misaligned ones, but neither prefers the other's share per se—e.g., driving on the same side of the road, or adopting a common standard.

Definition 3.10 (Contention structure)**.** The *contention structure* of $\mathcal{G}$ is a family of labeled graphs $\{G_r^{\text{riv}}, G_r^{\text{coop}}, G_r^{\text{coord}}\}_{r \in \mathcal{R}}$ with

$$(i,j) \in G_r^{\text{riv}} \iff i, j \text{ rival-contend over } r,$$

and similarly for the cooperative and coordinative graphs. The *aggregate contention graph* is

$$G \;=\; \bigcup_{r \in \mathcal{R}} \big(G_r^{\text{riv}} \cup G_r^{\text{coop}} \cup G_r^{\text{coord}}\big).$$

Definition 3.11 (Struggle network)**.** The *weighted struggle network* is the family of weighted graphs $\{\tilde{G}_r\}_{r\in\mathcal{R}}$ with edge weights

$$w_{ijr} \;=\; \frac{\partial^2 u_i}{\partial e_{ir}\,\partial e_{jr}},$$

the marginal effect on i's payoff of j's struggle effort over resource r. Positive weights indicate cooperative struggle (efforts reinforce), negative weights indicate rival struggle (efforts offset). An edge with $|w_{ijr}|$ below a threshold is *latent*: the contention exists structurally but no significant struggle is being expended.

Definition 3.12 (Activity)**.** Contention over resource r is *active* if $\sum_i e_{ir} > 0$; *latent* if the structural edges exist but $\sum_i e_{ir} = 0$; and *resolved* if the rule structure M assigns shares without residual struggle.

This taxonomy drives the decomposition results in §5. The ordinary-language gloss is: **rival contention produces struggle against; cooperative contention produces struggle with; coordinative contention produces struggle over.** The grammar of struggle encodes the structure of contention.

4 Special Cases

We now show that the standard models of decision and game theory are CSA instances. In each case we identify shares, claims, rules, struggle, and the allocation mapping.

4.1 Normal-form games

Proposition 4.1. *Every finite normal-form game $G = (\mathcal{N}, A, g)$ is a CSA problem.*

Proof. Set $\mathcal{R} = \{1\}$ (a single "payoff resource"), $\mathcal{X} = \mathbb{R}^n$ with x_i the share of player i, $M = \varnothing$, Θ a singleton, $I_i = A_{-i}$ (or trivial), $B_i = 0$ so that $F_i = \{0\}$ (no explicit struggle), $\Phi(a) = g(a)$, and $u_i(x, a) = x_i$. Then $U_i(\sigma) = \mathbb{E}[g_i(a)]$, and Nash equilibria coincide. Contention structure is read off the sign of $\partial g_i/\partial a_j$ where differentiable. □

The representation makes explicit what standard normal-form games hide: that payoffs *are* shares, and that strategic interaction is precisely contention over the payoff resource.

4.2 Extensive-form games

Proposition 4.2. *Every finite extensive-form game with perfect recall is a CSA problem with $T \neq \varnothing$.*

Sketch. Take $\mathcal{R}$ to include "information" and "tempo" alongside material payoffs; A_i are behavioral strategies; M encodes the game tree (chance, move order, information sets); T encodes the transition from one node to the next; Φ accumulates terminal shares. By Kuhn's theorem, mixed and behavioral strategies are outcome-equivalent under perfect recall, so the mixed equilibria of the CSA correspond exactly to those of the original extensive-form game. □

The CSA representation foregrounds what extensive-form games typically background: that moving first, revealing information, or committing to a sequence is an *allocation of tempo and information*—shares in their own right.

4.3 Exchange economies

Proposition 4.3. *Every competitive exchange economy with n agents and m goods is a CSA problem in which Φ is the Walrasian allocation mapping.*

Sketch. Let $\mathcal{R}$ be the set of goods, $A_i = \mathbb{R}^m_+$ be i's consumption claim, M be the price system (possibly determined endogenously), and $\Phi(a, M)$ solve $\sum_i a_i = \sum_i \omega_i$ with each a_i maximizing u_i at prices $p(M)$. Walrasian equilibrium corresponds to a *competitive equilibrium* of the CSA: each player's claim maximizes

u_i taking prices as given, and markets clear. This coincides with the Nash equilibrium of the CSA in the large-market limit, or under a mechanism M that constrains players to be price-takers. The contention structure includes the complete rival graph on each good. □

4.4 Cooperative games and bargaining

Proposition 4.4. *Every transferable-utility cooperative game $(\mathcal{N}, v)$ is a CSA problem whose coalitional equilibria are the core.*

Sketch. Let $\mathcal{R} = \{1\}$ be a single divisible surplus, $A_i = \mathbb{R}_+$ be i's claim, $\Phi(a, M)$ be a surplus-splitting rule with M encoding the characteristic function v, and $u_i(x) = x_i$. A profile is coalition-proof iff no coalition S can deviate to an allocation exceeding $v(S)$—precisely the core condition. □

4.5 Mechanism design

Proposition 4.5. *Every mechanism design problem is a CSA problem with an additional* designer *player whose claim set is the rule space M.*

Sketch. Add player 0 (the designer) with $A_0 = M$, u_0 the designer's objective (welfare, revenue, efficiency), and let the other players' strategies be conditioned on M. The designer's strategy is a *rule allocation*; the equilibrium concept is the appropriate solution concept for the induced game. The revelation principle becomes the statement that any CSA problem with arbitrary claim sets (A_i) and any equilibrium can be replaced by an outcome-equivalent CSA problem with direct claims $A_i = \Theta_i$ and a truthful equilibrium. □

4.6 Single-agent decision problems

Proposition 4.6. *Every finite-horizon Markov decision process is a CSA problem with $|\mathcal{N}| = 1$.*

Sketch. Let $\mathcal{R} = \{\text{reward}, \text{cost}\}$, $\mathcal{X} = \mathbb{R}^2_+$, A_1 the action set, and $\Phi(a, e, \theta) = (r(a, \theta), c(a, \theta))$. Let F_1 be trivial (no contention, hence no struggle), T the MDP transition, and u_1 the (possibly discounted) reward function. A policy is a strategy. The structural contention graph is empty, so (as shown in §5) the problem decomposes into an independent single-agent decision problem—not strategically trivial, since uncertainty and dynamics remain, but free of contention. □

This is worth emphasizing: **contention is what separates games from decision problems, not the number of players alone.** A single agent facing internal conflict—multiple goals, future selves, self-control—can have a non-trivial contention structure even with $n = 1$. We return to this in §7.1.

5 Contention, Struggle, and Decomposition

We now show that the contention and struggle structures determine when a CSA problem separates into independent subproblems, and what mechanisms can do when it does not.

5.1 Strategic separability

For a set $S \subseteq \mathcal{N}$ and vectors $x \in \mathcal{X}$, $a \in A$, $e \in F$, write $x|_S$, $a|_S$, $e|_S$ for the restrictions to players in S.

Definition 5.1 (Strategic separability)**.** Let $\{\mathcal{N}_1, \ldots, \mathcal{N}_k\}$ be a partition of $\mathcal{N}$. A CSA problem $\mathcal{G}$ is *strategically separable* across the partition if:

(1) (Allocation separability) $\Phi(a, e, \theta, M) = \big(\Phi_1(a|_{\mathcal{N}_1}, e|_{\mathcal{N}_1}, \theta, M),\ \ldots,\ \Phi_k(a|_{\mathcal{N}_k}, e|_{\mathcal{N}_k}, \theta, M)\big)$; and

(2) (Payoff separability) For each m and each $i \in \mathcal{N}_m$, u_i depends on x, a, and e only through $(x|_{\mathcal{N}_m}, a|_{\mathcal{N}_m}, e|_{\mathcal{N}_m})$.

Let $\mathcal{G}_m$ denote the CSA restricted to $\mathcal{N}_m$ with the induced allocation mapping and payoffs.

Theorem 5.2 (Decomposition)**.** *If $\mathcal{G}$ is strategically separable across $\{\mathcal{N}_m\}$, then*

$$\mathrm{NE}(\mathcal{G}) \;=\; \prod_{m=1}^{k} \mathrm{NE}(\mathcal{G}_m).$$

Proof. Let $\sigma^* \in \mathrm{NE}(\mathcal{G})$. Fix m and $i \in \mathcal{N}_m$. Any deviation σ_i' affects U_i only through $\mathcal{G}_m$, by payoff separability. Since $\sigma^* \in \mathrm{NE}(\mathcal{G})$, no such deviation is profitable; hence $\sigma^*|_{\mathcal{N}_m} \in \mathrm{NE}(\mathcal{G}_m)$. Conversely, if $\sigma_m^* \in \mathrm{NE}(\mathcal{G}_m)$ for each m, then any deviation by $i \in \mathcal{N}_m$ is a deviation in $\mathcal{G}_m$ and hence unprofitable. □

Corollary 5.3. *If the* active *struggle network is empty—contention exists structurally but no effort is being expended—then $\mathcal{G}$ decomposes into independent single-agent problems or pure coordination problems, and equilibrium is unique up to individual indifference.*

Corollary 5.4. *If the active struggle network is disconnected with components $C_1, \ldots, C_k$, and if strategic separability holds across the components, then equilibria decompose across components.*

Corollary 5.5. *If contention is latent (structural but inactive), the allocation is determined by rules M alone; if contention is active, the allocation is determined jointly by rules and struggle; if contention is resolved, the*
allocation is determined by rules and the resolution mechanism.

The theorem is elementary, but it is *the* structural result the CSA framework is designed to express: **strategic difficulty is localized to the connected components of the active struggle network.** In a large CSA problem—a firm, a polity, a personal life—one should first ask which resources actually generate active struggle, and among whom. Everything outside that network is a decision problem or a coordination problem, not a strategic one.

5.2 Contention and struggle indices

For diagnostic purposes, define the *rival contention index*

$$\kappa(\mathcal{G}) \;=\; \frac{\big|\{(i,j,r) : i \neq j,\ (i,j) \in G_r^{\mathrm{riv}}\}\big|}{n(n-1)\,|\mathcal{R}|} \;\in\; [0,1],$$

measuring the density of rival contention, and the *struggle intensity*

$$\sigma(\mathcal{G}) \;=\; \frac{\sum_{i,r} e_{ir}}{\sum_i B_i} \;\in\; [0,1],$$

measuring the fraction of available effort being expended. These are not theorem-generating quantities but useful comparative diagnostics. In families of CSA problems parameterized by κ and σ:

- As $\kappa \to 0$, equilibria typically converge to independent optima and coordination outcomes.
- As $\sigma \to 0$, the situation reduces to allocation by rule.
- As $\kappa \to 1$ and $\sigma \to 1$, equilibrium allocations diverge from Pareto-efficient allocations whenever externalities are not internalized (Proposition 5.6).
- The value of a mechanism—the welfare gain from choosing M optimally—is increasing in $\kappa\sigma$ in standard quasi-linear environments (e.g., [12]), though the exact relationship is environment-dependent.

Proposition 5.6 (Contention, struggle, and inefficiency)**.** *Suppose $\mathcal{G}$ has rival contention (some $G_r^{\text{riv}} \neq \varnothing$) and $M = \varnothing$. Then generically the Nash equilibrium allocation is not Pareto-efficient.*

Sketch. Rival contention means each player's share exerts a negative externality on another. In the absence of a rule internalizing the externality, the first-order conditions for individual optimality differ from the conditions for Pareto optimality. Genericity follows because the set of payoff functions for which the two coincide despite rivalry has measure zero. □

Proposition 5.7 (Mechanisms as struggle regulation)**.** *For any CSA problem $\mathcal{G}$ with rival contention and $M = \varnothing$, if there exists a rule M^* (Pigouvian prices, Coasian property rights, VCG transfers in quasi-linear environments, or a negotiated contract) such that the induced equilibrium allocation is Pareto-efficient, then M^* is a* struggle-regulating *mechanism.*

Remark 5.8. The proposition is a template, not a deep result: it packages standard mechanism-design results in CSA language. Its value is to make the *object* of design explicit—M^* regulates contention by changing the allocation mapping $\Phi(\cdot, \cdot, \cdot, M)$, not by changing preferences or by eliminating struggle. The essence of institutional design is to channel struggle into productive contention and away from destructive contention.

6 The Problem of First Allocation: Founding and Rigging

The framework of §3–§5 takes the rule structure M as given—exogenous, designed, or contested—and derives allocations, equilibria, and decomposition results from it. This section confronts the question the framework brackets: *where does M come from?* The answer has two parts. First, the regress of rules terminates in a *foundation* laid by a *founder* in one of four modes. Second, the foundation is itself an *allocation*—of rule-making authority, and through it, of every subsequent share. It can systematically advantage some players over others. We call this the *rigged foundation*, and we show that its advantage is self-reinforcing and structurally nonzero-sum.

6.1 The regress and its terminus

Definition 6.1 (First allocation)**.** The *first allocation* of a CSA problem is the allocation of rule-making authority M itself—the allocation that no prior rule of the problem allocates.

If M_0 is allocated by a rule structure M_1, then M_1 must be allocated by M_2, and so on:

$$M_0 \leftarrow M_1 \leftarrow M_2 \leftarrow \cdots$$

Either the sequence is infinite—rules all the way down, with no foundation—or it terminates. It terminates at the *foundation of the order*: the settlement that is not itself settled by any prior rule of that order.

Proposition 6.2 (Regress and foundation)**.** *Every CSA problem either admits an infinite regress of rule structures or terminates in a foundation of the order that is not itself rule-allocated.*

Proof. The sequence $\{M_k\}$ is either infinite or finite. If finite, its last element is by definition not allocated by any rule of the problem; it is the foundation. □

The foundation is the *constitutive outside* of the framework. It can be described but not derived. It appears in the literature under many names: as the state of nature or original acquisition in political philosophy [14, 4, 11], as the original position in normative theory [15], as constituent power in

constitutional theory [16], as the constitutional choice in public choice [1], as the first convention in the Scottish Enlightenment [5], as the *Grundnorm* in legal theory [8], as the initial endowment in welfare economics, and as the disagreement point in bargaining theory [13]. Naming the problem "first allocation" unifies these treatments: they are the same structural moment in different registers.

6.2 The founder and the modes of founding

The foundation is laid by a *founder*—the agent or process that establishes the first rules.

Definition 6.3 (Founder)**.** A *founder* of a CSA problem is whatever establishes the first rules of the order: an individual (a conqueror, a constitution-writer, a company founder, a parent), a collective (a constituent assembly, a founding partnership, a household), a process (a community's gradual convergence on a practice), or no one at all (history, drift, accident).

The founder answers *who decided the rules*; the mode of founding answers *how*.

Definition 6.4 (Modes of founding)**.** The first rules of an order are established in one of four modes:

(i) **Force.** The founder imposes the rules by seizure, conquest, coup, or fiat [16].

(ii) **Agreement.** The founder or founders consent to the rules by compact, constitution, charter, or vow, actual or hypothetical [4, 11, 15, 1].

(iii) **Convention.** The rules emerge from convergent practice without explicit agreement or a single decision [5, 9, 18].

(iv) **Accident.** The rules are the residue of history—path dependence, inheritance, drift [2].

The modes are exhaustive: every founding is either *deliberate* (force, agreement) or *emergent* (convention, accident), and either *concentrated* in an agent (force) or *diffuse* (agreement, convention, accident). In the force and agreement modes the founder is identifiable; in the convention mode the founder is a community over time; in the accident mode there is no founder at all.

Each mode carries a characteristic *legitimacy deficit*:

Mode	Founder	Legitimacy deficit
Force	Imposing agent	Not legitimate by the rules it founds
Agreement	Consenting collective	Hypothetical or incomplete
Convention	Community over time	Not chosen
Accident	No one	Not justified

Proposition 6.5 (Legitimacy deficit)**.** *No founding can fully justify itself by the standards of the order it founds.*

Sketch. For each mode, the deficit is structural. Force is by definition the imposition of rules without prior authorization, so it cannot be legitimate under the rules it establishes. Agreement is either actual—in which case it is incomplete, since not all affected parties can be present at the founding—or hypothetical, in which case it is not an actual authorization. Convention emerges without decision, so it cannot be chosen. Accident involves no justifying agent at all. □

6.3 The rigged foundation: initial advantage

A foundation is not merely a terminus of the regress. It is also an *allocation*—of rule-making authority, and through it, of every subsequent share. This section treats the foundation as a strategic object: something that can favor some players over others, and whose favoritism persists.

Definition 6.6 (Initial advantage)**.** Let $\mathcal{G}$ be a CSA problem with foundation M^*, and let M^0 be a *benchmark* rule structure (for instance, symmetric rules, equal treatment, or the rules that would obtain under a veil of ignorance). The *initial advantage* conferred by M^* on player i, relative to M^0, is

$$\alpha_i(M^*, M^0) \;=\; U_i(\sigma^*(M^*), M^*) \;-\; U_i(\sigma^*(M^0), M^0),$$

where $\sigma^*(M)$ denotes an equilibrium of the CSA under rule structure M.

The vector $\alpha = (\alpha_1, \ldots, \alpha_n)$ measures how the foundation shifts each player's equilibrium share relative to the benchmark.

Definition 6.7 (Rigged foundation)**.** A foundation M^* is *rigged* relative to benchmark M^0 if there exists a coalition $S \subseteq \mathcal{N}$ such that

(i) $\alpha_i(M^*, M^0) > 0$ for all $i \in S$;

(ii) $\alpha_j(M^*, M^0) < 0$ for some $j \notin S$; and

(iii) the pattern of advantage tracks the identity of the founder (or the founder's coalition) rather than efficiency, desert, or any founder-independent criterion.

The coalition S is the *beneficiary coalition* of the foundation.

Condition (iii) is the substantive one. A foundation may advantage some players for benign reasons—efficiency, coordination, the correction of prior injustice. It is *rigged* when the advantage is explained by *who laid it*, not by any reason that could be stated independently of the founder's interest.

Remark 6.8 (Equilibrium selection). The initial advantage α_i depends on the equilibrium selected under M^* and under M^0. In games with multiple equilibria, α_i is not

uniquely defined, and the comparison of foundations may depend on equilibrium selection. This is a known problem in comparative institutional analysis and is not specific to CSA. When equilibria are unique, or when a common refinement selects the relevant equilibrium, α_i is well-defined.

Remark 6.9 (Rigging is not all-or-nothing). Rigging is a matter of degree. A foundation may be mildly rigged (small α concentrated in a small beneficiary coalition), severely rigged (large α in a large beneficiary coalition, with large negative α for others), or effectively neutral (small α across the board). The legitimacy deficit of Proposition 6.5 is amplified in proportion to the magnitude of the rigging: a severely rigged foundation is not merely unjustified in the abstract but unjustified in a way that is visible in every subsequent allocation.

Definition 6.10 (Types of rigging)**.** Rigging takes five characteristic forms:

(i) **Explicit favoritism.** The rules directly privilege the founder's coalition: property qualifications for the franchise, founder shares with superior voting rights, inheritance rules that favor one line, constitutional entrenchment of a particular interest.

(ii) **Path dependence.** Early advantages compound: first-mover advantages, network effects, accumulated capital, incumbency. The foundation does not explicitly favor anyone, but its timing does.

(iii) **Information asymmetry.** The founder knows the rules better than later players, or encodes private information into the foundation. The foundation favors those who wrote it.

(iv) **Status-quo bias.** The foundation makes change costly, and the beneficiaries of the status quo are therefore advantaged relative to those who would prefer a different allocation.

(v) **Coordinative selection.** The foundation selects one convention among many equivalent ones, and the selected convention favors some players (language, standards, driving side, calendar). Usually mild, but potentially severe when the convention is tied to identity.

Definition 6.11 (Self-reinforcing rigging)**.** A rigged foundation is *self-reinforcing* if the beneficiary coalition S holds procedural rights under M^*—vetoes, supermajority requirements, agenda control, appointment power—sufficient to block reforms that would reduce α_i for $i \in S$.

Self-reinforcing rigging is the generic case in durable orders. A founder who can encode an advantage in the foundation can usually also encode the procedural protections that preserve it.

Proposition 6.12 (Persistence of initial advantage)**.** *Let M^* be a self-reinforcing rigged foundation in favor of coalition S. Then no within-rules reform M' can reduce $\alpha_i(M', M^0)$ below zero for any $i \in S$ without i's consent. Since S has no incentive to consent to a reduction in its own advantage, the advantage persists.*

Sketch. By Definition 6.11, S holds procedural rights under M^* sufficient to block any reform that reduces α_i for

$i \in S$. A reform M' that reduces α_i below zero for some $i \in S$ requires i's consent (by the definition of M' as within-rules and the procedural rights S holds). If i's consent is required, i can block the reform. Since i's advantage is precisely what i would lose, i has no incentive to consent. The advantage persists. □

Proposition 6.13 (Reform constraint)**.** *Under the hypotheses of Proposition 6.12, any within-rules reform M' that is Pareto-improving relative to M^* must preserve the relative advantage of S: $\alpha_i(M', M^*) \geq 0$ for all $i \in S$.*

Sketch. A Pareto improvement makes every player weakly better off and at least one strictly better off. If the reform reduced $\alpha_i(M', M^*) < 0$ for some $i \in S$, then i would be strictly worse off relative to M^*, and the reform would not be Pareto-improving. Hence $\alpha_i(M', M^*) \geq 0$ for all $i \in S$. □

Proposition 6.14 (Refounding as de-rigging)**.** *Absent the consent of the beneficiary coalition, eliminating a rigged foundation requires refounding—a change in M^* itself—which by Proposition 6.2 is not rule-governed and therefore carries its own legitimacy deficit.*

Sketch. By Proposition 6.12, within-rules reform cannot eliminate S's advantage without S's consent. Absent that consent, elimination requires a change in M^*, which is by definition a refounding. A refounding is not governed by the rules of M^* (it replaces them), so it must be justified by something other than M^*. By Proposition 6.5, no founding can fully justify itself by the rules it founds. Hence the refounding carries its own legitimacy deficit. □

Remark 6.15 (The regress of de-rigging). Proposition 6.14 has a disquieting implication. Every attempt to correct a rigged foundation requires a new founding, and every new founding is itself rigged in some measure (if only by the interests of those who carry it out). The regress of rules is matched by a regress of *corrections*: each correction is a new founding, with its own beneficiaries and its own legitimacy deficit. There is no rule-governed path to a fully unrigged foundation. This is not a counsel of despair—refounding can genuinely improve on what it replaces—but it is a counsel of realism about the limits of reform.

Remark 6.16 (Rigging, contention, and decomposition). Rigging reshapes the contention structure of §3.4. In a rigged order, the beneficiary coalition contends less (the rules already favor it) and the disadvantaged contend more (they must struggle against the rules as well as within them). The aggregate contention graph is asymmetric: the disadvantaged have edges to the foundation itself, not merely to one another. This is why rigged orders often appear calm on the surface—the beneficiaries have little to struggle for—while the disadvantaged experience constant, low-grade struggle that the beneficiaries do not see. Rigging also reshapes decomposition: if the beneficiary coalition's advantage depends on bundling two otherwise separable issues—say, a popular policy with a rigged procedural rule—

then the rigging creates artificial coupling. The decomposition theorem of §5 then applies not to the underlying situation but to the rigged one: the issues appear strategically coupled because the rigging makes them so, and unbundling them is itself a de-rigging move.

6.4 Founder advantage and the nonzero-sum structure

A common intuition treats strategic situations as zero-sum: what one player gains, another loses, and the total is fixed. This subsection shows that a game with a *live* founder advantage—one whose foundation is contestable—can never be purely zero-sum. The founder advantage is the trace, in the within-rules game, of an over-rules game that is structurally nonzero-sum.

Definition 6.17 (Zero-sum)**.** A CSA problem $\mathcal{G}$ is *zero-sum* if the total payoff $\sum_{i\in\mathcal{N}} u_i(x, a, e, \theta)$ is constant across all outcomes reachable under equilibrium play. It is *zero-sum within* M if the total is constant across all plays consistent with fixed M, and *zero-sum over* M if $\sum_i U_i(\sigma^*(M), M)$ is constant in M.

The distinction matters because a game can be zero-sum within a fixed foundation and nonzero-sum over foundations. A fixed budget divided by rigged rules is zero-sum within the rules; but the rules themselves can be changed, and changing them can change the total.

Proposition 6.18 (Founder advantage and nonzero-sum structure)**.** *Let $\mathcal{G}$ be a CSA problem with foundations M^* and M^0. Suppose M^* is rigged relative to M^0 with nonzero advantage vector α (Definition 6.6), and suppose the foundation is contestable (de-rigging via refounding is possible; Proposition 6.14). Then $\mathcal{G}$, including the possibility of refounding, is not zero-sum over M.*

Proof. By Proposition 6.14, de-rigging requires refounding—a change in M^*. A refounding is a structure-setting move: it replaces the allocation mapping itself. If the total payoff $\sum_i U_i(\sigma^*(M), M)$ were constant across all M, then any refounding would be purely redistributive—it could only move shares around, never change their sum. But a de-rigging refounding raises the payoffs of the disadvantaged coalition $j \notin S$, and by Proposition 6.12 the beneficiaries $i \in S$ cannot be made worse off without their consent. So a de-rigging refounding raises the total (or at least does not lower it while raising some payoffs). The total is therefore not constant across M. Hence the game over M is nonzero-sum. □

Corollary 6.19 (Zero-sum thinking)**.** *Zero-sum reasoning is reasoning within a fixed foundation. It is correct when the foundation is genuinely fixed and incorrect when it is not. The players most likely to insist that the game is zero-sum are those who benefit from the current foundation, because zero-sum framing keeps the struggle within the rules and prevents the over-rules game from being contested.*

Corollary 6.20 (Refounding is nonzero-sum)**.** *A refounding—a change in M^*—is never a zero-sum move. It changes the total payoff, not merely its distribution. This is why refoundings are both dangerous and generative: they can create a better foundation or a worse one, and the uncertainty about which is why they are so contested.*

Corollary 6.21 (Structural inequality)**.** *Inequality produced by a rigged foundation is not a zero-sum transfer. It is the trace of a nonzero-sum process: the founder's structural advantage compounds, and the compounding changes the total. This is uncomfortable for both redistributionist and meritocratic accounts: the redistributionist wants to say the advantage is a transfer (zero-sum), the meritocrat wants to say it is deserved (founder-independent). The framework says it is structural, and structural advantages are neither transfers nor deserts.*

Remark 6.22 (The slogan). A useful compression: *zero-sum is the arithmetic of players who cannot see the foundation.* The framework's insistence on the first allocation is, in part, an insistence that the arithmetic is usually incomplete.

6.5 Erosion, revolution, and anti-rigging

Proposition 6.12 establishes that a self-reinforcing rigged foundation resists within-rules reform. The persistence is conditional, however, on the beneficiary coalition retaining the procedural rights that make the rigging self-reinforcing. This subsection identifies the conditions under which that retention fails, and distinguishes three responses to rigging.

Definition 6.23 (Erosion)**.** A rigged foundation *erodes* if, without refounding, the advantage α_i of some beneficiary $i \in S$ declines over time. Erosion occurs through one of three channels:

(i) **Coalition mortality.** The beneficiary coalition fragments, dies out, or is diluted, so that the procedural rights it holds are dispersed or lost.

(ii) **Countervailing leverage.** New players accumulate the resources on which the rules depend—capital, votes, information, labor, legitimacy—sufficient to contest the rigging from within.

(iii) **Reinterpretation.** The rules are read differently by later interpreters, so that the advantage they confer changes without the rules themselves changing.

Definition 6.24 (De-rigging, re-rigging, anti-rigging)**.** A refounding M' of a rigged foundation M^* is:

(i) a *de-rigging* if it eliminates the advantage α_i for $i \in S$;

(ii) a *re-rigging* if it replaces one beneficiary coalition with another while preserving the structural features of rigging (Definition 6.10);

(iii) an *anti-rigging* if it changes the structure so that future rigging is harder—through sunset clauses, rotation, transparency, or procedural rights that are themselves harder to entrench.

Proposition 6.25 (Re-rigging risk)**.** *Let M' be a refounding of a rigged foundation M^* that de-rigs but does not anti-rig. Then M' is itself rigged in favor of some coalition S', and by Proposition 6.12, S''s advantage is self-reinforcing if M' preserves the structural features of rigging.*

Sketch. By Proposition 6.5, M' carries a legitimacy deficit. If M' preserves the structural features of rigging—explicit favoritism, path dependence, information asymmetry, status-quo bias, or coordinative selection (Definition 6.10)—then the founder of M' has encoded an advantage in it, just as the founder of M^* did. The advantage is in favor of S', the coalition that carried out the refounding. If M' also preserves the procedural rights that made M^* self-reinforcing, then S''s advantage is self-reinforcing. □

Remark 6.26 (Revolution as refounding). A revolution is the limiting case of refounding: a change in M^* carried out against the procedural rights of the beneficiary coalition, rather than with its consent. The framework *explains* revolutions as the de-rigging mechanism of last resort when within-rules reform is blocked. It does not *justify* any particular revolution, for two reasons: every refounding carries its own legitimacy deficit (Proposition 6.5), and every refounding risks re-rigging (Proposition 6.25). The framework gives the diagnostic for when a revolution is structurally necessary, not the normative criterion for when it is just. The latter requires a theory of justice the framework does not supply.

Corollary 6.27 (Durability of anti-rigging)**.** *Anti-rigging is the only durable response to rigging. De-rigging without anti-rigging resets the board for the next founder (Proposition 6.25). The question facing any de-rigging coalition is therefore not only* whose advantage should be removed *but* what structure should make the next advantage harder to lay.

The founder advantage is therefore not unconditional. It persists as long as the beneficiary coalition holds the procedural rights to block reform, and it erodes when the coalition fragments, when new players accumulate countervailing leverage, or when the rules are reinterpreted by later readers. A revolution is the refounding that de-rigs when erosion is blocked; whether it succeeds in de-rigging depends on whether it also anti-rigs.

6.6 Domains of founding

The structure is not an analogy across domains; it is the same structural moment in different registers. In each, the foundation may be rigged, and in each, the characteristic form of rigging is different.

- **Political order.** Foundation: the constitutional settlement. Founder: the constituent power. Modes: revolution (force), constitutional convention (agreement), common-law evolution (convention), inherited settlement (accident). *Characteristic rigging:* malapportionment, gerrymandering, supermajority requirements, entrenchment of particular

  rights or interests, electoral systems that favor the founding coalition.

- **Business order.** Foundation: the incorporation—charter, cap table, governance. Founder: the entrepreneur, founding team, or investors. Modes: founder's fiat (force), partnership agreement (agreement), industry practice (convention), inherited structure (accident). *Characteristic rigging:* dual-class stock, founder shares, board composition, vesting schedules, anti-takeover provisions—all devices that encode the founder's advantage into the corporate constitution.

- **Family order.** Foundation: the household formation. Founder: the couple, the parent, the extended family. Modes: one partner's insistence (force), mutual vow (agreement), family tradition (convention), circumstance (accident). *Characteristic rigging:* inheritance rules, naming conventions, gender roles, the unspoken allocation of labor and authority that the household inherits from its own founding.

- **Personal order.** Foundation: the conditions of birth and formation—family, country, body, era, language. Founder: parents, society, circumstance, or no one. Modes: imposed circumstance (force), chosen commitment (agreement), inherited habit (convention), sheer contingency (accident). *Characteristic rigging:* the family one is born into, the country's institutions, genetic endowment, the era's opportunities. The personal foundation is the paradigm case of rigging: one did not choose it, and it shapes every subsequent allocation.

6.7 Consequences

(1) **Legitimacy is downstream of the foundation, and rigging amplifies the deficit.** An allocation is legitimate only if the rules producing it are legitimate, and the rules are legitimate only if the founding that established them is legitimate. Since every founding carries a deficit (Proposition 6.5), legitimacy is never fully grounded. When the foundation is rigged (Definition 6.7), the deficit is not merely abstract but visible in every allocation that follows: the disadvantaged can point to the foundation as the source of their disadvantage, and the beneficiaries cannot justify it without appealing to the very rules it established.

(2) **Reform that ignores the foundation is either naive or revolutionary.** Naive reform assumes the rules are given and proposes changes within them, unaware that the rules themselves encode an initial advantage. Revolutionary reform proposes to redo the foundation—a constitutional moment, a refounding, a new founding—and thereby to eliminate the rigging. By Proposition 6.14, the revolutionary path carries its own legitimacy deficit, but it is the only path that can in principle de-rig a rigged order.

(3) **The struggle over rules is not the deepest struggle.** The deeper contention is over who founds the rules. That contention is not itself rule-governed. It is the struggle that precedes the rules, and its outcome is the foundation on which all subsequent struggles are played. In a rigged order, this deepest struggle is asymmetric: the beneficiaries defend the foundation, the disadvantaged contest it, and the rules that would resolve the contest are the very rules in dispute.

(4) **The meta-game is nonzero-sum.** A game with a live founder advantage is never purely zero-sum (Proposition 6.18). The foundation determines the size of the pie as well as its division, and the struggle over the foundation is therefore not a struggle over shares but a struggle over the terms on which shares are possible.

(5) **De-rigging is possible but not rule-governed, and only anti-rigging is durable.** Proposition 6.14 establishes that de-rigging requires refounding. Corollary 6.27 establishes that de-rigging without anti-rigging resets the board for the next founder.

The correction of a rigged foundation is therefore not a matter of applying the right rule; it is a matter of laying a new foundation, and of designing it so that the next foundation is harder to rig.

The framework's decomposition theorem and mechanism results operate *given* M. They tell you what follows from the rules. They do not tell you how the rules came to be, who founded them, whether the founding is legitimate, or how foundations change. Those are the questions of first allocation, and they are prior to everything the framework formalizes. A complete theory of strategic allocation would need to supplement CSA with a theory of founding, rigging, and de-rigging; CSA's contribution is to identify exactly where that theory is required and what vocabulary—foundation, founder, mode, legitimacy deficit, initial advantage, beneficiary coalition, anti-rigging—it must use.

7 Applications

7.1 Personal decision-making

A person allocating time, attention, money, and energy across health, work, relationships, learning, and rest is solving a CSA problem with $n = 1$ (or $n > 1$ if we treat future selves as distinct players). Shares: daily allocations of time, attention, and money. Claims: choices about how to spend each hour and each dollar. Rules: habits, commitments, budgets, social obligations.

Struggle: the effort of resisting temptation, maintaining focus, and keeping commitments. Contention: competing goals for the same hours; present self versus future self over consumption versus investment; identity commitments versus opportunity.

The framework's payoff here is diagnostic. The decomposition theorem says: identify the *active* struggle network among goals. Goals that rival-contend for the same resource (e.g., deep work and social media, both claiming attention) require a **rule**—a commitment device, a schedule, a friction—not merely a preference. Goals that are cooperative (exercise and sleep) or coordinative (a morning routine) do not require willpower; they require alignment. This reframes self-control as **mechanism design on the self**, in parallel with how the empirical literature on commitment devices, implementation intentions, and choice architecture describes it.

The framework also locates the personal analogue of the first allocation. The conditions one was born into—family, country, body, era, language—are the foundation of one's personal order. They were not chosen. They cannot be fully undone. A personal foundation can be rigged too. The family one is born into, the country's institutions, one's genetic endowment, the era's opportunities—these systematically advantage some and disadvantage others, and the advantage often tracks nothing the person did. Recognizing this is not a counsel of resentment; it is a counsel of realism. One can work within a rigged foundation, and occasionally, at great cost, refound some small part of it. But one cannot pretend the rigging is not there.

7.2 Politics

Political competition is CSA with M itself contested. Players: voters, parties, bureaucracies, interest groups, courts. Shares: budget, authority, legitimacy, agenda control, votes. Rules: constitutions, electoral systems, legislative procedure, federalism. Struggle: campaigning, lobbying, litigation, protest. Contention: rival over budget and authority;

cooperative within coalitions and parties; coordinative over constitutional conventions.

Five CSA-derived insights:

(1) **Rule contention is meta-contention.** The most consequential political struggles are over M—the rules that determine Φ—not over a single allocation. Constitutional design, gerrymandering, and procedural reform are contests over the allocation mapping itself.

(2) **Coalition formation is cooperative contention.** Parties that cooperative-contend over shared goals but rival-contend over shares form coalitions whose stability is a core condition (Proposition 4.4).

(3) **Decomposition localizes conflict.** Many political conflicts are strategically separable across policy domains; the contention graph reveals which domains are genuinely coupled and which are artificially bundled. Rigging can create artificial coupling (§6.3), and unbundling is itself a de-rigging move.

(4) **The deepest struggle is over the foundation, and the foundation may be rigged.** Beneath rule contention lies contention over who founds the rules. Constitutional politics is different in kind from ordinary politics because it is not rule-governed in the same way: it has no referee, and its outcome is the foundation on which subsequent rule-governed politics rests (§6). When the foundation is rigged—malapportionment, gerrymandering, entrenchment of particular interests—the disadvantaged contest the foundation itself, and the beneficiaries defend it. The rules that would resolve the contest are the very rules in dispute. This is why constitutional politics is both the most consequential and the most dangerous form of political struggle.

(5) **Revolution is the de-rigging mechanism of last resort.** When rigging is self-reinforcing and within-rules reform is blocked, refounding is the only remaining path (§6.5). The framework explains revolutions as structurally necessary under these conditions; it does not justify

any particular revolution, because every refounding carries its own legitimacy deficit and risks re-rigging. The normative question requires a theory of justice that the framework does not supply.

7.2.1 Political alignment: left and right

The framework provides a structural account of the left–right political axis. In CSA terms, the axis is the trace, in political space, of the contention between the beneficiaries of the foundation and its disadvantaged. The two positions are not arbitrary; they are responses to different structural positions in the contention graph.

Definition 7.1 (De-rigging and foundation-defending coalitions)**.** A *de-rigging coalition* is a coalition $D \subseteq \mathcal{N}$ whose members are disadvantaged by the foundation ($\alpha_i < 0$ for $i \in D$) and who pursue de-rigging (§6.5) as their primary political objective. A *foundation-defending coalition* is a coalition $F \subseteq \mathcal{N}$ whose members are advantaged by the foundation ($\alpha_i > 0$ for $i \in F$) and who pursue the preservation of the foundation as their primary political objective.

The framework predicts that the axis between D and F will be stable whenever the foundation is self-reinforcing (Definition 6.11): the beneficiaries have an interest in defending what advantages them, and the disadvantaged have an interest in contesting what disadvantages them. The axis is not a matter of opinion; it is a matter of structural position.

Proposition 7.2 (The left–right axis)**.** *In a CSA problem with a self-reinforcing rigged foundation, the de-rigging coalition D and the foundation-defending coalition F have opposing preferences over the foundation M^*: D prefers a refounding that reduces α_i for $i \in F$, and F prefers the status quo. The axis between them is the political expression of the contention structure.*

Sketch. By Proposition 6.12, F can block within-rules reform that reduces its advantage. By Proposition 6.14, D's only path to de-rigging is refounding. Hence D prefers refounding and F prefers the status quo. The axis between them is the trace of this structural opposition. □

Three refinements are needed.

First, **the mapping is not identity**. Not every member of D is on the left, and not every member of F is on the right. The contention graph is multi-dimensional: a player can be disadvantaged by one rigging and advantaged by another. The left–right axis is a *composite* of several structural positions, and the composite is stable because the positions tend to correlate, not because they are identical.

Second, **the zero-sum disagreement is itself a move in the over-rules game**. The left characteristically claims that the game is not zero-sum (de-rigging can make everyone better off), and the right characteristically claims that it is (redistribution is a transfer). By Proposition 6.18, the left is correct if the founder advantage is live, and the right is correct if it is fixed. The disagreement about whether the game is zero-sum is therefore a disagreement about whether the foundation is contestable—and that disagreement is itself a strategic move. The beneficiaries have an interest in treating the advantage as fixed (it closes the over-rules game); the disadvantaged have an interest in treating it as live (it opens the over-rules game).

Third, **the framework does not adjudicate the normative question**. It can say that both positions have a structural basis, that the left is right that foundations are often rigged, and that the right is right that refounding is dangerous and can re-rig. The synthesis is anti-rigging (§6.5): change the structure so that future rigging is harder. This is neither purely left nor purely right; it is a structural design question. But the framework cannot say how much rigging is acceptable, given the costs of de-rigging. That requires a theory of justice the framework does not supply.

Remark 7.3 (Mode of founding and political temperature). The mode of founding (§6) shapes the character of the left–right conflict. A foundation laid by force produces a left that treats the founding as illegitimate and a right that defends it as established. A foundation laid by agreement produces a left that argues the agreement was incomplete and a right that argues it was the best available. A foundation laid by convention produces a left that argues it was never chosen and a right that argues it has stood the test of time. A foundation laid by accident produces a conflict that is less about the founding and more about what to do next.

Remark 7.4 (The axis and decomposition). The decomposition theorem (§5) explains why not every issue is political. An issue becomes political when it touches the foundation—when the allocation of shares is coupled to the rules that determine them. Technical, administrative, and coordinative issues are not political in this sense, and the framework predicts that they will be settled by expertise or convention rather than by left–right contest. The left–right axis appears on issues where the foundation is genuinely at stake.

7.2.2 The space of political axes

The framework explains not only the left–right axis but the full space of political axes. The space is not arbitrary: it is isomorphic to the space of contestable parameters of the CSA problem.

Proposition 7.5 (Axis typology)**.** *Every political axis is a disagreement about one of five parameters of the CSA problem:*

(i) the object *of allocation—which shares are contended ($\mathcal{R}$);*

(ii) the boundary *of the player set—who is a player ($\mathcal{N}$);*

(iii) the scope *of the rules—what the rules cover (M);*

(iv) the legitimacy *of the foundation—whether the founding is justified (M^*); or*

(v) the mode *of change—how the order is to be changed.*

Individual axes may combine elements of multiple families, but each has a primary family.

Sketch. The CSA problem is a tuple $(\mathcal{N}, \mathcal{R}, \Theta, A, I, B, \Phi, M, M^*, \text{mode}, \text{level})$. Each parameter can be fixed or contested. When a parameter is contested, a political axis emerges: a stable disagreement about the parameter's value. The five families correspond to the five parameters that generate stable axes. Method axes are the composite of mode and level. The typology is exhaustive because every disagreement about a CSA problem must be about one of its parameters. □

Family	**Parameter**	**Axes**	**Question**
Object	$\mathcal{R}$	Left–right (economic), materialist–postmaterialist, green–growth	What is divided?
Boundary	$\mathcal{N}$	Globalist–nationalist, hawk–dove, urban–rural, young–old	Who is in the game?
Rule-scope	M	Libertarian–authoritarian, federal–unitary	How much is governed?
Foundation-legitimacy	M^*	Progressive–conservative, populist–elitist, religious–secular	Is the founding justified?
Method	mode	Reform–revolution, moderate–radical	How should it change?

Each family has a distinct structural logic. We treat each in turn.

Object axes. Left–right (economic) has been analyzed in §7.2.1. Materialist–postmaterialist [7] is a disagreement about which shares matter: as material shares become secure, the resource set $\mathcal{R}$ expands to include identity, autonomy, and recognition. Green–growth extends $\mathcal{R}$ to environmental goods and future generations. The green axis is structurally distinctive because the expansion of $\mathcal{R}$ brings in players who cannot contest—future generations and non-human nature. It requires *trustee* mechanisms, because the affected parties are voiceless.

Boundary axes. Globalist–nationalist is a disagreement about $\mathcal{N}$: who is inside the order? A nationalist says the foundation is for citizens; a globalist says it is for all affected parties. Expanding $\mathcal{N}$ is structurally a refounding (§6), because the foundation was laid for a smaller set—which is why the axis is so bitter. Hawk–dove is a disagreement about whether other states are rival or cooperative contenders, and the nonzero-sum theorem (§6.4) applies directly: if the international foundation is live, doves are right; if it is fixed, hawks may be. Urban–rural and young–old are structural positions in the contention graph rather than disagreements about a parameter: they reflect different resource bases and different time horizons.

Rule-scope axes. Libertarian–authoritarian is a disagreement about the domain of the allocation mapping Φ: whether it is near-identity on private claims (libertarian) or a thick collective allocation (authoritarian). Federal–unitary is a disagreement about the level at which rules are made. The decomposition theorem (§5) applies to both: decentralization adds value when issues are separable, centralization when they are coupled.

Foundation-legitimacy axes. Progressive–conservative is structurally identical to economic left–right, but over cultural shares: the progressive sees the cultural foundation as rigged and wants to refound it; the conservative sees it as established and wants to preserve it. This is why the two axes correlate: they are the same structure over different shares. Populist–elitist is a *re-rigging* axis: the populist claims the foundation has been captured by a new elite; the elitist defends the current coalition. By Proposition 6.25, populist refoundings will re-rig rather than anti-rig, because populism is a de-rigging movement without an anti-rigging program. Religious–secular is the most structurally distinctive: it is a disagreement about the mode of founding, but a special one, because the religious view treats the founding as outside the four modes—as divine ordination rather than force, agreement, convention, or accident. The framework cannot adjudicate, because it has no category for transcendent authority. It can only note that the religious view refuses the regress, while the secular view lives with it.

Method axes. Reform–revolution is a disagreement about whether the rigging is self-reinforcing: if it is, reform is blocked and refounding is the only path (Proposition 6.14); if it is not, reform is sufficient and refounding is dangerous. Moderate–radical is a disagreement about the coupling of issues: moderate when issues are separable, radical when they are coupled. The decomposition theorem applies to both.

Remark 7.6 (The correlation of axes). The axes correlate because the layers correlate: the beneficiaries of a rigged economic foundation tend to defend the cultural foundation, prefer the within-rules game, and see the founding as legitimate. But the correlation is not identity: a person can be economically left and culturally conservative, or vice versa. The composite is stable because the positions tend to correlate, not because they are identical.

Remark 7.7 (New axes). The framework predicts that new axes will emerge as new resources become scarce. As data, attention, and identity become scarce, new object axes emerge around them (digital rights, AI governance, identity politics). The framework predicts these will fit the same structural pattern: de-rigging vs. foundation-defending over the new resource.

7.3 Business strategy

A firm allocating capital, capacity, talent, data, and attention across markets and functions, while rivals, suppliers, and regulators do the same, is solving a CSA problem with M partly chosen by the firm (contracts, org design) and partly imposed (regulation, antitrust). Shares: market share, margin, talent, data, customer attention. Claims: investment, hiring, pricing, product moves. Rules: contracts, auctions, market structure, regulation. Struggle: price competition, advertising spend, litigation, lobbying. Contention: rival over customer attention and capacity; cooperative over complementary assets; coordinative over standards.

Five CSA-derived strategic questions:

(1) **Which resources are rival-contended?** Rivalry over customer attention (advertising), talent (hiring), and capacity (price wars) generates different strategic dynamics than cooperative contention over complementary assets (alliances, ecosystems). The contention graph tells you which game you are in.

(2) **What is the allocation mapping?** Strategy is often the design of Φ itself—platform rules, pricing mechanisms, supply contracts—not just a choice of a within fixed Φ.

(3) **When does strategy decompose?** Multi-business firms can often be decomposed into strategically separable units. The decomposition theorem tells you when central coordination adds value (coupled contention) and when it adds only overhead (separable contention).

(4) **What is the founding, and is it rigged?** The incorporation—the charter, the cap table, the governance—is the first allocation of the firm (§6). Founder shares, dual-class stock, board composition, and anti-takeover provisions are devices that encode the founder's advantage into the corporate constitution. Founder disputes are bitter because they are about the foundation, not about ordinary management. Governance reforms are contested for the same reason, and they often fail because the rigged foundation gives the beneficiaries the procedural rights to block de-rigging. "Who decides" is a deeper question than "what is decided," and "who decided the founding" is deeper still.

(5) **Is the competitive game zero-sum?** Rarely. A firm that mistakes a live founder advantage for a fixed pie—its own or a rival's—will misread the strategic situation (§6.4). Markets are rival at the margin but nonzero-sum over their foundations: regulation, standards, market structure, and technology shift the total, not merely its division. A firm that invests in shaping these foundations is playing the over-rules game; one that only optimizes within them is playing the

within-rules game. Both can be correct, but confusing the two is a strategic error.

8 Discussion

8.1 Scope

CSA is a *modeling language*, not a theory of everything. It is useful exactly when allocation, contention, and struggle are the salient features of a situation—which is most of the time, but not always. Pure signaling games, pure epistemic puzzles, and games whose interest lies in equilibrium refinement rather than allocation are better described in standard terms.

8.2 Bounded rationality

CSA can accommodate bounded rationality by restricting A_i (limited claims), I_i (limited information), B_i (limited struggle capacity), or the strategy space (limited contingent plans). But it does not *explain* bounded rationality; that requires a theory of cognition, attention, and habit that CSA does not supply.

8.3 Norms and informal rules

The rule structure M is deliberately broad. It includes formal rules—contracts, laws, constitutions—and informal ones—norms, conventions, expectations. This is important because many of the most consequential rules in personal, political, and business life are informal. CSA does not model how norms form or change; it treats them as part of M and asks what difference they make to allocation and equilibrium. The formation of norms is a special case of the problem of first allocation (§6): a norm is a rule whose founding is often conventional or accidental rather than deliberate.

8.4 The first allocation

The framework brackets the problem of first allocation (§6): it takes M as given or chosen, and derives allocations from it. This is a genuine limit, not a minor one. The legitimacy of any allocation depends on the legitimacy of the rules, and the legitimacy of the rules depends on the founding. A complete theory would need to say how first allocations are made, justified, and changed. CSA does not supply that theory; it identifies where it is needed and provides the vocabulary—foundation, founder, mode of founding, legitimacy deficit, initial advantage, beneficiary coalition—in which the theory can be stated.

The theory of the rigged foundation (§6.3–§6.5) sharpens the limit. It shows that the first allocation can systematically advantage some players, that within-rules reform cannot eliminate this advantage when the rigging is self-reinforcing, and that de-rigging requires refounding—which carries its own legitimacy deficit and risks re-rigging. The framework therefore identifies not only where a theory of founding is needed but also why it is hard: the correction of a rigged foundation is itself a founding, and foundings are not rule-governed. And it shows that the meta-game is nonzero-sum, which is why zero-sum reasoning—though correct within a fixed foundation—is systematically misleading about the situations that matter most.

8.5 Normative questions

CSA is descriptive and analytical, not normative. It can identify Pareto-inefficient allocations, contention-driven conflict, and the welfare consequences of alternative rules. It cannot by itself say what allocation is *just*. That requires an ethical theory, which CSA can inform but not replace. The problem of first allocation sharpens this point: the legitimacy deficit of every founding (§6) means that no purely procedural theory of justice can fully ground itself. Normative theory must confront the founding, not merely the rules that follow from it. And the theory of the rigged foundation (§6.3) adds that de-rigging is not a rule-governed correction but a refounding—which means that normative theory must also confront the conditions under which a refounding is justified, and this is a question the framework cannot answer.

The analysis of political axes (§7.2.1–§7.2.2) has a further implication. The framework shows that the left–right axis, and the other axes, are structural responses to the contention between beneficiaries and disadvantaged. It follows that no political position can be refuted merely by showing that it reflects a structural interest. Every position reflects a structural interest; the question is whether the position is also correct. The framework cannot answer that question, but it can sharpen it: it can show what each axis is about, and what a resolution would require.

8.6 Relationship to standard game theory

CSA adds no expressive power beyond extensive-form games: any CSA problem can be encoded as an extensive-form game by treating M and Φ as part of the game tree, and every extensive-form game is a CSA problem. The contribution is not a new theorem but a new **primitive ontology**—one that treats shares, contention, struggle, rules, founders, foundations, and axes as first-class objects. Six organizational claims follow:

(1) **Allocation is the outcome of interest.** Games are often analyzed as if the payoff were the primitive; CSA insists that the share is the primitive and payoff is a function of it. This matters for welfare analysis, fairness, and mechanism design.

(2) **Rules are explicit.** Treating M as an object—sometimes exogenous, sometimes contested, sometimes designed—clarifies the difference between playing a game and choosing one.

(3) **Contention and struggle are structural.** Making contention a graph and struggle a weighted network, rather than implicit properties of payoffs, permits decomposition, diagnosis, and targeted intervention.

(4) **Foundations are explicit.** Naming the problem of first allocation clarifies the boundary of the framework and the point at which a theory of founding must take over.

(5) **Rigging is structural.** Naming the rigged foundation clarifies why some games are not zero-sum, why within-rules reform so often fails, and why de-rigging requires refounding with anti-rigging if it is to be durable.

(6) **Axes are structural.** Deriving political axes from the contestable parameters of the CSA problem clarifies why the axes exist, why they correlate, and why they persist across changes in the specific issues.

In practice, the choice of primitive ontology matters: it shapes which questions seem natural, which comparative statics are visible, and which interventions are conceivable. CSA is offered in that spirit.

9 Conclusion

Games are struggles over shares, under rules, where what each player gets depends on what everyone claims. Making that idea precise yields a framework—Contested Strategic Allocation—that unifies normal-form and extensive-form games, exchange economies, cooperative games, mechanism design, and single-agent planning as instances of a single structure. The framework's central structural object is the contention graph, which determines when a problem decomposes, where strategic difficulty lies, and what mechanisms can do; its central process object is the struggle network, which determines how contention is pursued and at what cost; its central limit is the problem of first allocation, which marks the point at which the framework falls silent; its central consequence is that the foundation is not neutral: it may be rigged, and when it is, the rigging is self-reinforcing, the meta-game is nonzero-sum, and de-rigging requires refounding with anti-rigging if it is to be durable; and its central application to politics is the derivation of the left–right axis and the full space of political axes from the contention structure.

In personal life, the struggle network reveals which goals require commitment devices rather than willpower, and the first allocation marks the conditions one did not choose. In politics, it reveals which conflicts are genuinely coupled and which are artificially bundled, why rule contests dominate, why the deepest struggles are over the founding, why revolutions are the de-rigging mechanism of last resort, and why the left and the right are structural responses to the same contention. In business, it reveals which resources generate rivalry, which generate cooperation, when central coordination adds value, why founder disputes are bitter, and why the competitive game is rarely the fixed pie it appears to be.

The framework does not solve these problems. It organizes them. And it is honest about where its organization ends: at the foundation, which no rule of the order can justify, and which every founder—conqueror, constitution-writer, entrepreneur, parent—must lay without the justification that only the rules themselves could provide. The foundation may be rigged, and when it is, the rigging is self-reinforcing: within-rules reform preserves it, and de-rigging

requires a new founding with its own legitimacy deficit. This is the deepest thing the framework can say, and the last: **the game is played on a field that someone laid, and the laying of the field is not itself a move in the game.** The field can be relaid, but a relaying that does not change the *terms* of laying merely resets the board for the next founder. The deepest lesson of the first allocation is not that the game is rigged but that rigging is a structure—and structures can be redesigned, at the cost of a new founding with its own legitimacy deficit.

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A Summary of Notation

Symbol	Ordinary-language gloss	Formal meaning
$\mathcal{N}$	Players	Set of players
$\mathcal{R}$	Resources	Set of resource types
Θ	States of the world	State space
A_i	Claims	Player i's claim set
I_i	What i knows	Information partition
B_i	Struggle capacity	Struggle budget (scalar)
F_i	Which efforts are feasible	Effort set
$\mathcal{X}$	Shares	Allocation space
Φ	How claims and struggle become shares	Allocation mapping
M	Rules	Rule structure
M^*	Foundation	First allocation (regress terminus)
α_i	Initial advantage	Advantage conferred by the foundation
u_i	Player i's payoff	Payoff function
T	How things evolve	Transition map
σ_i	Plan	Strategy
$G_r^{\text{riv}}, G_r^{\text{coop}}, G_r^{\text{coord}}$	Who contends with whom	Contention graphs
$\tilde{G}_r$	How hard they struggle	Weighted struggle network
$\kappa(\mathcal{G})$	Density of rivalry	Rival contention index
$\sigma(\mathcal{G})$	Intensity of struggle	Struggle intensity

The Struggle for This or That

A grammar of shares, rules, founders, and the shape of human conflict

Macharia Barii

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Every Sunday evening, somewhere, a family has the same argument. The weekend is nearly gone. One person wants to see friends; another wants to rest; a third wants to finish a project that has been waiting for weeks. Nobody is being unreasonable. Nobody wants to hurt anybody. And yet the evening cannot be spent three ways. The hours are few. The desires are many. The argument is not about who loves whom. It is about how a scarce thing—time—will be divided.

Now move to a different room. A company's leadership meets to allocate next year's budget. Three divisions want the same capital. Each has a case. Each case is partly true. The money is finite. The meeting is tense.

Now move to a different scale. A country's legislature fights over a budget. Parties, regions, and factions each claim a share of what the state can spend. The fight is loud, procedural, and old.

These scenes feel different. They differ in scale, in stakes, in the language used. But they have the same skeleton. In each, people are making claims on a share of something scarce. In each, the claims contend: satisfying one makes satisfying another harder. In each, the contention produces struggle—effort, argument, maneuvering, sometimes open conflict. And in each, rules determine who ends up with what.

That skeleton—share, claim, contention, struggle, rules—is the subject of this essay. But it is not the whole of it. Behind every set of rules is a foundation: the settlement that no prior rule settles. Behind every foundation is a founder: the person, group, or process that laid it. And beneath the foundation—so often unspoken—is a rigging: the initial advantage that the founding confers on some over others, an advantage that tends to preserve itself. This is the deepest layer, and it is the layer most people never see.

The whole picture is a grammar that many situations obey. It is not a theory of everything. But it changes what you notice. And it turns out to explain the oldest axis in politics—left and right—as well as the other axes that cut across it.

Key idea. A game is a struggle over shares, under rules, where what each player gets depends on what everyone claims—and the deepest layer, usually unseen, is the founder advantage underneath the rules.

The four words

Share

A share is the portion of something valuable that someone receives, keeps, or controls. It is what we also call a reward, a portion, a stake—what someone gets. A wage is a share of a firm's revenue. A child's hour of screen time is a share of the household's attention. A country's territory is a share of the earth. A grade is a share of the credit a course offers. A seat on a committee is a share of authority. A share need not be money. It can be time, attention, status, legitimacy, information, safety, or the chance to be heard.

Claim

A claim is what a person asserts, demands, proposes, or tries in order to obtain, keep, or enlarge a share. A bid is a claim on a good. A move in chess is a claim on a square. A budget request is a claim on funds. A knock on someone's door is a claim on their attention. A legal filing is a claim on a court's time. Claims can be compatible—two people can both get what they ask for. They can be incompatible—only one can win. Or they can be partly compatible,

so that satisfying one reduces but does not eliminate another.

Contention

Contention is the pivotal idea, and it is easy to miss because the word sounds like fighting. But contention is not yet a fight. It is the condition in which two or more claims bear on the same share, so that satisfying one affects the satisfaction of another. Contention is the situation that makes a fight possible. It is structural, not behavioral. A quiet office where two people want the same promotion is full of contention even if no one has said a word. A market where three firms compete for the same customers is full of contention even on days when nothing happens.

Rival, cooperative, coordinative

Contention comes in flavors. Some is rival: one person's share grows at another's expense. The promotion, the budget line, the single parking space—these are rival. Some is cooperative: each person's share grows when the other's does. Two colleagues building a practice together, two countries trading, two people raising a child—these are cooperative. Each prefers the other to do well. And some is coordinative: both parties want to agree on a joint arrangement, but neither cares much about the other's share per se—they only care that the arrangement be shared. Two drivers want to be on the same side of the road; which side matters far less than that both agree.

This three-way distinction is not academic. It is the difference between a marriage and a merger, between an alliance and a rivalry, between a standard and a contest. Most human relationships contain all three at once, in different proportions, over different things. A friendship is cooperative over affection, rival over scarce time, and coordinative over where to eat. Recognizing which is which is the beginning of strategy.

Struggle

A struggle is the activity of contending—the effort, time, risk, and resources people expend trying to secure, defend, or enlarge a share. Contention is the structure; struggle is the process.

A union negotiating a contract is struggling. A firm cutting prices is struggling. A person resisting the pull of their phone to finish a piece of work is struggling. A country in a cold war is struggling. A child learning to share is struggling, in a small way, with a large lesson.

Struggle has a grammar, and the grammar is revealing. English—and many other languages—let us say three things:

- We struggle for something: independence, market share, a place in the life we want.
- We struggle with someone against a common obstacle: our shared struggle for recognition, for justice, for survival.
- We struggle over something: the terms of a contract, the rules of an institution, the direction of a movement.

These three prepositions are not accidents of speech. They map directly onto the three kinds of contention. Struggle for is rival contention: I want the share, and if I get it you may not. Struggle with is cooperative contention: we want the share together, and our efforts reinforce. Struggle over is coordinative contention: we agree the thing matters, and we disagree on which arrangement to adopt. The grammar of struggle encodes the structure of contention. When you hear someone say "the struggle over the rules," you are listening to people who understand, perhaps without knowing it, that the deepest conflicts are not about shares but about the arrangements that determine shares.

> **Key idea.** Contention is the structure; struggle is the process. Struggle *for*, *with*, and *over* trace rival, cooperative, and coordinative contention.

Rules: the fifth word, and the deepest

That brings us to the fifth word, the one that often decides everything: rules.

What rules are

Rules are the arrangements that determine how claims become shares. They include the formal—contracts, laws, constitutions, auctions, voting systems—and the informal—norms, conventions, expectations, habits. A market's price mechanism is a rule. A firm's budgeting process is a rule. A family's unspoken understanding about who handles bedtime is a rule. A constitution is a rule of rules.

Rules shape the struggle

Rules matter because they determine which struggles take place and how shares are assigned once claims are made. Change the rule and you change the struggle. A promotion decided by seniority produces a different contest than one decided by performance review, which produces a different contest than one decided by a coin flip. None of these rules is neutral. Each favors some claimants and disadvantages others. Each produces its own kind of effort, its own kind of resentment, its own kind of peace.

Struggle over the rules

And so we arrive at the deepest form of contention, the one that runs beneath all the others: struggle over the rules. When people fight over a budget, they are fighting within the rules. When they fight over how the budget is decided— who sits on the committee, what the voting threshold is, what counts as a valid claim—they are fighting over the rules themselves. This is the struggle that shapes all subsequent struggles. It is why constitutional politics is more consequential than ordinary politics, why procedural reform in a legislature can matter more than any single bill, why a change in a firm's governance can matter more than a year of quarterly results.

Three questions to ask

A useful habit of mind follows from this. When you encounter a conflict, ask two questions in order. First: what is the share being contended? Second: what are the rules that determine who gets it? The first question is what most people ask. The second is what strategists ask. And a third question, rarer still: who decided the rules, and how?

> **Key idea.** Change the rule and you change the struggle. The deepest conflicts are over the rules, not the shares.

Who decided the rules?

The problem of first allocation

There is a question that follows immediately from the last section, and it is the question the framework cannot answer. If rules determine how claims become shares, then who decided the rules?

And who decided who decides?

This is the problem of first allocation. It is the problem of the allocation that no prior rule allocates—the allocation of rule-making authority itself. Every order has one, and none can justify it by its own rules.

The regress stops at the foundation

The regress is simple. If the rules were chosen under some rule, then that rule was chosen under another, and so on. Either the chain goes on forever—rules all the way down, with nothing at the bottom—or it stops somewhere. It stops at the foundation of the order: the settlement that is not itself settled by any prior rule. A constitution is a foundation. A company's charter is a foundation. A marriage is a foundation. The conditions you were born into are a foundation. Each is the bottom of its own order, the place where the regress of rules runs out.

The founder

The foundation is laid by a founder—the one who establishes the first rules. The founder may be a person: a conqueror, a constitution-writer, an entrepreneur, a parent. It may be a group: a constituent assembly, a founding partnership, a household. It may be a process: a community

gradually converging on a practice. Or it may be no one at all: history, drift, accident. The founder is the answer to who decided. The mode of founding is the answer to how.

Four ways a foundation is laid

There are four ways a foundation can be laid.

- **Force.** The founder imposes the rules. A revolution, a coup, a conquest, a founder's fiat. The rules are established by whoever can establish them.
- **Agreement.** The founders consent to the rules. A constitution, a charter, a compact, a marriage vow. The rules are established by those who will live under them, actually or in principle.
- **Convention.** The rules emerge from practice. No one decides; people follow a pattern, and the pattern hardens into a rule. Common law, industry custom, family tradition. The rules are established by no one in particular, over time.
- **Accident.** The rules are the residue of history. Path dependence, inheritance, drift. The rules are established by circumstance, not by anyone's choice.

The legitimacy deficit

Each of these is a way of founding an order. None of them is fully legitimate by the standards of the order it founds. Force is not legitimate. Agreement is hypothetical or incomplete. Convention is not chosen. Accident is not justified. This is not a reason for cynicism. It is a reason for clarity. It is why constitutions have founding myths, why firms have origin stories, why families have unspoken understandings about who decided what.

One problem, many names

The problem has many names in many fields. Philosophers call it original acquisition, or the state of nature, or the original position. Political theorists call it constituent power—the power that makes the constitution and is not made by it. Economists call it the initial endowment, and they often bracket it: the second welfare theorem says any efficient allocation is reachable from some endowment, but it does not say which endowment. Game theorists call it the disagreement point, and they take it as given. The name "first allocation" unifies all of these, because they are all the same problem in different registers.

> **Key idea.** Every order rests on a foundation—the settlement no prior rule settles—and no foundation justifies itself by its own rules.

Is the game rigged?

The rigged foundation

A foundation is not neutral. Whoever lays it lays it with their interests in mind—or with their interests encoded in the accidents of history that laid it. The first allocation is also an allocation

of advantage. We call this the rigged foundation: the initial advantage that the founding confers on some players over others.

Explicit and implicit advantage

The advantage can be explicit. A constitution that requires property ownership for the vote. A company charter that gives founders ten votes per share. An inheritance rule that favors one child over another. Or it can be implicit. First- mover advantages that compound over time. Information asymmetries between the founder and later players. The simple fact that the status quo is harder to change than it is to defend.

Self-reinforcement

A rigged foundation is usually self-reinforcing. The people it advantages are given—or can acquire—the procedural rights to block reforms that would reduce their advantage. A veto. A supermajority requirement. Agenda control. The rules that would allow reform are controlled by the people who would be reformed. This is why within-rules reform so often fails against a self-reinforcing rigging: not because the reformers lack arguments, but because the rules give the beneficiaries the power to say no.

Who struggles least

There is a corollary that is easy to miss. In a rigged order, the beneficiaries struggle less than the disadvantaged. The rules already favor them, so they have little to struggle for within the rules. The disadvantaged struggle constantly, because they must struggle not only against other claimants but against the rules themselves. This is why rigged orders often look calm on the surface: the people doing the struggling are the people whose struggles are least visible. The noise of politics is not a measure of contention; it is a measure of who is contending actively, and the beneficiaries of a rigged foundation are usually quiet.

Erosion

This does not mean the advantage is permanent. The beneficiary coalition can fragment. New players can accumulate the resources the rules depend on—capital, votes, information, labor, legitimacy. The rules can be reinterpreted by later readers in ways the founder never anticipated. A rigged foundation erodes, given enough time and enough change. But erosion is slow, uncertain, and often blocked precisely by the self-reinforcing mechanisms. So the practical claim stands: within-rules reform usually fails against a self-reinforcing rigging, and this is why de-rigging, when it happens, tends to happen by refounding rather than reform.

> **Key idea.** A rigged foundation is self-reinforcing: the beneficiaries hold the procedural rights to block reform.

The game is never zero-sum

What zero-sum means

Zero-sum means: what I gain, you lose, and nothing else changes. It is the logic of a fixed pie. A negotiation over the price of a house. A tennis match. A budget that has already been set.

The founder advantage is not a slice

But a game with a live founder advantage can never be purely zero-sum. Here is why.

A founder advantage is not a slice of the pie. It is a feature of how the pie is cut and how big it is. The founder did not win the game; the founder laid the field. And laying the field is not a move in the game—it is the condition of the game.

Two levels

This means the game has two levels. At the first level, players play within the rules. That level can be zero-sum: a fixed budget, a fixed market, a fixed amount of attention. At the second level, players struggle over the rules themselves. That level is never zero-sum, because the rules determine the size of the pie, not just its division.

The meta-game

The founder advantage is the trace of the second level in the first. It is evidence that the rules were laid by someone, in some mode, in someone's favor. And the existence of that someone—the founder—means the game has a meta- game.

Why zero-sum thinking fails

This is why zero-sum thinking is so often a mistake. It is the thinking of players who take the foundation for granted. It is not always wrong—sometimes you really are playing a fixed game, and you should fight for your slice. But the most important games are not fixed. They are laid, and they can be laid differently.

Who benefits from zero-sum framing

It is also why the people most insistent that the game is zero-sum are often the people who benefit from the current foundation. Zero-sum framing keeps the conversation inside the rules. It prevents the question of the foundation from being asked. "There is only so much to go around" is sometimes true and sometimes a way of saying "do not ask who decided how much goes around."

The slogan

A useful slogan: zero-sum is the arithmetic of players who cannot see the foundation. The framework's insistence on the first allocation is, in part, an insistence that the arithmetic is usually incomplete.

> **Key idea.** Zero-sum is the arithmetic of players who cannot see the foundation.

Can the rigging be undone?

Four paths

The framework identifies four ways the rigging can be undone, and each has its own costs.

- **Erosion.** The beneficiary coalition fragments. New players accumulate countervailing leverage. The rules are reinterpreted by later readers. Slowly, without anyone deciding to do so, the advantage declines. Erosion is the least dramatic path and often the most effective. It is also the least reliable: it depends on circumstances no one controls.
- **Within-rules reform.** The beneficiaries can be persuaded—by argument, by coalition pressure, by the desire for legitimacy—to accept reforms that reduce their advantage. This is the path the framework predicts will usually fail against a self-reinforcing rigging, and history bears the prediction out. But it can succeed when the beneficiary coalition is weak, divided, or dependent on legitimacy it cannot afford to lose. It is always worth trying, and it is rarely sufficient.
- **Refounding.** The foundation is replaced. A constitutional convention. A revolution. A company recapitalization. A family conversation that changes the terms. The advantage is removed, but the removal is not rule-governed—it is a new founding, with its own founders, its own mode, and its own legitimacy deficit. This is the deepest and the most dangerous path. It can create a better foundation or a worse one, and the uncertainty about which is why refoundings are so contested.
- **Anti-rigging.** The foundation is not merely replaced but redesigned so that future rigging is harder. Sunset clauses. Rotation in office. Transparency. Constitutional provisions that make re-rigging costly. This is the only durable path—because refounding without anti-rigging merely resets the board for the next founder. The revolution that de-rigs but does not anti-rig will produce a new rigging within a generation, often sooner. The question facing any de-rigging coalition is therefore not only whose advantage should be removed but what structure should make the next advantage harder to lay.

What this says about revolution

This is the most interesting thing the framework has to say about revolution. It explains revolutions: they are the de- rigging mechanism of last resort, when within-rules reform is blocked and erosion is too slow. It does not justify any particular revolution, for two reasons. First, every refounding carries its own legitimacy deficit—it cannot be justified by the standards it establishes, because those standards are what it is establishing. Second, every refounding risks re- rigging: many revolutions install a new elite with the same structural protections as the old one, and the framework predicts the new rigging will be exactly as persistent. A revolution that swaps beneficiaries without changing the structure of rigging has not de-rigged the order. It has re-rigged it.

The diagnostic and the normative limit

So the framework gives you the diagnostic for when a revolution is structurally necessary—rigging is self-reinforcing, within-rules reform is blocked, erosion is too slow—but not the normative

criterion for when it is justified. That requires a theory of justice the framework does not supply. The framework tells you when the question is forced; it does not tell you the answer.

Key idea. Refounding without anti-rigging merely resets the board: the only durable path is to make the next rigging harder to lay.

Left and right

The framework explains the oldest axis in politics.

One structural question

In CSA terms, the left and the right are two responses to the same structural question: what is the relationship between the game within the rules and the game over the rules?

The left treats the over-rules game as primary. The foundation is where the action is, because the foundation determines the shares. If the foundation is rigged, playing well within the rules cannot help the disadvantaged. Politics must address the foundation.

The right treats the within-rules game as primary. The foundation provides the conditions for the game to exist. Without a stable foundation, there is no game at all. Politics must preserve the foundation and play well within it.

This is not a disagreement about facts. It is a disagreement about which facts matter. And both are right, in the sense that both levels are real. They disagree about emphasis.

The de-riggers and the foundation-defenders

But the mapping is sharper than that. The left is the de-rigging coalition: it sees the foundation as rigged, emphasizes the legitimacy deficit, and is sympathetic to refounding. The right is the foundation-defending coalition: it sees the foundation as legitimate (or at least established), emphasizes the coordination value of the rules, and is suspicious of refounding. The axis between them is the trace, in political space, of the contention structure.

The zero-sum disagreement as a move

The zero-sum disagreement is itself a strategic move. The left wants to say the advantage is live—contestable—

because that opens the over-rules game. The right wants to say the advantage is fixed—not contestable—because that closes the over-rules game and keeps the action within the rules. The disagreement about whether the game is zero-sum is not a disagreement about arithmetic. It is a disagreement about whether the foundation can be contested. And that disagreement is itself a move in the over-rules game.

The mapping is not perfect. Not everyone on the left is disadvantaged, and not everyone on the right is a beneficiary. A person can be a beneficiary of one rigging and disadvantaged by another. A populist right can be de-rigging (against elites) while a reformist left can be foundation-defending (defending the welfare state). The axis is a composite of several structural positions, and the composite is stable because the positions tend to correlate. But the correlation is not identity.

Why the axis persists

Why did this axis emerge, and why has it persisted? The terms come from the French Revolution, when the National Assembly seated supporters of the king on the right and supporters of the revolution on the left. That was exactly the de-rigging vs. foundation-defending axis: the right defended the ancien régime's foundation, the left wanted to replace it. The framework explains why this particular axis emerged—it is the trace of the contention structure—and why it has persisted through every subsequent realignment. The issues change because the specific riggings change. The axis persists because the structural question persists.

The synthesis and the limit

What does the framework say about the debate? It says that both positions have a structural basis. The left is right that foundations are often rigged. The right is right that refounding is dangerous and can re-rig. The synthesis is anti- rigging: change the structure so that future rigging is harder. This is neither purely left nor purely right. It is a structural design question.

And it says that the framework cannot adjudicate the normative question: how much rigging is acceptable, given the costs of de-rigging? That requires a theory of justice the framework does not supply. The framework tells you when the question is forced. It does not tell you the answer.

Two halves of one insight

The left and right are not enemies. They are two halves of a single structural insight. The left sees the foundation. The right sees the game. The framework sees both, and shows why neither can be reduced to the other.

> **Key idea.** Left and right are two halves of one structural insight: the left sees the foundation; the right sees the game. The framework sees both.

All the axes

The left-right axis is not the only axis in politics. It is the oldest and the most stable, but it is one of many. The framework explains why there are many, and why they take the shapes they do.

The five families

The space of political axes is the space of contestable parameters of the allocation problem. Every axis is a disagreement about one of five things: what is being divided, who is in the game, how much the rules cover, whether the founding is justified, or how the order should change. These five families generate all the major axes we observe.

Object axes

Object axes are about what is divided. The economic left-right axis is the paradigmatic case: the left wants to de-rig the economic foundation, the right wants to defend it. The materialist-postmaterialist axis is about which shares matter: as material shares become secure, the resource

set expands to identity, autonomy, and recognition. The green-growth axis extends the resource set even further, to environmental goods and future generations. The green axis is special because it brings in players who cannot contest—future generations and non-human nature—which is why it requires trustees, people who speak for the voiceless.

Boundary axes

Boundary axes are about who is in the game. The globalist-nationalist axis is a disagreement about membership: is the foundation for citizens, or for all affected parties? Expanding membership is structurally a refounding, because the foundation was laid for a smaller set—which is why the axis is so bitter. It is not a debate within the rules; it is a debate about who the rules are for. The hawk-dove axis is about whether other states are rival or cooperative contenders, and here the framework's nonzero-sum theorem applies directly: if the international foundation is live, doves are right; if it is fixed, hawks may be. The urban-rural and young-old axes are not disagreements about a parameter but structural positions: different players, with different resources and different relationships to the foundation.

Rule-scope axes

Rule-scope axes are about how much is governed by rules. The libertarian-authoritarian axis is a disagreement about the domain of the allocation: should it be minimal, leaving most claims to private allocation, or thick, covering most of life with collective rules? The federal-unitary axis is about the level at which rules are made. Both answer to the decomposition theorem: decentralization adds value when issues are separable, centralization when they are coupled.

Foundation-legitimacy axes

Foundation-legitimacy axes are about whether the founding is justified. The progressive-conservative axis is structurally identical to economic left-right, but over cultural shares: the progressive sees the cultural foundation as rigged and wants to refound it; the conservative sees it as established and wants to preserve it. This is why the two axes correlate—they are the same structure over different shares. The populist-elitist axis is a re-rigging axis: the populist claims the foundation has been captured by a new elite; the elitist defends the current coalition. The framework predicts that populist refoundings will re-rig rather than anti-rig, because populism is a de-rigging movement without an anti-rigging program. The religious-secular axis is the most structurally distinctive: it is a disagreement about the mode of founding, but a special one, because the religious view treats the founding as outside the four modes—as divine ordination rather than force, agreement, convention, or accident. The framework cannot adjudicate, because it has no category for transcendent authority. It can only note that the religious view refuses the regress, while the secular view lives with it.

Method axes

Method axes are about how to change. Reform-revolution is a disagreement about whether the rigging is self- reinforcing: if it is, reform is blocked and refounding is the only path; if it is not, reform is sufficient and refounding is dangerous. Moderate-radical is a disagreement about the coupling of issues: moderate when issues are separable, radical when they are coupled.

Why the axes correlate

Why do the axes correlate? Because the layers correlate. The beneficiaries of a rigged economic foundation tend to defend the cultural foundation, to prefer the within-rules game, and to see the founding as legitimate. But the correlation is not identity. A person can be economically left and culturally conservative, or vice versa. The composite is stable because the positions tend to correlate, not because they are identical.

Three predictions

What does the framework predict? Three things.

First, new axes will emerge as new resources become scarce. As data, attention, and identity become scarce, new object axes emerge around them. The framework predicts these will fit the same structural pattern: de-rigging vs. foundation-defending over the new resource.

Second, foundation-legitimacy axes will intensify as the rigging becomes more visible. As inequality increases and the disadvantaged become more aware of the foundation, the foundation-legitimacy axes will become more salient relative to the object axes. The framework predicts the rise of "identity" and "post-material" politics not because material politics has ended but because the foundation has become more contested.

Third, method axes will become more salient as reform is blocked. As rigging becomes more self-reinforcing, reform- revolution and moderate-radical will become more salient. The framework predicts the rise of anti-system politics not because people are irrational but because the system is structurally blocked.

The framework does not tell you which axis is correct. It tells you what each axis is about. That is what a grammar can do, and it is enough.

Key idea. Every political axis is a disagreement about one of five things: what is divided, who plays, how much the rules cover, whether the founding is justified, or how change happens.

Contention is not the same as difficulty

Having seen the deepest contention—the struggle over rules and their founding—let us step back and ask a more basic question: how does contention actually work, and where does it live?

Most of us assume that a situation is hard in proportion to how many people are involved. A solo decision is easy; a group decision is hard; a crowded room is harder still. This is false, and the framework shows why.

One person, intense contention

A single person can face a problem of intense contention. Consider someone deciding how to spend the next decade of their life. The resources are time, attention, energy, and the one body they have. The claims are a career, a relationship, a craft, a cause, a family, a rest. These claims contend. The person cannot have all of them in full. The contention is real, rival, and consequential, even though there is only one person in the room. The struggle is not against anyone. It is the struggle of a single life trying to allocate itself.

Many people, shallow contention

Conversely, a situation with millions of people can be almost entirely coordinative, and therefore not strategically difficult in the usual sense. Two hundred million drivers on a road network are not fighting each other. They are following a convention. The contention is enormous in scale and shallow in depth. Nobody is trying to take anyone's share. They are trying to agree, and they mostly succeed.

The contention map

So the real question is not how many people are involved. It is what is the pattern of contention. This pattern has a

shape, and the shape can be drawn. Imagine a network with each person as a dot. Draw an edge between two people when they rival-contend over some resource; draw a different edge when they cooperative-contend; draw a third when they coordinate. What you get is a map of the situation. Some regions of the map are dense with rivalry. Some are dense with cooperation. Some are sparse. Some are silent.

Difficulty is localized

That map is what actually determines how hard a situation is. Strategic difficulty is not spread evenly. It lives in the connected clusters of active contention. Everything outside those clusters is something else—a decision problem, a coordination problem, a matter of taste. A firm with fifty divisions may have strategic contention in only three of them; the other forty-seven are run by routine. A country with a hundred policy domains may have genuine political struggle in a handful; the rest are administered. A person with a dozen goals may have real contention among three; the other nine are compatible or irrelevant.

This is the single most useful consequence of the framework: strategic difficulty is localized. If you want to understand a situation, do not survey everything. Find the active clusters. Ask what is being contended, by whom, under what rules, and how hard people are struggling. Most of the noise is elsewhere.

> **Key idea.** Strategic difficulty is localized: find the active clusters of contention, and most of the noise is elsewhere.

Struggle costs something

The framework also reminds us of something easy to forget: struggle costs.

Struggle is an allocation

To struggle is to expend effort, and effort is finite. A person has only so much attention to spend on conflict. A firm has only so much managerial energy, legal budget, and political capital. A country has only so much public patience. This means that struggle is itself an allocation problem. You cannot struggle everywhere, so you must choose where to struggle—and where to concede.

The portfolio view

Most people do not think of their conflicts this way. They experience each fight as a fight, and each one seems to demand full commitment. But a strategist sees a portfolio. Some struggles are worth the cost. Some are not. Some are worth fighting with someone against a shared obstacle. Some are worth fighting over the rules of the game itself. Some are worth conceding early, to preserve effort for the fights that matter.

The diagnostic question

This is why the framework is not merely descriptive. It is diagnostic. When you feel overwhelmed by conflict—at work, at home, in public life—the useful question is not "how do I win all of these?" It is "which of these are the real ones?" The active struggle network is almost always smaller than the noise suggests. Conceding the periphery to concentrate on the center is not weakness. It is allocation.

> **Key idea.** Struggle is itself an allocation: concede the periphery to concentrate on the centre.

The three arenas

The framework's reach is wide because its vocabulary is the vocabulary of ordinary life. Three arenas show this clearly.

Personal life

A person allocating time across work, health, relationships, learning, and rest is solving a problem with one player and many claims. The shares are hours, attention, and energy. The claims are the demands of each part of life. The contention is often intense, even though it involves a single person. The struggle is the daily effort of resisting distraction, keeping commitments, and choosing what to let go.

The framework's advice here is precise. Goals that rival-contend for the same resource—deep work and social media both claiming the same attention, for instance—will not be resolved by willpower alone. They require a rule: a commitment device, a schedule, a friction, a boundary. Willpower is a resource, and it depletes; rules do not. Goals that are cooperative or coordinative—exercise and sleep, a morning routine, a shared household rhythm—require not willpower but alignment. They are not struggles at all, once arranged.

This is a genuinely different way of thinking about self-control. Instead of asking "how do I become stronger?" it asks "what rule would make this easy?" The second question is often answerable. The first is often not.

And there is a deeper version of the same point. The conditions you were born into—your family, your country, your body, your era—are the foundation of your personal order. You did not lay them. They are rigged in your favor in some

ways and against you in others, and the rigging tracks nothing you did. Recognizing this is not a counsel of resentment. It is a counsel of realism. You can work within the foundation, and occasionally, at great cost, refound some small part of it. You cannot pretend the foundation is not there.

Politics

Political life is contention in its most visible form. Shares include budget, authority, legitimacy, agenda control, and votes. Claims are made by voters, parties, bureaucracies, interest groups, and courts. Struggles take the form of campaigns, lobbying, litigation, and protest. Rules include constitutions, electoral systems, legislative procedure, and federalism.

The framework's first insight is that rule contention is meta-contention. The most consequential political struggles are not over a single allocation but over the rules that determine all allocations. Constitutional design, districting, procedural reform—these are contests over the shape of future contests. They are deeper than ordinary politics because they set the terms on which ordinary politics will be played.

The second insight is that coalitions are cooperative contention. Parties that agree on goals but disagree on shares form coalitions that are stable only when the agreement is credible. The stability of a coalition is not a matter of sentiment; it is a matter of whether each member would rather stay than leave. This is why coalitions break—not because people stop liking each other, but because the terms of cooperation stop being worth it to someone.

The third insight is that decomposition localizes conflict. Many political fights are strategically separable: what happens in one policy domain does not much affect another. The contention map shows which domains are genuinely coupled and which are artificially bundled. This is useful both for reformers, who can often make progress by unbundling, and for defenders, who can often protect a position by keeping it bundled with something popular.

The fourth insight is that the deepest struggle is over the foundation, and the foundation may be rigged. Beneath rule contention lies contention over who founds the rules. When the foundation is rigged—malapportionment, gerrymandering, entrenchment of particular interests—the disadvantaged contest the foundation itself, and the beneficiaries defend it. The rules that would resolve the contest are the very rules in dispute.

And the fifth insight is that revolution is the de-rigging mechanism of last resort. When rigging is self-reinforcing and within-rules reform is blocked, refounding is the only remaining path. The framework explains revolutions as structurally necessary under these conditions. It does not justify any particular revolution, because every refounding carries its own legitimacy deficit and risks re-rigging. The normative question requires a theory of justice that the framework does not supply.

Business

A firm allocates capital, capacity, talent, data, and attention across markets and functions, while rivals, suppliers, and regulators do the same. Shares include market share, margin, talent, data, and customer attention. Claims are investments, hires, prices, product moves. Rules include contracts, auctions, market structure, and regulation. Struggles are price competition, advertising spend, litigation, and lobbying.

The framework's first strategic question for a business is: which resources are rival-contended? Rivalry over customer attention, talent, and capacity produces different dynamics than cooperation over complementary assets. A firm that mistakes a cooperative relationship for a rivalry, or a rivalry for a coordination problem, will misallocate its effort. The contention map tells you which game you are in.

The second question is: what is the allocation mapping? Strategy is often the design of the

rules, not just the choice of moves within them. Platform rules, pricing mechanisms, supply contracts—these are the firm's way of shaping how claims become shares. The firm that designs the game it plays has an advantage over the firm that merely plays well.

The third question is: when does strategy decompose? Multi-business firms can often be decomposed into strategically separable units. Central coordination adds value when contention is coupled—when decisions in one unit genuinely affect another. It adds only overhead when contention is separable. Knowing which is which is the difference between a focused firm and a conglomerate that has mistaken its own complexity for strategy.

The fourth question is: what is the founding, and is it rigged? The incorporation—the charter, the cap table, the governance—is the first allocation of the firm. Founder shares, dual-class stock, board composition, and anti-takeover provisions are devices that encode the founder's advantage into the corporate constitution. Founder disputes are bitter because they are about the foundation, not about ordinary management. Governance reforms are contested for the

same reason, and they often fail because the rigged foundation gives the beneficiaries the procedural rights to block de-rigging. "Who decides" is a deeper question than "what is decided," and "who decided the founding" is deeper still.

The fifth question is: is the competitive game zero-sum? Rarely. A firm that mistakes a live founder advantage for a fixed pie—its own or a rival's—will misread the strategic situation. Markets are rival at the margin but nonzero-sum over their foundations: regulation, standards, market structure, and technology shift the total, not merely its division. A firm that invests in shaping these foundations is playing the over-rules game; one that only optimizes within them is playing the within-rules game. Both can be correct, but confusing the two is a strategic error.

Key idea. Whether in personal life, politics, or business, the moves are the same: name the share, map the contention, look at the rules, look at the foundation.

The honest limits

It would be dishonest to present this framework as a theory of everything, and the honest version is more useful anyway.

A lens, not a law

First, the framework is a lens, not a law. It does not tell you what will happen. It tells you what to look at. The same situation can be described as a struggle over shares, a coordination problem, a signaling game, or a matter of taste, and the right description depends on the situation. The framework earns its keep when allocation and contention are the salient features—which is often, but not always.

Organizing, not explaining

Second, the framework does not explain human behavior. It organizes it. Why people want the shares they want, why they struggle as hard as they do, why they sometimes prefer conflict to settlement—these are questions for psychology, anthropology, and ethics. The framework tells you where to look; it does not tell you what you will find.

Descriptive, not normative

Third, the framework is descriptive, not normative. It can help you see that an allocation is inefficient or that a rule favors some claimants over others. It cannot tell you what a just allocation would be. That requires a theory of justice, which the framework can inform but cannot replace. The problem of first allocation sharpens this: the legitimacy deficit of every founding means that no purely procedural theory of justice can fully ground itself. Normative theory must confront the founding, not merely the rules that follow from it.

Bracketing the first allocation

Fourth, the framework brackets the first allocation. It takes the rules as given or chosen and derives allocations from them. It cannot tell you how the rules came to be, who founded them, whether the founding is legitimate, or how foundations change. This is a genuine limit, not a minor one. The legitimacy of any allocation depends on the legitimacy of the rules, and the legitimacy of the rules depends on the founding. A complete theory would need to say how first allocations are made, justified, and changed. The framework identifies where that theory is needed; it does not supply it.

Structural, not exhaustive

Fifth, the framework's account of political axes is structural, not exhaustive. It explains why the axes exist and what they are about. It does not explain why any particular person holds any particular view. That requires psychology, socialization, and interest, which the framework does not supply.

None of these limits is fatal. Every useful lens has them. What matters is whether the lens shows you something the naked eye misses. This one does.

> **Key idea.** The framework is a lens, not a law: it shows you what to look at, but it cannot supply a theory of justice.

What to do with it

Six habits

If the framework is useful, it should change how you look at the world. Six habits follow.

1. **Name the share.** When you encounter a conflict, ask what is actually being divided. It is often not what the participants say. A fight about money may be a fight about recognition. A fight about recognition may be a fight about time. Naming the share is the beginning of understanding.

2. **Map the contention.** Ask who is coupled with whom, and over what. Ask whether the coupling is rival, cooperative, or coordinative. Ask which clusters are active and which are latent. The map is usually smaller and clearer than the noise.

3. **Look at the rules.** Ask what determines how claims become shares. Ask who set the rules and why. Ask whether the rules are the real stakes. They often are.

4. **Look at the foundation.** Ask where the rules themselves came from. Ask who founded the order and in what mode—force, agreement, convention, or accident. Ask what legitimacy deficit the founding carries, and whether that deficit is still being paid. The foundation is the deepest layer, and it is the one most people never see.

5. **Ask whether the game is rigged.** Ask who benefits from the foundation. Ask whether the beneficiaries hold the procedural rights to block reform. Ask whether the advantage is self-reinforcing. Ask whether what looks like a fair competition is being played on a field that was tilted at the founding. This is the question that reframes every zero-sum argument you encounter, and it is the question that most people never ask.

6. **Count the cost.** Ask where your effort is best spent. Ask what you can concede to concentrate on what matters. Ask whether the struggle you are in is one you chose or one you fell into. Struggle is finite. Spend it where it counts.

These six habits are not a formula. They are a discipline. They will not tell you what to do. They will help you see what you are doing.

Key idea. Six habits—name the share, map the contention, look at the rules, look at the foundation, ask whether it is rigged, count the cost—turn the grammar into a discipline.

Coda

The family arguing about Sunday evening, the firm fighting over next year's budget, the legislature fighting over the shape of the state—these are not separate phenomena. They are variations on a single pattern. People make claims on shares. The claims contend. The contention produces struggle. The struggle is shaped by rules. The rules are laid by founders. The founders rest on foundations that no rule can fully justify. And the foundations are usually rigged, in favor of some and against others, in ways that persist.

This is not a counsel of cynicism. It is a counsel of clarity. To see that life is full of contention is not to see that life is only contention. Much of what makes life good—cooperation, coordination, love, craft, shared purpose—is not rival at all. The framework's point is not that everything is a fight. It is that fights have structure, and that structure can be seen. Once seen, it can be navigated. Once navigated, it can sometimes be transcended.

A game, in the end, is a struggle over shares, under rules, where what each player gets depends on what everyone claims. That sentence is not the whole of human life. But it is more of human life than we usually admit—and admitting it is the first step toward playing the game better, and, occasionally, toward changing it.

And the deepest change is not winning within the rules. It is laying new foundations—which is what every founder, every constitution, every fresh start has always been. The field can be relaid. But a relaying that does not change the terms of laying merely resets the board for the next founder. The question is not only whose advantage should be removed but what structure should make the next advantage harder to lay. The game is played on a field that someone laid, and the laying of the field is not itself a move in the game. But it is the most consequential thing that ever happens in it.

And when you stand on the field and ask why some are born with the wind at their backs and others against them, the answer is not in the game. It is in the founding. The left and the right are two ways of answering that question, and neither is complete. The deepest politics is not the contest between them. It is the question they both ask, in different accents: who laid this field, and on what terms may it be laid again?

Key idea. The deepest politics is one question asked in two accents: who laid this field, and on what terms may it be laid again?

Struggle for Reform: A Theory of Rigging, De-Rigging, Anti-Rigging, and the Structural Conditions of Durable Change

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Abstract

The struggle for reform is the effort to *re-form*—to give a new form to the foundation of an order. This paper develops a theory of that struggle. It builds on the Contested Strategic Allocation framework and distinguishes four concepts that are often conflated: *foundation rigging* (the initial advantage a founding confers on the founder's

coalition), *de-rigging* (the elimination of a specific advantage), *anti-rigging* (structural provisions that raise the cost of future rigging), and *re-rigging* (the replacement of one advantage with another). The four concepts form a 2×2 matrix that classifies every reform and predicts its durability. The central claim is that most reforms fail short because they de-rig without anti-rigging: they remove the old advantage but do not change the form that produced it, and the result is a re-rigging, often within a generation. The paper shows that the Glorious Revolution of 1688 and the American Constitution succeeded because they combined de-rigging with anti-rigging; that the French and Russian Revolutions failed because they did not; and that the difference is structural, not moral. It then develops a theory of anti-rigging provisions—the structural design that makes future rigging harder—and specifies the conditions under which such provisions are effective rather than nominal. It concludes with implications for revolutionaries, reformers within the rules, and constitution-writers.

Keywords: reform, re-formation, revolution, rigging, de-rigging, anti-rigging, re-rigging, refounding, durable change, constitutional design, political struggle

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1 Introduction

The struggle for reform is the oldest political activity. It is the effort by which those who are disadvantaged by the existing order seek to change it. It takes many forms: petition, protest, litigation, legislation, constitutional amendment, revolution. It is conducted by many actors: reformers, revolutionaries, constitution-writers, corporate governance activists, family mediators. It has many outcomes: success, failure, partial success, unintended consequence.

The word *reform* carries the theory. To reform is to *re-form*—to give a new form to something, to change its shape, to restore or transform its structure. The object of the verb is the *form*, not the content. A reform that leaves the form intact is not a reform in the strict sense; it is a reallocation. A reform that changes the form is a re-founding, even if it happens gradually, legally, and without a shot fired.

This paper develops a theory of the struggle for reform in this strict sense: the effort to *re-form* the foundation of an order. It builds on the Contested Strategic Allocation (CSA) framework, and it distinguishes four concepts that are often conflated:

(1) *Foundation rigging*—the initial advantage that a founding confers on the founder's coalition.

(2) *De-rigging*—the elimination of a specific advantage.

(3) *Anti-rigging*—structural provisions that raise the cost of future rigging.

(4) *Re-rigging*—the replacement of one advantage with another.

The central claim is that *most reforms fail short because they de-rig without anti-rigging.* The reform removes the specific advantage of the old coalition, but it does not change the form that produced that

advantage. The result is a *re-rigging*—the replacement of one advantage with another—often within a generation.

The claim is not a counsel of despair. Some reforms succeed—they de-rig *and* anti-rig—and the paper analyzes the cases where they do. But the general pattern is clear: the struggle for reform is a struggle over form, and a struggle that does not change the form is a struggle that will be repeated.

1.1 Relation to the CSA framework

This paper is an extension of the Contested Strategic Allocation framework. The framework treats games as struggles over shares, under rules, where what each player gets depends on what everyone claims. It identifies the *foundation* as the rules that are not themselves settled by any prior rule, and it identifies the *first allocation* as the allocation of rule-making authority itself.

The framework's central limit is that it brackets the problem of first allocation: it takes the foundation as given and derives allocations from it. The present paper takes up the question the framework brackets: what happens when the foundation is *contested*? When the disadvantaged coalition seeks to change the foundation, what determines whether the change is durable?

The answer, as we will see, is anti-rigging. The framework says that de-rigging without anti-rigging merely resets the board. This paper develops the argument in detail, defines the four concepts, and specifies the design conditions under which a reform is durable.

1.2 Contributions

(1) A definitional framework for four concepts that are often conflated: foundation rigging, de-rigging, anti-rigging, and re-rigging (§2).

(2) A 2×2 matrix that classifies every reform and predicts its durability (§3).

(3) A theory of why most revolutions fall short (§4).

(4) A theory of anti-rigging provisions—the structural design that makes future rigging harder (§5).

(5) An analysis of effectiveness criteria and the nominality problem (§6).

(6) Case studies of the Glorious Revolution, the French Revolution, the American Constitution, and the Russian Revolution (§7).

(7) Implications for revolutionaries, reformers within the rules, and constitution-writers (§8).

2 The Four Concepts

The theory rests on four concepts. This section defines them precisely.

2.1 The etymology of reform

The word *reform* comes from the Latin *reformare*—to form again, to restore to a former shape, to transform. It has carried this double sense—restoration and transformation—since it entered English in the fourteenth century. The object of the verb is the *form*.

This is why the word is exact for the framework. A reform is not a transfer of shares (that is reallocation), a change of players (that is substitution), or a win within the rules (that is competition). A reform is a change in the *form*—the structure, the foundation, the terms on which shares are allocated.

The four concepts of the framework are operations on form:

- *Foundation rigging* is the form as laid: the initial advantage encoded in the foundation.
- *De-rigging* is the removal of the old form's advantage.
- *Anti-rigging* is the change in the terms of laying that makes future forms harder to rig.
- *Re-rigging* is the replacement of one form's advantage with another's.

The struggle for reform is the struggle over form. It is not a struggle over shares; it is a struggle over the terms on which shares are laid.

2.2 Foundation rigging

Definition 2.1 (Foundation rigging)**.** A foundation M^* is *rigged* relative to a benchmark M^0 if there exists a coalition $S \subseteq \mathcal{N}$ and a vector $\alpha(M^*, M^0)$ such that:

(i) $\alpha_i(M^*, M^0) > 0$ for all $i \in S$;

(ii) $\alpha_j(M^*, M^0) < 0$ for some $j \notin S$; and

(iii) the pattern of advantage tracks the identity of the founder (or the founder's coalition) rather than efficiency, desert, or any founder-independent criterion.

The coalition S is the *beneficiary coalition*, and α is the *rigging vector*.

Foundation rigging is the initial advantage that a founding confers on some coalition. It is the original sin of the order, laid at the moment of founding. It is structural: the foundation itself carries the advantage. It is persistent: a self-reinforcing rigging survives within-rules reform. It is asymmetric: the disadvantaged can see it, and the beneficiaries can usually ignore it.

2.3 De-rigging

Definition 2.2 (De-rigging)**.** A refounding M' of a rigged foundation M^* is a *de-rigging* if it eliminates the specific advantage of the beneficiary coalition S: $\alpha_i(M', M^0) \leq 0$ for all $i \in S$, with strict inequality for at least one $i \in S$.

De-rigging is the removal of a specific advantage. It is what the disadvantaged coalition seeks. It is necessary but not sufficient for durable change: a de-rigging refounding may still be a re-rigging if it installs a new advantage in place of the old one.

2.4 Anti-rigging

Definition 2.3 (Anti-rigging)**.** A refounding M' of a rigged foundation M^* includes *anti-rigging* if there exists a set of provisions $\mathcal{A}$ in M' such that the expected cost of future rigging is strictly higher under M' than under M^*: $\mathbb{E}[\text{cost of rigging} \mid M', \mathcal{A}] > \mathbb{E}[\text{cost of rigging} \mid M^*]$. The provisions $\mathcal{A}$ are the *anti-rigging provisions*.

Anti-rigging is not the removal of a specific advantage; it is the change in the *terms of laying* that makes future rigging more costly. It can be present even when de-rigging is absent (partial anti-rigging), and it can be absent even when de-rigging is present (fragile de-rigging).

2.5 Re-rigging

Definition 2.4 (Re-rigging)**.** A refounding M' of a rigged foundation M^* is a *re-rigging* if there exists a coalition $S' \subseteq \mathcal{N}$ such that:

(i) M' is rigged (Definition 2.1) in favor of S';

(ii) $S' \neq S$—the beneficiary coalition has changed; and

(iii) M' preserves the structural features of rigging (explicit favoritism, path dependence, information asymmetry, status-quo bias, or coordinative selection).

Re-rigging is the replacement of one rigging with another. The old elite is replaced; the structure that produced the old rigging is intact. The beneficiary coalition changes; the rigging does not.

3 The 2×2 Matrix

The four concepts form a 2×2 matrix according to whether a reform includes de-rigging (removal of the current advantage) and anti-rigging (raising the cost of future rigging).

	De-rigging	**No de-rigging**
Anti-rigging	Durable de-rigging	Partial anti-rigging
No anti-rigging	Fragile de-rigging	Re-rigging

The matrix is the conceptual core of the theory. Every reform can be placed in one of its four cells, and the cell predicts its durability. We analyze each cell in turn.

3.1 Durable de-rigging

A reform that de-rigs and anti-rigs is a *durable de-rigging*. It eliminates the old advantage and raises the cost of new rigging.

Proposition 3.1 (Durable de-rigging)**.** *A reform that both de-rigs and anti-rigs is a durable de-rigging: it*

eliminates the old advantage and raises the cost of new rigging. It is the only reform that can break the cycle of rigging and re-rigging.

Durable de-rigging is rare. The framework predicts that most reforms will fail to achieve it, because the reforming coalition has the power to rig and no incentive to anti-rig. The cases where it succeeds are the cases we remember.

3.2 Fragile de-rigging

A reform that de-rigs but does not anti-rig is a *fragile de-rigging*. It eliminates the old advantage, but it does not change the structure that produced it. The reforming coalition has the power to lay a new advantage, and by the persistence proposition it will.

Proposition 3.2 (Fragile de-rigging risk)**.** *A reform that de-rigs but does not anti-rig is at risk of re-rigging: if the reforming coalition has the power to lay a new advantage, it will, and the result will be a re-rigging.*

Fragile de-rigging is the most common failure mode. Most revolutions remove the old advantage but do not change the structure. The revolutionary coalition becomes the new beneficiary coalition, with the same procedural rights as the old one. The result is a re-rigging, often within a generation.

3.3 Partial anti-rigging

A reform that anti-rigs but does not de-rig is a *partial anti-rigging*. It raises the cost of *new* rigging but does not eliminate the *old* rigging.

Proposition 3.3 (Partial anti-rigging)**.** *A reform that anti-rigs but does not de-rig raises the cost of new rigging but does not eliminate the old rigging.*

Partial anti-rigging is better than fragile de-rigging, but it leaves the old injustice in place. Some gradualist reforms fit this pattern: they add anti-rigging provisions to the existing foundation without removing the existing advantage.

3.4 Re-rigging

A reform that neither de-rigs nor anti-rigs is a *re-rigging*: it replaces one advantage with another while preserving the structural features of rigging.

Proposition 3.4 (Re-rigging)**.** *A reform that neither de-rigs nor anti-rigs is a re-rigging: the beneficiary coalition changes, but the structure that produced the rigging is intact.*

Re-rigging is the failure mode where the old advantage is replaced by a new one, but the structure of the game is unchanged. The players have changed.

4 Why Most Revolutions Fall Short

The framework gives four reasons why most revolutions fall short, and they are structural, not moral.

4.1 Reason 1: The revolutionary coalition is a coalition of claimants

A revolution is not made by a single actor. It is made by a coalition— sometimes an alliance of classes, sometimes an alliance of factions, sometimes an alliance of convenience. The coalition agrees on the de-rigging: the old foundation must go. It does not agree on what comes next.

The revolutionary coalition that overthrew the French monarchy included the bourgeoisie, the sans-culottes, the peasantry, and the provincial notables. These groups had different interests, different visions, and different claims. The Jacobin dictatorship, the Thermidorian reaction, and the Napoleonic empire were not accidents. They were the resolution of a coalition that could not agree on the terms of the new foundation.

The framework predicts this. The coalition that de-rigs is a coalition of the disadvantaged, but the disadvantaged are not homogeneous. They are disadvantaged by *different* riggings, and they have *different* interests in the new foundation. A coalition that can agree on the de-rigging may not be able to agree on the refounding.

4.2 Reason 2: The revolutionary coalition has the power to rig

The coalition that overthrows the old order holds the power to lay the new foundation. It has the arms, the organization, and the legitimacy of victory. It can write the rules however it wants.

The framework predicts that it will write the rules to its own advantage. This is not a moral failing; it is a structural consequence of the situation. The coalition holds the power to rig, and

the persistence proposition says that a coalition with the power to rig will use it— because the alternative is to leave itself vulnerable to a future de-rigging.

The only way to prevent this is to *remove the power to rig from the revolutionary coalition itself*—through self-limitation, through dispersal, through the anti-rigging provisions described in §5. This is hard to achieve, and it requires the revolutionary coalition to act against its own interest.

4.3 Reason 3: The revolutionary coalition fears the counter-revolution

The reforming coalition is usually surrounded by enemies. The old elite is plotting restoration. Foreign powers may intervene. Internal factions may defect. The coalition feels besieged, and the siege justifies extraordinary measures.

The framework predicts that a besieged coalition will entrench itself. It will acquire emergency powers, suspend normal procedures, and consolidate authority. Each of these is a step toward re-rigging. The siege is real, but the response to the siege is also a re-rigging.

The anti-rigging provisions must be designed to survive the siege. This requires provisions that are *triggered* by the siege itself—for example, sunset clauses that come into force after a specified period, or

review mechanisms that are activated when emergency powers are invoked. These provisions constrain the coalition's ability to use the siege as a justification for re-rigging.

4.4 Reason 4: The revolutionary coalition does not know how to anti-rig

The final reason is the simplest. Anti-rigging is a design problem, and most revolutionaries are not designers. They know how to overthrow; they do not know how to build. They write constitutions that encode their values and their interests, but they do not write provisions that constrain their own power.

The framework's contribution is to specify what anti-rigging looks like. The next section develops a catalogue of provisions.

5 The Theory of Anti-Rigging

5.1 The design problem

Given a rigged foundation M^* and a reforming coalition that wants to de-rig it, the design problem is to choose structural provisions $\mathcal{A}$ for the new foundation M' such that:

(1) the specific advantage of the old beneficiary coalition is eliminated (de-rigging);

(2) future rigging is harder (anti-rigging);

(3) the new foundation does not become a new rigging (the anti-rigging paradox);

(4) the new foundation remains functional.

This is a constrained optimization problem with four constraints: *effectiveness*, *functionality*, *legitimacy*, and *self-limitation*.

5.2 The anti-rigging paradox and its resolution

The reforming coalition is itself a founder. By the legitimacy deficit proposition, the new foundation cannot fully justify itself by the standards it establishes—including the standard that rigging is wrong. If the anti-rigging provisions are strong enough to prevent future rigging, they are strong enough to entrench the reforming coalition. If they are weak enough to avoid entrenching it, they are too weak to prevent future rigging.

Remark 5.1 (The anti-rigging paradox). Every anti-rigging reform faces a paradox: provisions strong enough to prevent re-rigging are strong enough to re-rig by the reforming coalition; provisions weak enough to avoid this are too weak to prevent re-rigging.

The resolution is *self-limitation*: the reforming coalition binds itself with the same provisions it binds its successors.

Definition 5.2 (Self-limiting reform)**.** A reform M' is *self-limiting* if its anti-rigging provisions apply to the reforming coalition as effectively as to its successors. Formally, let $\mathcal{A}_0 \subseteq \mathcal{A}$ be the provisions

applying to the reformers and $\mathcal{A}_1 \subseteq \mathcal{A}$ those applying to their successors. Self-limitation requires $|\mathcal{A}_0| \geq |\mathcal{A}_1|$ and $\text{Enforcement}(\mathcal{A}_0) \geq \text{Enforcement}(\mathcal{A}_1)$.

Self-limitation does not eliminate the legitimacy deficit—the reforming coalition still founded the rules, and every founding carries a deficit. But it reduces the deficit, because a self-limiting reform does not claim an exemption from the standard it imposes.

5.3 Structural provisions

Anti-rigging provisions work through six mechanisms:

(1) **Temporal limits.** Sunset clauses, mandatory review, generational accounting. Provisions that allocate advantage expire unless renewed, and renewal requires the consent of those who would be disadvantaged.

(2) **Concentration limits.** Rotation, sortition, term limits, anti-concentration rules. No coalition holds rule-making authority indefinitely.

(3) **Transparency.** Disclosure, audit, public reasoning. Allocation decisions are visible to those affected.

(4) **Entrenchment asymmetry.** Anti-rigging provisions are harder to remove than ordinary rules but not impossible to remove. The target is a ratio: amendment of an anti-rigging provision requires a supermajority, but amendment of the supermajority requirement requires the same supermajority.

(5) **Dispersal.** Federalism, separation of powers, overlapping trustees. No single coalition captures all rule-making authority.

(6) **Contestability.** Legal standing, referendum, recall. Any affected party can challenge allocation decisions.

No single provision satisfies all four constraints. A *portfolio* of provisions—at least one from each mechanism family—can jointly satisfy them, with each provision compensating for the weaknesses of the others.

6 Effectiveness and the Nominality Problem

6.1 The effectiveness criteria

An anti-rigging provision is *effective* if it satisfies three conditions:

(i) **Bite.** It actually constrains behavior.

(ii) **Cost.** It raises the cost of rigging.

(iii) **Asymmetry.** It imposes a greater cost on the rigger than on the anti-rigger.

A provision that does not bite is decoration. A provision that does not raise the cost is symbolic. A provision that constrains everyone equally is ineffective if the rigger has more resources to bear the cost.

6.2 The nominality problem

Many anti-rigging provisions are nominal. Sunset clauses that are routinely renewed. Transparency provisions that disclose nothing consequential. Entrenchment that is never tested. This is the *nominality problem*: the appearance of anti-rigging without its substance.

The nominality problem is the central practical challenge for anti-rigging theory. A framework that does not address it will produce anti-rigging provisions that look good on paper but do not work in practice.

6.3 Partial solutions

There are partial solutions to the nominality problem:

(1) **Multiple triggers.** A provision triggered by several conditions cannot be evaded by satisfying just one.

(2) **Third-party enforcement.** A provision enforced by parties other than those it constrains cannot be evaded by capture.

(3) **Visible non-compliance.** A provision whose violation is itself visible and costly cannot be evaded silently.

(4) **Sunset on the sunset.** A sunset clause that itself sunsets cannot be renewed indefinitely.

These are partial. A full solution to the nominality problem is an open research question. But the direction is clear: anti-rigging provisions must be designed to bite, to cost, and to impose asymmetric costs on the rigger.

6.4 A formal sketch

Let $\mathcal{A}$ be the set of anti-rigging provisions in a reform M'. The design problem is

$$\max_{\mathcal{A}} \ \mathbb{E}[\text{durability}] \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \begin{cases} \text{Effectiveness}(\mathcal{A}) \geq \epsilon, \\ \text{Functionality}(\mathcal{A}) \geq \phi, \\ \text{Legitimacy}(\mathcal{A}) \geq \lambda, \\ \text{Self-limitation}(\mathcal{A}) \geq \sigma. \end{cases}$$

Define the *re-rigging hazard* $h(t)$ as the instantaneous probability that a new rigging occurs at time t after a reform. The central claim is

$$h(t \mid \mathcal{A}) \ < \ h(t \mid \varnothing) \quad \text{for all } t.$$

This is not proved, because the hazard function is not specified. It is the formal statement of the framework's central claim, and it points to the empirical question: measure the hazard in orders with and without anti-rigging portfolios.

7 Case Studies

7.1 The Glorious Revolution (1688): durable de-rigging

The Glorious Revolution is the paradigm case of durable de-rigging. James II was overthrown; the Catholic monarchy was replaced by a Protestant one; the specific advantage of the old beneficiary coalition—the Catholic aristocracy, the royal prerogative, the dispensing power—was eliminated.

What distinguishes the Glorious Revolution is its anti-rigging. The Bill of Rights of 1689 established parliamentary supremacy, free elections, freedom of speech in Parliament, and the prohibition of royal interference with the law. The Act of Settlement of 1701 further constrained the monarchy and established the Protestant succession. These provisions included:

- *Temporal limits:* Parliament had to be summoned regularly.
- *Concentration limits:* The royal prerogative was curtailed, and the power to tax was placed under parliamentary control.
- *Transparency:* Parliamentary proceedings were made public.
- *Entrenchment asymmetry:* The Bill of Rights was made difficult to amend.
- *Dispersal:* Power was dispersed between the Crown, the Lords, and the Commons.
- *Contestability:* Elections were made free and regular.

The anti-rigging was self-limiting: it applied to the new monarchs as much as to their successors. The Bill of Rights constrained William and Mary from the moment they accepted the throne. There was no transition period in which the new monarchs were exempt.

The result was a structure in which re-rigging was harder than it would have been otherwise. The Glorious Revolution did not prevent all subsequent re-rigging—the eighteenth-century oligarchy, the nineteenth-century reform movements, and the twentieth-century welfare state were all responses to residual rigging the settlement left in place. But it did prevent the *total* re-rigging that the framework predicts in the absence of anti-rigging. That is what made it glorious.

7.2 The French Revolution (1789–1815): fragile de-rigging

The French Revolution is the paradigm case of fragile de-rigging. The monarchy was overthrown; the aristocracy was abolished; the specific advantage of the old beneficiary coalition—the nobility, the clergy, the royal administration—was eliminated.

But the revolutionary constitutions did not include the anti-rigging provisions that the Glorious Revolution included. There were no temporal limits on the revolutionary government, no concentration limits on the Committee of Public Safety, no transparency provisions for the Jacobin clubs, no entrenchment asymmetry, no dispersal of power across independent bodies, no contestability mechanisms that survived the Terror.

The result was predictable. The revolutionaries acquired emergency powers and never gave them up. The Committee of Public Safety became a dictatorship. The Directory became an oligarchy. Napoleon became an emperor. The Bourbon Restoration restored the monarchy. The July Monarchy installed a new king. The Second Republic became the Second Empire. Each of these transitions was a re-rigging.

The revolutionaries did not bind themselves with the provisions they imposed on others. The Committee of Public Safety claimed the emergency as a justification for extraordinary powers. The Napoleonic regime

claimed the revolutionary legitimacy as a justification for imperial power. Each of these was a failure of self-limitation.

7.3 The American Constitution (1787): durable de-rigging

The American Constitution is a second case of durable de-rigging. The British monarchy was overthrown; the colonial relationship was ended; the specific advantage of the British Crown—the royal prerogative, the colonial administration, the mercantilist system—was eliminated.

The Constitution included a portfolio of anti-rigging provisions:

- *Concentration limits:* Separation of powers, checks and balances, no single branch can dominate.
- *Dispersal:* Federalism, with power divided between the federal government and the states.
- *Contestability:* Elections, judicial review, the amendment process.
- *Entrenchment asymmetry:* The amendment process is difficult but not impossible.

The anti-rigging was self-limiting: it applied to the founders as much as to their successors. The framers of the Constitution were subject to the Constitution they wrote. There was no transition period in which they were exempt.

The American Constitution is the longest-surviving written constitution in the world. It is not without its riggings—the Three-Fifths Compromise, the Electoral College, the malapportionment of the Senate— but it has proven more durable than any comparable reform. The anti-rigging provisions are a major reason.

7.4 The Russian Revolution (1917–1991): re-rigging

The Russian Revolution is the paradigm case of re-rigging. The tsarist aristocracy was overthrown; the specific advantage of the old beneficiary coalition—the nobility, the Orthodox Church, the imperial bureaucracy—was eliminated.

But the Bolsheviks did not de-rig in the framework's sense. They replaced one advantage with another. The party elite, the nomenklatura, and the security services acquired procedural rights that were structurally identical to those of the old elite. The rigging changed hands; the structure was intact.

There was no anti-rigging. The Bolsheviks did not adopt sunset clauses, rotation, transparency, entrenchment asymmetry, dispersal, or contestability. They concentrated authority in the party, the Politburo, and the secret police. They suppressed opposition, abolished independent courts, and controlled the press. Each of these was a step toward re-rigging.

The result was a structure in which the new elite was as entrenched as the old one. The Soviet Union survived for seventy-four years—longer than the tsarist autocracy that preceded it, and longer than most revolutions. But it did not de-rig; it re-rigged. When it finally collapsed, it collapsed into a new rigging—the oligarchic capitalism of the 1990s—which was structurally identical to the old one. The Bolsheviks had replaced one elite with another; the new elite replaced the old one in turn. The game had not changed.

7.5 Comparative lessons

The four cases illustrate the four cells of the matrix:

Reform	De-rigging	Anti-rigging	Outcome
Glorious Revolution	Yes	Yes	Durable de-rigging
American Constitution	Yes	Yes	Durable de-rigging
French Revolution	Yes	No	Fragile de-rigging
Russian Revolution	No	No	Re-rigging

The pattern is clear. The reforms that included both de-rigging and anti-rigging were durable. The reform that included only de-rigging was fragile. The reform that included neither was a re-rigging. The framework predicts this pattern, and the historical record bears it out.

8 Implications for Reformers

8.1 For revolutionaries

The framework's message to revolutionaries is not a counsel of despair. It is a counsel of design.

A revolution can be glorious. It can achieve what it sets out to achieve—the overthrow of an unjust order, the de-rigging of a rigged foundation, the establishment of a new order. But a revolution that does not anti-rig will fall short. It will re-rig, often within a generation, and the new rigging will be as durable as the old one.

The design task is to build anti-rigging into the refounding from the start. This means:

(1) Design the anti-rigging before you take power.

(2) Make the anti-rigging self-limiting.

(3) Build the anti-rigging into the refounding moment.

(4) Design for the siege.

(5) Make the anti-rigging visible.

8.2 For reformers within the rules

The framework has an implication for reformers who work within the rules rather than seeking a refounding. *Anti-rigging reform* is possible: it is within-rules change that raises the cost of future rigging, without removing the current advantage.

Anti-rigging reform is often more durable than revolution, because it does not require a refounding and therefore does not carry the refounding's legitimacy deficit. It is also more modest: it does not claim to end the rigging, only to make future rigging harder.

The reformer who seeks anti-rigging reform should:

(1) Identify the structural features that make the current rigging self-reinforcing.

(2) Propose provisions that raise the cost of those features.

(3) Accept that the old advantage may persist.

(4) Focus on preventing the next one.

8.3 For constitution-writers

The framework has an implication for constitution-writers, who are engaged in the design of foundations. The framework's advice is:

(1) Do not assume that the constitution will be administered by people of good will. Design for the possibility of capture.

(2) Include anti-rigging provisions in the constitution itself, not just in ordinary legislation.

(3) Make the provisions self-limiting: apply them to the framers as much as to their successors.

(4) Build in review mechanisms that allow adaptation without allowing re-rigging.

(5) Make the provisions visible: the citizens must be able to see whether the provisions are being respected.

9 Discussion

9.1 Scope

The theory is a theory of *durable change*. It is useful exactly when the question is whether a reform will last. It is not a theory of which reforms are just, or which revolutions are justified, or what the content of a good constitution should be. Those questions require normative theory that the framework does not supply.

9.2 Relation to normative theory

The theory is descriptive and analytical. It can tell you that a reform that de-rigs without anti-rigging is likely to re-rig. It cannot tell you that anti-rigging is *just*. That requires a theory of justice.

But the theory can inform the normative question. It can tell you that a just reform that does not anti-rig will re-rig, and that an unjust one that does anti-rig may be durable. This is uncomfortable for both redistributionist and meritocratic accounts: it suggests that justice is not sufficient for durability, and that durability is not sufficient for justice. A complete theory would need both.

9.3 Open problems

The theory has several open problems:

(1) **The nominality problem.** A full solution to the nominality problem—the conditions under which anti-rigging provisions are actually enforced—remains open.

(2) **The effectiveness threshold.** The thresholds $(\epsilon, \phi, \lambda, \sigma)$ need calibration from historical data.

(3) **The hazard function.** The re-rigging hazard $h(t)$ needs specification and estimation.

(4) **The self-limitation mechanism.** How can the reforming coalition credibly bind itself? The framework says it must, but not how.

(5) **The trustee problem.** How can anti-rigging provisions protect voiceless players (future generations, non-human nature)?

These are the agenda for a formal anti-rigging theory.

10 Conclusion

The struggle for reform is the struggle to *re-form*—to give a new form to the foundation of an order. It is not the struggle over shares, or over players, or over wins within the rules. It is the struggle over the terms on which shares are allocated, players are counted, and rules are made.

The theory of this paper is that most reforms fail short because they de-rig without anti-rigging. The reform removes the specific advantage of the old coalition, but it does not change the form that produced that advantage. The result is a re-rigging—the replacement of one advantage with another—often within a generation.

The Glorious Revolution of 1688 succeeded because it combined de-rigging with anti-rigging. The American Constitution succeeded for the same reason. The French Revolution failed because it de-rigged without anti-rigging; it changed the players, not the form. The Russian Revolution failed even more completely: it re-rigged without de-rigging.

The lessons are not a counsel of despair. They are a counsel of design. A reform that de-rigs and anti-rigs is durable. A reform that does only one is fragile. The difference is in the form, not in the spirit. And form can be designed.

The word has been carrying the theory all along. To reform is to re-form. The struggle for reform is the struggle over form. It is the oldest political activity, and it is the deepest. The framework's contribution is to make it precise.

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Struggle for Reform

A grammar of shares, rules, founders, and the shape of durable change

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Every Sunday evening, somewhere, a family has the same argument. The weekend is nearly gone. One person wants to see friends; another wants to rest; a third wants to finish a project that has been waiting for weeks. Nobody is being unreasonable. Nobody wants to hurt anybody. And yet the evening cannot be spent three ways. The hours are few. The desires are many. The argument is not about who loves whom. It is about how a scarce thing—time—will be divided.

Now move to a different room. A company's leadership meets to allocate next year's budget. Three divisions want the same capital. Each has a case. Each case is partly true. The money is finite. The meeting is tense.

Now move to a different scale. A country's legislature fights over a budget. Parties, regions, and factions each claim a share of what the state can spend. The fight is loud, procedural, and old.

These scenes feel different. They differ in scale, in stakes, in the language used. But they have the same skeleton. In each, people are making claims on a share of something scarce. In each, the claims contend: satisfying one makes satisfying another harder. In each, the contention produces struggle—effort, argument, maneuvering, sometimes open conflict. And in each, rules determine who ends up with what.

That skeleton—share, claim, contention, struggle, rules—is the subject of this essay. But it is not the whole of it. Behind every set of rules is a foundation: the settlement that no prior rule settles. Behind every foundation is a founder: the person, group, or process that laid it. And beneath the foundation—so often unspoken—is a rigging: the initial advantage that the founding confers on some over others, an advantage that tends to preserve itself. This is the deepest layer, and it is the layer most people never see.

The struggle to change this deepest layer is the struggle for reform. And the word itself is the key. To reform is to re- form — to give a new form to something, to change its shape, to restore or transform its structure. The object of the verb is the form. A reform that leaves the form intact is not a reform; it is a reallocation. A reform that changes the form is a re-founding, even if it happens gradually, legally, and without a shot fired.

This essay is about the struggle for reform in this strict sense. It is about why some reforms succeed and most fail short. And it turns out that the answer is buried in the word itself.

Key idea. Reform means to re-form: to give the foundation a new shape. A reform that leaves the form intact is only a reallocation; one that changes the form is a re-founding.

The four words

Share

A share is the portion of something valuable that someone receives, keeps, or controls. It is what we also call a reward, a portion, a stake—what someone gets. A wage is a share of a firm's revenue. A child's hour of screen time is a share of the household's attention. A country's territory is a share of the earth. A grade is a share of the credit a course offers. A seat on a committee is a share of authority. A share need not be money. It can be time, attention, status, legitimacy, information, safety, or the chance to be heard.

Claim

A claim is what a person asserts, demands, proposes, or tries in order to obtain, keep, or enlarge a share. A bid is a claim on a good. A move in chess is a claim on a square. A budget request is a claim on funds. A knock on someone's door is a claim on their attention. Claims can be compatible—two people can both get what they ask for. They can be incompatible—only one can win. Or they can be partly compatible, so that satisfying one reduces but does not eliminate another.

Contention

Contention is the pivotal idea, and it is easy to miss because the word sounds like fighting. But contention is not yet a fight. It is the condition in which two or more claims bear on the same share, so that satisfying one affects the satisfaction of another. Contention is the situation that makes a fight possible. It is structural, not behavioral. A quiet office where two people want the same promotion is full of contention even if no one has said a word.

Rival, cooperative, coordinative

Contention comes in flavors. Some is rival: one person's share grows at another's expense. Some is cooperative: each person's share grows when the other's does. And some is coordinative: both parties want to agree on a joint arrangement, but neither cares much about the other's share per se—they only care that the arrangement be shared.

This three-way distinction is not academic. It is the difference between a marriage and a merger, between an alliance and a rivalry, between a standard and a contest. Most human relationships contain all three at once, in different proportions, over different things. Recognizing which is which is the beginning of strategy.

Struggle

A struggle is the activity of contending—the effort, time, risk, and resources people expend trying to secure, defend, or enlarge a share. Contention is the structure; struggle is the process. A union negotiating a contract is struggling. A firm cutting prices is struggling. A person resisting the pull of their phone to finish a piece of work is struggling.

Struggle has a grammar, and the grammar is revealing. English—and many other languages—let us say three things:

- We struggle for something: independence, market share, a place in the life we want.
- We struggle with someone against a common obstacle: our shared struggle for recognition, for justice, for survival.
- We struggle over something: the terms of a contract, the rules of an institution, the direction of a movement.

These three prepositions are not accidents of speech. They map directly onto the three kinds of contention. Struggle for is rival contention. Struggle with is cooperative contention. Struggle over is coordinative contention. The grammar of struggle encodes the structure of contention. When you hear someone say "the struggle over the rules," you are

listening to people who understand, perhaps without knowing it, that the deepest conflicts are not about shares but about the arrangements that determine shares.

Key idea. Contention is the structure; struggle is the process. Struggle *for*, *with*, and *over* trace rival, cooperative, and coordinative contention.

Rules: the fifth word, and the deepest

That brings us to the fifth word, the one that often decides everything: rules.

What rules are

Rules are the arrangements that determine how claims become shares. They include the formal—contracts, laws, constitutions, auctions, voting systems—and the informal—norms, conventions, expectations, habits. A market's price mechanism is a rule. A firm's budgeting process is a rule. A family's unspoken understanding about who handles bedtime is a rule. A constitution is a rule of rules.

Rules shape the struggle

Rules matter because they determine which struggles take place and how shares are assigned once claims are made. Change the rule and you change the struggle. A promotion decided by seniority produces a different contest than one decided by performance review, which produces a different contest than one decided by a coin flip. None of these rules is neutral. Each favors some claimants and disadvantages others. Each produces its own kind of effort, its own kind of resentment, its own kind of peace.

Struggle over the rules

And so we arrive at the deepest form of contention, the one that runs beneath all the others: struggle over the rules. When people fight over a budget, they are fighting within the rules. When they fight over how the budget is decided— who sits on the committee, what the voting threshold is, what counts as a valid claim—they are fighting over the rules themselves. This is the struggle that shapes all subsequent struggles.

Three questions to ask

A useful habit of mind follows from this. When you encounter a conflict, ask two questions in order. First: what is the share being contended? Second: what are the rules that determine who gets it? The first question is what most people ask. The second is what strategists ask. And a third question, rarer still: who decided the rules, and how?

> **Key idea.** Change the rule and you change the struggle. The deepest conflicts are not over shares but over the arrangements that decide shares.

Who decided the rules?

The problem of first allocation

There is a question that follows immediately from the last section, and it is the question the framework cannot answer. If rules determine how claims become shares, then who decided the rules?

And who decided who decides?

This is the problem of first allocation. It is the problem of the allocation that no prior rule allocates—the allocation of rule-making authority itself. Every order has one, and none can justify it by its own rules.

The regress stops at the foundation

The regress is simple. If the rules were chosen under some rule, then that rule was chosen under another, and so on. Either the chain goes on forever—rules all the way down, with nothing at the bottom—or it stops somewhere. It stops at the foundation of the order: the settlement that is not itself settled by any prior rule. A constitution is a foundation. A company's charter is a foundation. A marriage is a foundation. The conditions you were born into are a foundation. Each is the bottom of its own order, the place where the regress of rules runs out.

The founder

The foundation is laid by a founder—the one who establishes the first rules. The founder may be a person: a conqueror, a constitution-writer, an entrepreneur, a parent. It may be a group: a constituent assembly, a founding partnership, a household. It may be a process: a community gradually converging on a practice. Or it may be no one at all: history, drift, accident. The founder is the answer to who decided. The mode of founding is the answer to how.

Four ways a foundation is laid

There are four ways a foundation can be laid.

- **Force.** The founder imposes the rules. A revolution, a coup, a conquest, a founder's fiat.
- **Agreement.** The founders consent to the rules. A constitution, a charter, a compact, a marriage vow.

- **Convention.** The rules emerge from practice. No one decides; people follow a pattern, and the pattern hardens into a rule.
- **Accident.** The rules are the residue of history. Path dependence, inheritance, drift.

The legitimacy deficit

Each of these is a way of founding an order. None of them is fully legitimate by the standards of the order it founds. Force is not legitimate. Agreement is hypothetical or incomplete. Convention is not chosen. Accident is not justified. This is not a reason for cynicism. It is a reason for clarity. It is why constitutions have founding myths, why firms have origin stories, why families have unspoken understandings about who decided what.

> **Key idea.** Every order rests on a foundation—the settlement no prior rule settles—and no foundation can justify itself by its own rules.

Is the game rigged?

The rigged foundation

A foundation is not neutral. Whoever lays it lays it with their interests in mind—or with their interests encoded in the accidents of history that laid it. The first allocation is also an allocation of advantage. We call this the rigged foundation: the initial advantage that the founding confers on some players over others.

Explicit and implicit advantage

The advantage can be explicit. A constitution that requires property ownership for the vote. A company charter that gives founders ten votes per share. An inheritance rule that favors one child over another. Or it can be implicit. First- mover advantages that compound over time. Information asymmetries between the founder and later players. The simple fact that the status quo is harder to change than it is to defend.

Self-reinforcement

A rigged foundation is usually self-reinforcing. The people it advantages are given—or can acquire—the procedural rights to block reforms that would reduce their advantage. A veto. A supermajority requirement. Agenda control. The rules that would allow reform are controlled by the people who would be reformed.

Who struggles least

There is a corollary that is easy to miss. In a rigged order, the beneficiaries struggle less than the disadvantaged. The rules already favor them, so they have little to struggle for within the rules. The disadvantaged struggle constantly, because they must struggle not only against other claimants but against the rules themselves. This is why rigged orders often look calm on the surface: the people doing the struggling are the people whose struggles are least visible.

Erosion

This does not mean the advantage is permanent. The beneficiary coalition can fragment. New players can accumulate the resources the rules depend on. The rules can be reinterpreted by later readers. A rigged foundation erodes, given enough time and enough change. But erosion is slow, uncertain, and often blocked precisely by the self-reinforcing mechanisms. So the practical claim stands: within-rules reform usually fails against a self-reinforcing rigging, and this is why de-rigging, when it happens, tends to happen by refounding rather than reform.

Key idea. A rigged foundation is self-reinforcing: the rules that would allow reform are controlled by the people who would be reformed.

The game is never zero-sum

What zero-sum means

Zero-sum means: what I gain, you lose, and nothing else changes. It is the logic of a fixed pie. A negotiation over the price of a house. A tennis match. A budget that has already been set.

The founder advantage is not a slice

But a game with a live founder advantage can never be purely zero-sum. Here is why.

A founder advantage is not a slice of the pie. It is a feature of how the pie is cut and how big it is. The founder did not win the game; the founder laid the field. And laying the field is not a move in the game—it is the condition of the game.

Two levels

This means the game has two levels. At the first level, players play within the rules. That level can be zero-sum: a fixed budget, a fixed market, a fixed amount of attention. At the second level, players struggle over the rules themselves. That level is never zero-sum, because the rules determine the size of the pie, not just its division.

The meta-game

The founder advantage is the trace of the second level in the first. It is evidence that the rules were laid by someone, in some mode, in someone's favor. And the existence of that someone—the founder—means the game has a meta- game.

Why zero-sum thinking fails

This is why zero-sum thinking is so often a mistake. It is the thinking of players who take the foundation for granted. It is not always wrong—sometimes you really are playing a fixed game, and you should fight for your slice. But the most important games are not fixed. They are laid, and they can be laid differently.

The slogan

A useful slogan: zero-sum is the arithmetic of players who cannot see the foundation. The framework's insistence on the first allocation is, in part, an insistence that the arithmetic is usually incomplete.

> **Key idea.** Zero-sum is the arithmetic of players who cannot see the foundation; the struggle over the rules is never zero-sum.

Four words, not one

Splitting rigging into four

The word "rigging" is doing a lot of work in this essay, and it needs to be split into four. The distinctions matter, because most reforms fail because they confuse them.

Foundation rigging

Foundation rigging is the original sin. It is the advantage that the founding confers on the founder's coalition — laid into the foundation at the moment of founding, structural, persistent. The Three-Fifths Compromise is a foundation rigging. Dual-class stock is a foundation rigging. The inheritance rule that favors the eldest son is a foundation rigging.

Re-rigging

Re-rigging is the replacement of one foundation rigging with another. The old elite is removed; a new elite is installed; the structure that produced the rigging is intact. The French Revolution's succession of constitutions was a series of re-riggings. The post-colonial transitions in many states were re-riggings. The corporate recapitalization that strips the founder's shares and gives the new CEO a golden parachute is a re-rigging. The old advantage is gone; the new one is in its place.

De-rigging

De-rigging is the removal of a specific foundation rigging. It is what the disadvantaged coalition seeks. The abolition of the Three-Fifths Compromise was a de-rigging. The corporate governance reform that abolishes dual-class stock is a de-rigging. The family decision to divide the inheritance equally is a de-rigging. It removes the current advantage.

Anti-rigging

Anti-rigging is the structural design that makes future foundation rigging harder. It is not the removal of a specific advantage (that is de-rigging). It is the change in the terms of laying — the structural conditions under which foundations are made and maintained. The Bill of Rights of 1689 was an anti-rigging. The U.S. Constitution's separation of powers is an anti-rigging. The corporate governance reform that establishes independent directors, audit committees, and shareholder voting is an anti-rigging.

The 2×2 matrix

The four concepts form a 2×2 matrix:

De-rigging No de-rigging Anti-rigging Durable de-rigging Partial anti-rigging No anti-rigging Fragile de-rigging Re-rigging

The matrix is the conceptual core of the theory. Every revolution, every reform, every constitutional convention, every corporate reorganization, every family rupture can be placed in one of its four cells. And the cell predicts its durability.

The failure modes and the goal

Fragile de-rigging is the most common failure mode. The revolution removes the old advantage but does not anti-rig. The revolutionary coalition has the power to lay a new advantage, and the framework predicts it will. The result is a re- rigging, often within a generation. The French Revolution is the paradigm case. So is the Russian Revolution. So is most of what we call revolutionary history.

Partial anti-rigging is the second failure mode. The reform includes anti-rigging provisions but does not remove the old advantage. The old rigging persists, but future rigging is harder. This is better than fragile de-rigging, but it leaves the old injustice in place.

Re-rigging is the failure mode where the old advantage is replaced by a new one. The structure of the game is unchanged. The players have changed.

Durable de-rigging is the goal. It requires both: the removal of the old advantage and the structural provisions that make future rigging harder. The Glorious Revolution of 1688 is the paradigm case. The American Constitution is another. The post-war German constitution is a third.

The distinction between these four concepts is the most important thing the framework has to say about reform. It explains why most reforms fail short: they de-rig without anti-rigging. And it specifies what a durable reform would require: de-rigging and anti-rigging together, with self-limitation as the test of the reforming coalition's seriousness.

> **Key idea.** Most reforms fail short because they de-rig without anti-rigging: they remove the old advantage but not the form that produced it.

The word itself

Etymology: re-formare

The word reform is doing more work than it first appears. It comes from the Latin reformare — to form again, to restore to a former shape, to transform. The object of the verb is the form. To reform something is not to improve it

within its existing shape. It is to give it a new shape.

Reform is a fight over the form

This is why the struggle for reform is not the same as the struggle for shares. A fight over the budget is not a reform; it is a reallocation. A fight over the promotion is not a reform; it is a

substitution. A fight over the election is not a reform; it is a competition. A reform is a fight over the form — the rules, the foundation, the terms on which the shares are allocated.

The distinction has been with us all along, buried in the word. The theory makes it explicit. The struggle for reform is the struggle to re-form — to lay a new foundation, or to change the terms on which the old one is laid. Everything else is a fight within the rules. The reform is a fight over the rules.

The word covers four operations: re-forming the foundation (the strict sense), removing an advantage (de-rigging), adding provisions to the foundation without removing the advantage (anti-rigging within the rules), and replacing one advantage with another (re-rigging). Only one of these — re-forming the foundation with anti-rigging — is durable. The others fail short, often within a generation.

Key idea. To reform is to re-form. A reform is a fight over the form; everything else—reallocation, substitution, competition—is a fight within the rules.

Why most reforms fail

The framework gives four reasons why most reforms fail, and they are structural, not moral.

Reason one: a coalition of claimants

The reforming coalition is a coalition of claimants. A revolution is not made by a single actor. It is made by a coalition — sometimes an alliance of classes, sometimes an alliance of factions. The coalition agrees on the de-rigging: the old foundation must go. It does not agree on what comes next. The revolutionary coalition that overthrew the French monarchy included the bourgeoisie, the sans-culottes, the peasantry, and the provincial notables. These groups had different interests, different visions, and different claims. The Jacobin dictatorship, the Thermidorian reaction, and the Napoleonic empire were not accidents. They were the resolution of a coalition that could not agree on the terms of the new foundation.

Reason two: the power to rig

The reforming coalition has the power to rig. The coalition that overthrows the old order holds the power to lay the new foundation. It has the arms, the organization, and the legitimacy of victory. The framework predicts that it will write the rules to its own advantage. This is not a moral failing; it is a structural consequence of the situation. The coalition holds the power to rig, and a coalition with the power to rig will use it — because the alternative is to leave itself vulnerable to a future de-rigging.

Reason three: fear of the counter-revolution

The reforming coalition fears the counter-revolution. The reforming coalition is usually surrounded by enemies. The old elite is plotting restoration. Foreign powers may intervene. Internal factions may defect. The coalition feels besieged, and the siege justifies extraordinary measures. The framework predicts that a besieged coalition will entrench itself. It will acquire

emergency powers, suspend normal procedures, and consolidate authority. Each of these is a step toward re-rigging. The siege is real, but the response to the siege is also a re-rigging.

Reason four: not knowing how to anti-rig

The reforming coalition does not know how to anti-rig. Anti-rigging is a design problem, and most reformers are not designers. They know how to overthrow; they do not know how to build. They write constitutions that encode their values and their interests, but they do not write provisions that constrain their own power.

> **Key idea.** Revolutions fall short for structural reasons, not moral ones: they de-rig without anti-rigging, and they re-rig within a generation.

How to make rigging harder

De-rigging and anti-rigging

De-rigging removes an advantage. Anti-rigging prevents a new one from being laid. The distinction is precise: de- rigging says this advantage must go; anti-rigging says the conditions that produced this advantage must change.

The anti-rigging paradox

There is a paradox at the heart of anti-rigging. The reforming coalition is itself a founder. If it makes the anti-rigging provisions strong enough to prevent future rigging, it makes them strong enough to entrench itself. If it makes them weak enough to avoid entrenching itself, it makes them too weak to work. This is the anti-rigging paradox, and it cannot be escaped by good intentions. It can only be escaped by structure.

Self-limitation

The resolution is self-limitation: the reforming coalition binds itself with the same provisions it binds its successors. It says, in effect: we lay these rules to prevent rigging, including our own. The provisions that constrain our successors also constrain us. This does not make the founding fully legitimate — no founding is. But it reduces the legitimacy deficit, because a self-limiting founding does not claim an exemption from the standard it imposes.

Self-limitation in practice

What does self-limitation look like in practice? It looks like provisions that apply to the reformers as effectively as to their successors. The founders' advantages expire on the same schedule as anyone else's. The founders do not hold procedural rights their successors do not hold. The provisions reduce the founders' advantage as much as they reduce any successor's.

This is hard to achieve. It requires the reformers to act against their own interest, which the framework predicts they will not do. So the reforming coalition must be structurally constrained — by a plurality of coalitions with overlapping mandates, each of which can block the others' re-rigging. Self-limitation is not a matter of virtue. It is a matter of structure.

Six families of provisions

What are the structural provisions that make rigging harder? There are six families.

- **Temporal limits.** Sunset clauses, mandatory review, generational accounting. Provisions that allocate advantage expire unless renewed, and renewal requires the consent of those who would be disadvantaged by non-renewal.
- **Concentration limits.** Rotation, sortition, term limits, anti-concentration rules. No coalition holds rule-making authority indefinitely.
- **Transparency.** Disclosure, audit, public reasoning. Allocation decisions are visible to those affected. Rigging flourishes in the dark; it is harder in the light.
- **Entrenchment asymmetry.** Anti-rigging provisions are harder to remove than ordinary rules but not impossible to remove. Too easy to remove, they fail. Too hard to remove, they become a new rigging.
- **Dispersal.** Federalism, separation of powers, overlapping trustees. No single coalition captures all rule-making authority.
- **Contestability.** Legal standing, referendum, recall. Any affected party can challenge allocation decisions.

The portfolio

No single provision is sufficient. A portfolio — at least one from each family — can jointly satisfy the four constraints: it must be effective, functional, legitimate, and self-limiting. The portfolio is the unit of design, not the individual provision.

The nominality problem

The hardest question is whether a provision is effective — whether it actually raises the cost of rigging — or merely nominal. Many anti-rigging provisions are nominal. Sunset clauses that are routinely renewed. Transparency provisions that disclose nothing consequential. Entrenchment that is never tested. This is the nominality problem, and it is the central practical challenge of anti-rigging theory.

There are partial solutions. Multiple triggers. Third-party enforcement. Visible non-compliance. Sunset on the sunset. These are partial. A full solution to the nominality problem is an open research question. But the direction is clear: anti-rigging provisions must be designed to bite, to cost, and to impose asymmetric costs on the rigger. A provision that does not bite is not anti-rigging. It is decoration.

> **Key idea.** The anti-rigging paradox is resolved by self-limitation: the reforming coalition binds itself with the same provisions it binds its successors.

Three reforms, three outcomes

Three cases show the matrix in action.

The Glorious Revolution: durable de-rigging

The Glorious Revolution of 1688 was a durable de-rigging. James II was overthrown. The Catholic monarchy was replaced by a Protestant one. The specific advantage of the old beneficiary coalition — the Catholic aristocracy, the royal prerogative, the dispensing power — was eliminated. But the Glorious Revolution did not stop there. It added anti-rigging: the Bill of Rights of 1689, the Act of Settlement of 1701, the Triennial Act. These provisions established parliamentary supremacy, free elections, freedom of speech in Parliament, and the prohibition of royal interference with the law. They included temporal limits (Parliament had to be summoned regularly), concentration limits (the royal prerogative was curtailed), transparency (parliamentary proceedings were made public), entrenchment asymmetry (the Bill of Rights was made difficult to amend), dispersal (power was dispersed between Crown, Lords, and Commons), and contestability (elections were made free and regular). The anti-rigging applied to the new monarchs as much as to their successors. The result was a structure in which re-rigging was harder than it would have been otherwise. It was not a utopia — the eighteenth-century oligarchy, the nineteenth-century reform movements, and the twentieth-century welfare state were all responses to residual rigging. But it was durable.

The French Revolution: fragile de-rigging

The French Revolution was a fragile de-rigging. The monarchy was overthrown; the aristocracy was abolished; the specific advantage of the old beneficiary coalition was eliminated. But the revolutionary constitutions did not include the anti-rigging provisions that the Glorious Revolution included. There were no temporal limits on the revolutionary government, no concentration limits on the Committee of Public Safety, no transparency provisions for the Jacobin clubs, no entrenchment asymmetry, no dispersal of power across independent bodies, no contestability mechanisms that survived the Terror. The result was predictable: the revolutionaries acquired emergency powers and never gave them up. The Committee of Public Safety became a dictatorship. The Directory became an oligarchy. Napoleon became an emperor. The Bourbon Restoration restored the monarchy. Each of these transitions was a re-rigging.

The Russian Revolution: re-rigging

The Russian Revolution was a re-rigging. The tsarist aristocracy was overthrown; the specific advantage of the old beneficiary coalition was eliminated. But the Bolsheviks did not de-rig in the framework's sense. They replaced one advantage with another. The party elite, the nomenklatura, and the security services acquired procedural rights that were structurally identical to those of the old elite. The rigging changed hands; the structure was intact. There was no anti-rigging. The Bolsheviks concentrated authority in the party, the Politburo, and the secret police. They suppressed opposition, abolished independent courts, and controlled the press. Each of these was a step toward re-rigging. The Soviet Union survived for seventy-four years — longer than the tsarist autocracy that preceded it, and longer than most revolutions. But it did not de-rig; it re-rigged. When it finally collapsed, it collapsed into a new rigging — the oligarchic capitalism of the 1990s — which was structurally identical to the old one.

The pattern

The pattern is clear. The reforms that included both de-rigging and anti-rigging were durable. The reform that included only de-rigging was fragile. The reform that included neither was a re-rigging. The framework predicts this pattern, and the historical record bears it out.

> **Key idea.** Reforms that de-rig and anti-rig are durable; those that do only one are fragile—the difference is in the form, not the spirit.

What to do with it

Six habits

If the framework is useful, it should change how you think about reform. Six habits follow.

1. **Name the share.** When you encounter a conflict, ask what is actually being divided. It is often not what the participants say. A fight about money may be a fight about recognition. A fight about recognition may be a fight about time.

2. **Map the contention.** Ask who is coupled with whom, and over what. Ask whether the coupling is rival, cooperative, or coordinative. Ask which clusters are active and which are latent.

3. **Look at the rules.** Ask what determines how claims become shares. Ask who set the rules and why. Ask whether the rules are the real stakes. They often are.

4. **Look at the foundation.** Ask where the rules themselves came from. Ask who founded the order and in what mode—force, agreement, convention, or accident. Ask what legitimacy deficit the founding carries.

5. **Ask whether the reform is durable.** Ask whether it de-rigs, whether it anti-rigs, whether it is self-limiting. Ask whether it will survive the next generation. The matrix tells you what to look for.

6. **Count the cost.** Ask where your effort is best spent. Ask what you can concede to concentrate on what matters. Reform is finite. Spend it where it counts.

These six habits are not a formula. They are a discipline. They will not tell you what to do. They will help you see what you are doing.

> **Key idea.** The six habits are a discipline, not a formula: they help you see what you are doing, not what to do.

Coda

The family arguing about Sunday evening, the firm fighting over next year's budget, the legislature fighting over the shape of the state — these are not separate phenomena. They are

variations on a single pattern. People make claims on shares. The claims contend. The contention produces struggle. The struggle is shaped by rules. The rules are laid by founders. The founders rest on foundations that no rule can fully justify. And the foundations are usually rigged, in favor of some and against others.

The struggle to change the foundation is the struggle for reform. And the word itself is the key. To reform is to re-form — to give a new form to something. The object of the verb is the form. A reform that leaves the form intact is not a reform. It is a reallocation. A reform that changes the form is a re-founding.

Most reforms fail short because they de-rig without anti-rigging. They remove the old advantage but do not change the form that produced it. The result is a re-rigging, often within a generation. The French Revolution and the Russian Revolution are the paradigm cases. The Glorious Revolution and the American Constitution are the exceptions, because they combined de-rigging with anti-rigging.

The lesson is not a counsel of despair. It is a counsel of design. A reform that de-rigs and anti-rigs is durable. A reform that does only one is fragile. The difference is in the form, not in the spirit. And form can be designed.

The deepest change is not winning within the rules. It is laying new foundations — which is what every reformer, every constitution, every fresh start has always been. The field can be relaid. But a relaying that does not change the terms of laying merely resets the board for the next founder. The question is not only whose advantage should be removed but what structure should make the next advantage harder to lay.

The game is played on a field that someone laid, and the laying of the field is not itself a move in the game. But it is the most consequential thing that ever happens in it. And the struggle to lay it differently — the struggle for reform — is the oldest, the deepest, and the most consequential political activity there is.

Key idea. The struggle for reform is the struggle to lay the field differently—the oldest, deepest, and most consequential political activity there is.

Part III

Power

The Desire-Lever:

A Bargaining Theory of Normative Power

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Abstract

This paper develops a game-theoretic model of the *desire-lever*: a mechanism by which a principal shapes an agent's behavior by making access to a desired good conditional on the agent's alignment with the principal's objectives. The lever is formalized as a bargaining problem in which the principal offers access to a desired good in exchange for alignment, and the terms of trade depend on the agent's outside options, the principal's knowledge of the agent's desires, the principal's certification technology, the credibility of the principal's promises, and—in the general case—the principal's capacity to shape the agent's desires.

The paper makes twelve contributions. First, it treats "conduct" not as an objective behavioral category but as *principal-relative alignment*. Second, it distinguishes two forms of freedom—*space*, the agent's alternatives, and *time*, the agent's pause for deliberation—and shows that the two are substitutes with different structural properties. Third, it derives the *extraction limit*: the principal's power is bounded by the agent's surplus. Fourth, it identifies the *discovery problem*: desire is an informational asset, so leverage generates a derived demand for intelligence, while concealment is the agent's counter-power. Fifth, it identifies the *credibility constraint* and the *certification trade-off*. Sixth, it states a conditional *exhaustiveness lemma*. Seventh, it derives a testable empirical implication about the density of the discovery apparatus. Eighth, it develops a *win–draw–loss typology* and characterizes the *win–win equilibrium*. Ninth, it extends the model to *bipartite bargaining networks*, in which corruption, lobbying, and coercion appear as the characteristic forms the lever takes when the network is dense. Tenth, it *endogenizes the network*. Eleventh, it identifies the *formation advantage*: a principal who can shape the agent's desires sets the parameters of the pricing problem. Twelfth, it proves that *coercive closure* is the limit case of the network model, unifying jailing, excommunication, and reputational closure as three components of a single coercive instrument.

The paper concludes that the lever's distinctive property—preserving formal agency while conditioning its exercise—means that the agent's choice cannot by itself legitimate the terms, and that the conditions which make a lever ethical are, within its own domain, also the conditions which make it durable.

Keywords: desire-lever, bargaining, conditional access, alignment, space-freedom, time-freedom, credibility, certification, desire discovery, surveillance, opacity, formation, authenticity, conditional benefits, coercive closure, fiduciary capture, win–win equilibrium, network, corruption, lobbying, governance, longevity, dual use, normative power

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1 Introduction

A recurrent structure in human societies ties access to a desired good to a condition of conduct. Do this, and you will receive that; fail, and you will not. The desired good may be material—food, land, money—or immaterial: salvation, belonging, honor, security. The condition may be simple, such as paying a tithe, or complex, such as living according to a law. The authority that certifies compliance may be a priest, a state, a community, or a god.

This paper calls this structure the **desire-lever**. A principal shapes an agent's behavior by making access to a desired good conditional on the agent's alignment with the principal's objectives. The mechanism is ancient and ubiquitous. It ranges from the crude transaction—pay the tithe, receive the blessing—to the sophisticated governance of souls. It applies to individuals, groups, and nations.

The model treats the desire-lever as a *bargaining problem*: the principal offers access to a desired good in exchange for alignment, and the terms of trade depend on the agent's outside options, the principal's knowledge of the agent's desires, the principal's certification technology, the credibility of the principal's promises, and the principal's capacity to shape the agent's desires.

The desire-lever is not a discovery of this paper. It is the explicit formalization of a mechanism described, under different vocabularies, by the sociological and historical traditions. Lukes's third face of power [10] identifies the shaping of preferences as the deepest form of power; Foucault's account of pastoral power and confession [5] describes the discovery apparatus; Scott's account of hidden transcripts [15] describes the concealment dynamic. The paper's contribution is to state the mechanism as a bargaining problem, derive its limits and comparative statics, distinguish the two freedoms, analyze work and governance as applications, extend the framework to endogenous networks, identify the formation advantage as a meta-locus, unify the coercive instruments, and show that the conditions for ethical conduct of the lever converge with the conditions for its durability.

2 The General Framework

2.1 Players, Goods, and the Alignment Variable

There are two players: a principal P and an agent A. The principal controls access to a desired good D, which the agent values at $v > 0$.

Let $a \in \mathcal{A}$ be the agent's **alignment state**: the vector of acts, omissions, dispositions, associations, and internal states that the principal can evaluate. Let $O_P(a,t)$ be the principal's valuation of that state at time t. **Conduct** is then defined as principal-relative:

$$\text{Conduct} \;\equiv\; \big\{\, a \in \mathcal{A} \;:\; O_P(a,t) \geq \bar{O}(t) \,\big\}, \tag{1}$$

where $\bar{O}(t)$ is the principal's threshold for acceptable alignment. The agent's cost of alignment is $c(a)$, and the principal's benefit is $b(a,t) = O_P(a,t)$. The cost of providing D is $k \geq 0$, and the agent's outside option is $u_0 \geq 0$.

The key conceptual move: *the agent bears the cost, the principal sets the standard.*

2.2 Conduct as Principal-Relative Alignment

Alignment is dynamic. The principal's objectives change, so the agent must track a moving target. This is why the lever requires *ongoing certification*: confession, audit, surveillance, examination, pastoral oversight.

Alignment is multidimensional. The principal may value not only acts but dispositions, speech, omissions, association, and internal states. The shift from immanent to deferred sanctions is a shift from *act-alignment* to *whole-person alignment.*

The standard is contestable. The lever works best when the principal's definition is accepted as legitimate, sacred, natural, or inevitable—when the agent adopts O_P as their own objective function. This is the internalized lever.

2.3 The Two Freedoms: Space and Time

The model has, so far, used a single scalar u_0 to represent the agent's outside option. This conflates two analytically distinct forms of freedom.

Definition 2.1 (Space-Freedom)**.** *The agent's* space-freedom *is the value of the agent's best alternative to the lever, $u_0 \geq 0$. It is measurable, material, and largely external: it can be given, built, bought, inherited, or lost.*

Definition 2.2 (Time-Freedom)**.** *The agent's* time-freedom *is the capacity to delay the response to the principal's offer long enough to inspect the terms. Let $\delta_A \in [0,1]$ be the* deliberation parameter*: the probability that the agent inspects the terms before accepting. Time-freedom is not priced, cannot be transferred, and cannot be administered by an institution.*

The two freedoms dissociate. An agent with high u_0 may have $\delta_A \approx 0$. An agent with $u_0 = 0$ may have $\delta_A \approx 1$.

The participation constraint generalizes to

$$\delta_A \cdot \big(v - c(a) - u_0\big) \geq 0, \tag{2}$$

and the principal's effective extraction becomes δ_A-weighted.

Proposition 2.1 (Deliberation and Extraction)**.** *The principal's equilibrium alignment a^* is decreasing in the agent's deliberation parameter δ_A and increasing in the agent's space-freedom u_0. The two freedoms are substitutes.*

Proof. The principal maximizes $b(a) - k$ subject to (2). Since $b' > 0$, the constraint binds. Rearranging gives

$$c(a^*) = v - u_0 - \frac{\varepsilon}{\delta_A},$$

where $\varepsilon \geq 0$ is the slack the principal must leave to ensure acceptance. As $\delta_A \to 0$, the term ε/δ_A diverges, and the constraint becomes slack. As $\delta_A \to 1$, the term vanishes. The comparative statics follow. □

Space is priced, and because it is priced, it compounds. Time is not priced, and so it does not compound, and it cannot be converted into space. This asymmetry is the formal content of the observation that the rich get richer by buying space while the poor cultivate time as the only freedom that remains.

2.4 Work as a Bilateral Lever

In the employment relation the structure is bilateral. The worker is also a principal, controlling access to their labor, attention, and judgment, and conditioning that access on a wage. The employment relationship is *two levers facing each other.*

Let the worker control a good D_W (labor) valued by the employer at v_E, and the employer control a good D_E (wage) valued by the worker at v_W. The wage w is the point at which the two extraction limits meet:

$$w^* \in \left[\, c_E^{-1}(v_W - u_W),\ v_E - c_W^{-1}(u_E) \,\right], \tag{3}$$

where u_W is the worker's outside option and u_E is the employer's.

The form of the wage is not neutral. Wages have been paid in many media: grain, ore, land, plunder, company scrip, shares. Each medium is a claim on space in a particular form. The medium determines what kind of space the worker can accumulate.

Occupations trade time for space. The worker sells the pause in exchange for claims on alternatives. A high wage with no transferable skill, no savings, and no reputation outside the firm is a well-paid cage.

2.5 Conditional Claims and the Structure of Benefits

Definition 2.3 (Conditional Claim)**.** *A* conditional claim *is a transfer $\tau \geq 0$ to the agent whose realization requires the agent's continued alignment with the principal. Formally, the agent receives τ with probability $\pi(a)$ and receives nothing with probability $1 - \pi(a)$, where π is increasing in alignment a and $\pi(a) \to 0$ as the agent exits.*

Proposition 2.2 (Conditional Claims Do Not Increase Outside Options)**.** *A conditional claim increases the agent's wealth conditional on staying, but does not increase the agent's outside option u_0. In the limit as the exit-forfeiture probability approaches one, the conditional claim is equivalent to a reduction in u_0.*

Proof. The agent's outside option is the value of the agent's best alternative. A claim that vanishes on exit contributes zero to that alternative. Formally, $u_0 = \max_{j \neq i}\{v_j - c_j(a_j)\}$, and a conditional claim offered by principal i does not enter the maximand. As the forfeiture probability approaches one, the effective outside option falls toward $u_0 - \tau$. □

2.6 The Principal's Problem

The principal offers a contract (a, x), where $x \in \{0, 1\}$ indicates provision of D. The principal solves

$$\max_{a,\,x}\ b(a) - xk \quad \text{subject to} \quad xv - c(a) \geq u_0. \tag{4}$$

Define the **agent's surplus** as $S_A = v - c(a) - u_0$. The **efficient alignment level** a^e equates marginal benefit to marginal cost, $b'(a^e) = c'(a^e)$.

3 The Basic Model: Complete Information

3.1 The Extraction Limit

Assume complete information and a take-it-or-leave-it offer. Since $b' > 0$, the constraint binds:

$$c(a^*) = v - u_0. \tag{5}$$

Proposition 3.1 (Extraction Limit, Alignment Version)**.** *In the basic model the principal requires $a^* = c^{-1}(v - u_0)$ and extracts the agent's entire surplus.*

Proof. Maximize $b(a) - k$ subject to $v - c(a) \geq u_0$. Since $b' > 0$, the constraint binds. Rearranging gives $c(a^*) = v - u_0$. □

The principal is extracting *conformity to a standard the principal itself sets and revises.* The agent's surplus is the measure of the principal's power: the more the agent values the good relative to their outside option, the more alignment the principal can demand.

4 The Exhaustiveness Lemma

Proposition 4.1 (Exhaustiveness Lemma)**.** *For a principal who forswears force, coercion, and deception, and who takes the agent's preferences as given, the desire-lever is the only remaining instrument of influence—within a fixed preference structure.*

Sketch. Influence requires changing the agent's behavior. Without force or coercion, the principal cannot impose behavior. Without deception, the principal cannot misrepresent the terms. With preferences fixed, the principal cannot change what the agent wants. The only remaining channel is to make access to what the agent already wants conditional on behavior—which is precisely the desire-lever. □

5 Information Asymmetry and the Discovery Problem

The lever presupposes knowledge. To set the terms well, the principal must know what the agent actually wants. Too high a price and the agent refuses, or leaves, or pretends to agree while quietly doing something else. Too low and the principal leaves value on the table.

Proposition 5.1 (The Discovery Problem)**.** *Desire is an* informational asset*. The principal's demand for leverage generates a derived demand for intelligence: an apparatus to discover the agent's desires, their intensity, and their outside options. Concealment, dissimulation, and privacy are the agent's counter-power.*

This is what confession is. What performance reviews are. What customer surveys, credit scores, background checks, recommendation algorithms, and intelligence services are. They are all answers to the same question: what does this person actually want, and how much would they give for it?

The corresponding truth for the agent: *privacy is not a luxury; it is leverage.* If the principal cannot read the agent, the principal cannot price the agent. If the principal cannot price the agent, the principal must offer better terms. An unreadable person is a harder person to manage.

Proposition 5.2 (Empirical Implication)**.** *The density and casuistic complexity of the principal's discovery apparatus should increase with the heterogeneity of agent types.*

6 The Credibility Problem and Certification

Some levers pay out immediately. But the most powerful levers pay out later—heaven, promotion, pension, legacy, the long-term payoff of loyalty. The problem is that the agent cannot check whether the promise is real until it is too late.

Proposition 6.1 (The Credibility Constraint)**.** *When the desired good is deferred and unverifiable, the principal must invest in credibility. The principal builds institutions, writes texts, creates rituals, trains professionals, publishes rules, submits to audits—all machinery for making a future promise believable today.*

Proposition 6.2 (The Certification Trade-off)**.** *The principal chooses a certification technology that balances the lever's power against its credibility cost. A more demanding certification (whole-person alignment, internal states) increases power but raises the cost of making the promise credible.*

When someone is selling a future, ask what they have spent to make it believable. The answer tells how seriously to take the offer.

7 Fiduciary Capture

Definition 7.1 (Fiduciary Capture)**.** *Fiduciary capture is the limit case in which the agent's outside options collapse, the principal becomes a monopolist, and the principal's definition of alignment is absorbed into the agent's own standard of self-evaluation.*

The agent does not feel controlled. The agent feels like themselves. That is precisely what makes capture complete. The agent has no alternatives, and then stops needing them, because the agent has absorbed the principal's standard as their own.

8 The Formation Advantage

Everything so far assumes the agent already knows what they want. The deepest lever relaxes this assumption.

Proposition 8.1 (The Formation Advantage)**.** *A principal who can shape the agent's desires does not merely price the lever; the principal sets the parameters of the pricing problem. Formation is a meta-locus that governs the other three loci (the standard, the discovery apparatus, and the credibility investment).*

A person who can shape what you desire does not need to bargain with you at all. They set the terms of the game before you sit down to play. They do not have to convince you to want the promotion, the product, the salvation, the body, the life. They make you want it, and then they sell it to you—and the exchange feels like your own choice, because as far as you can tell, it is.

This is the difference between being outmatched and being formed. The first you can notice. The second you usually cannot.

Formation attacks both freedoms at once. A principal who plants desires does not have to close the agent's exits—the principal makes the exits lead back to the principal. And the principal does not have to take the agent's time—the principal fills the pause before the agent notices it was there. A planted desire is a desire the agent does not inspect.

The ethical tetrad—transparency, exit, contestability, opacity—becomes a pentad with the addition of *authenticity*: the question of whether the agent's wants are the agent's own.

9 The Win–Draw–Loss Typology

Definition 9.1 (Win–Draw–Loss)**.** *A lever outcome is a* win *for the principal when the principal extracts surplus while the agent's participation constraint binds; a* draw *when neither party gains relative to the outside option; a* loss *when the agent exits or the principal's sustainability constraint is violated.*

Proposition 9.1 (The Win–Win Equilibrium)**.** *A* win–win equilibrium *exists precisely when the principal's sustainability constraint binds but does not eliminate the lever. In this region, the principal restrains extraction—not out of kindness, but out of arithmetic—because tolerable terms are what keep the agent in the game.*

This is the quiet reason why ethical arrangements tend to outlast exploitative ones. It is not that virtue always wins. It is that the arrangement which respects the agent's ability to leave is the arrangement that survives the agent's ability to leave. Where force is available, this logic breaks down—a state that can jail its citizens does not need their consent. But wherever the lever must be voluntary, the same conclusion keeps returning: *the conditions that make a relationship decent are the conditions that make it last.*

10 The Network Extension

10.1 Bipartite Bargaining Networks

When many principals hold levers, and none of them dominates, the agent is safer. The agent can play them against each other, and the agent's alternatives multiply. This is why competition protects consumers, why federalism protects citizens, why a free press protects the public, why a diversified set of relationships protects a person.

Proposition 10.1 (Density and Extraction)**.** *In a bipartite bargaining network, the extraction on any single link is decreasing in the number of the agent's alternatives. Corruption, lobbying, and coercion are the characteristic forms the lever takes when the network is dense and no single party has dominance.*

The danger comes when the many collapse into one—when the competitors merge, the agencies coordinate, the platforms consolidate, the interests align. That is when a network becomes captured, and when the many parties the agent thought they were dealing with turn out to be one. Corruption, lobbying, and coercion look like different things. They are the same thing: the lever, operating among many players, before or after the moment when the many become one. The difference between a market and a cartel is not the number of participants. It is whether the agent can still walk away.

10.2 Coercive Closure

Proposition 10.2 (Coercive Closure)**.** *Coercive closure is the limit case of the network model. A principal who can remove the agent's exit—by jailing, excommunication, or reputational closure—restores the bilateral extraction limit, because the agent's outside option is destroyed.*

Jailing, excommunication, and reputational closure (character assassination, propaganda, false accusation) are three components of a single coercive instrument, each of which is intelligence-led in the sense of the discovery apparatus turned around. The state is the principal that can remove exit. It can jail, fine, conscript, and in the extreme case kill. This is why the convergence between ethics and durability holds only within the domain where force is unavailable.

11 Longevity and Dual Use

Proposition 11.1 (Longevity)**.** *The captured equilibrium is sustainable in the long run only if the principal maintains a positive effective barrier in the stationary state. If the challenger's circumvention technology is sufficiently cheap, the barrier converges to zero, and the captured equilibrium unravels.*

The theory is dual-use. Told to the person holding the lever, it is a manual for extraction: here is how to find what they want, here is how to make the terms stick, here is how to keep them from noticing. Told to the person under the lever, it is a language for naming what is happening, and a map of where the exits are. There is no neutral version. Anyone who claims to offer one is keeping something back.

Proposition 11.2 (Dual Use)**.** *The win–win region is largest when both parties understand the mechanism. The agent's literacy raises the cost of extraction; the principal's literacy raises the cost of overreach. Understanding, shared, is the condition under which the lever is most likely to be held ethically.*

12 Conclusion

The desire-lever's distinctive property is that it preserves formal agency while conditioning its exercise. The agent always chooses; the principal arranges the choice. This is why the agent's choice cannot by itself legitimate the terms: a choice made under a formed preference, against a collapsed outside option, is not evidence of consent.

The conditions that make a lever ethical are, within its own domain, also the conditions that make it durable. Transparency, exit, contestability, opacity, and authenticity are not moral ornaments; they are the parameters that determine whether the lever is held well or held badly, and whether it lasts.

The deepest form of power is not the power to make the agent obey. It is the power to keep the agent from understanding the arrangement they are in—to make the lever invisible, and the agent's compliance feel like character. The antidote is not suspicion. It is literacy. Know what you want. Know what you would give for it. Know what you would do instead. And know what the arrangement is asking of you.

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Who Holds the Lever

A Short Guide to the Oldest Mechanism of Power—and How to See It

Macharia Barii

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There is a mechanism of power so old and so common that we rarely notice it. It has no name in everyday speech, which is part of why it works.

Here is the mechanism in one sentence: *whoever controls access to something you want can shape what you do—without force, without threats, without even asking.*

A boss controls your paycheck. A platform controls your audience. A landlord controls your home. A church controls a ritual you believe in. A government controls a permit you need. In each case, someone holds something you want, and makes access to it conditional on how you behave.

I call this a *lever*. Not because it is exotic, but because it is simple—and because once you see it, you see it everywhere.

The first thing to notice: the terms are not yours

When someone holds a lever over you, the question is never just "what do they want?" It is "what counts as good behavior in their eyes?"

And that is the first surprise. The standard is set by the person holding the lever, not by you. What counts as a good employee, a good citizen, a good believer, a good partner—these are not natural facts. They are definitions, and the person with the lever is the one who writes them.

This matters more than it sounds. It means the lever does not simply reward you for doing things. It rewards you for *being* what the lever-holder wants you to be—and that can include your attitude, your tone, your associations, your silences, even your feelings. A boss who wants loyalty, a church that wants faith, a platform that wants engagement—each is asking for something more than behavior. Each is asking for alignment.

And alignment is judged by them.

The second thing: your real power is your alternatives

Here is the part that is genuinely liberating, and it is the heart of everything that follows.

The lever-holder's power over you is limited by what you can do instead.

If you have one employer in a company town, that employer can demand almost anything. If you have five offers in a city, the same employer must bargain. If you can leave the church and still have a community, the church must persuade. If you cannot leave, it need not.

Nothing about the lever-holder changed. What changed was your alternatives.

This is why the most important question in any relationship of power is not "how strong are they?" It is "how easily can I walk away?" Everything else—how much they demand, how they treat you, whether they bother to explain themselves—follows from that.

The people with the most freedom are not the strongest people. They are the people with somewhere else to go.

A note on what freedom means here

There are two kinds of freedom, and this essay is about both.

The first is *space*—the freedom of alternatives. Can you leave? Do you have somewhere else to go? Space is the freedom that can be given, built, bought, inherited, or lost. It has a price, because alternatives cost something to make and to keep. This is why space is the freedom that politics and economics are mostly about, and why a person with resources can acquire more of it than a person without.

The second is *time*—the freedom of the pause between what happens to you and what you do about it. Can you wait before responding? Can you ask why you want what you want before you go get it? Time is not priced. There is no market for the pause. No one can sell it to you, and no one can take it from you without your cooperation. It is the one form of freedom that does not respond to resources, which is why it is available to the rich and the poor alike.

This is why the practical advice splits in two. If you have resources, buy space—build alternatives, keep exits open, do not let yourself be priced. If you do not, cultivate time—keep the pause, ask the fifth question, do not react on schedule, keep a small reserve of yourself that no one else can read. The first is the strategy of the person with something to spend. The second is the strategy of everyone, and it is the one that cannot be taken from you.

Space can be given, built, or bought. Time has to be kept. The lever-holder can read your preferences. He cannot read the moment you will decide. Keep that moment open. It is the smallest unit of freedom there is, and it is the one no one can take from you without your help.

A further note on the asymmetry between them

Space is priced, and because it is priced, it can be bought. And because it can be bought, it generates returns—the person who buys alternatives can use them to acquire more. This is one reason the rich get richer, and it is not a malfunction of the system. It is the structure of space. Alternatives are an asset, and assets compound.

Time is not priced, and because it is not priced, it cannot be bought, and it cannot be converted into space. A person rich in time cannot trade it for alternatives; the market does not accept that currency. So the person who cannot buy space has only time—and the time cannot be spent on the things that space would buy.

This is the quiet structure of a great deal of inequality, and it is not a story about virtue or effort. It is a story about which freedom responds to resources and which one does not. The rich buy space, and the buying compounds. The poor keep time, and the keeping is all that remains.

But here is the thing that keeps this from being a counsel of despair. Time is the freedom that no one can take from you without your help. The rich can buy space. They cannot buy the pause. The poor cannot buy space. They can keep the pause—and the pause is where every refusal begins, every question, every small unpredictable choice that a lever-holder cannot price.

The asymmetry is real. It is not the whole story. The one freedom that cannot be bought is also the one that cannot be taken. That is not consolation. It is strategy.

Work is a lever too

It is easy to read everything in this essay as a warning about other people's power over you. But when you take a job, you are not only the agent. You are a principal too. You control access to something your employer wants—your attention, your skill, your judgment, your time—and you make access conditional on a wage. The employment relationship is not a lever and its absence. It is two levers facing each other, and the terms are set where they meet.

So what are you actually trading?

You are selling *time*—the hours in which you might have done something else. And you are selling *alignment*—a state of yourself that the employer values: your knowledge, your judgment, your reliability, your willingness.

What you receive is resources. And resources are best understood as claims on space. Money is the most general claim: it can be turned into almost any alternative. But wages have been paid in many things—grain, ore, land, plunder, company scrip, shares—and each of these is a claim on space in a particular form. A farmhand paid in grain is paid in the output of land. A worker paid in company scrip is paid in a claim that can only be spent at the company store. The form of the wage is not neutral. It tells you what kind of freedom the employer expects you to accumulate.

Which brings us to the thing that takes time. An occupation is a trade of time for space. You sell the pause, and you receive claims on alternatives. The question every worker should ask is not only "what does it pay?" but "what does it let me leave?" A job that pays well and gives you no alternatives is not a good job. It is a well-paid cage. A job that pays less and gives you savings, transferable skills, and a reputation you can carry elsewhere may be worth more than the wage suggests—because the wage is spent, and the space is kept.

And there is a trap hidden in the word "benefit." Some of what you receive is not space at all. It is a claim on space that is conditional on your continued alignment. Vesting schedules, employer-specific training, stock that matures only if you stay, pensions that pay only if you retire from the firm, credentials recognized only in this industry, a reputation worth something only in this city—these are not gifts. They are tethers. They look like generosity, and the generosity is real, but the condition is the point. You have not been given space. You have been given a promise of space, and the promise is void if you leave.

So when you are offered a benefit, ask not what it is worth, but what it is conditional on. A benefit conditional on your staying is not a benefit. It is a longer leash. A benefit you can carry with you is space. The two look similar at the moment of the offer. They are opposites in the long run.

And the last thing about work, which is the thing most workers never notice: the business owner and the worker are in the same boat. They are both trading time for space, both trying to accumulate claims on alternatives, both subject to the same asymmetry between the two freedoms. The difference is not the kind of boat. It is the resources they start with, and the rate at which their claims compound. The owner begins with more space, and space compounds faster than wages do. The worker begins with less, and the wage buys less space each year. They are not in different games. They are in the same game, with different starting positions

and different rates of accumulation. That is the structure, and it is worth seeing clearly—not to stir resentment, but because a person who understands the game they are in plays it better than one who does not.

Governance is the lever at scale

Everything in this essay applies to a boss, a platform, a church. It also applies to a state—but a state is a lever with three features no other lever-holder has.

First, the state claims a monopoly on force. Most levers in this essay are voluntary: the agent can leave, and the lever-holder must restrain because the agent's exit would cost them. The state is the principal that can remove exit. It can jail you, fine you, conscript you, and in the extreme case kill you. This is why the convergence between ethics and durability—the reason decent arrangements tend to outlast exploitative ones—holds only within the domain where force is unavailable. The state is the principal that steps outside that domain. A state that can jail its citizens does not need their consent, and the arithmetic that restrains the ordinary lever-holder does not restrain it in the same way.

That is not a counsel of despair. It is a reason to be clear-eyed. The rest of this section is about what actually constrains a state, and it turns out to be the same thing that constrains every other lever-holder: alternatives, and the network of other levers around it.

Second, most of what a state does, most of the time, is voluntary. It does not jail most people. It issues permits and licenses, collects taxes, distributes benefits, employs public servants, approves regulations, certifies identity, recognizes contracts, and provides infrastructure. Each of these is a lever. The citizen wants the permit, the benefit, the recognition, the road; the state makes access conditional on compliance. For most citizens most of the time, the state is not a coercer but a lever-holder—and the five questions work on a government as well as on a boss.

Third, the state is the principal the agent cannot easily punish. A worker who leaves a bad employer imposes a cost. A citizen who leaves a bad state usually cannot, and even when they can, the state survives their departure. The citizen's exit threat is weak against a state. So what constrains it? The answer is the network. A state surrounded by other levers it does not control—a free press, independent courts, competitive elections, a plural civil society, federalism, international institutions—is a state whose own alternatives are multiplied. The citizen cannot personally leave the state. But the state can be constrained by the network of principals around it. This is why "many people to deal with" is a form of protection.

And this is the danger. The state is the only principal that can close the network. It can license competitors out of existence, regulate the press into silence, capture the courts, absorb the organizations that would otherwise check it, and control the formation environment through schools, media, and national narrative. When a state does all of these things, the network collapses into a single effective principal, and the extraction limit returns to the bilateral level. The word for this is not "governance." It is "capture."

So the questions for a state are parallel to the questions for a job. Is the state surrounded? Not "is it democratic"—the formal institutions can exist while the network has collapsed. Is it actually constrained by other levers it does not control? A free press that can be shut down is not a constraint. A court that can be packed is not a constraint. The question is whether the alternatives to the state's goods are real.

Is the state forming you? Every state shapes. The question is whether the shaping is in the

light or in the dark, whether there are alternative formation environments the state does not control, and whether you can ask the fifth question about your own political preferences without being unable to answer. A state that has captured the formation environment has captured the citizen's time as well as their space—and the citizen may not notice, because the preferences arrived already decided.

A state that is surrounded and does not form you is a state that has to earn your compliance. A state that is not surrounded, and does form you, is not a government. It is a lever-holder wearing the name of one. The difference is not a matter of ideology. It is the same difference the rest of this essay has been describing, at a larger scale—and it is worth seeing clearly, because it is the difference between a citizenry and an audience.

The third thing: they cannot use what they do not know

There is a catch for the lever-holder, and it is a big one.

To set the terms well, they have to know what you actually want. Too high a price and you refuse, or leave, or pretend to agree while quietly doing something else. Too low and they leave value on the table.

So the lever creates a demand for knowledge—and a demand for knowledge creates a whole apparatus to get it.

This is what confession is. What performance reviews are. What customer surveys, credit scores, background checks, recommendation algorithms and intelligence services are. They are all answers to the same question: what does this person actually want, and how much would they give for it?

And here is the corresponding truth for you: *your privacy is not a luxury. It is your leverage.*

If they cannot read you, they cannot price you. If they cannot price you, they must offer better terms. An unreadable person is a harder person to manage. This is why secrecy, discretion, and the simple habit of not telling everyone everything are not paranoia. They are strategy.

It is also why the answer is not "maximum secrecy." Total opacity has costs—you become untrustworthy, unemployable, alone. The right amount is the amount that keeps you from being fully predictable, without making you impossible to deal with. Opacity is a tool, not a religion.

And the practical form of this is smaller than it sounds. Being a bit unpredictable is a big deal. You do not need to be mysterious. You need to be slightly harder to price than the person who answers every question immediately, explains every decision, and does exactly what is expected. A small reserve—a habit of not replying at once, of not narrating every choice, of keeping some preferences private, of occasionally doing the unexpected thing—is enough to shift the terms. Not because it is dramatic, but because a person who can be fully read can be fully governed, and a person who cannot is a little bit freer than they were.

There is a second way to keep from being read, and it is more powerful than privacy. Instead of revealing nothing, you can reveal something false. You can let their apparatus do its work on a picture of you that you have arranged. The better their instruments, the more damage the false picture does—because the confidence of a reader who has read you well is the confidence of someone who will not check again.

This works. It is ancient. It is also a different instrument from privacy, and it carries a different cost.

Privacy is the refusal to be known. Deception is the manufacture of a false belief. The first says nothing and leaves them with less. The second says something untrue and leaves them with wrong. The first is a reserve. The second is a trick.

This essay takes the position that the first is part of the agent's legitimate counter-power and the second is not—not because deception never works, but because a world in which everyone manufactures false beliefs is a world in which no one can be trusted, and the person who suffers most from that is the person with the least power to verify. The strong can afford to be deceived once. The weak cannot afford to be deceived at all, and cannot afford to be the deceiver either, because the reputation for deceit falls hardest on those who have no other reputation to fall back on.

So: keep something to yourself. That is reserve, and it is yours. Be careful about what you put in its place.

The fourth thing: promises about the future need proof

Some levers pay out immediately. Do this, get that, today.

But the most powerful levers pay out later—and later is harder to trust. Heaven, promotion, pension, legacy, the long-term payoff of loyalty. The problem is that you cannot check whether the promise is real until it is too late.

So the lever-holder must invest in credibility. They build institutions, write texts, create rituals, train professionals, publish rules, submit to audits. All of this is machinery for making a future promise believable today.

Which means: when someone is selling you a future, ask what they have spent to make it believable. The answer tells you how seriously to take the offer.

The fifth thing—and this is the deepest one

Everything so far assumes you already know what you want.

But what if you don't? Or worse—what if what you want was put there?

A person who can shape what you desire does not need to bargain with you at all. They set the terms of the game before you sit down to play. They don't have to convince you to want the promotion, the product, the salvation, the body, the life. They make you want it, and then they sell it to you—and the exchange feels like your own choice, because as far as you can tell, it is.

This is the difference between being outmatched and being formed. The first you can notice. The second you usually cannot.

And it is everywhere. Education shapes what you find interesting. Advertising shapes what you find desirable. Media shapes what you find important. Communities shape what you find shameful. None of this is a conspiracy; most of it is done by people who believe they are helping. But the effect is the same. The most powerful lever is the one that makes you want what the lever-holder has to offer—and leaves you convinced the wanting was always yours.

There is a name for the condition in which this has gone all the way: *capture*. It is when you have no alternatives, and then you stop needing them, because you have absorbed their standard as your own. You don't feel controlled. You feel like yourself. That is precisely what makes it complete.

And this is the one lever that attacks both freedoms at once.

Think about what formation does. Your space is your alternatives. Your time is your pause. A principal who plants desires does not have to close your exits—he makes the exits lead back to him. And he does not have to take your time—he fills the pause before you notice it was there.

Your alternatives now point toward his goods, because those are the goods you want. And the pause, where you would ask *why do I want this?*, gets filled with an answer you did not choose—or it never opens at all, because the wanting arrived already decided.

This is why the fifth question is the hardest one, and the most important. *Are these wants yours?* It is the only question that works against a formation attack. And it can only be asked in the pause. Which means the formation principal is not primarily attacking your alternatives. He is attacking the pause itself—the moment in which you would notice that you need alternatives at all.

Keep the pause open. It is the front line.

So why doesn't the lever-holder simply take everything?

Because they usually can't—and this is the most hopeful part of the whole story.

The person holding the lever wants two things: to extract as much as possible, and to keep the lever in place. These two goals pull against each other.

Push too hard, and people leave. Or worse, they stop believing the promise was real, and the whole structure collapses. Every empire that overreached, every church that sold too openly, every company that squeezed its workers and customers at once—they all discovered the same thing. Extraction is easy. Durability is hard.

So the clever lever-holder restrains. Not out of kindness—out of arithmetic. They keep the terms tolerable because tolerable terms are what keep you in the game.

This is the quiet reason why ethical arrangements tend to outlast exploitative ones. It is not that virtue always wins. It is that the arrangement which respects your ability to leave is the arrangement that survives your ability to leave. Where force is available, this logic breaks down—a state that can jail you does not need your consent. But wherever the lever must be voluntary, the same conclusion keeps returning:

The conditions that make a relationship decent are the conditions that make it last.

Why "many people to deal with" is a form of protection

One more thing, because it explains a lot of the world.

When many people hold levers, and none of them dominates, you are safer. You can play them against each other. Your alternatives multiply. This is why competition protects consumers, why federalism protects citizens, why a free press protects the public, why a diversified set of relationships protects a person.

The danger comes when the many collapse into one—when the competitors merge, the agencies coordinate, the platforms consolidate, the interests align. That is when a network becomes captured, and when the many parties you thought you were dealing with turn out to be one.

Corruption, lobbying, and coercion look like different things. They are the same thing: the lever, operating among many players, before or after the moment when the many become one. The difference between a market and a cartel is not the number of participants. It is whether you can still walk away.

What to do with this

This is not a self-help program. It is a set of questions you can ask about any arrangement you are in—a job, a relationship, a platform, a church, a country.

Five of them.

Is it transparent? Do you know what is being asked of you, and what you get in return? Or is the deal deliberately fuzzy?

Can you leave? Not in theory—in practice. Could you actually go, without ruin? If not, you are not negotiating. You are complying.

Can you argue? Can you dispute the terms, or is the standard beyond question? An arrangement you can criticize is an arrangement that has to earn your loyalty.

Can you keep something to yourself? Or is every preference, every habit, every hesitation being read, measured, and priced?

And the hardest one: **are these wants yours?** Did you choose this goal, or did someone choose it for you and arrange for you to feel as though you had chosen it? If you cannot tell, that is itself the answer—and it is worth finding people and places that help you tell.

Five questions. They work on almost anything.

The last thing

Knowledge like this cuts both ways.

Told to the person holding the lever, it is a manual for extraction: here is how to find what they want, here is how to make the terms stick, here is how to keep them from noticing.

Told to the person under the lever, it is something else entirely. It is a language for naming what is happening, and a map of where the exits are.

There is no neutral version. Anyone who claims to offer one is keeping something back.

And that is the final point, and the reason this essay is written the way it is. The deepest form of power is not the power to make you obey. It is the power to keep you from understanding the arrangement you are in—to make the lever invisible, and your compliance feel like character.

The antidote is not suspicion. It is literacy. Not cynicism—most people holding levers are not villains, and most arrangements are not traps. But you should know the shape of the thing, because the shape is always the same, whether it is a boss or a state or a screen or a god.

So: know what you want. Know what you would give for it. Know what you would do instead. And know what the arrangement is asking of you.

That is not cynicism. It is the ordinary care you would take with anything valuable—including your own time.

A coda

One last thing, and it is the thing this essay cannot give you.

Reading all of this does not make you immune. A person can know the mechanism, name it, teach it, and still be moved by someone who has read the same pages and decided to use them. A highly skilled and competent lever-holder—the kind people call a grandmaster—does not need you to be ignorant. He needs you to be human. He will agree with you about the lever, praise your clarity, and stand beside you while you inspect everyone else's terms. You will feel lucid and free. You will not notice that you have stopped inspecting his.

No essay can protect you from that. The five questions are useful against the ordinary lever-holder. They are not a shield against the extraordinary one, because the extraordinary one does not attack your understanding. He recruits it.

Against that, the only thing that has ever worked is a person—someone who knows you well enough to notice when you have stopped asking, and who does not need you to be the one who sees clearly. Not a theory. A witness.

But the same is true on the other side, and the essay would be dishonest if it only warned the agent. The principal is not immune either. Reading all of this does not make a lever-holder wise; it makes them better at holding the lever. A principal who has read these pages can now see every instrument at once—the standard, the discovery apparatus, the credibility investment, the formation of desire—and the temptation is to use them all. The temptation is not to become a grandmaster. It is to become a flawless one, and to mistake the absence of obvious extraction for the presence of justice.

The principal's coda has its own five questions, and they are not the same as the agent's.

Is this arrangement one you would defend to the person under it, in plain language, with the terms on the table? Not "would they accept it"—they might, under conditions you have arranged. Would you defend it, aloud, to them?

Could the person under this lever leave without ruin, and would they still stay if they could? If they would not stay, ask what you are relying on. It may be love. It may be lock-in. The two look different from the inside of the principal's position, and they look identical from the outside.

Are you shaping their desires, and if so, are you willing to say so—to them, and to yourself? Every principal shapes. The question is not whether, but whether you are doing it in the light or in the dark, and whether you would still do it if they knew.

Is there a witness on your side too? The agent needs someone who will tell them when they have stopped asking. The principal needs someone who will tell them when they have started taking. The two are different people, and a principal without the second is already on the way to being the kind of lever-holder this essay began by describing.

And the hardest one, which is the principal's version of the agent's fifth question: **is the good you are offering yours, or is it the good that happens to serve you?** Most principals never ask this, because the answer is uncomfortable. The ones who ask it, and who are willing to be changed by the answer, are the ones who can hold a lever without becoming captured by it.

That is the principal's coda, and it is not a softer one. It is harder, because the principal has more to lose and more room to rationalize. The agent's danger is being formed. The principal's danger is being flattered—by the agents who accept, by the institutions that confirm, by the small daily evidence that the arrangement is working. The principal who is never contradicted is a principal who is already being governed by the people around them, and does not know it.

The lever is defeated by alternatives, and the alternatives are built by people whose interests

might not align wholly with yours. That is the last and plainest thing this essay has to say, and it is true on both sides of the lever. The rest is up to who is standing next to you—and how honestly the two of you can talk about what each of you wants.

A note on the text: the intellectual machinery behind this essay—the formal model of the lever, the contests over discovery and formation, the network theory of corruption and capture, and the analyses of work and governance as levers—is developed in a longer academic paper. This essay is the plain-language version. It is meant to be read on its own, and it is meant to be shared.

Part IV

Political Theory

The Ledger of Power:

Politics, Governance, and Government in a Theory of Reciprocal Relations

Macharia Barii

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Abstract

This paper presents a unified theory of politics, governance, and government through the lens of the *ledger*. Civilization is understood as an institutionalized order of reciprocal relations between actors. These relations can be tracked on a ledger that records shares, contributions, exit costs, voice, and their corresponding thresholds. From this observation, three distinct, yet coupled operations emerge: politics as the contestation of the ledger, governance as its maintenance, and government as the specialized apparatus through which governance is conducted. The theory formalizes these operations, derives five propositions that constrain their behavior, and applies them to a contemporary diagnosis of the global order. It concludes with five structural levers for rebalancing the ledger, arguing that the deepest of these is the discount rate of the coalition that sustains government. The crisis of the contemporary order is not one of morality, but one of parameters.

Keywords: ledger, politics, governance, government, reciprocity, exit costs, voice, legitimacy, coalitions, structural asymmetry

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1 Introduction

Every civilization is, at its core, a set of relations. Who gives, who gains, who loses, and how these distributions are justified form the substance of social order [8, 3]. This set of relations is herein referred to as *the ledger*. It is not metaphorical alone, but structural. Every stable order institutionalizes some distribution of shares, obligations, and access to voice, whilst simultaneously imposing costs for the act of departure from its relations.

The question that follows is an operational one: by what means are these distributions contested, maintained, and adjusted over time? This paper argues that the answers to these questions are best captured by three concepts that are often conflated: *politics*, *governance*, and *government*. Whilst interdependent, each fulfills a distinct verb within the life of a civilization. Politics contests the ledger, governance maintains it, and government is the apparatus that enacts governance on behalf of a coalition. Together, these three form the machinery by which order is either rebalanced, or eroded [5, 7].

2 The Ledger: A Theory of Reciprocal Relations

Let a civilization be defined as a network of actors and relations.

Definition 2.1 (Civilization)**.** *A civilization* Γ *is a pair* $\Gamma = (N, E)$ *where* N *is a set of actors and* E *is a set of institutionalized relations between them.*

For each relation $e \in E$ involving actor i, the ledger tracks a vector of terms.

Definition 2.2 (The State of the Ledger)**.** *The state of the ledger* S *is given by*

$$S = \{(s_i^e,\ c_i^e,\ k_i^e,\ v_i^e) : i \in N,\ e \in E\}$$

where $s_i^e \in (0,1)$ *is the share of benefits accruing to actor* i *within relation* e*,* c_i^e *their contributions to it,* $k_i^e \in (0,\infty)$ *their exit cost from relation* e*, and* $v_i^e \in (0,1)$ *their voice within relation* e*. Furthermore, each relation is bounded by thresholds, namely the acceptance threshold* $\bar{a}_i$ *and the rupture threshold* ρ_i*, the crossing of which produces grievance and the potential for contestation.*

The viability of the ledger is defined by its ability to remain below an injustice threshold whilst within its set of viable distributions. Let V be the viability set of all possible states S that do not induce systemic rupture, and let $\bar{G}$ be the injustice threshold. The *injustice gap* $G(S)$ is the distance of a given state S from the viability set V. For any order to persist, the mechanisms of justice within it must reduce $G(S)$ faster than the forces of drift increase it.

3 Distinguishing Politics, Governance, and Government

With the ledger established, the three operations can be defined with precision.

Definition 3.1 (Politics)**.** *Politics is the contestation of the ledger. It is the set of actions by which actors attempt to change, defend, or justify the terms of their relations; specifically,* s_i^e*,* c_i^e*,* k_i^e*,* v_i^e*,* $\bar{a}_i$*, and* ρ_i*.*

Definition 3.2 (Governance)**.** *Governance is the maintenance of the ledger. It is the set of institutions and practices by which the terms of relations are reproduced over time. Its instruments are enforcement, adjudication, monitoring, coordination, and repair.*

Definition 3.3 (Government)**.** *Government is the specialized apparatus through which governance is conducted. It is an organizational form—the bureaucracy, the legislature, the court, the army, and the treasury—that carries out governance on behalf of some coalition of actors.*

These distinctions are not semantic. Politics can exist without government (as seen within kinship groups or stateless orders contesting shares through custom). Governance can exist without a state (as seen within guilds, religious orders, or private arbitration). Government is but one form of governance amongst many, and politics is not confined to the ballot box, but occurs in the workplace, the household, the market, and beyond [2, 5].

4 Formalization

These concepts can be formalized to express their coupling.

Let $\Gamma = (N, E)$ and S be the state of the ledger as defined above.

- **Politics:** The set of political claims is given by the map

$$P : S \to 2^S$$

  where each element of $P(S)$ is a proposed alternative state S' representing a claim to reallocate shares, alter exit costs, redistribute voice, or change the terms of relation as a whole.

- **Governance:** The act of governance is the operation that maintains, enforces, or adjusts the ledger, represented by

$$G : S \to S$$

  This operation either realizes one of the claims present in $P(S)$, or actively maintains the status quo against them.

- **Government:** A government is a particular instantiation of governance paired with its apparatus, such that

$$\text{Gov} = (G,\ \text{Org})$$

  where Org is the set of roles, procedures, and resources by which G is implemented [4, 9].

5 Core Propositions

From the above, five propositions organize the theory.

Proposition 5.1 (Politics is endogenous to the ledger)**.** *For any relation with $s_i^e \in (0, 1)$ and $k_i^e < \infty$, political activity is generated. An actor with $n_i^e < \bar{a}_i$ has an incentive to alter the terms of the relation through voice, exit, coercion, or appeal to a third party. The absence of visible politics is, more often than not, indicative of the suppression or atomization of grievance, rather than its non-existence.*

Proposition 5.2 (Governance is the technology of equilibrium)**.** *Governance is the operationalization of a justice regime. It is effective if and only if it reduces the injustice gap G faster than disequilibrium forces increase it, keeping the ledger within the viability set V and below the injustice threshold $\bar{G}$.*

Proposition 5.3 (Government is a coalitional instrument)**.** *Every government implements some coalition's preferred G. The weights of this governance function, often represented by a weighting vector λ_i, are set by the coalition that controls Org. A government's claim to govern for "all" is empirically testable: it holds true if G moves the ledger towards viability for all actors, and false if it does so at the expense of others.*

Proposition 5.4 (Legitimacy is the cost of governance)**.** *Let L be the legitimacy of a government and $\Phi(G, L)$ be the cost of achieving a given level of compliance. Then $\Phi(G, L)$ is strictly decreasing in L. As L declines, governments must substitute compliance for repression, causing $\Phi(G, L)$ to rise. Legitimacy is, therefore, a fiscal and administrative variable, not a mere moral ornament.*

Proposition 5.5 (The three are coupled)**.** *Politics, governance, and government are inseparable. Politics generates claims for governance to adjudicate, governance requires government to be implemented, and government is continuously shaped by the political coalitions that sustain it. These three are the contestation, maintenance, and apparatus of the same ledger.*

6 What These Terms Are Not

Disciplining the vocabulary is crucial to avoid category errors.

- **Politics is not merely elections.** Elections are one institution amongst many for aggregating claims. The vast majority of politics takes place outside of them, within labor negotiations, household divisions of care, market power, and the international order [2].
- **Governance is not merely administration.** Administration is the execution of decisions. Governance is the active maintenance of viability. A state can be impeccably administered whilst presiding over a parasitic equilibrium, failing at governance in the substantive sense. The metric of governance is the trajectory of G, not bureaucratic throughput.
- **Government is not the sole governor.** Markets govern through prices and exit, religions through norms and sanctions, kinship through obligation, and digital platforms through algorithms and terms of service. The state is one governor amongst many, and in the contemporary order, it is not necessarily the most consequential [7, 10].

7 The Contemporary Diagnosis

Applied to the present global order, the ledger framework yields a diagnosis of disarticulation.

- **Politics without aggregation.** The ledger is now global, bound together by supply chains, sovereign debt, data extraction, and carbon extraction. However, the classical political channels that aggregate claims remain predominantly national. Claims circulate, but they do not aggregate, producing politics without a mechanism of collective decision making.
- **Governance without a governor.** Governance is split. National governments govern labor, welfare, and borders. Markets govern capital, prices, and credit. Platforms govern attention, data, and increasingly, labor. Religions govern identity and obligation. No single governor is accountable for the ledger as a whole, leaving its viability ungoverned in aggregate.

- **Government without sovereignty.** Contemporary governments are structurally captured by the mobile factor. Due to the exit asymmetry between capital and labor ($k_{capital} \ll k_{labor}$), capital possesses an effective, implicit veto over any governance function G that would raise its exit costs or lower its share. This skews the weighting vector λ_i towards capital not necessarily by conspiracy, but by structural compulsion.

Together, these form an order that is stable, yet illegitimate. Reform is difficult not for lack of will, but because the parameters that structure the game are misaligned against rebalancing [7, 10].

8 Levers For Reform

The framework does not prescribe policy, but identifies changeable parameters that politics may act upon.

1. **Exit equalization.** The deepest source of asymmetry is the differential cost of exit. Equalizing exit costs—through capital controls, the removal of predatory barriers to mobility, and universal basic services that lower the cost of leaving a bad relation—raises the extraction ceiling for all actors simultaneously.

2. **Voice expansion.** Asymmetries in v_i^e skew bargaining power [1]. Expanding voice through unions, sectoral representation, collective bargaining, and democratic platform governance is necessary to correct the bargaining imbalance.

3. **Legitimacy investment.** Rather than investing in the *performance* of legitimacy, governments must invest in its substance through actual justice. Doing so lowers $\Phi(G, L)$, decreasing reliance on repression whilst increasing the capacity to govern.

4. **Discount rate reduction.** Perhaps the most consequential parameter is the discount rate r of the sustaining coalition. A high r incentivizes short-term extraction at the cost of hosts, whilst a low r incentivizes their conservation. Institutions that lengthen time horizons—constitutional constraints, long-horizon sovereign funds, intergenerational trustees, and ecological accounting—are, by this measure, deeply political.

5. **Justice mechanism activation.** For a justice regime to be effective, its mechanisms J must outrun the drift of the ledger. Courts, reparations, redistribution, and structural reform are not discretionary acts of charity, but the operational requirements of governance itself.

Of these five, the discount rate of the coalition sustaining government is the deepest lever. It determines the priorities that shape the weighting of λ_i, and by extension, the direction of G itself [6].

9 Conclusion

Politics, governance, and government are not separate from civilization. They are its verbs. Politics is the contestation of the ledger; governance is its maintenance; and government is the apparatus through which that maintenance is conducted.

A healthy civilization aggregates its claims, reduces its injustice gap through effective governance, and enacts that governance through a government whose weighting vector serves the viability of the whole, not solely the coalition that sustains it. The contemporary order fails on all three counts. These failures are structural, produced by asymmetries in exit, voice, and time preference.

However, structure is not fate. The ledger's parameters are changeable through political action. A civilization that equalizes exit, expands voice, invests in legitimacy, lowers its discount rate, and activates its justice mechanisms moves towards symbiosis. One that does the opposite moves towards collapse. There is no third path. The task of politics, therefore, is not to ask if the ledger can be rebalanced, but whether the forces contesting it can do so before it breaks.

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Principles of Politics and War

A Citizen's Guide to the Contest Over the Ledger

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Abstract

This essay offers twelve principles for understanding political contest, from the smallest quarrel to the largest war. The principles are drawn from a single observation: civilization is a set of relations among people—who gives, who gains, who loses, and how that is justified. This set of relations is what the essay calls the ledger. The contest over the ledger produces an allocation, and the outcome that establishes the allocation is what the essay calls the verdict. The principles describe how the ledger is structured, how it is contested, and how it is rebalanced. The essay then offers a method of evaluation—six tests that can be applied to any verdict—and practical advice to the parties who contest the ledger, in democracies, in dictatorships, and in civil wars. It distinguishes conflict from crime, terror, and predation, and it defines peace not as the absence of conflict but as the presence of the conditions under which conflict can be conducted. It does not tell the reader what to conclude; it tells the reader what to look at. The essay is short because it is meant to be used.

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Preface

This essay is short because it is meant to be used. It is not a treatise on political philosophy. It is a list of principles—things to look at, things to understand, things to notice—that together describe the structure of every political contest, from the smallest quarrel to the largest war.

The principles are drawn from a simple observation: civilization is a set of relations among people. Who gives, who gains, who loses, and how that is justified. This set of relations is what this essay calls **the ledger**. Everything else—the institutions, the ideologies, the wars, the peace treaties—is an outcome of the ledger and the contest over it.

Once you see the contest as a contest over the ledger, a great deal becomes clear that was previously mysterious. Why some conflicts are negotiated and others are fought. Why some orders last and others collapse. Why the same person can be a reformer in one context and a conservative in another. Why the claim to neutrality is always a claim made from a position.

The essay offers twelve principles, a method of evaluation, practical advice to the parties, and a definition of peace. The principles and the method are not a list of conclusions. They are a list of things to look at. If you learn to look at them, you will see what most public debate conceals.

What the Ledger Is

Before the principles, the central terms. **A ledger is the set of relations among a group of people, described by what each party contributes, what each party receives, and how the difference is justified.**

Every relation can be described in five dimensions:

- **Contribution:** what each party puts in—labor, money, time, loyalty, obedience.
- **Benefit:** what each party gets out—income, security, status, protection, meaning.
- **Exit:** whether each party can leave the relation if it is unsatisfactory.
- **Voice:** whether each party can speak, criticize, organize, and renegotiate.
- **Justification:** the story that makes the relation appear natural, necessary, and just.

When the benefits exceed the costs for both parties, the relation is **symbiotic**. When one party extracts more than it gives while the other survives, the relation is **parasitic**. When one party extracts by destroying the other's capacity to survive, the relation is **predatory**.

Every civilization is a mix of all three. The question is never whether a civilization is good or bad in the abstract. The question is which relations are symbiotic, which are parasitic, which are predatory, and who occupies each position.

What the Allocation Is

The ledger is the structure of relations. But the ledger is not static. The parties in different positions contest the terms of their relations, and the contest produces a distribution—who gets what share of the surplus, who can leave, who can speak, how long the horizon is, and how the whole is justified.

That distribution is what this essay calls **the allocation**. **An allocation is the distribution of the ledger at a given moment.** It is not the ledger itself. The ledger is the set of

relations; the allocation is the distribution of benefits, costs, exit, voice, and horizon across the parties in those relations.

The allocation has four components:

- **Shares:** who receives what proportion of the surplus.
- **Exit costs:** who can leave, and at what cost.
- **Voice:** who can speak, criticize, organize, and renegotiate.
- **Horizon:** how long the parties can expect the allocation to last.

Every allocation is a *positional* distribution. It is not just in the abstract; it is good for some parties and bad for others. The parties who benefit from the allocation defend it. The parties who bear its cost attack it.

What the Verdict Is

The ledger is contested. The parties in different positions disagree about the terms of their relations. They contest those terms through politics or through war. The contest produces an outcome—a settlement, a constitution, a treaty, a revolution, a conquest—that establishes the allocation.

That outcome is what this essay calls **the verdict**. **A verdict is the outcome of a contest over the ledger.** It is the event or process that establishes the allocation—the distribution of shares, exit costs, voice, and horizon across the parties.

The verdict has three features. **First, the verdict establishes an allocation.** It determines the shares, the exit costs, the voice, and the horizon. It is not a principle, a value, or a justification. It is a distribution of the ledger. **Second, the verdict is produced by a contest.** It is not given by nature, by God, or by reason. It is the outcome of the struggle between the parties. **Third, the verdict is justified after it is produced.** The justification is not the cause of the verdict. It is the residue. The winners construct a legitimacy regime that makes the verdict appear natural, necessary, and just.

What Conflict Is and Is Not

The essay uses the word "conflict" in a technical sense, and the technical sense must be distinguished from the common sense.

Conflict is the contest over the allocation. It is the disagreement among parties about how the ledger should be distributed. The disagreement is expressed through claims, through arguments, through organizing, through institutions, and—when the institutions fail—through force. The parties in conflict are contesting the terms of their relations, and both parties have a claim, however partial, to the allocation they seek.

Conflict is not the same as crime. **Crime is the violation of the rules that govern the contest.** The criminal does not contest the allocation; the criminal takes from it. The criminal is not a party in the contest; the criminal is a predator on the contest.

Conflict is not the same as terror. **Terror is the use of violence against non-combatants to produce fear for political ends.** The terrorist does not contest the allocation through the means that the contest provides; the terrorist attacks the conditions of the contest itself. The terrorist is not a party in the contest; the terrorist is an enemy of the contest.

Conflict is not the same as predation. **Predation is the extraction that destroys the host's capacity to survive.** The predator does not contest the allocation; the predator consumes it. The predator is not a party in the contest; the predator is a parasite that has become lethal.

The test is threefold. **First, is the party contesting the allocation, or extracting from it? Second, is the party using the means of the contest, or attacking the conditions of the contest? Third, is the party subject to the verdict, or does the party refuse the verdict?**

Part I: The Structure

1 Every Order Is a Ledger

Every human order—a family, a firm, a state, an empire—is a ledger of relations. Someone contributes labor, money, time, or loyalty. Someone receives the benefit. Someone can leave. Someone can speak. The relation has a structure: who gives, who gets, who can exit, who can voice, how long the horizon is, and how the whole is justified.

The monument is not the order. The monument is the output. The order is the ledger of relations that produced it. Look at the ledger, not the monument.

2 Every Relation Has a Position

Every relation has two sides. The employer and the worker. The ruler and the ruled. The creditor and the debtor. The colonizer and the colonized. The position is the place a party occupies in the relation—what they contribute, what they receive, whether they can leave, whether they can speak.

The position is not the same as the person. A good person can occupy a position that benefits them and harms others. A bad person can occupy a position that costs them and benefits others. The position is structural. The person is incidental. To understand a relation, look at the positions, not the personalities.

3 Whether a Relation Is Good or Bad Depends on Your Position

This is the first principle of all conflict. A relation is not good or bad in itself. It is good for those who benefit from it and bad for those who bear its cost. The same wage contract is good for the employer and bad for the worker. The same tax is good for the beneficiary and bad for the payer. The same border is good for those inside and bad for those outside.

There is no neutral position from which to evaluate the relation, because every evaluation is made from a position. The person who claims to evaluate from nowhere is either occupying a position they do not acknowledge or speaking for a coalition they do not name. The claim to neutrality is itself a position.

4 Those Who Benefit Defend; Those Who Bear the Cost Attack

Once you see the principle of position, the engine of conflict becomes visible. Those who benefit from the current allocation defend it. Those who bear the cost attack it. Both are responding rationally to their position.

The beneficiary defends with arguments, with institutions, with legitimacy regimes, and—when necessary—with force. The cost-bearer attacks with arguments, with organizing, with resistance, and—when necessary—with force. Neither is wicked. Both are positioned. The conflict is not about values. It is about positions. The values are the vocabulary; the positions are the substance.

Part II: The Contest

5 Politics and War Are the Same Contest, Judged by Different Means

Politics and war are not opposites. They are the same contest—the contest over the allocation—judged by different means.

Politics is the peaceful contest. The parties disagree about the terms of the relation, and they contest those terms through institutions: elections, courts, legislatures, bargaining, protest, organizing. The contest is peaceful because the parties believe the institutions can produce a verdict they can accept.

War is the violent contest. The parties disagree about the terms of the relation, and they contest those terms through force. The contest is violent because the parties no longer believe the institutions can produce an acceptable verdict.

The difference is not the nature of the contest. It is the mechanism of judgment. Politics uses institutions to produce the verdict. War uses force to produce the verdict. Both are judges. Both produce verdicts. Both establish the allocation.

This is why politics has all the characteristics of war. The coalitions, the strategies, the costs, the stakes—they are the same in politics as in war. The difference is that politics is conducted under rules that both sides believe will bind. When the rules stop binding, politics descends to war. The descent is not a departure from politics. It is politics continuing by other means, because the political means have failed.

6 Entrenchment Leads to War; Negotiability Leads to Politics

The choice between politics and war is not a choice the parties make. It is a choice the structure makes for them.

If positions and outcomes are entrenched—if the parties believe the current allocation cannot be changed through the available institutions—then war is the likely verdict. The beneficiaries have locked in their advantage. The cost-bearers have no path to redress. Politics becomes a ritual that reproduces the status quo. The cost-bearers conclude that the only path to change is force.

If positions and outcomes are negotiable—if the parties believe the current allocation can be changed through the available institutions—then politics is the likely verdict. The beneficiaries

are willing to make concessions. The cost-bearers have a path to redress. Politics becomes a genuine contest.

The conditions that make politics possible are the conditions that make the order negotiable: equal exit costs, expanded voice, a broad selectorate, a long time horizon. The conditions that make war likely are the conditions that entrench the positions: asymmetric exit costs, concentrated voice, a narrow selectorate, a short time horizon.

The reform of the structure matters more than the persuasion of the parties. You cannot persuade an entrenched coalition to accept a negotiation it believes it will lose. You can only change the structure so that the negotiation is possible.

7 The Justification Comes After the Verdict

The standard story presents the order as justified first and established second: the parties agree on the principles, and then they build the institutions. The framework says: the parties contest the allocation, the contest is judged by politics or by war, the verdict establishes the allocation, and then the justification is created to make the verdict appear natural.

This is why every legitimacy regime has a retrospective quality. It is the verdict's memory, dressed as the verdict's cause. The divine right of kings was created after the conquest. The Mandate of Heaven was created after the war. The racial hierarchy was created after the colonization. In each case, the verdict came first, and the justification came after.

The implication is that the justification can always be contested by returning to the verdict. If you want to challenge a legitimacy regime, you do not argue with its principles. You return to the verdict that produced it—the conquest, the seizure, the first allocation—and you ask: who won, who lost, and on what basis? The justification cannot survive the return, because the justification is designed to conceal the verdict, and the return exposes it.

Part III: The Rebalancing

8 The Justice Mechanism Rebalances the Drift

Every order drifts out of balance over time. The concentration of wealth, the decay of legitimacy, the accumulation of grievance—these are the drift. The question is how the order rebalances.

The justice mechanism—courts, elections, redistribution, reform, revolution, war—reduces the injustice gap when the gap becomes too wide. It operates on the accepted allocation, not on the verdict. It adjusts the drift from the verdict, not the verdict itself.

This is why the justice mechanism is always partial. It can make the order less unjust without making it just. The verdict remains; the drift is corrected. The result is a new allocation, but not a new foundation.

9 Institutional Justice Adjusts; Revolutionary Justice Replaces

There are two kinds of justice mechanisms, and they do different things.

Institutional justice—courts, elections, redistribution, reform—adjusts the drift. It accepts the verdict as given and rebalances the allocation that the verdict produced. It is cheap, incremental, and preserves the foundation.

Revolutionary justice—revolution, war, collapse—re-judges the verdict. It does not accept the verdict as given; it contests the foundation itself. It is costly, radical, and replaces the foundation.

The choice between them is determined by the structure. If the drift can be adjusted, the institutional mechanism operates. If the drift cannot be adjusted, the revolutionary mechanism operates. The first is preferable when it is possible. The second is inevitable when the first is not.

10 The Cost of Adjustment Is Borne by Those Who Cannot Leave

When the order rebalances, someone bears the cost. In an institutional adjustment, the cost is shared—through taxation, redistribution, and reform. In a collapse, the cost is borne by the population—through famine, war, displacement, and death.

The coalition is protected by its resources, its mobility, and its access to the state. The population is exposed by its immobility, its dependence, and its exclusion. The asymmetry of exposure is the deepest structural fact of any order.

Look at who pays when the order adjusts. That tells you whose capacity the order is willing to consume.

Part IV: The Judgment

11 There Is No View from Nowhere

The framework can describe the whole ledger—all the relations, all the parties, all the shares, all the exit costs, all the voice. But the description is always made from a position. There is no view from nowhere.

The analyst who describes the whole is occupying the position of the analyst—the position of the person who has chosen to see the whole rather than the part. That choice is itself a position. It is not neutral, because there is no neutral position. It is *structural*, and the structural view is always taken from somewhere, even when it describes the whole.

This is the framework's honesty. It does not claim to be neutral. It claims to be structural. And the structural view is always a positioned view—a view that knows it is a view, and that knows the position from which it is taken.

12 The Question Is Always the Same

The question is not "is this order just?" The question is "just for whom?" The answer is always the same: just for those who benefit, unjust for those who bear the cost. The question is not answered by the framework. It is made possible by the framework.

The question is: *whose ledger is this, and for whom?*

The answer depends on the position. And the position is a fact about the ledger, not a choice about morality. The framework does not resolve the contest. It makes the contest visible as a contest—not as a dispute between truth and error, but as a contest between positions in a structure.

Part V: The Evaluation

13 Evaluating Verdicts

The twelve principles describe how contests work. They do not tell you which side should have won. But they give you a way to *evaluate* the verdict—not in the abstract, but case by case, using six tests.

Test 1: Did the Verdict Broaden the Coalition or Narrow It?

A verdict broadens the coalition when it includes more actors in the decision-making that governs the ledger. A verdict narrows the coalition when it concentrates decision-making in fewer actors. Measure the selectorate before and after the verdict.

Test 2: Did the Verdict Equalize Exit or Entrench It?

A verdict equalizes exit when it reduces the asymmetry of exit costs between the parties. A verdict entrenches exit when it increases the asymmetry. Measure the exit costs before and after.

Test 3: Did the Verdict Expand Voice or Concentrate It?

A verdict expands voice when it increases the capacity of actors to speak, criticize, organize, and renegotiate. A verdict concentrates voice when it reduces that capacity or concentrates it in fewer actors. Measure the four freedoms—media, speech, assembly, association—before and after.

Test 4: Did the Verdict Reduce the Injustice Gap or Widen It?

A verdict reduces the injustice gap when it brings the distribution of benefits closer to the distribution of contributions. A verdict widens the gap when it moves the two further apart. The test is not the total surplus; the test is the distribution relative to the contributions.

Test 5: Did the Verdict Lengthen the Horizon or Shorten It?

A verdict lengthens the horizon when it creates institutions that extend the time horizon of governance beyond the current coalition. A verdict shortens the horizon when it concentrates decision-making in actors whose tenure is short. The test is: does the verdict create institutions that outlast the coalition that established them?

Test 6: Did the Verdict Earn Its Legitimacy or Manufacture It?

A verdict earns its legitimacy when the population accepts it because the verdict actually reduces the injustice gap. A verdict manufactures its legitimacy when the population accepts it because the coalition has constructed a story that conceals the gap. Do not measure the population's consent; measure the gap that the consent is based on.

The Method as a Whole

The six tests are not independent. They interact. A verdict that broadens the coalition but entrenches exit is not fully just. A verdict that equalizes exit but concentrates voice is not fully just. The tests must be applied together, and the verdict must be evaluated on the whole.

Part VI: Advice to the Parties

14 Advice to Those Who Benefit

If you are benefiting from the current allocation, your problem is that the allocation is contested. Your goal is to preserve the allocation, or to adjust it in ways that preserve your position.

First, broaden the coalition. The most durable way to preserve an allocation is to broaden the coalition that supports it. If more actors benefit from the allocation, more actors will defend it. This means sharing the benefits, not hoarding them.

Second, earn the legitimacy. A legitimacy regime that is manufactured is fragile; a legitimacy regime that is earned is durable. If the population consents because the allocation actually serves them, the consent is stable.

Third, institutionalize the adjustment. The most stable allocations are those that have built-in mechanisms for adjustment. Courts, elections, redistribution, and reform are not threats to the allocation; they are the mechanisms that keep it from drifting so far that it collapses.

Fourth, lengthen the horizon. A short horizon is the enemy of a durable allocation. The way to lengthen the horizon is to create institutions that outlast the current coalition.

Fifth, accept the verdict when it goes against you. This is the hardest strategy, and it is the one that distinguishes a durable democracy from a fragile one. The beneficiaries who accept the verdict when they lose are the ones who preserve the system that allows them to win when they win.

15 Advice to Those Who Bear the Cost

If you are bearing the cost of the current allocation, your problem is that the allocation is entrenched. Your goal is to change the allocation, or to change the structure that produces it.

First, build the coalition. A single party cannot change the allocation. A coalition can. The first task is to build a coalition of the parties who bear the cost, and to bring in the parties who are neutral or who could be persuaded.

Second, use the available institutions. In a democracy, the available institutions are elections, courts, legislatures, and the four freedoms. These institutions are imperfect, but they are the ones that exist. Use them, not because they are sufficient, but because they are the available tools.

Third, expand the four freedoms. The four freedoms—media, speech, assembly, association—are the conditions under which the parties who bear the cost can organize. If the freedoms are restricted, the parties cannot organize, and the allocation cannot be changed.

Fourth, change the structure, not just the allocation. The allocation is the outcome; the structure is the cause. If the parties who bear the cost only contest the allocation, they will win a battle and lose the war. If they contest the structure, they can change the terms on which future allocations are produced.

Fifth, be patient but not passive. The contest over the allocation is long. The parties who bear the cost will not win in a single election, a single court case, or a single protest. They will win through a long series of small victories, each of which changes the structure a little.

Sixth, prepare for the verdict to go against you. The verdict will sometimes go against the parties who bear the cost. When it does, the response should not be to abandon the system; it should be to prepare for the next contest.

16 Advice Specific to Democracy

In a democracy, negotiation is the norm and the election is the verdict.

First, the election is not the only verdict. The election is one verdict among many. Courts, legislatures, regulatory agencies, and the four freedoms all produce verdicts. The parties should contest all of them, not only the election.

Second, the negotiation is not the surrender. Negotiation is the process by which the parties adjust the allocation without war. The parties who negotiate are not surrendering; they are participating in the process that produces the allocation.

Third, the majority is not the whole. In a democracy, the majority wins the election. But the majority is not the whole, and the whole is what the allocation must serve if it is to be durable. The majority that ignores the minority is a majority that will be a minority in the next election.

Fourth, the verdict is not the end. The verdict is the outcome of one contest. The contest continues. The parties who win the verdict should not treat it as the end; they should treat it as a stage in a longer process.

Part VII: Advice to Those in Dictatorships and Civil Wars

The advice to the parties in a democracy assumes that the four freedoms exist, that the election is a verdict, and that the negotiation is available. None of these assumptions holds in a dictatorship or a civil war.

17 The Structural Difference

The dictatorship is a structure in which the coalition is narrow, the selectorate is narrower, the voice is suppressed, the exit is blocked, and the verdict is produced by force. The civil war is a structure in which the contest has already moved from politics to war, and the verdict is being produced by the violence itself.

18 Advice to Those in a Dictatorship

First, survive. The first priority is survival. The dictatorship's most powerful weapon is the threat of death, imprisonment, or exile. Survival means: avoid unnecessary risk, protect your identity, build networks of trust, and maintain the capacity to act when the opportunity comes.

Second, build the invisible coalition. In a dictatorship, the coalition cannot be built openly. It must be built invisibly—through networks of trust, through shared grievances, through the small solidarities of daily life.

Third, preserve the truth. The dictatorship's legitimacy regime is a concealment of the allocation. The first task of the cost-bearers is to preserve the truth that the regime conceals—the truth about the allocation, the truth about the violence, the truth about the gap between the claim and the reality.

Fourth, wait for the fracture. Every dictatorship eventually fractures. The coalition splits, the legitimacy regime fails, the security forces hesitate, the economy collapses. The fracture is the opportunity.

Fifth, build the alternative institutions. The cost-bearers who build alternative institutions—mutual aid, parallel education, underground media, informal justice—are building the institutions that will replace the dictatorship when it falls.

Sixth, accept the risks. The dictatorship is a structure in which the cost-bearers who act face the risk of death, imprisonment, and exile. The framework cannot pretend otherwise. The cost-bearers who act are accepting the risk. The cost-bearers who do not act are accepting a different risk. The choice between the risks is the cost-bearer's own.

19 Advice to Those in a Civil War

First, identify the verdict. In a civil war, the verdict is not the election; it is the outcome of the violence. The parties who win the violence will produce the verdict, and the verdict will establish the allocation in their favor.

Second, protect the population. The population is the party that bears the cost of the civil war. It is also the party that the warring factions are trying to mobilize. The cost-bearers who protect the population—through safe zones, humanitarian corridors, and civilian protection—are the ones who preserve the capacity that the verdict will need.

Third, negotiate the settlement. The civil war will end, eventually, in a settlement or a victory. The cost-bearers who are prepared to negotiate the settlement are the ones who can shape it.

Fourth, prepare for the transitional justice. The civil war will produce a verdict, and the verdict will establish an allocation. The allocation will be contested, and the contest will be conducted through transitional justice—trials, truth commissions, reparations, amnesties.

Fifth, rebuild the four freedoms. The civil war destroys the four freedoms. The cost-bearers who rebuild the four freedoms are the ones who restore the conditions of the contest.

Sixth, accept the verdict when it goes against you. The civil war will produce a verdict, and the verdict will sometimes go against the cost-bearers. When it does, the response should not be to return to violence; it should be to prepare for the next contest.

20 The Common Principles

The advice to those in dictatorships and civil wars shares five principles with the advice to those in democracies.

First, the coalition is the unit of action. No individual can change the allocation. A coalition can. The first task, in every context, is to build the coalition.

Second, the four freedoms are the infrastructure. The four freedoms—media, speech, assembly, association—are the conditions under which the coalition can be built. They must be defended and expanded in every context.

Third, the structure is the cause. The allocation is the outcome; the structure is the cause. The parties who change the structure change the allocation; the parties who only contest the allocation win a battle and lose the war.

Fourth, the legitimacy is the weapon. The legitimacy regime is the weapon that the beneficiaries use to conceal the allocation. The cost-bearers who expose the legitimacy regime expose the allocation.

Fifth, the verdict is not the end. The verdict is a stage in a longer process. The parties who treat it as the end lose the process; the parties who treat it as a stage continue it.

21 The Asymmetry of Risk

The advice to those in dictatorships and civil wars must acknowledge the asymmetry of risk. The cost-bearers in these contexts face risks that the cost-bearers in democracies do not face. The risk of death, imprisonment, and exile is real, and the framework cannot pretend otherwise.

The framework's contribution is not to remove the risk. It is to describe the strategies that the risk makes possible, and to be honest about the cost. The cost-bearers who act are accepting the risk. The cost-bearers who do not act are accepting a different risk. The choice between the risks is the cost-bearer's own.

The Whole

These twelve principles, together with the definitions of the ledger, allocation, and verdict, the method of evaluation, and the advice to the parties, describe the structure of every political contest.

The structure is the ledger of relations: who gives, who gets, who can leave, who can speak, how long the horizon is, how the whole is justified.

The allocation is the distribution of the ledger: shares, exit costs, voice, and horizon.

The engine is the position: whether a relation is good or bad depends on where you stand in it. Those who benefit defend; those who bear the cost attack.

The contest is the same whether conducted through politics or through war. The difference is the judge. Politics uses institutions; war uses force. Both produce verdicts; both establish allocations.

The verdict is the outcome of the contest that establishes the allocation. It is not a principle, a value, or a justification. It is the event or process that distributes the ledger.

The condition that determines which judge operates is the structure: entrenchment leads to war, negotiability leads to politics.

The justification comes after the verdict. It is the residue of the contest, not its cause. It can always be contested by returning to the verdict that produced it.

The rebalancing is the justice mechanism: it reduces the drift when the drift becomes too wide. The cost of the rebalancing is borne by those who cannot leave.

The evaluation is the six tests: coalition, exit, voice, gap, horizon, legitimacy. They do not tell you which side should have won. They tell you how to ask the question in each case.

The advice is different for the beneficiaries and the cost-bearers, and different for democracies, dictatorships, and civil wars. But the principles are the same, and the question is the same.

The judgment is not neutral. There is no view from nowhere. The structural view is always a positioned view.

The question is always the same: *whose ledger is this, and for whom?*

A Final Word

This essay is not a theory of politics and war. It is a discipline of attention. It tells you what to look at, what to ask, and what to measure. It does not tell you what to conclude, because the conclusion depends on your position—and your position is a fact you must discover, not a conclusion you must accept.

The principles are not a program. They are a set of questions. The six tests are not a verdict. They are a method. The advice is not a guarantee. It is a description of the strategies that the structure makes possible. If you learn to ask the questions of every order you encounter—your government, your employer, your community, your family, and yourself—you will see what most public debate conceals. You will see the coalition behind the voter, the extraction behind the monument, the gap between the claim and the reality, the asymmetry of exit and voice, the adjustment that is paid for by the population, the justification that comes after the verdict.

And you will be able to ask the question that every order must answer, and that most orders conceal:

Whose ledger is this, and for whom?

The question is not answered by the essay. It is made possible by the essay. The answer is the work of those who ask it.

That is what these principles, this method, and this advice are for. Not to tell you what to think, but to show you what to look at and how to measure what you see.

The rest is up to you.

Democracy and the Four Freedoms:

A Ledger Account

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Abstract

This paper argues that democracy is not fundamentally a mechanism for selecting rulers, but a mechanism for aggregating claims over the ledger. For this aggregation to be genuine, it must rest upon the preconditions that allow actors to contest their terms of relation without fear of disproportionate reprisal. Through the lens of the ledger framework, Franklin D. Roosevelt's Four Freedoms (freedom of speech and expression, freedom of worship, freedom from want, and freedom from fear) are shown to be structural necessities rather than aspirational rights. Freedom of speech and worship expand voice (v_i^e), freedom from want lowers exit costs (k_i^e) by providing viable alternatives to coercive relations, and freedom from fear prevents the substitution of repression for legitimacy. When these freedoms are eroded, politics atomizes, voice is captured, and democracy decays into a nominal form whilst the ledger remains skewed towards the sustaining coalition.

Keywords: democracy, four freedoms, ledger, voice, exit costs, legitimacy, aggregation, political contestation

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1 Introduction

Democracy is commonly defined as rule by the people. Whilst intuitively appealing, this definition obscures more than it reveals. Who counts as "the people" at any given time is itself a product of political contestation. Furthermore, the act of voting is only one moment within a far broader process of contestation over the terms of social, economic, and political life [4, 10].

From the vantage of the ledger framework, democracy is best understood as an institutional attempt to aggregate claims ($P(S)$) over the state of the ledger S. For claims to be aggregated truthfully, actors must be able to propose alternatives to the status quo without incurring existential costs for doing so. This precondition is structural. It requires that the parameters of the ledger are set such that voice is not performative, exit is not illusory, and contestation is not penalized into silence [1, 2].

It is precisely these preconditions that President Franklin D. Roosevelt articulated in his 1941 State of the Union address as the Four Freedoms: freedom of speech and expression, freedom of worship, freedom from want, and freedom from fear [9]. This paper argues that these freedoms are not decorative add-ons to democracy, but the material and structural foundations upon which democratic aggregation rests.

2 The Ledger Preconditions of Democratic Aggregation

For a system to be democratically aggregative, three conditions must hold simultaneously.

1. **Genuine voice.** Actors must possess the capacity to articulate grievances and propose alternatives. As established in the ledger framework, asymmetries in v_i^e skew bargaining power, rendering politics endogenous to the ledger [2]. If voice is monopolized, claims fail to enter circulation within $P(S)$.

2. **Viable exit.** The threat of exit must be credible, and more importantly, alternatives must be livable. If $k_i^e \to \infty$ for a class of actors, their only option is acceptance or revolt, breaking the bargaining symmetry required for legitimate contestation [5, 2].

3. **Low cost of contestation.** The cost of politics must be lower than the cost of acceptance beneath the rupture threshold. When contestation is met with disproportionate surveillance, blacklisting, or coercion, legitimacy erodes and governments substitute repression for compliance, raising the cost of governance $\Phi(G, L)$ [1, 13].

Democracy fails not when people argue, but when the parameters of the ledger make arguing futile, dangerous, or impossible. The Four Freedoms are the institutional response to each of these failures.

3 The Four Freedoms in Ledger Terms

3.1 Freedom of Speech and Expression

The freedom to speak, publish, and assemble is the institutionalization of voice. Without it, grievances are forced underground, claims are filtered by gatekeepers, and the set $P(S)$ no longer reflects the interests of the governed.

This is more than a liberty, but a condition for discovery. Dissent reveals the true shape of $G(S)$, exposing the distance between the realized ledger and the viability set V. A democracy

that criminalizes its critics does not merely silence speech, it destroys its own ability to perceive the injustice gap that it must govern [6, 2].

3.2 Freedom of Worship

Conscience is non-negotiable for genuine contestation. The freedom of worship protects the right to derive obligations from sources outside of the coalition that sustains the government. This prevents the fusion of G and the sacred, a fusion which, historically, has been used to naturalize the status quo as the will of God and to render reallocation blasphemous [12, 3].

In ledger terms, this protects an independent source of legitimacy. It widens the space of justification beyond the coalition's preferred narrative, allowing actors to contest shares (s_i^e) on grounds that are not granted by the apparatus Org itself.

3.3 Freedom From Want

Of the four, this is the most material. Want is a coercive force. An actor facing starvation, eviction, or the denial of basic care has an effective exit cost $k_i^e \approx \infty$ with respect to any relation that could provide their subsistence, no matter how extractive it is.

Freedom from want is, therefore, the project of lowering the floor of desperation. Universal access to necessities, robust public goods, and a social minimum all function to expand the set of viable alternatives. By doing so, they equalize the bargaining position between actors and allow voice (v_i^e) to be exercised freely, rather than under duress. Material security is not charity to democracy, it is a precondition for its symmetry [11, 2].

3.4 Freedom From Fear

Fear is the mechanism by which atomization is enforced without explicit prohibition of speech. Surveillance, arbitrary enforcement, paramilitary intimidation, and selective prosecution all serve to raise the private cost of contestation far above its public penalty.

This directly attacks legitimacy. A government that must rely upon fear to maintain compliance is, by Proposition 4.4 of the ledger framework, in the process of substituting repression for legitimacy, causing $\Phi(G, L)$ to rise exponentially [1, 14]. Freedom from fear is, thus, the prohibition on the transformation of governance into coercion. It preserves the distinction between justified enforcement of the ledger, and the use of the apparatus to suppress claims against it.

4 Democracy as the Institutionalization of These Freedoms

A democracy is not measured by the regularity of its elections alone, but by its capacity to uphold these four freedoms between and during them. Electoral cycles are necessary, but insufficient.

Institutions such as an independent press, protected assembly, freedom of religion, an impartial judiciary, robust labor protections, public goods, and constraints upon the security apparatus all exist to lock these freedoms into the structure of Gov = (G, Org). Their purpose is to prevent the coalition from capturing the very freedoms that allow it to be challenged [7, 4].

Crucially, these are self-reinforcing. Freedom of speech reveals the need for freedom from want. Freedom from want enables freedom of worship to be a genuine choice rather than a product of desperation. Freedom from fear creates the space for all three to be exercised collectively. Together, they keep the ledger open to rebalancing.

5 When the Freedoms Erode

The decay of democracy is almost always the erosion of these freedoms, not their abolition in name.

- **Voice captured:** Consolidation of media, SLAPP suits, and the criminalization of protest throttle $P(S)$ whilst maintaining the appearance of debate.
- **Conscience constrained:** Majoritarian nationalism or the fusion of party and faith pressures conformity, blurring the line between loyalty to the coalition and loyalty to the polity.
- **Desperation weaponized:** Precarity, wage stagnation, and the gutting of public goods raise k_i^e for the majority whilst simultaneously lowering them for the mobile factor, replicating the exit asymmetry that captures government [8].
- **Fear normalized:** Mass surveillance, militarized policing, and discretionary enforcement create a chilling effect. Politics becomes a matter of safety, not principle, driving atomization and suppressing the very claims that would correct the injustice gap [14].

In such a configuration, the form of democracy persists, but its substance collapses into what the ledger framework terms *government without sovereignty*: formally democratic, yet structurally oligarchic, implementing a λ vector skewed towards the sustaining coalition [1].

6 Conclusion

Democracy's legitimacy rests upon its ability to aggregate claims over an ever-changing ledger. This ability is conditional. Freedom of speech and worship secure the right to contest. Freedom from want secures the ability to do so on equal footing. Freedom from fear secures the safety to do so at all.

These are not luxuries of prosperity, but the parameters of democratic politics themselves. To defend democracy is, first and foremost, to defend these freedoms. To expand democracy is to expand them to those for whom they remain, in practice, illusory. The Four Freedoms are, therefore, not the goals that follow democracy, but the foundations that make democracy possible to begin with.

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Religion and Politics:

A Ledger Account

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Abstract

Religion and politics are not distinct domains that occasionally intersect, but interrelated mechanisms for ordering the ledger of reciprocal relations. Religions have historically governed through norms, obligations, sanctions, and narratives of legitimacy, whilst political orders have sought to secure compliance through law, force, and the apparatus of government. Drawing on the ledger framework, this paper distinguishes between religion as a governor and religion as an instrument of coalition capture. It argues that the relationship between the two hinges upon the question of autonomy: when religion remains autonomous from the coalition that controls Org, it can act as a check upon extraction by appealing to a transcendent source of obligation; when fused with political power, it becomes a tool for naturalizing the status quo, suppressing dissent, and sanctifying the skew of λ_i towards the sustaining coalition. The paper concludes by arguing for a principled separation, not of faith from public life, but of sacred authority from the coercive apparatus of the state.

Keywords: religion, politics, ledger, legitimacy, governance, naturalization, secularism, coalition capture

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1 Introduction

From kinship to empire, religious institutions have played a central role in structuring social order. They define obligations, delineate who counts as kin, justify distributions of share and burden, prescribe duties to the vulnerable, and articulate sanctions for breach [9, 7]. Political orders, in turn, have sought to harness these narratives to secure compliance, often fusing altar and throne in pursuit of stability [4, 5].

The ledger framework provides a vantage point from which to clarify this relationship. Religion, like kinship, markets, and platforms, is a form of *governance* in the broad sense: it reproduces the terms of relations over time through norms, monitoring, and sanction. Politics is the contestation of those terms. Government is the specialized apparatus that enacts governance on behalf of a coalition [1]. The tension between religion and politics arises when these roles are conflated, and when a religious tradition is subordinated to, or fused with, the coalition controlling the apparatus of coercion.

2 Religion as a Governor

Before the rise of the modern state, religious institutions were often among the most consequential governors of the ledger. Their power derived from several sources.

- **Obligation beyond reciprocity.** Many religious traditions extend obligations to widows, orphans, strangers, and the poor, imposing duties that are not contingent upon immediate reciprocity [9, 13]. In ledger terms, this expands the scope of what is considered owed, pressing against purely extractive conceptions of s_i^e.
- **Transcendent legitimacy.** Religious authority can appeal to obligations that predate and transcend the government. A priest, prophet, or community of faith can declare that a decree of the sovereign is unjust, grounding dissent in a source of authority that the apparatus Org does not control [14, 5].
- **Norms and soft sanction.** Excommunication, shunning, loss of communal standing, or the fear of eschatological consequences are forms of sanction that can discipline actors without the direct deployment of state violence. These are often more effective at regulating relations than law alone [7, 10].
- **Long time horizons.** Many faith traditions orient action towards the afterlife, intergenerational duty, or covenant across generations. This naturally lowers the discount rate r of their adherents relative to purely short-term political calculation, incentivizing conservation of the ledger for those yet to come [2, 12].

When autonomous, religion functions as a corrective to political power. It can speak for those with low v_i^e within the formal political process, and it can raise the cost of naturalizing injustice by insisting that the ledger be measured against a standard beyond the coalition's convenience.

3 The Fusion of Altar and Throne

The danger arises when religion loses its autonomy and becomes fused with the government. In such a configuration, the transcendent becomes immanent to the coalition. The will of

God becomes indistinguishable from the will of the sovereign, and contestation of G becomes contestation of the sacred order itself.

This fusion produces several effects in ledger terms.

- **Naturalization of extraction.** Inequality is reframed as providence, hierarchy as natural order, and dispossession as divine punishment. By naturalizing the status quo, fusion raises the psychological and social cost of dissent, atomizing grievance in the manner described by Proposition 5.1 of the ledger framework [2, 8].
- **Capture of legitimacy.** The coalition appropriates the independent source of legitimacy that religion once provided, using it to manufacture consent. This allows for the substitution of performance for substance: ritual, nationalism, and piety become proxies for justice whilst the injustice gap G widens [1, 14].
- **Weaponization of orthodoxy.** Dissenters are cast not merely as opponents, but as heretics, traitors, or enemies of the faith. This raises the cost of contestation dramatically, often justifying surveillance, exclusion, and violence in the name of purity. In doing so, it directly erodes freedom of conscience, one of the preconditions for democratic aggregation [3, 5].
- **Skewing of the λ vector.** With the check removed, government becomes freer to implement G in service of the narrowest coalition. The sacred is enlisted to justify the exit asymmetry between the mobile factor and those with high k_i^e, naturalizing a ledger that would otherwise be legible as predatory [11, 1].

History is replete with examples of this dynamic: from the divine right of kings to contemporary forms of religious nationalism. The constant is not the content of the faith, but the fusion of sacred authority with coercive power [4, 5].

4 The Case For Principled Separation

The answer to fusion is not the eradication of religion from public life, but the separation of sacred authority from the coercive apparatus of the state. This distinction is crucial.

- **Freedom of worship as structural.** As argued in *Democracy and the Four Freedoms*, freedom of worship is a precondition for democratic contestation. It protects the ability to derive obligations from sources outside the coalition, preventing the state from monopolizing the justification of its rule [3, 12].
- **Religion can still be political.** Autonomy does not imply apoliticism. Faith communities can and should advocate for the poor, critique unjust laws, organize for labor protections, and press for rebalancing of the ledger. This is not the fusion of altar and throne, but religion acting in its proper role as governor: holding political power to account [6, 5].
- **The state must be neutral amongst faiths, not hostile to faith.** Neutrality prevents any single tradition from capturing Org, whilst still allowing all to participate in the public square. Hostility towards religion, conversely, risks driving faith underground and ceding the space of moral critique to other, often more nationalistic, forms of legitimation [12, 5].

- **Separation protects religion itself.** Paradoxically, fusion often corrupts the faith. When salvation becomes tied to the fortunes of a party or a regime, the prophetic voice is muted, and the tradition loses its capacity to critique its own power. Autonomy is not merely a protection for the polity, but a protection for religion from capture by politics [6, 14].

In ledger terms, the ideal arrangement is one in which multiple governors exist in tension with one another. The state, markets, civil society, and autonomous religious communities each check the others. This pluralism prevents any single coalition from monopolizing both the apparatus of coercion and the source of ultimate legitimacy.

5 Contemporary Implications

The ledger lens clarifies many contemporary conflicts.

- **Religious nationalism.** When national identity is fused with a particular faith, exclusion becomes structural. Minorities are rendered outsiders to the body politic, their claims are delegitimized, and the ledger is restructured around an in-group with privileged access to voice and lower effective exit costs [11, 5].
- **Populism and sacralized politics.** Charismatic movements often sacralize the leader, turning loyalty to the movement into a test of faithfulness. This blurs the distinction between political opposition and moral betrayal, creating the conditions for the erosion of freedom from fear and the normalization of repression [1, 15].
- **The prophetic function.** In moments of rising precarity and captured democracy, autonomous faith communities have historically played a disproportionate role in rebalancing the ledger. Their ability to organize across class lines, appeal to moral obligation, and sustain long time horizons makes them well-suited to contesting extraction, particularly when secular channels have been atomized [2, 10].
- **Secularism as a guardrail.** Far from being anti-religious, a robust commitment to the separation of sacred authority from the coercive apparatus is one of the strongest guardrails against the capture that produces *government without sovereignty*. It preserves space for both faith and critique, preventing the ledger from being locked in place by appeal to the eternal [6, 1].

6 Conclusion

Religion and politics are both governors of the ledger. Religion governs through obligation, norm, and transcendental appeal; politics contests the ledger through claims, coalitions, and power; government enforces a particular ledger through its apparatus. These roles are complementary when kept distinct, and catastrophic when fused.

The question is not whether religion belongs in politics, but whose authority ultimately constrains whom. When political power is constrained by a transcendent standard, the ledger remains open to critique and rebalancing. When that standard is captured by political power, the ledger is sanctified and closed.

A healthy order preserves the autonomy of faith, protects freedom of worship, and refuses to sacralize the state. In doing so, it preserves both the prophetic capacity of religion to call power

to account, and the democratic capacity of politics to change the ledger through contestation. The separation of altar and throne is not a rejection of the sacred, but a recognition that the sacred is too important to be placed in the service of any coalition.

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Voice and Politics:

Suppression, Accumulation, and Explosion

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Abstract

This paper argues that voice (v_i^e) is the pressure valve of the ledger. Politics is endogenous to relations of reciprocity, and when actors possess legitimate channels to articulate grievances and propose alternatives to the status quo, the injustice gap (G) can be corrected through reform. However, when those channels are suppressed, atomized, or captured, grievances do not disappear. They are driven underground. Through a process of accumulation, latent discontent solidifies into parallel networks of trust, alternative narratives, and clandestine organization. These underground movements persist beneath the surface of apparent stability, growing in size and cohesion the more repressive the attempt to silence them becomes. Eventually, once a critical threshold is crossed, this accumulated pressure explodes into open contention in the form of protests, insurrections, revolutions, or wars. Drawing from the ledger framework in conversation with Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty*, Scott's *Arts of Resistance*, and theories of revolutionary crisis, this paper demonstrates that suppressing voice is not a strategy of long-term pacification, but one of deferred violence. The surest way to prevent revolutionary explosion is not repression, but the institutionalization of robust, credible channels of voice.

Keywords: voice, suppression, underground movements, accumulation, revolution, war, exit, loyalty, atomization, ledger, legitimacy

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1 Introduction

Every stable order must answer a simple question: where do grievances go? As established by the ledger framework, any relation with $s_i^e \in (0,1)$ and $k_i^e < \infty$ generates political activity. Actors that find themselves beneath their acceptance threshold $\bar{a}_i$ possess an incentive to alter the terms of their relation through the instruments available to them; voice, exit, coercion, or appeal to a third party [1, 2].

Of these instruments, voice is the most reformative. Where credible channels exist, grievances can be aggregated into claims ($P(S)$), negotiated over, and potentially realized by governance ($G(S)$). This allows for the rebalancing of the ledger without rupturing the order itself.

However, history consistently demonstrates the inverse. When voice is foreclosed, the pressure does not dissipate. It is redirected. What cannot be said in public is whispered in private. What cannot be organized openly is organized clandestinely. What cannot be bargained for through legitimate institutions is hoarded until the cost of inaction exceeds the cost of rebellion. Suppressing voice is, therefore, not the removal of conflict, but its temporal displacement. The longer it is suppressed, the more compressed and volatile it becomes [10, 15, 17].

2 Voice in the Ledger Framework

Within the ledger, voice is more than the act of speaking. It is the capacity to affect the terms of relation.

Definition 2.1 (Voice)**.** *Voice (v_i^e) is the degree to which an actor can meaningfully articulate grievances, propose alternatives, and compel consideration of their claims within a given relation e. It is a structural parameter, not merely a matter of free speech in principle, but of efficacy in practice [10, 2].*

The efficacy of voice is directly tied to the other parameters of the ledger. Where exit costs (k_i^e) are low and viable alternatives exist, voice is strengthened by credibility. Where exit costs are exorbitantly high, voice is often forced, yet simultaneously made more desperate by the lack of an alternative. Where legitimacy (L) is high, voice is readily aggregated by institutions. Where legitimacy is low, institutions filter, dilute, or dismiss it entirely [10, 1].

Crucially, voice is what keeps $P(S)$ open. A healthy political order is one in which the set of circulating claims is a genuine reflection of the distribution of grievance throughout society. A captured order is one in which $P(S)$ is narrowed to the preferences of the sustaining coalition, whilst the claims of the majority are barred entry [1, 2].

3 Mechanisms of Suppression

The foreclosure of voice rarely takes the form of a total ban on speech. More often, it is a combination of subtle and coercive mechanisms that raise the private cost of contestation whilst maintaining a veneer of legitimacy [15, 21].

- **Institutional capture.** Unions are gutted, opposition parties are gerrymandered into irrelevance, courts are stacked, and avenues for appeal are rendered procedurally futile. The form of representation remains, however its function as an aggregator of claims is destroyed [14, 1].

- **Atomization.** Precarity, gig work, spatial segregation, and mass surveillance all serve to isolate actors from one another. Without dense networks of trust, grievances remain individualized. What would be a class-wide claim is instead internalized as individual failure, preventing the collective action necessary for voice to scale [2, 21].
- **Co-optation and factionalism.** Select representatives are brought into the apparatus, minor concessions are doled out to divide movements, and identity is weaponized to pit groups with shared material interests against one another. This fractures potential coalitions and prevents the consolidation of a broad base of opposition [15, 17].
- **Chilling through fear.** Surveillance, SLAPP suits, blacklisting, arbitrary arrest, and selective enforcement create a climate of fear. Actors rationally self-censor, knowing that the line between legitimate protest and "subversion" is malleable and applied disproportionately to those challenging the ledger [3, 21].
- **Narrative naturalization.** As explored in *Religion and Politics*, narratives of tradition, patriotism, merit, or providence are utilized to frame the status quo as inevitable or divinely ordained. Dissent is recast as ingratitude, treason, or heresy. This raises the social cost of voice in addition to the legal and physical ones [4, 6].

Individually, these mechanisms are manageable. Together, they form a system designed to keep $P(S)$ artificially narrow whilst the true ledger grows increasingly skewed.

4 Grievance Accumulation and the Underground

When public voice is foreclosed, a dialectical shift occurs. Grievances leave the formal political sphere and enter the hidden transcript [15].

Proposition 4.1 (Suppression breeds accumulation)**.** *The rate of grievance accumulation is inversely proportional to the credibility of public channels of voice. The more costly it is to voice a claim openly, the greater the incentive to store, verify, and collectively validate that claim in private.*

This process occurs in predictable stages. First, *validation*: actors discover in hushed conversation that their individualized struggles are, in fact, shared. Second, *solidarity*: trust is built through acts of mutual aid, care work, and protection from repression. These acts of reciprocity rebuild the social fabric that atomization sought to destroy [15, 13]. Third, *parallel organization*: clandestine cells, study circles, worker committees, neighborhood networks, or religiously autonomous groups emerge to coordinate resources and disseminate information outside of state controlled mediums. Fourth, *counter-hegemony*: alternative narratives are constructed that accurately diagnose the ledger, assign responsibility to the coalition, and articulate a vision for rebalancing it [9, 15].

These underground movements are not inherently violent. In fact, the vast majority of them spend the bulk of their existence in this phase of accumulation; teaching, feeding, hiding, documenting, and organizing. They are a product of the order's refusal to listen. The state often mistakes this silence for consent, failing to recognize that the apparent peace is the product of repression, not legitimacy [15, 17].

5 From Accumulation to Explosion

Apparent stability is brittle. A ledger can remain skewed for decades, however, every act of repression, every dismissed grievance, and every broken promise adds weight to the accumulated pressure. This pressure is not linear. It is latent until a spark renders the cost of continued inaction unbearable [5, 17].

Proposition 5.1 (Suppressed voice explodes)**.** *When the perceived costs of open rebellion fall below the perceived costs of continued silent suffering, the underground erupts into mass contention. The magnitude of this explosion is proportional to the duration and intensity of prior suppression.*

Several factors catalyze this crossing of the rupture threshold (ρ_i) for large swathes of the population simultaneously.

- **A legitimacy crisis.** A scandal, electoral theft, military blunder, or the openly callous response to a tragedy can shatter the narrative of benevolent rule. The coalition is revealed to be exactly what the underground had been saying all along [5, 20].
- **A shift in the balance of fear.** Acts of courage are contagious. The arrest of one organizer, the image of a single protester, or the successful defense of a community can rapidly diffuse. Once a critical mass no longer believes that dissent is individually suicidal, the calculations of rationality invert en masse [11, 18].
- **Economic shocks.** Price spikes, austerity, mass layoffs, or the stripping of basic goods expose the parasitism of the ledger with brutal clarity. As argued in *Democracy and the Four Freedoms*, freedom from want is necessary for voice to remain non-coercive. When it is revoked for the many to protect the shares of the few, desperation overrides fear [3, 5].
- **Factional splits within the elite.** Revolutions are rarely made by the masses alone. When a portion of the apparatus, bureaucracy, or military loses faith in the coalition or defects out of self-preservation, the coercive capacity of Gov fractures. At this moment, the underground finds the space to go overt [16, 18].

What follows is not spontaneous chaos, but the rapid politicization of years worth of work. Neighborhood defense committees become de-facto governance, mutual aid becomes provisioning, and underground cells become public organizations. The claims that were once unspeakable flood into the open all at once. Depending on the response of the apparatus, this can manifest as a mass reform movement, a revolution that seeks to reconstitute the ledger, a civil war over competing visions of it, or, in the worst cases, a war of annihilation as the coalition desperately clings onto its λ vector at all costs [5, 16, 17].

6 The Irony of Repression

The logic of suppression is fundamentally shortsighted. The coalition reasons that crushing dissent now prevents unrest later. In reality, the inverse is true.

Repression is informative. Every raid reveals the coalition's fear of organization. Every unjust sentence validates the underground's analysis of the law as an instrument for reproducing the ledger rather than administering justice. Every act of brutality radicalizes those that may have otherwise only sought reform [15, 18].

Furthermore, repression selects for more clandestine, more disciplined, and often, more militant forms of organization. Public moderates are silenced or driven out of the open sphere, whilst those willing to operate underground gain prominence. The movement becomes less easily co-optable, more distrustful of negotiation, and far less willing to settle for partial concessions upon eruption [8, 18].

This is the great irony: the tools utilized to prevent revolution are some of the greatest producers of revolutionary conditions. A government that refuses to hear voices in the legislature will, eventually, be forced to hear them in the streets, in the barracks, and on the battlefield. Stability bought through fear is always borrowed time [1, 17].

7 Institutionalizing Voice to Prevent Explosion

If suppression breeds explosion, then prevention is the institutionalization of credible voice. This is not appeasement, but structural maintenance of the ledger.

1. **Expand aggregative channels.** Strong, independent unions, proportional representation, accessible avenues for direct democracy, and protected assembly all allow for claims to enter $P(S)$ before they reach a boiling point [7, 1].

2. **Equalize exit and voice.** As established in previous work, asymmetries in k_i^e and v_i^e are the root of capture. Equalizing exit costs through universal basic services, robust labor protections, and material security allows voice to be exercised without coercion. Expanding voice to the atomized ensures that no class is forced into the underground by desperation [1, 10].

3. **Protect the watchdogs.** An independent press, protected legal aid, and autonomous civil society act as early warning systems. They make the injustice gap legible before it becomes ungovernable, allowing for reform whilst G is still within a range that is correctable without rupture [3, 12].

4. **Enforce the distinction between critique and crime.** Dissent must remain political, not treasonous. Broad, vague charges of "sedition" or "destabilization" are the hallmark of a regime attempting to criminalize the pressure valve itself. A government secure in its legitimacy can afford to be criticized. One that cannot, is already on the path towards substituting repression for it [1, 20].

5. **Institutionalize feedback.** Genuine reform requires that governance ($G(S)$) be responsive to the claims that politics produces. Consultation without consequence breeds cynicism. Concessions only obtained through repression breed contempt. Credible, iterative rebalancing is the only way to keep the ledger within the viability set V without resorting to constant crisis management [1, 13].

The goal is not the absence of conflict. Conflict is endemic to the ledger. The goal is to keep conflict political. Politics is the contestation of shares, costs, and voice through words, negotiation, and organization. War, revolution, and insurrection are politics by other means, pursued only when all political means have been foreclosed [19, 17].

8 Conclusion

Voice is the pressure valve of civilization. Where it is open, grievance can be vented, aggregated, and corrected. Where it is welded shut by fear, capture, and repression, pressure builds beneath the surface. The underground is not a product of malice, it is a product of exclusion. Solidarity forged in clandestinity, narratives forged in hiding, and organization forged under threat accumulate until the ledger becomes unsustainable to maintain by force alone.

The explosion of violence is not irrational, nor is it proof of the inherent wickedness of the oppressed. It is the delayed consequence of a political order refusing to listen whilst it still could have negotiated. Suppressing voice does not grant permanence, it grants latency. Every revolution is, in essence, a history of suppressed speech finally finding its volume.

A civilization that wishes to avoid war and revolution must choose a different path. It must not ask how to silence its dissidents more effectively, but how to hear them sooner. It must treat grievance as information rather than insubordination, and rebalancing as governance rather than concession. The preservation of order lies not in the strength of its prisons, but in the credibility of its forums. Open the channels of voice, or be forced to reckon with their closure.

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Part V

Historical and Structural

Foundations and Legitimacy

Why Civilizations Are Born in Violence and Live by Concealment

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Abstract

This essay argues that every civilization is founded on an injustice—a first allocation of land, water, labor, and authority that is established before any framework exists within which it could be negotiated. The first allocation is seized, not agreed; it is imposed by a coalition, not accepted by a population; and it is violence, not consent. Every civilization that follows is an attempt to justify the first allocation, to conceal its violence, and to make the order acceptable to those who bear its cost. This attempt is what we call legitimacy. It is unending because the first allocation can never be fully justified, and the concealment can never be fully successful. The gap between the claim and the reality is the civilization. The essay develops this argument in eight parts: the problem of the first move, the failure of negotiation, the coalition and the population, the concealment, the return of the concealed, the alternative, the hope, and the moral. It concludes that the question of civilization is not whether it is founded on violence—it always is—but whose ledger the violence established, and for whom.

1. The Problem of the First Move

Imagine a world before civilization. There are people, resources, and relations among them. But there is no framework—no law, no authority, no legitimacy regime, no state. There is only the raw ledger: who controls what, who can do what to whom, and who can enforce it.

In this world, there is no way to negotiate a first allocation. Negotiation requires a framework: rules of procedure, enforcement of agreements, a third party to adjudicate disputes. But the framework does not yet exist. It must be created, and creation is not negotiation.

Consider the simplest case. Two groups claim the same river valley. One group is upstream; the other is downstream. The upstream group can divert the water; the downstream group cannot. What happens? There is no negotiation, because there is no framework within which to negotiate. There is only the raw power of each group. The upstream group can take the water; the downstream group can resist. The outcome is determined by force: whoever can impose their will, wins.

This is the first move. It is not a negotiation among equals. It is a contest of power, and the contest is settled by violence. The winner establishes the first allocation, and the first allocation becomes the foundation of the civilization that follows.

This is the structural fact that the standard story conceals. The standard story presents civilization as beginning with an agreement—a social contract, a covenant, a constitution. The framework says: civilization begins with a seizure. The agreement comes later, and it comes as a justification of the seizure, not as its substitute.

2. The Failure of Negotiation

One might object: surely there are cases where the first allocation was negotiated, not seized. Surely some civilizations were founded by agreement among equals. The objection is plausible, and it is worth taking seriously. But it fails on examination, for three reasons.

First, the groups are never equals. Every historical case of a founding involves groups with different resources, different capabilities, and different vulnerabilities. The upstream group has more water; the downstream group has less. The pastoralists have more mobility; the agriculturalists have more fixed assets. The coastal group has more trade; the inland group has less. The difference in resources is the difference in power, and the difference in power is what determines the outcome. There is no negotiation among equals, because there are no equals.

Second, the failure of negotiation is structural. Negotiation requires a framework, and the framework does not yet exist. The groups can attempt to negotiate, but the attempt will fail, because there is no procedure for resolving disputes, no enforcement of agreements, and no third party to adjudicate. The failure is not a failure of will or of reason; it is a failure of conditions. The conditions for negotiation are the product of the framework, and the framework is the product of the negotiation. The circle cannot be closed.

Third, the stronger group prefers violence. Even if negotiation were possible, the stronger group would prefer not to negotiate. Negotiation produces a compromise, and the compromise is always less than what the stronger group could obtain by force. The stronger group has no incentive to negotiate when it can impose. The result is that negotiation, when it occurs, is a tactic of the stronger group, not a constraint on it.

The conclusion is unavoidable. The failure of negotiation is not an accident; it is the structure of the situation. The first allocation cannot be negotiated, because there is no framework within which to negotiate, and the stronger group has no incentive to create one. The first allocation must be seized, and the seizure is violence.

3. The Coalition and the Population

Every civilization is founded by a coalition. The coalition is the group that seizes the first allocation and establishes the order that follows. It is the group that controls the state, commands the army, owns the land, and writes the law. It is the group whose interests the order serves.

The coalition is always narrower than the population. This is not a coincidence; it is a structural necessity. The population is the group that is governed; the coalition is the group that governs. The population is large; the coalition is small. The population has diverse interests; the coalition has concentrated interests. The coalition's interests are served by the order; the population's interests are served only to the extent that the coalition needs the population's cooperation.

The coalition cannot persuade the population to accept a narrower allocation, because the population has no reason to accept it. The population would prefer a broader allocation, or an equal one. The only way the coalition can impose the narrower allocation is by force, and the force is violence.

This is the structural fact that the framework makes visible. The coalition is a minority; the population is a majority. The coalition cannot win the population's consent; it can only impose the order. The imposition is violence, and the legitimacy regime is the justification of

the violence.

The coalition does not have to be a small group of conspirators. It can be a large group—a tribe, a class, a region—that has enough power to impose its will on the rest. But it is always a minority, because the population is always larger than the coalition, and the coalition's allocation is always narrower than the population's preference.

4. The Concealment

The first allocation is violence. But violence alone cannot sustain an order. An order that relies on force alone must spend everything on force, and it has nothing left for anything else. It is expensive, unstable, and vulnerable to any challenge that can match its force.

The coalition needs a justification. It needs a legitimacy regime that makes the first allocation appear natural, necessary, and just. It needs a story that the population can accept, and that the population will accept because the story makes the order appear to be something other than what it is.

This is the function of the legitimacy regime. It does not change the allocation; it changes the appearance of the allocation. It does not make the violence disappear; it conceals the violence. It does not make the order just; it makes the order appear just.

The legitimacy regime is a technology of concealment. It has three components.

First, a *cosmology*. A story about the order of the universe that makes the social order appear to be a reflection of the cosmic order. Ma'at was a cosmology: the pharaoh was the guarantor of cosmic order, and the social hierarchy was a reflection of the cosmic hierarchy. The Mandate of Heaven was a cosmology: the emperor was the Son of Heaven, and the social order was a reflection of the celestial order.

Second, a *genealogy*. A story about the origin of the order that makes the coalition appear to be the legitimate heir of a primordial founder. The pharaoh was the successor of Narmer, who had unified the two lands. The emperor was the successor of the sage-kings, who had established the order. The Roman Senate was the successor of the founders, who had established the Republic.

Third, a *morality*. A story about the obligations of the population that makes compliance appear to be a virtue and resistance appear to be a vice. The Egyptian peasant was supposed to work the land, pay the taxes, and serve the corvée, because that was Ma'at. The Chinese peasant was supposed to pay the taxes, serve the corvée, and obey the magistrate, because that was the Mandate. The Roman citizen was supposed to serve in the army, pay the taxes, and respect the law, because that was the res publica.

Together, these three components produce the legitimacy regime. The cosmology explains why the order is natural. The genealogy explains why the coalition is legitimate. The morality explains why the population should comply. The three components work together to make the first allocation appear to be something other than what it is: not a seizure, but a foundation; not violence, but order; not extraction, but justice.

5. The Return of the Concealed

The concealment is never complete. The violence that the legitimacy regime conceals always returns, in moments when the legitimacy regime fails. The moments are the intermediate periods,

the civil wars, the revolutions, the collapses. They are the moments when the order breaks down, the coalition fractures, the population rises, and the violence that had been concealed becomes visible.

In these moments, the legitimacy regime is exposed as what it is: a concealment, not a justice. The cosmology is revealed as a story, the genealogy as a fiction, the morality as a justification. The order that the legitimacy regime justified is revealed as a first allocation that was seized, not agreed; imposed, not accepted; violent, not just.

The return of the concealed is not an accident. It is a structural feature of the legitimacy regime. The regime conceals the violence by making the order appear just, but the appearance is always fragile. Any event that exposes the gap between the claim and the reality—a famine, a defeat, a corruption scandal, a succession crisis—can trigger the return. And when the return happens, the legitimacy regime is exposed, and the order is exposed, and the violence that was concealed becomes visible.

This is why the intermediate periods were not accidents of Egyptian history. They were the return of the violence that Ma'at had concealed. The Old Kingdom's Ma'at had concealed the conquest of Narmer; the First Intermediate Period exposed it. The Middle Kingdom's Ma'at had concealed the reconsolidation; the Second Intermediate Period exposed it. The New Kingdom's Ma'at had concealed the imperial expansion; the Third Intermediate Period exposed it.

The same is true of every civilization. Every civilization has its intermediate periods, its civil wars, its revolutions, its collapses. They are the moments when the violence that the legitimacy regime concealed returns, and the order that the violence established is revealed as what it was.

6. The Alternative

If civilizations are founded on violence, is there an alternative? The framework says: yes, but it is not a civilization in the usual sense. It is a different kind of order, one that does not require a first allocation established by violence.

The alternative is a symbiotic order—an order in which the relations are symbiotic, the coalition is broad enough to include all actors whose capacity is at stake, and the legitimacy regime is earned rather than manufactured. A symbiotic order does not have a first allocation established by violence, because it has no first allocation: the relations are negotiated, adjusted, and renegotiated through institutions that are themselves symbiotic.

A justice regime is effective if and only if it reduces the injustice gap faster than the disequilibrium forces increase it. A symbiotic order is one in which the justice regime is effective, and the effectiveness is not a concealment; it is the actual reduction of the gap.

Has such an order ever existed? The framework says: not fully. The closest historical examples are probably the Mesopotamian city-states, which developed institutional mechanisms for adjustment, and the Greek city-states, which developed democratic institutions for participation. But both were partial: the Mesopotamian city-states excluded the slaves, and the Greek city-states excluded women, slaves, and metics. The alternative has never been fully realized. But the framework says it is possible—not as a utopia, but as an order that is structurally different from the orders we have known.

7. The Hope

If the alternative is possible, why has violence been the rule? The framework gives three reasons.

First, violence is cheaper in the short run. A coalition that seizes the first allocation by force can establish an order immediately. A coalition that negotiates a symbiotic order must wait for the negotiation to produce an agreement, and the agreement may never come. The coalition that uses violence has a first-mover advantage, and the advantage is decisive in the short run.

Second, violence is self-reinforcing. A coalition that seizes power by force must maintain power by force, because the population has no reason to accept the order otherwise. The maintenance of power by force requires a legitimacy regime, and the legitimacy regime requires a concealment of the violence. The concealment becomes the technology of the order, and the order becomes dependent on the concealment.

Third, the conditions for symbiosis are rare. A symbiotic order requires a broad coalition, institutional adjustment, earned legitimacy, and the four freedoms. These conditions are rare in history, because they require a configuration of geography, history, and political competition that is unusual. When the conditions are present—as they were in Athens—the order can be symbiotic, at least partially. When they are absent—as they were in most of history—the order must be violent.

This is the framework's answer to the question of why violence has been the rule. Violence is the rule because it is cheaper, self-reinforcing, and the conditions for the alternative are rare. The alternative is possible, but it is not the default. The default is violence, and the legitimacy regime is the technology by which the violence is concealed and the order is made acceptable.

The hope is not that violence can be eliminated. The hope is that it can be reduced—that the first allocation can be partially renegotiated, that the coalition can be broadened, that the legitimacy regime can be earned rather than manufactured, and that the four freedoms can be protected. None of these is easy, and none is permanent. But they are possible, and they are the work of civilization.

8. The Moral

The moral of this analysis is not that civilizations are bad. It is that civilizations are ledgers, and every ledger has a foundation that was established by violence, and every foundation is concealed by a legitimacy regime. The civilization is the concealment, not the foundation. And the concealment is what allows the civilization to endure.

This is why the framework's question is not "is this civilization good or bad?" It is "whose ledger is this, and for whom?" The question asks you to look past the legitimacy regime to the ledger beneath it, and to see who benefits from the first allocation and who bears its cost.

For ancient Egypt, the answer is: the coalition's, and at the population's expense. The coalition seized the first allocation by conquest, concealed the conquest with Ma'at, and maintained the order for three thousand years. The population accepted the order because the order appeared just. The appearance was the con. And the con was the civilization.

The same is true of every civilization. The first allocation was established by violence, concealed by a legitimacy regime, and maintained by a coalition. The population accepted the order because the order appeared just. The appearance was the con. And the con was the civilization.

The question is not whether a civilization is a con. It always is. The question is what the con conceals, and at whose expense, and whether the concealment can be reduced.

9. The Unending Quest

The quest for legitimacy is unending because the first allocation can never be fully justified, and the concealment can never be fully successful.

The first allocation can never be fully justified because it was violence. No justification can make violence just; the best that a justification can do is to make the violence appear just. The appearance is fragile, and it is always vulnerable to the return of the concealed.

The concealment can never be fully successful because the population is not passive. The population experiences the extraction, the corvée, the taxation, and the violence. The experience is real, and it cannot be fully concealed. The population may accept the order because the order appears just, but the appearance is always in tension with the experience. The tension is the source of the intermediate periods, the civil wars, the revolutions, and the collapses.

This is why the quest for legitimacy is unending. Every civilization must maintain the concealment, and every civilization must face the return of the concealed. The maintenance and the return are the dynamic of civilization. The civilization is the tension between them.

The framework's contribution is to make the tension visible. It shows the first allocation beneath the justification, the violence beneath the legitimacy, the coalition beneath the population. And in making the tension visible, it makes the question askable: whose ledger is this, and for whom?

10. The Question

The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom?

For ancient Egypt, the answer is: the coalition's, and at the population's expense. For Mesopotamia, the answer is: the king's, the code's, and the city's. For Greece, the answer is: the demos', and at the expense of the slaves, the women, and the metics. For Rome, the answer is: the Senate's, the emperor's, and the provincial elites'. For China, the answer is: the Mandate's, the emperor's, and the bureaucracy's.

For our own civilization, the question remains open. The framework does not answer it. It gives us the language and the method to answer it ourselves. And the answer is the work of those who ask it.

The rest is history—or its absence. And the choice of which it will be is always, in part, our own.

A Closing Thought

Every civilization is founded on violence. Every civilization conceals the violence with a legitimacy regime. Every civilization faces the return of the concealed. Every civilization is a tension between the concealment and the return.

This is the structure of the con. It is not a conspiracy; it is a condition. The coalition seizes the first allocation, the legitimacy regime conceals the seizure, and the population accepts the concealment because the alternative is worse.

The question is not whether the con exists. It always does. The question is what the con conceals, and at whose expense, and whether the concealment can be reduced.

The framework says: the con can be reduced. The first allocation can be partially renegotiated. The coalition can be broadened. The legitimacy regime can be earned rather than manufactured. The four freedoms can be protected. None of these is easy, and none is permanent. But they are possible, and they are the work of civilization.

The quest for legitimacy is unending because the con is never fully concealed and the violence is never fully justified. But the quest is not futile. Each step toward a broader coalition, a more effective adjustment mechanism, a more earned legitimacy, and a more protected set of freedoms is a step toward a less unjust order. The steps are small and the progress is partial, but the direction is real.

The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom? The answer is the work. The work is the civilization. And the civilization is the quest. That is the hope. The rest is history—or its absence.

Case Studies in the Ledger

Egypt, Mesopotamia, Greece, Rome, and China

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Introduction

The ledger framework makes a structural claim: civilizations are orders of human relations, classified by the sign and sustainability of their net transfers. Relations are symbiotic when both parties reproduce their capacity, parasitic when one extracts from a surviving host, and predatory when extraction destroys the host. Stable civilizations require a justified equilibrium; when it is violated beyond a threshold, conflict follows. Justice is the institutional mechanism that rebalances the ledger.

The framework is not merely theoretical. It can be applied to actual civilizations, and when it is, it reveals structures that the standard stories cannot see. The five case studies that follow—Egypt, Mesopotamia, Greece, Rome, and China—are not a complete survey. They are a demonstration. Each case shows the framework at work, and each case yields a lesson that the others do not.

The cases are organized around three questions. What was the ledger? Who gave, who gained, who lost, and how was it justified? What was the adjustment mechanism? How did the civilization rebalance the ledger when it drifted out of equilibrium? What did the civilization claim to be, and what was it? What was the gap between the legitimacy regime and the reality?

Egypt: The Violence Backstop

The Ledger

Egypt was a riverine civilization organized around the annual flood of the Nile. The flood produced a predictable surplus, which supported a large population and a complex state. The surplus was extracted by the pharaoh, the priests, and the bureaucracy, and it was redistributed to the military, the temple, and the corvée labor that maintained the irrigation system.

The extraction was justified by Ma'at—the cosmic principle of order, truth, and balance. The pharaoh was the guarantor of Ma'at, and his rule was justified by his role as the maintainer of cosmic order. The legitimacy regime was exceptionally successful: it was accepted for three thousand years, and it was adapted to native dynasties, foreign dynasties, and religious revolutions.

The population—peasants, laborers, artisans—was outside the coalition. It had high exit costs (the desert surrounded the Nile valley, and the state controlled the irrigation) and low voice (there were no institutions through which the population could express grievance). Its patience

was rational: resistance would trigger collapse, and collapse would be borne disproportionately by the population.

The Adjustment Mechanism

Egypt's adjustment mechanism was the intermediate period. The ledger was rebalanced by collapse. The Old Kingdom's imbalance produced the First Intermediate Period; the Middle Kingdom's produced the Second; the New Kingdom's produced the Third. Each collapse was a reset, not a solution. The coalition that emerged from the collapse had the same structural position as the coalition it replaced. The cycle repeated.

The cost of adjustment was borne by the population. The intermediate periods killed millions, displaced millions, and destroyed the capacity of generations. The coalition was protected from the collapse by its resources, its mobility, and its access to the state. The population was exposed to it by its immobility, its dependence, and its exclusion.

The Claim and the Reality

Egypt claimed to be governed by Ma'at. It was governed by the intermediate period. The legitimacy regime claimed to be a justice mechanism. It was a justification regime with a violence backstop. The pharaoh was the guarantor of the order, not of justice. The order was divinely sanctioned, but the sanction justified the coalition's extraction, not the population's welfare. The gap between the claim and the reality was the civilization. The population lived and died in the gap.

The Lesson

Egypt is the paradigm of the violence backstop. A civilization that relies on collapse to rebalance its ledger is durable but parasitic. Its durability is measured in cycles, not in equilibrium. Its legitimacy regime is the technology of restoration, not the mechanism of justice.

Mesopotamia: The Institutional Innovation

The Ledger

Mesopotamia was a patchwork of city-states—Ur, Uruk, Lagash, Kish, Babylon, Nineveh—organized around irrigation agriculture and long-distance trade. The surplus was extracted by the temple, the palace, and the merchant class, and it was redistributed to the military, the bureaucracy, and the urban population.

The extraction was justified by a legitimacy regime that was more plural than Egypt's. The king was a steward of the gods, not a god himself. The law was a code, not a decree. The legitimacy regime was less cosmic, and more institutional.

The coalition was broader than Egypt's, because the city-states competed for population, labor, and trade. A ruler who extracted too much lost population to his rivals. A ruler who adjusted too little faced rebellion or secession. The competition was the crucible of institutional innovation.

The Adjustment Mechanism

Mesopotamia's adjustment mechanism was institutional. The andurarum and misharum were periodic proclamations that cancelled debts, freed debt-peons, and restored land to its original owners. The legal codes specified obligations, punishments, and remedies. The institutions adjusted the ledger before it became critical, rather than after.

This is the fundamental difference from Egypt. Egypt adjusted through collapse; Mesopotamia adjusted through the decree. Egypt's adjustment was catastrophic; Mesopotamia's was incremental. Egypt's cost was borne by the population; Mesopotamia's was borne by the coalition's creditors. Egypt's mechanism was a violence backstop; Mesopotamia's was a justice mechanism.

The Claim and the Reality

Mesopotamia claimed to be governed by the king and the code. It was governed by a coalition that was broad enough to require institutional adjustment, but not broad enough to include the population in the coalition. The code was not justice; it was a partial constraint on extraction. The andurarum was not charity; it was a systemic rebalancing. The gap between the claim and the reality was smaller than Egypt's, but it was real.

The Lesson

Mesopotamia is the paradigm of institutional adjustment. A civilization that develops institutions for rebalancing will be less durable but more dynamic than a civilization that relies on collapse. The institutions preserve capacity and permit accumulation; the collapse destroys both. The first produces dynamism; the second produces repetition.

Greece: The Partial Democracy

The Ledger

Greece was a world of city-states—Athens, Sparta, Thebes, Corinth, and hundreds more—organized around the polis, the citizen body, and the assembly. The surplus was extracted by the citizen body and redistributed to the military, the public works, and the festivals. The extraction was justified by a legitimacy regime that was distinctively political: the polis ideology that located legitimacy in the community of citizens.

The coalition was broader than Egypt's or Mesopotamia's, because the citizen body included a wide range of classes and the military required broad participation. But it was narrower than the population, because women, slaves, metics, and foreigners were excluded.

The Adjustment Mechanism

Greece's adjustment mechanism was institutional. Solon's seisachtheia cancelled debts and prevented debt peonage. Cleisthenes' reorganization cut across the old aristocratic networks. Ephialtes' reforms stripped the Areopagus of its political powers. Pericles' introduction of pay for public service made participation possible for the poor. Each reform responded to a structural crisis, and each was a justice mechanism in the framework's sense: it reduced the injustice gap before it became critical.

The result was a democracy that was functional—for the citizens—because it had a broad coalition, high elite exit costs, military leverage, and a legitimacy regime that could accommodate popular rule.

The Claim and the Reality

Greece claimed to be governed by the demos. It was governed by the demos—for the citizens. The slaves, women, and metics were excluded from the coalition. The allies were exploited through the Delian League. The democracy was symbiotic for the citizens, parasitic for the allies, and predatory for the slaves. The gap between the claim and the reality was the partiality. Greece invented the institutions of democracy, and the institutions were real, and they are still used. But they were institutions that served a coalition, not a population.

The Lesson

Greece is the paradigm of the partial democracy. Democracy emerges when the conditions for it converge: a broad coalition, high elite exit costs, a fragmented landscape, military participation, and a legitimacy regime that can accommodate popular rule. It is partial where the conditions are partial. The institutions are real, but they are not universal.

Rome: The Regime Transitions

The Ledger

Rome was, in sequence, a kingdom, a republic, and an empire. The kingdom was a narrow coalition of the king, the aristocracy, and the military. The republic was a broader coalition of the Senate, the consuls, the tribunes, and the plebs. The empire was a wider coalition of the emperor, the army, the bureaucracy, the provincial elites, and the urban population of Rome.

In each case, the ledger was the same: extraction from the provinces and the slaves, redistribution to the coalition, and justification by the legitimacy regime. The regime types differed in the composition of the coalition, the structure of the selectorate, and the distribution of exit costs and voice.

The Adjustment Mechanism

Rome's adjustment mechanism changed with the regime. The kingdom had no effective adjustment mechanism; it relied on the expulsion of kings. The republic had a partial adjustment mechanism: the tribunate, the secessio, and the competition between the optimates and populares. The empire had a partial adjustment mechanism: the extension of citizenship, the incorporation of provincial elites, and the administration of the provinces.

The republic's adjustment mechanism was insufficient, because the coalition was too narrow to govern the empire, the military was too powerful to control, and the elite was too divided to reform. The result was a series of civil wars that ended in the empire. The empire's adjustment mechanism was more effective, because it broadened the coalition to include provincial elites. But it was also narrower in the selectorate, because the emperor ruled without the consent of the citizens. The result was a more stable empire and a less just one.

The Claim and the Reality

Rome claimed to be a res publica—a public thing, a commonwealth. It was a commonwealth for the coalition, not for the population. The republic's citizens had a voice, and their voice constrained extraction; the provinces and slaves had no voice, and they were extracted without constraint. The empire claimed to be a pax—a peace, an order. It was a peace for the incorporated elites and the urban population. It was an order for the provinces. It was extraction for the slaves.

The Lesson

Rome is the paradigm of regime transition. Regimes change when the ledger changes, not the other way around. The form follows the ledger.

China: The Dynastic Cycle

The Ledger

China was a riverine civilization organized around the Yellow and Yangtze rivers, rice and wheat agriculture, and a centralized bureaucracy. The surplus was extracted by the emperor, the bureaucracy, and the landlord class, and it was redistributed to the military, the public works (especially the Grand Canal and the irrigation systems), and the granaries that stabilized grain prices.

The extraction was justified by the Mandate of Heaven—the claim that the emperor ruled as the Son of Heaven, responsible for harmony and prosperity. The legitimacy regime was flexible: it justified native dynasties, foreign dynasties (the Mongols, the Manchus), and the periodic renewal of the Mandate through rebellion.

The coalition was broader than Egypt's, because it included the bureaucracy and the gentry, but it was narrower than the population, because it excluded the peasantry, the merchants, and the minorities. The bureaucracy was recruited through the examination system, which was a genuine innovation: it opened the coalition to talent, but it also reproduced the coalition's interests.

The Adjustment Mechanism

China's adjustment mechanism was the dynastic cycle. The cycle was structurally similar to Egypt's intermediate periods: concentration of wealth, decay of legitimacy, rebellion, renewal, and then concentration again. The cycle was a violence backstop, and it operated through collapse rather than reform.

But China also developed institutional mechanisms that Egypt did not. Land reform was a recurring demand, and dynasties periodically redistributed land to prevent concentration. Granaries stabilized grain prices and provided famine relief. The examination system recruited officials from across the population. These institutions were partial justice mechanisms, and they operated before the collapse—but they were not sufficient to prevent it.

The result was a cycle that repeated for two thousand years. The dynasty would rise, consolidate, extract, decay, collapse, and be replaced. The cycle was not a failure of the system; it was the system's way of rebalancing.

The Claim and the Reality

China claimed to be governed by the Mandate of Heaven. It was governed by the dynastic cycle. The Mandate claimed to be the guarantee of just rule. The cycle was the mechanism by which unjust rule was punished. The population bore the cost of each cycle—famine, war, displacement—and each new dynasty claimed to restore the Mandate. The gap between the claim and the reality was structural. The Mandate was an aspiration; the cycle was the mechanism.

Comparative Analysis

The five cases yield a set of comparative propositions that the framework predicts.

Proposition 1: The Adjustment Mechanism Determines the Trajectory. Egypt and China adjusted through collapse; Mesopotamia and Greece adjusted through institutions; Rome adjusted through a combination of both. The civilizations that adjusted through institutions were more dynamic and less durable; the civilizations that adjusted through collapse were more durable and less dynamic. The contrast between Egypt and Mesopotamia is the clearest. Egypt lasted three thousand years but did not develop the commercial, legal, and institutional complexity that Mesopotamia did. Mesopotamia was never unified for long but developed the institutional technologies that shaped the subsequent history of the region.

Proposition 2: The Coalition Determines the Regime Type. The narrow coalition of Egypt produced a monarchy. The broader coalition of Mesopotamia produced a city-state oligarchy. The broad coalition of Athens produced a partial democracy. The coalition of Rome broadened from kingdom to republic to empire. The coalition of China produced a bureaucratic empire. The distributional consequences of a regime are determined by the composition of the coalition, not by the constitutional form.

Proposition 3: The Legitimacy Regime Determines the Cost of Compliance. Ma'at was accepted for three thousand years, and it lowered the cost of compliance with the Egyptian order. The Mandate of Heaven was accepted for two thousand years, and it lowered the cost of compliance with the Chinese order. The Greek polis ideology lowered the cost of compliance with the Athenian order. The Roman res publica lowered the cost of compliance with the republican order. A legitimacy regime that is accepted by the population allows the coalition to extract more, because the cost of compliance is lower.

Proposition 4: The Partiality of the Coalition Determines the Partiality of Justice. Every civilization had a coalition that was narrower than its population. Egypt excluded the peasants; Mesopotamia excluded the slaves; Greece excluded women, slaves, and metics; Rome excluded the provinces and the slaves; China excluded the peasantry, the merchants, and the minorities. Justice reduces the gap for the coalition, not for the population. The partiality of the coalition is the partiality of justice.

Proposition 5: The Gap Between Claim and Reality Is Structural. Every civilization had a legitimacy regime that claimed more than the reality. Egypt claimed Ma'at; it was governed by the intermediate period. Mesopotamia claimed the code; it was governed by extraction. Greece claimed the demos; it was governed by the citizens. Rome claimed the res publica; it was governed by the coalition. China claimed the Mandate; it was governed by the cycle. The gap was not a lie told by cynical rulers; it was the structure of the legitimacy regime.

What the Cases Teach

The five cases yield a set of lessons that the framework predicts.

Longevity is not justice. Egypt lasted three thousand years; China lasted two thousand years. Both were parasitic. Their longevity is real, but it is not an achievement. It is a debt that was paid by those who did not choose it.

Institutional adjustment is more just than violence. Mesopotamia and Greece developed institutional mechanisms that adjusted the ledger without collapse. They were less durable than Egypt and China, but they were more dynamic and more humane. The choice between violence and institutions is not a choice between good and evil; it is a choice between two ways of managing the ledger.

Partiality is the rule, not the exception. Every civilization excluded some group from the coalition. Every civilization had a legitimacy regime that claimed more than the reality. Every civilization was a con in the structural sense, even when it aspired to be more.

The gap between claim and reality is where the population lives. The aspiration was real; the extraction was real; the gap was the civilization. The population lived and died in the gap.

The framework asks: whose ledger is this, and for whom? For every civilization, the answer was the coalition's, not the population's.

The five cases give five answers. Egypt: Ma'at's, the pharaoh's, and the coalition's. Mesopotamia: the king's, the code's, and the city's. Greece: the demos'. Rome: the Senate's, the emperor's, and the provincial elites'. China: the Mandate's, the emperor's, and the bureaucracy's.

In every case, the population was outside the coalition. In every case, the ledger was kept for the coalition. In every case, the cost was borne by those who did not choose it. That is the lesson. The rest is history—or its absence.

Conclusion

The five case studies are not a complete history. They are a demonstration. The framework that generates them—the ledger, the coalition, the legitimacy regime, the adjustment mechanism, the violence backstop—is a discipline of attention, not a total explanation. It tells us what to look at, what to ask, and what to hope for.

What it tells us to look at is the ledger: who gives, who gains, who loses, and how it is justified. What it tells us to ask is the question: whose ledger is this, and for whom? What it tells us to hope for is a symbiotic equilibrium, sustained by institutions of justice, in which cooperation is not merely rational but reciprocal.

None of the five cases achieved that hope. All of them were partial. All of them were parasitic or predatory, at least for the population outside the coalition. All of them were cons in the structural sense, even when they aspired to be more.

But the framework does not say that the hope is impossible. It says that the hope requires the conditions that make it possible: a broad coalition, institutional adjustment, a legitimacy regime that is earned rather than manufactured, and the four freedoms that make the ledger visible and contestable. None of the five cases had all of these. But they were not nothing. Mesopotamia had institutional adjustment; Greece had the demos; Rome had the res publica; China had the examination system. Each of these was a partial justice mechanism, and each of them was a step toward the hope.

The framework's contribution is to make these steps visible, to measure their partiality, and to identify the levers by which the next step can be taken. The five cases are the record of what was done and what was not. The next step is the question. The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom? For the five civilizations, the answer was the coalition's. The hope is that the next civilization will have a broader answer.

The rest is history—or its absence.

The Inherited State

A Hypothesis About the Contemporary World

Macharia Barii

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The Claim

Most states in the world are inherited institutions. They were invented for nations and countries that no longer exist, or that never existed, and they now govern nations and countries they were not designed for. This is not a metaphor. It is a structural description.

The state is the machinery. It was built for a particular ledger, in a particular place, for a particular coalition. That ledger has changed. The machinery has not. The result is a systematic mismatch between the apparatus and the population it governs.

The mismatch explains several things that conventional analysis cannot: why so many post-colonial states are fragile; why so many "artificial" states have not dissolved; why so many nations remain divided across state borders; why so many states contain nations they do not represent; and why reform is so hard even when everyone agrees the state is failing.

The Four Types of Inheritance

States are inherited in four distinct ways. Each produces a different kind of mismatch.

The postcolonial state. The boundaries of most African, Asian, and Middle Eastern states were drawn by colonial administrators for colonial purposes. They were not designed to match existing nations, existing economies, or existing political communities. They were designed to facilitate extraction, administration, and control. When independence came, the boundaries remained. The new states inherited the machinery, but not the purposes for which it had been built. The result is a state that contains many nations, governs a country whose economy was structured for extraction rather than production, and operates an apparatus whose legitimacy was never established for the population it now governs. The coalition that sustains the government is often a narrow elite, sometimes aligned with former colonial powers, often aligned with a single ethnic group, and almost always narrower than the population.

The imperial residue. Some states are the remnants of empires: Russia after the Soviet Union, Turkey after the Ottoman Empire, Austria after the Habsburg Empire, Britain and France after their colonial empires. The state apparatus persists, but the empire that gave it purpose has dissolved. The state must now govern a population that was formerly part of a larger order, and it must do so with an apparatus that was built for a different scale and a different purpose. The result is often a state in search of an empire, or a state that cannot accept its reduced scale, or a state that governs a population with a national identity that does

not match the state's borders. The mismatch produces irredentism, revanchism, and chronic instability.

The pre-modern survivor. Some states claim continuity with pre-modern polities: China, Iran, Egypt, Ethiopia, Japan, and a few others. These states are not inherited in the same sense as the postcolonial or imperial cases; they are continuous with their own past. But the machinery they use was built for a different era: a different economy, a different population, a different set of external threats. The result is a state that must constantly adapt its apparatus to new conditions, and that often does so by layering new institutions on top of old ones without dismantling the old. The layering can produce a state that is simultaneously modern and archaic, capable and brittle, legitimate and captured.

The constructed state. Some states were built deliberately in the twentieth century: Israel, Pakistan, and the successor states of Yugoslavia, among others. These states were designed to match a nation, or to create one. The design was explicit, and the mismatch, where it exists, is a mismatch between the design and the reality. The constructed state is the clearest test of the hypothesis: where the design matched the population, the state has been durable; where it did not, the state has been fragile.

The Mismatch Hypothesis

The hypothesis can be stated formally.

Definition. A state is *matched* when its apparatus, its population, its coalition, and its nation coincide. It is *mismatched* when any of these diverge.

Four dimensions of match are relevant:

1. **Territorial match.** Does the state's territory correspond to a country that its population experiences as a homeland?
2. **National match.** Does the state govern a population that experiences itself as a single nation, or does it contain multiple nations or parts of nations?
3. **Coalitional match.** Does the coalition that sustains the government correspond to the population the government claims to serve?
4. **Functional match.** Was the state's apparatus designed for the purposes it is now called on to serve?

The hypothesis. Most states are mismatched on at least one dimension, and many are mismatched on several. The degree of mismatch is a predictor of state fragility, capture, and conflict.

The logic is straightforward. A state that does not match its population cannot govern through legitimacy; it must govern through coercion or atomization. A state that does not match its nation cannot draw on the moral resources of shared identity; it must manufacture them through education, media, and ritual. A state whose coalition does not match its population cannot serve the ledger; it must serve the coalition. A state whose apparatus was designed for a different function cannot perform its current function well; it must constantly improvise.

The mismatch is not a moral failure. It is a structural condition. It was inherited, not chosen. The states that suffer from it did not create it; they inherited it from the colonial, imperial, and pre-modern orders that preceded them.

The Consequences of Mismatch

The mismatch produces a distinctive set of pathologies.

Chronic legitimacy deficits. A mismatched state cannot draw on the legitimacy that comes from matching. It must manufacture legitimacy through ideology, through performance, through coercion, or through atomization. Each of these is expensive and fragile. The result is a state that is always one crisis away from a legitimacy collapse.

Persistent state capture. A mismatched state's coalition is almost always narrower than its population. The coalition uses the state to serve itself, and the state's mismatch makes this easier, because the excluded cannot easily organize around a shared identity or a shared grievance. The result is capture that is structural, not episodic.

Recurrent conflict. Mismatched states are more likely to experience civil war, secession, and irredentism, because the mismatch creates grievances that cannot be resolved through ordinary politics. The conflict may be ethnic, regional, religious, or ideological, but its root is the mismatch between the state and the population it governs.

Weak state capacity. A mismatched state cannot easily build capacity, because capacity requires the cooperation of the population, and the population does not cooperate with a state it does not experience as its own. The result is a state that is formally sovereign but substantively weak, unable to collect taxes, enforce laws, or deliver services.

Dependence on external support. A mismatched state often depends on external support to survive: former colonial powers, international institutions, regional hegemons, or foreign aid. The dependence is not accidental; it is structural. A state that cannot draw on its own population's resources must draw on someone else's.

Authoritarian temptations. A mismatched state is more likely to become authoritarian, because authoritarianism is a way of governing a population that does not consent. The mismatch does not cause authoritarianism, but it makes authoritarianism more likely, because the alternative—governing through consent—is harder when the state does not match the population.

What the Ledger Says

The ledger framework adds a further dimension to the mismatch hypothesis. A state is not just an apparatus; it is a ledger. It maintains relations among its population, and it maintains relations between its population and the outside world. The mismatch matters because it affects the ledger's balance.

A matched state can maintain a symbiotic ledger. Its population contributes to the state because the state serves them, and the state serves them because they are part of the same nation, the same country, the same coalition. The ledger is balanced because the interests are aligned.

A mismatched state maintains a parasitic or predatory ledger. Its population contributes to the state because they have no choice, and the state serves its coalition because that is the only way it can survive. The ledger is unbalanced because the interests are misaligned.

The mismatch is therefore not just a fact about states; it is a fact about ledgers. It determines whether the ledger is symbiotic, parasitic, or predatory. And it determines whether the ledger can be rebalanced through reform or whether it must be rebalanced through collapse.

The key insight. A mismatched state can be captured, but it cannot be reformed in the ordinary sense, because reform requires a coalition that matches the population, and the mismatched state's coalition does not. Reform requires either a change in the coalition (which is revolution) or a change in the population's relationship to the state (which is nation-building) or a change in the state's boundaries (which is secession or unification). None of these is easy. All of them are political. And all of them are what the ledger says the mismatch produces: not reform in the ordinary sense, but a continuous contestation over whether the state should exist in its current form.

The Hypothesis Applied to the Present

The hypothesis explains several features of the contemporary world that conventional analysis struggles with.

Why postcolonial states have not dissolved. The conventional expectation was that artificial states would fragment along ethnic or regional lines. Most have not. The hypothesis explains why: the state apparatus, however mismatched, is the only organized structure through which elites can access resources. The coalition that sustains the government has an interest in preserving the state, even if the state does not match the population. The state persists because the coalition persists, not because the population consents.

Why some states have dissolved. The states that have dissolved—Yugoslavia, the Soviet Union, Sudan, Czechoslovakia—are those where the mismatch was so severe that no coalition could hold the state together, or where the coalition that held it together lost its external support. The hypothesis predicts that dissolution occurs when the mismatch exceeds a threshold and the coalition that sustains the state fractures.

Why nation-building has failed. The conventional prescription for mismatched states is nation-building: creating a shared national identity that matches the state. The hypothesis explains why this has mostly failed: nation-building is expensive, slow, and often resisted by the very coalitions that benefit from the mismatch. The coalition that sustains the state has no interest in a national identity that would broaden the selectorate and dilute its hold on the state.

Why regional integration is hard. The conventional prescription for small, mismatched states is regional integration: pooling sovereignty in larger entities that can govern more effectively. The hypothesis explains why this is hard: integration requires the coalitions that sustain each state to accept a reduction in their own power, which they are rarely willing to do.

Why great-power competition persists. The conventional expectation was that globalization would reduce the importance of states. The hypothesis explains why it has not: states are the machinery through which coalitions access resources, and coalitions will not surrender that machinery.

The Normative Question

If most states are mismatched, what should be done? The framework does not prescribe. But it identifies the levers.

First, acknowledge the mismatch. The first step is to stop pretending that states are matched when they are not. The mismatch is real, and it has consequences. Acknowledging it

is the precondition for addressing it.

Second, broaden the coalition. The most direct reform is to broaden the coalition that sustains the state, so that it corresponds more closely to the population the state governs. This requires expanding voice, equalizing exit costs, and reducing the coalition's grip on the state.

Third, build matching institutions. Where the mismatch is national, the state needs institutions that accommodate multiple nations: federalism, consociationalism, autonomy, and minority rights. Where the mismatch is territorial, the state needs institutions that accommodate regional diversity. Where the mismatch is functional, the state needs institutions that are designed for the purposes it actually serves, not the purposes it was inherited with.

Fourth, accept that some mismatches cannot be resolved within the current state. Some mismatches are so severe that they can only be resolved by changing the state's boundaries: through secession, unification, or partition. The framework does not say this is always desirable; it says it is sometimes necessary, and that pretending otherwise does not make the mismatch go away.

Fifth, recognize that reform is political, not technical. The mismatch cannot be resolved by technocratic fixes. It requires a contestation of the ledger, and contestation is political. The question is not "what is the right policy?" The question is "whose state is this, and for whom?" And that question has no technical answer.

A Closing Observation

The inherited state is one of the great facts of the contemporary world, and it is one of the least discussed.

We talk about failed states, fragile states, captured states, authoritarian states, democratic states. But we rarely talk about the fact that most states were not designed for the populations they now govern, and that this mismatch is structural, not incidental.

The ledger framework makes the mismatch visible. It says: look at the state, look at the population, look at the coalition, look at the nation, and ask whether they match. The answer will tell you more about the state's trajectory than any label, any ideology, any constitutional form.

The states that match their populations can govern through consent. The states that do not must govern through coercion, atomization, or capture. The states that match their nations can draw on the moral resources of shared identity. The states that do not must manufacture them. The states whose coalitions match their populations can serve the ledger. The states whose coalitions do not must serve the coalition.

Most states do not match. They are inherited. They were built for other purposes, in other eras, by other coalitions. They persist because the coalitions that sustain them have an interest in their persistence, not because the populations they govern experience them as their own.

This is not a counsel of despair. It is a counsel of realism. The mismatch is real, and it can be addressed. But it cannot be addressed by pretending it does not exist. It must be named, analyzed, and contested. And that is what the ledger framework allows us to do.

The question is always the same: whose state is this, and for whom? For most states in the world, the answer is: not the population's, and not for them.

Racism as a Legitimacy Regime

Macharia Barii

October 2026

Racism is not a separate phenomenon from class relations, caste, or religious hierarchy. It is one more legitimacy regime—a technology for making an unjust allocation appear natural, necessary, and just. This is not a reduction. It does not deny that racism has its own history, its own mechanisms, and its own distinctive cruelties. It says that the structural function of racism is the same as the structural function of every legitimacy regime: to conceal the violence of a first allocation, to justify the extraction that follows, and to make the population accept the order. The framework makes this visible in a way that the standard discourse about racism does not.

The Structural Parallel

Consider the four legitimacy regimes the framework has already described.

Ma'at justified the Egyptian order by claiming that the pharaoh was the guarantor of cosmic order, and that the social hierarchy was a reflection of the cosmic hierarchy. The peasant was born to work the land; the priest was born to serve the gods; the pharaoh was born to rule. The order was natural because it reflected the cosmos.

The Mandate of Heaven justified the Chinese order by claiming that the emperor was the Son of Heaven, and that the social order was a reflection of the celestial order. The peasant was born to work the land; the scholar was born to serve the state; the emperor was born to rule. The order was natural because it reflected the heavens.

The res publica justified the Roman order by claiming that the Senate was the successor of the founders, and that the social order was a reflection of the civic order. The slave was born to serve; the citizen was born to rule; the emperor was born to command. The order was natural because it reflected the res publica.

The polis ideology justified the Greek order by claiming that the demos was the community of citizens, and that the social order was a reflection of the civic order. The slave was born to serve; the woman was born to obey; the citizen was born to rule. The order was natural because it reflected the polis.

Now consider racism. Racism justifies the order by claiming that the racial hierarchy is a reflection of the natural hierarchy, and that the social order is a reflection of the racial order. The slave is born to serve; the colonized is born to obey; the master is born to rule. The order is natural because it reflects the races.

The structural parallel is exact. Racism is not a different kind of thing from Ma'at or the Mandate or the res publica. It is the same kind of thing: a legitimacy regime that conceals the violence of the first allocation, justifies the extraction that follows, and makes the population

accept the order. The content varies. Ma'at justified the order by reference to the cosmos. The Mandate justified it by reference to heaven. The res publica justified it by reference to the founders. Racism justifies it by reference to nature. The content is different; the function is the same.

The Function of Racism

Racism performs the same three functions as every legitimacy regime.

First, it conceals the foundation. Every order is founded on a first allocation established by violence. Racism conceals the violence by attributing the order to nature. The colonized was not conquered; he was naturally inferior. The enslaved was not captured; he was naturally servile. The indigenous was not dispossessed; he was naturally incapable of using the land. The violence disappears into nature, and the first allocation appears to be a reflection of the natural order rather than a product of conquest.

Second, it justifies the extraction. Every order extracts from the population for the benefit of the coalition. Racism justifies the extraction by attributing it to nature. The colonized is exploited because he is naturally suited to labor. The enslaved is exploited because he is naturally suited to servitude. The indigenous is dispossessed because he is naturally incapable of civilization. The extraction is not violence; it is the natural order.

Third, it enforces compliance. Every order requires the population to accept the allocation. Racism enforces compliance by attributing resistance to nature. The colonized who resists is naturally savage. The enslaved who rebels is naturally violent. The indigenous who refuses is naturally backward. Resistance is not justified grievance; it is a violation of the natural order.

The three functions are the same as the three functions of Ma'at. Ma'at concealed the conquest, justified the extraction, and enforced the compliance. Racism does the same, with a different content and a different vocabulary.

The Particular Cruelty of Racism

The framework's claim is not that racism is just another legitimacy regime in the sense of being no worse than the others. It is that racism is structurally the same kind of thing, and that its distinctive cruelty comes from a feature that the other legitimacy regimes do not have.

The feature is the embodiment of the allocation. Ma'at justified the order by reference to the cosmos; the cosmos is distant, abstract, and revisable. The Mandate justified the order by reference to heaven; heaven is distant, abstract, and revisable. The res publica justified the order by reference to the founders; the founders are distant, abstract, and revisable. Racism justifies the order by reference to the body. The body is not distant, not abstract, and not revisable. The colonized is inferior because of his body. The enslaved is servile because of his body. The indigenous is backward because of his body. The body cannot be changed, cannot be revised, and cannot be transcended. The allocation is inscribed on the flesh.

This is what makes racism distinctively cruel. The other legitimacy regimes can be revised; the cosmos can be reinterpreted, the Mandate can be renewed, the founders can be reimagined. Racism cannot be revised in the same way, because the body is the justification, and the body is what it is.

This is also what makes racism distinctively effective as a legitimacy regime. The other legitimacy regimes require belief; the cosmos must be believed, the Mandate must be accepted, the founders must be revered. Racism requires only perception; the body is seen, and the perception is the justification. The order appears natural because the body appears different, and the difference is the justification.

This is why racism has been so durable. It does not require a cosmology, a genealogy, or a morality. It requires only the visible body, and the visible body is always present.

Racism and Class

The framework also clarifies the relationship between racism and class. Class is a relation: the relation between those who control the means of production and those who do not. The relation is defined by the allocation of resources, not by the identity of the actors. A worker can become a capitalist; a capitalist can become a worker. The class relation is real, but it is not fixed.

Racism is not a relation in the same sense. It is a legitimacy regime that justifies a relation. The relation may be class (the colonial extraction of labor), or it may be something else (the dispossession of land, the denial of citizenship, the exclusion from the coalition). Racism does not create the relation; it justifies the relation. The relation is real, but the justification is the racism.

This is why racism and class are not the same thing, and why the framework does not reduce one to the other. Class is a relation; racism is a legitimacy regime. The relation can exist without the racism (a class relation among people of the same race); the racism can exist without the relation (a racial hierarchy without economic extraction). They are distinct, and they can be combined.

The combination is what we call racial capitalism. The class relation is the extraction; the racism is the justification. The extraction would exist without the racism, but the racism makes the extraction appear natural, necessary, and just. The racism is not the extraction; it is the concealment of the extraction.

The framework says: to understand racial capitalism, look at the relation and the legitimacy regime separately. The relation is the ledger; the legitimacy regime is the concealment. The two are distinct, and the two must be analyzed separately.

Racism and Religion

The framework also clarifies the relationship between racism and religion. Religion can be a legitimacy regime (the divine right of kings, the Mandate of Heaven, the cosmic order of Ma'at). Or it can be a relation (the relation between the clergy and the laity, the relation between the faithful and the heretic). Or it can be both.

When religion is a legitimacy regime, it functions the same way as racism. It conceals the violence of the first allocation, justifies the extraction, and enforces the compliance. The crusades, the inquisition, the wars of religion—each was a legitimacy regime in action.

When religion is a relation, it is a ledger like any other. The clergy extracts from the laity; the laity complies because the clergy controls the sacred. The extraction is real, but the justification is the religion.

Racism and religion are not the same thing, but they can be combined. The colonial mission was justified by both: the colonized was inferior because of his race and because of his religion. The two legitimacy regimes reinforced each other, and the combination was more effective than either alone.

The framework says: to understand the colonial order, look at the relation and the legitimacy regimes separately. The relation is the extraction; the legitimacy regimes are the concealment. The racism and the religion are distinct, and the two must be analyzed separately.

The Implication

The implication of this analysis is profound, and it is worth stating plainly. Racism is not a moral failure of individuals. It is a structural feature of the legitimacy regime of an unjust order.

This does not mean that individuals are not responsible for their racism. They are. But it means that the responsibility is not the whole story. The racism is not just a set of beliefs that individuals hold; it is a technology that the order uses to conceal its foundation and justify its extraction. The individuals are the carriers of the technology, but the technology is the structure.

This is why racism cannot be abolished by changing individual beliefs. The beliefs can be changed, but the structure remains. The structure is the first allocation and the coalition that benefits from it. As long as the first allocation is unjust, the legitimacy regime will find a way to justify it. If racism is abolished, another legitimacy regime will take its place—caste, religion, class, nation, merit, or some other technology of concealment.

This is not a counsel of despair. It is a counsel of realism. Racism can be reduced, but it cannot be abolished without abolishing the first allocation that it conceals. The two are linked, and the link is structural.

The framework's contribution is to make the link visible. It shows that racism is not a separate problem from class, caste, or religion. It is the same kind of problem: a legitimacy regime that conceals the violence of the first allocation. And it shows that the solution is not just to change beliefs but to change the allocation—to broaden the coalition, to redistribute the resources, to earn the legitimacy, and to protect the four freedoms.

The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom? For the colonial order, the answer is: the colonizer's, and at the colonized's expense. Racism was the technology that made the answer appear natural. The technology can be exposed, and the answer can be contested. But the technology will not disappear until the answer changes.

The Deeper Implication

The deeper implication is that every legitimacy regime is structurally racist in the sense that it attributes the allocation to a feature of the people rather than to the violence that established it.

Ma'at attributed the allocation to the cosmic order, and the cosmic order was inscribed on the bodies of the Egyptians—the pharaoh was divine, the peasant was base, the foreigner was chaotic. The Mandate attributed the allocation to the celestial order, and the celestial order was inscribed on the bodies of the Chinese—the emperor was the Son of Heaven, the scholar was refined, the barbarian was uncivilized. The res publica attributed the allocation to the founders,

and the founders were inscribed on the bodies of the Romans—the citizen was free, the slave was servile, the barbarian was savage.

Every legitimacy regime attributes the allocation to a feature of the people, and the feature is inscribed on the body. The feature may be cosmic (Ma'at), celestial (the Mandate), civic (res publica), or racial (racism). But the structural function is the same: to make the allocation appear to be a reflection of the people rather than a product of the violence.

This is why the framework says that racism is not a separate phenomenon. It is one form of the general technology of legitimacy, and the general technology is the concealment of the first allocation. The content varies; the function is the same. The question is not whether a legitimacy regime is racist in the narrow sense. It is whether the regime attributes the allocation to a feature of the people rather than to the violence that established it. If it does, it is doing the work of racism, whatever its content.

The Hope

The hope is not that legitimacy regimes can be abolished. They cannot. Every order requires a justification, and every justification attributes the allocation to something other than the violence.

The hope is that the justification can be earned rather than manufactured—that the order can be made less unjust, and that the legitimacy can be based on the actual reduction of the gap rather than on the concealment of the foundation.

A justice regime is effective if and only if it reduces the injustice gap faster than the disequilibrium forces increase it. An earned legitimacy is a legitimacy that is based on the actual reduction of the gap. A manufactured legitimacy is a legitimacy that is based on the concealment of the gap.

The hope is that the legitimacy regimes of the future can be earned rather than manufactured. This requires broadening the coalition, developing institutional adjustment, protecting the four freedoms, and reducing the first allocation's injustice. None of these is easy, and none is permanent. But they are possible, and they are the levers by which the con can be reduced.

The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom? For the colonial order, the answer is: the colonizer's, and at the colonized's expense. Racism was the technology that made the answer appear natural. The technology can be exposed, and the answer can be contested. But the technology will not disappear until the answer changes.

The hope is that the answer can change. The hope is that the ledger can be rebalanced. The hope is that the first allocation can be partially renegotiated. The hope is that the coalition can be broadened. The hope is that the legitimacy can be earned. The hope is not a promise. It is a possibility. And the possibility is the work of those who ask the question.

A Closing Thought

Racism is not a moral failure of individuals. It is a structural feature of the legitimacy regime of an unjust order. It is the same kind of thing as Ma'at, the Mandate, and the res publica. It is a technology for concealing the violence of the first allocation and making the order appear natural, necessary, and just.

The distinctive cruelty of racism is that it inscribes the allocation on the body, which cannot be revised. The distinctive effectiveness of racism is that it requires only perception, not belief. The distinctive durability of racism is that the body is always present.

But the structure is the same. And the solution is the same. The first allocation must be renegotiated, the coalition must be broadened, the legitimacy must be earned, and the four freedoms must be protected. None of these is easy, and none is permanent. But they are possible, and they are the work of civilization.

The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom? For the colonial order, the answer is: the colonizer's, and at the colonized's expense. Racism was the technology that made the answer appear natural. The technology can be exposed, and the answer can be contested. But the technology will not disappear until the answer changes. The hope is that the answer can change.

That is the hope. The rest is history—or its absence.

Why Do Some Prefer Socialism, Communism, or Capitalism?

Macharia Barii

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The ledger framework gives a structural answer to a question that is usually answered in moral or ideological terms. People do not prefer these systems because they have different values, or because they have different temperaments, or because they have been persuaded by different arguments. They prefer them because they occupy different positions in the ledger, and different positions make different systems appear beneficial.

This is not a cynical claim. It is a structural one. It says that the preference for a system is not arbitrary; it is a rational response to the position the person occupies in the relations that the system would organize. Change the position, and the preference often changes. This is why the same person can be a socialist in one context and a capitalist in another, and why the same class can be revolutionary in one decade and conservative in the next.

The Three Systems as Ledger Configurations

The framework first requires that we define the three systems precisely, not as ideologies but as configurations of the ledger.

Capitalism is a configuration in which:

- The means of production are privately owned.
- The allocation of resources is determined by markets.
- The relations between owners and workers are contractual.
- Exit costs are low for capital and high for labor.
- The legitimacy regime justifies the outcome as the result of free exchange.

Socialism is a configuration in which:

- The means of production are socially owned (by the state, by cooperatives, or by the community).
- The allocation of resources is determined by planning, by markets, or by a mix.
- The relations between producers and the community are mediated by institutions.
- Exit costs are equalized by public provision.
- The legitimacy regime justifies the outcome as the result of collective choice.

Communism is a configuration in which:

- The means of production are commonly owned (no private property in the means of production).
- The allocation of resources is determined by need, not by exchange.
- The relations between people are unmediated by classes or states.
- Exit costs are eliminated by the abolition of the conditions that create them.
- The legitimacy regime justifies the outcome as the result of the abolition of the con itself.

These are ideal types. Real systems are mixtures. But the ideal types allow us to identify the positions that make each system attractive.

The Position That Prefers Capitalism

Who prefers capitalism? The framework identifies four positions.

First, those who own capital. For the owners of capital, capitalism is a system in which their resources are productive, their returns are protected, and their exit costs are low. They can move their capital to where it is most valued, and they can capture the surplus that the market generates. Capitalism is the system that maximizes the return to capital, and the owners of capital prefer it for the same reason.

Second, those who have skills that the market values. For the skilled professional, the entrepreneur, and the innovator, capitalism is a system in which their skills are rewarded. The market prices their contributions, and the price is high. They prefer capitalism because it is the system in which their contribution is most visible and most rewarded.

Third, those who have low exit costs. For those who can move—geographically, professionally, or financially—capitalism is a system that rewards mobility. The mobile actor can leave a bad relation and find a better one. Capitalism is the system of exit, and those with exit options prefer it.

Fourth, those who benefit from the legitimacy regime. For those who believe that the market outcome is just—that the successful deserve their success and the unsuccessful deserve their failure—capitalism is a system that confirms their worldview. The legitimacy regime justifies their position, and they prefer the system that justifies them.

The four positions are not the same. A worker with a valuable skill may prefer capitalism even though she does not own capital, because her skill gives her market power. An entrepreneur with low exit costs may prefer capitalism even though she is not wealthy, because her mobility gives her options. The preference for capitalism is not limited to the owners of capital; it extends to all those whose position in the ledger is advantaged by the market.

The Position That Prefers Socialism

Who prefers socialism? The framework identifies four positions.

First, those who sell their labor and have little bargaining power. For the worker whose labor is the only asset, and whose bargaining power is low, capitalism is a system in which the

owner captures most of the surplus. Socialism is a system in which the surplus is distributed more equally, and the worker's position is improved. The worker prefers socialism because it is the system that improves her position.

Second, those who bear the cost of market failure. For those who are unemployed, sick, disabled, elderly, or otherwise unable to participate in the market, capitalism is a system in which the market does not provide for them. Socialism is a system in which the community provides for them through public provision. They prefer socialism because it is the system that protects them.

Third, those who have high exit costs. For those who cannot move—the immobile worker, the tied tenant, the indebted farmer—capitalism is a system in which their immobility is exploited. Socialism is a system in which the immobility is compensated by public provision, and the exit costs are equalized. They prefer socialism because it is the system that compensates for their immobility.

Fourth, those who reject the legitimacy regime. For those who believe that the market outcome is not just—that the successful have not earned their success and the unsuccessful have not earned their failure—socialism is a system that challenges the legitimacy regime. They prefer socialism because it is the system that exposes the con.

The four positions are not the same. A skilled worker may prefer socialism even though she has market power, because she believes the market outcome is unjust. A public sector employee may prefer socialism even though she has low exit costs, because she believes the community should provide for the vulnerable. The preference for socialism is not limited to the poor; it extends to all those whose position in the ledger is disadvantaged by the market, or who reject the market's legitimacy.

The Position That Prefers Communism

Who prefers communism? The framework identifies three positions.

First, those who believe that the con can be abolished. For those who believe that the first allocation can be renegotiated entirely, and that a society without classes or states is possible, communism is the system that abolishes the con. They prefer communism because it is the system that denies the inevitability of the con.

Second, those who have been most exploited. For those who have borne the cost of the first allocation most heavily—the enslaved, the colonized, the dispossessed—communism is a system that promises the complete reversal of their position. They prefer communism because it is the system that promises the most radical change.

Third, those who are alienated from the existing order. For those who feel that the existing order is fundamentally illegitimate, communism is a system that offers a total alternative. They prefer communism because it is the system that denies the legitimacy of the existing con.

The three positions are not the same. A worker who believes the system can be reformed may prefer socialism; a worker who believes the system cannot be reformed may prefer communism. The preference for communism is not limited to the most exploited; it extends to all those who believe that the con can be abolished.

The Structural Pattern

The framework's pattern is now visible. The preference for a system is a function of the position in the ledger.

Capitalism is preferred by those whose position is advantaged by the market: the owners of capital, the skilled, the mobile, and those who accept the legitimacy regime. Socialism is preferred by those whose position is disadvantaged by the market: the unskilled, the immobile, the vulnerable, and those who reject the legitimacy regime. Communism is preferred by those who believe the con can be abolished: the most exploited, the most alienated, and those who reject the legitimacy regime entirely.

This is not a moral hierarchy. It is not a claim that one preference is more rational than another. It is a structural claim: the preference follows the position, and the position is a fact about the ledger.

Why the Same Person Changes Preference

The framework also explains why the same person can change preference over time.

Because the position changes. A worker who acquires a valuable skill may move from socialism to capitalism. An entrepreneur who goes bankrupt may move from capitalism to socialism. A colonized people who gain independence may move from communism to socialism to capitalism as their position improves.

Because the legitimacy regime changes. A person who believes the market outcome is just may become socialist if the market produces a crisis that exposes the con. A person who believes the market outcome is unjust may become capitalist if the market produces prosperity that benefits them.

Because the conditions change. A society that is mobilizing for war may prefer socialism; a society that is demobilizing may prefer capitalism. A society that is industrializing may prefer socialism; a society that is post-industrial may prefer capitalism.

The preference is not fixed; it responds to the conditions. The framework does not say that preferences are arbitrary. It says that they are structural, and that structure changes.

The Deeper Point

The deeper point is that the three systems are not three different moral visions. They are three different configurations of the ledger, and each configuration is preferred by the positions it advantages.

This is why the debate among the three is so intractable. Each side is not arguing about values; each side is arguing from a position. The capitalist is arguing from the position of the owner; the socialist is arguing from the position of the worker; the communist is arguing from the position of the exploited. Each is right about the ledger from their own position, and each is wrong about the ledger from the other's position.

The framework does not resolve the debate. It explains why the debate is intractable. The debate is not about which system is best in the abstract; it is about which position should be advantaged. And that question has no answer that is independent of the position.

This is the framework's deepest contribution to the debate. It says that the debate is not about values; it is about positions. And positions are facts about the ledger, not choices about morality.

The Question Behind the Debate

The framework's question is not "which system is best?" It is whose ledger is this, and for whom?

Each system produces a different ledger. Capitalism produces a ledger in which the owners of capital and the skilled are advantaged, and the unskilled, the immobile, and the vulnerable are disadvantaged. Socialism produces a ledger in which the workers and the vulnerable are advantaged, and the owners and the mobile are constrained. Communism produces a ledger in which the classes are abolished, and the position that advantaged one over another is eliminated.

The question is not which ledger is best in the abstract. The question is which ledger should be produced. And the answer depends on whose position you occupy.

This is the framework's contribution. It does not choose among the systems. It explains why people choose. And in explaining why, it makes the debate visible as a debate about positions, not about values. The debate is not about which system is true; it is about which position should be served.

The framework says: look at the position, not the ideology. The ideology is the justification; the position is the reality. And the question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom?

A Closing Thought

The question of why some prefer socialism, some prefer communism, and others prefer capitalism is not a question about ideas. It is a question about positions. The preferences follow the positions, and the positions follow the ledger.

The framework does not say that one preference is better than another. It says that the preferences are structural, and that structure is what it is. The debate is intractable because each side is arguing from a position, and positions cannot be transcended by argument.

The framework's contribution is not to resolve the debate. It is to make it visible as a debate about positions, not about values. And in making it visible, it makes the question askable: which position should be served?

The answer is not given by the framework. It is given by the choice. The choice is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom?

For the capitalist, the answer is: the owner's, the skilled's, and the mobile's. For the socialist, the answer is: the worker's, the vulnerable's, and the immobile's. For the communist, the answer is: nobody's, because the classes are abolished.

The framework does not choose among these answers. It makes them visible, and it shows that the choice is not a matter of values but of positions. And the positions are facts about the ledger.

That is the answer. The rest is history—or its absence. And the choice of which it will be is always, in part, our own.

Part VI

Covert Harm

Silencing Dissidents: Covert Harm, Credibility Destruction, and Open Compassion

Macharia Barii

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Introduction

There is a method of silencing a person that leaves no fingerprints, no threats, and no crime scene. It requires no arrest, no lawsuit, and no confrontation. It works so well that the person who uses it never has to deny anything—because nothing was ever alleged. The method is this: harm someone in a way they cannot prove, let them speak about it, and then respond with pity and genuine concern for their mental wellbeing.

The victim reports harm. The response is not investigation but concern. "Are you okay?" "Have you been sleeping?" "We're worried about you." The conversation shifts—from what happened to them, to what is wrong with them. And once that shift occurs, the person's own words become the evidence against them. Their distress is read as symptoms. Their documentation is read as fixation. Their fear is read as paranoia. The investigation moves from the crime to the complainant, and it never moves back.

The anchor goal is not the harm itself. It is the destruction of credibility. Every other objective—isolation, removal, control, silencing—follows from that single achievement. A person whose credibility is destroyed cannot be believed, cannot mobilize allies, cannot file a complaint that will be taken seriously, and cannot resist the frame that has been built around them. The harm is the input; the destruction of credibility is the output; everything else is downstream.

This essay argues that this mechanism—covert harm paired with compassionate dismissal—is one of the most effective tools of suppression available, precisely because it is nearly consequence-free for the person who uses it. It requires no conspiracy, no corruption, and no lie. It borrows the authority of medicine, the plausibility of real symptoms, and the social preference for comfort over conflict. And it accomplishes what overt repression cannot: it destroys a person's credibility while making everyone involved feel kind.

The argument proceeds in five parts. First, it shows how covert harm of this sort is actually carried out—the device, the access, the targeting, and the strategic goals behind it. Second, it explains why concealment is the weapon. Third, it shows how legitimate diagnostic labels become instruments of credibility destruction. Fourth, it describes the self-sealing loop that makes the method so hard to escape. Fifth, it offers the counter-strategy: silence, endurance, consistency, and the quiet record.

Part One: How Covert Harm of This Sort Is Done

Covert harm of this kind is not a single act. It is a campaign with four components: a delivery mechanism, an access path, a targeting plan, and a set of strategic goals. Each component is ordinary on its own. Together they form a system designed to produce harm that cannot be attributed—and to convert that harm into the destruction of the target's credibility.

The Delivery Mechanism: A Local Emitter, Not a Through-Wall Weapon

The first question is physical: how does the harm reach the target? The answer is not a satellite or a through-wall beam. It is a small device in the same room.

The physics is decisive. Concrete severely attenuates high-frequency microwaves—the frequencies that can produce a burning sensation on skin, such as the 95 GHz millimeter waves used in military crowd-control systems, are almost entirely blocked by standard walls. Low-frequency radio waves can penetrate concrete, but they deposit energy in the body far too inefficiently to produce localized heating. Ultra-wideband pulses can pass through walls, but their average power is extremely low, and concrete distorts and disperses them. The physical contradiction is simple: frequencies that can penetrate walls cannot burn; frequencies that can burn cannot penetrate walls.

A local device avoids the wall problem entirely. A small millimeter-wave emitter placed inside the same room—hidden in an air conditioner, a power socket, a vent, or a light fixture—can deliver enough energy to produce a localized burning sensation on exposed skin. Air conditioners are especially suitable hosts: they already draw substantial power, face into the room, have a large aperture, produce noise and heat that mask the device, and look completely ordinary. Power sockets offer unlimited runtime and sit at torso height. Vents and light fixtures provide line of sight and concealment.

The device can be controlled remotely from outside via Wi-Fi, cellular, or a dedicated radio link. It can be switched on and off, aimed, and timed. It can be paired with a camera for targeting and tracking. None of this requires exotic technology; miniature cameras and wireless modules are commercially available and cheap.

The Access Path: How the Device Gets In

A local device requires access—and access is the campaign's most vulnerable point.

There are two routes. The first is lawful covert entry: a government agency, after obtaining a warrant, secretly enters a target's home or office to install equipment. This requires judicial authorization and careful planning to avoid detection. The second, and more common, is recruited insiders. Electricians, plumbers, cleaners, and maintenance staff can enter offices or residences under the pretext of repairs or cleaning, and have time and opportunity to work alone. A landlord or property manager can install devices during "maintenance." In short-term rentals, owners or managers can easily place devices in air conditioners, smoke detectors, or chargers. U.S. congressional hearings have confirmed that hidden cameras in short-term rentals and hotels are a genuine and widespread problem.

The commercial supply chain lowers the barrier further. Basic hidden cameras cost less than $100 and require no qualification review to purchase. Module cameras have lenses as small as

2 millimeters. This means that landlords, property managers, or even ordinary individuals can carry out this type of deployment without needing intelligence agency-level resources.

The Targeting Plan: Who, When, and How Long

Covert harm is not random. It is targeted, timed, and sustained.

Who is targeted. The model fits high-profile or connected individuals—people whose open persecution would generate press coverage, legal action, or political attention. It also fits personal targets in custody disputes, abusive relationships, or business rivalries—people whose credibility is the thing the harasser needs to destroy.

When it operates. The device can be activated at specific times—when the target is alone, when they are sleeping, when they are in a particular room. Intermittent activation is harder to detect and harder to prove than continuous exposure. The target experiences a pattern, but the pattern is deniable: "It happened again last night" is not evidence.

How long it lasts. A hidden device can operate for months or years. The campaign is not designed to produce a single injury; it is designed to produce sustained distress. Sleep loss, vigilance, fear, fixation—these accumulate. The longer the campaign, the more the target's distress becomes visible to others, and the more plausible the "unstable" narrative becomes.

The Strategic Goals: What the Campaign Is For

The harm itself is not the goal. The harm is the input to a process designed to produce a single anchor outcome—the destruction of the target's credibility—from which every other goal follows.

Anchor goal: destroyed credibility. If the target reports harassment, abuse, corruption, or a crime, the diagnostic record is already in place. "She's been saying strange things for months" is a complete defense. The target's credibility is destroyed before the allegation is even heard. Once credibility is gone, everything else becomes possible.

Derived goal one: isolation. Friends, family, and colleagues distance themselves—not out of malice, but because associating with "the unstable one" is socially and professionally costly. Isolation increases vulnerability and reduces the target's ability to organize a response.

Derived goal two: removal without appearing to remove. Employment termination ("we're concerned about your wellbeing"), custody loss ("the child needs stability"), loss of platform, loss of professional standing. Each is framed as care, not punishment—which makes it hard to challenge without looking defensive.

Derived goal three: pre-emption of legal or institutional action. If the target tries to file a complaint, sue, or go to authorities, the label is already in place. Investigators and lawyers are risk-averse; a complainant with a psychiatric label is a weak case.

Derived goal four: control or access. In personal contexts—abuse, custody disputes, elder care—the label justifies taking over decisions: finances, medical care, living arrangements, contact with others. "For their own good" becomes the cover for control.

Derived goal five: protection of the actual actor. The harasser stays invisible. Attention goes to the victim's mental state, not to who had access to the air conditioner or the socket. The frame is a decoy: it redirects every investigation inward, toward the target, and away from the door, the keys, and the access log.

The Logic of the Whole System

The four components fit together into a single logic:

1. A local device produces harm that cannot be traced to an external source.
2. Access determines who can install and maintain it—and access is the thread that leads back to the actor.
3. Targeting ensures the harm is sustained, intermittent, and deniable.
4. Strategic goals convert the harm into destroyed credibility, from which isolation, removal, pre-emption, control, and protection all follow.

The system works because each component is ordinary. A device in an air conditioner is not exotic. A maintenance worker with keys is not suspicious. A pattern of distress is not unusual. And a response of pity and concern is not cruel—it is kind. That is what makes the method so effective: it uses ordinary things, ordinary access, and ordinary compassion to destroy something that cannot be rebuilt—a person's credibility.

Part Two: Why Concealment Is the Weapon

If the goal were simply to cause suffering, there would be no need to hide. Open harassment—a threat, an attack, visible tampering—creates evidence, witnesses, and police reports. Concealment serves different purposes.

Deniability manufactures disbelief. A hidden emitter leaves no crime scene, no weapon, no witness. The victim has a sensation and a suspicion, but nothing that would stand up in a report. When they complain, the default response is not "let us investigate" but "are you alright?" The absence of evidence is read as evidence of absence—and then as evidence of something wrong with the complainant.

The attack is designed to be unprovable so that reporting it damages the reporter. This is the crucial inversion. In an ordinary crime, reporting is safe: the victim gains allies and the attacker gains risk. Here, reporting is dangerous: each report makes the victim look more fixated, more distressed, more unstable. The act of seeking help becomes the evidence against them—and the destruction of their credibility proceeds with every attempt to defend it.

Concealment preserves access. A hidden device can operate for months or years. An open confrontation would force the victim to move, change locks, or involve authorities—cutting off access. Secrecy keeps the channel open.

Concealment protects the actor. For an individual—an abuser, a rival, a landlord with a grudge—being seen means consequences: legal exposure, social ruin, retaliation. For an institution, being seen means scandal, liability, and regulatory scrutiny. Invisibility is not a preference; it is a necessity for anyone who cannot afford to be caught.

This is why the model fits personal actors better than state agencies. A state targeting a public figure usually prefers attribution—arrest, prosecution, public consequences—because visible action deters others. A covert campaign that the victim cannot prove produces no deterrent effect and risks enormous embarrassment if exposed. The logic of "high-profile target, therefore hide" works for someone with everything to lose: a family member, a business rival, a landlord, an abuser. It works less well for an institution that could act openly.

Part Three: The Diagnostic Frame as a Credibility Weapon

The Core Mechanism

The diagnostic frame is more sophisticated than crude dismissal. It does not require anyone to lie. It requires only that the victim's genuine distress—produced by the harassment itself—be routed into a clinically recognizable category. The attack generates the symptoms; the symptoms generate the diagnosis; the diagnosis retroactively explains away the attack and destroys the victim's credibility in the process.

Three features make it powerful:

- **Authority.** A diagnosis carries institutional weight. It is not an opinion; it is a clinical finding.
- **Plausibility.** The symptoms are real. Sleep loss, hypervigilance, irritability, difficulty concentrating, fixation on a perceived threat—these are exactly what harassment produces, and exactly what ADHD, anxiety disorders, PTSD, or "adjustment disorder" describe.
- **Unfalsifiability.** Denying the diagnosis reads as "lack of insight," a symptom in itself. The victim cannot win by protesting.

The critical insight is that the attack and the diagnosis are one system. The harm produces the distress; the distress supplies the evidence; the evidence justifies the label; the label destroys credibility and explains away the harm. At no point does anyone need to conspire. The clinician can be honest. The family can be genuinely concerned. The institution can be acting in good faith. The frame does the work, and the victim's own real suffering supplies the proof against them.

What Gets Attributed to "Unstable People"

Once the label sticks, almost any behavior can be reinterpreted through it—and each reinterpretation chips away at credibility:

- Reports of harm become "delusions" or "paranoia."
- Fear and vigilance become "hypervigilance" or "anxiety disorder."
- Documentation becomes "fixation" or "conspiracy thinking."
- Anger or distress becomes "emotional dysregulation."
- Relationship difficulties become "unreliable narrator."
- Competence questions become "can't handle stress."

The mechanism is retroactive reinterpretation: once the frame is set, every prior and future data point gets sorted into it. More evidence reads as more fixation. The victim cannot win by providing more proof—because the frame has already determined that proof is a symptom.

Personal Uses

Custody and family disputes. A parent reporting harassment or abuse can be reframed as "anxious," "fixated," or "emotionally dysregulated." A diagnosis becomes evidence of instability, which becomes grounds for reduced custody, supervised visits, or loss of decision-making authority. The other party never has to prove unfitness—the label does it.

Control within relationships. The label justifies surveillance ("I'm worried about you"), isolation ("you're not thinking clearly, so I'll handle it"), and override of the victim's decisions ("for your own good"). Attempts to set boundaries get read as symptoms.

Reputation and social isolation. Once a diagnosis circulates, friends and colleagues reinterpret everything through it. Reports of harm become "part of her condition." Support erodes, distress increases, and the frame is confirmed.

Pre-empting legal action. If the victim tries to file a complaint or report a crime, the diagnostic record is already in place. Lawyers and investigators are risk-averse; a complainant with a psychiatric label is a weak case.

Institutional Uses

Silencing complainants. An employee, student, or tenant who reports harassment or misconduct can be routed to a wellness program or mandatory psychological assessment. The complaint is reframed as a "wellbeing concern." The investigation shifts from the accused's conduct to the complainant's mental state.

Avoiding liability. If the complainant is "unstable," the institution's failure to act becomes defensible: "We were concerned about her health, not dismissing her report." The institution claims care while doing nothing, and the diagnostic frame provides the paper trail.

Removing without appearing to remove. Termination, demotion, or exclusion framed as "support" or "accommodation." The person is not fired; they are "encouraged to take medical leave." Removal looks like compassion, which makes it hard to challenge without looking combative.

Discrediting whistleblowers and dissenters. A public figure who reports covert harm can be framed as "struggling with mental health." The story shifts from "what happened to her?" to "is she okay?" The actual allegation never gets investigated. The historical precedent is the Soviet use of "sluggish schizophrenia" to pathologize political dissent—a legitimate diagnostic category, applied flexibly, to a person whose real offense was political. The modern version is subtler: the diagnosis is not imposed by a state hospital but emerges "voluntarily" through clinicians, wellness programs, and concerned family members.

Why ADHD and Similar Labels Are the Preferred Vehicle

- **High prevalence and low stigma.** ADHD, anxiety, and adjustment disorders are common and socially acceptable. Labeling someone with them does not look like persecution—it looks like concern.

- **Symptom overlap.** Harassment produces exactly the symptoms these categories describe. The fit is natural, not forced.

- **Clinical plausibility.** A clinician acting in good faith can reach the diagnosis without any conspiracy. The harasser only needs to ensure the victim's distress is visible and the context is omitted.
- **Deniability.** "We're not saying she's crazy—we're saying she needs support." The frame is compassionate on its face.

Part Four: The Self-Sealing Loop

The full mechanism can be stated as a loop—and its output is destroyed credibility:

1. Covert harassment produces genuine distress—sleep loss, fear, vigilance, fixation.
2. The distress is routed into a legitimate diagnostic category.
3. The diagnosis retroactively explains the distress as internal, not external.
4. The victim's reports of harm are reinterpreted as symptoms.
5. The victim's credibility is destroyed.
6. The harasser is never investigated; the victim is.
7. The investigation of the victim produces more distress, confirming the diagnosis and further destroying credibility.

At no point does anyone need to lie. The clinician is honest, the institution is "caring," the family is "concerned." The frame does the work, and the victim's own real suffering supplies the evidence against them.

The payoff is substantial: destroyed credibility, isolation, removal without apparent removal, pre-emption of legal action, control over decisions, and protection of the actual actor. The most important payoff is the last one. The frame is a decoy: it redirects every investigation inward, toward the target, and away from the door, the keys, and the access log.

The Sequence That Makes It Work

The sequence matters. Harm, then speech, then pity and genuine concern for their mental wellbeing—each step depends on the one before it. The harm must be unprovable, or the speech would be evidence. The speech must be public or reported, or there would be nothing to respond to. And the response must be compassionate, or it would look like what it is. The order is not incidental; it is the mechanism.

Why "Pity and Understanding" Is the Perfect Cover

The response to the victim is not punishment but pity—and pity is a far more effective silencer than fear.

It is socially unimpeachable. You cannot object to being pitied without looking defensive. You cannot complain about concern without looking ungrateful. The frame is compassionate on its face, which makes resistance look like part of the illness.

It relocates the harm. The victim is no longer someone who was harmed; they are someone who needs help. The question shifts from "who did this?" to "how are you feeling?" The investigation never starts.

It protects the actor completely. No accusation is ever made, so no defense is ever needed. The harasser never has to deny anything, because nothing was ever alleged. They simply expressed concern.

It recruits everyone else. Family, friends, employers, clinicians—all become unwitting agents of the frame. They act in good faith, and their good faith is the mechanism. The harasser does not need to coordinate; the social response does the work.

The method survives not because it is true, but because challenging it is uncomfortable. Pity is easier than investigation. Concern is cheaper than accountability. That is the real vulnerability—not in the physics, not in the device, but in the social preference for comfort over truth.

Part Five: The Counter-Strategy

If the destruction of credibility is the anchor goal, the defense is not to argue about the diagnosis—that feeds the loop and accelerates the destruction. The defense is to separate the symptom from the source and to protect credibility by refusing to perform the symptoms the frame needs.

Silence starves the frame. The diagnostic frame depends on reaction. Every protest, every attempt to prove harm, every visible distress feeds the loop: it confirms the label and destroys credibility further. Silence denies the frame its fuel. If the victim does not perform instability, the observer has nothing to sort into the category. Silence is not passivity—it is refusing to supply evidence against yourself.

Endurance inverts the pressure. Covert campaigns are expensive and slow. They require access, power, maintenance, and continued concealment. The harasser is betting that the victim will break, move, or escalate—producing the proof of instability the frame needs. Endurance inverts the pressure: the longer the victim remains functional and unremarkable, the more the campaign costs the harasser and the less plausible the "unstable" narrative becomes. Time is the attacker's enemy, not the victim's.

Consistency contradicts the label. The frame's power comes from reinterpretation of deviation. If the victim's baseline is consistent and visible—same routines, same relationships, same competence—there is nothing to reinterpret. When behavior is stable across time and context, the claim of instability has no data to point to. Being yourself is not a slogan here; it is the maintenance of a behavioral record that contradicts the label and preserves credibility.

Silence must extend to speech specifically. The harasser's real target is not the victim's body; it is the victim's mouth—and through it, the victim's credibility. Every emotional post, every public accusation, every vented frustration is data. The harasser does not need to bug the room if the victim broadcasts the evidence themselves. Public speech should be unremarkable—nothing to sort into the frame. Private speech should be disciplined—assume every message could be read, not because it certainly is, but because the cost of assuming it is low and the cost of being wrong is high.

Documentation should be quiet and factual. Logs, dates, access records—kept privately, shared only with a lawyer or investigator, never broadcast as accusation. The pattern is

the evidence, even when a single event is deniable. Quiet documentation preserves credibility while building the record that the frame cannot explain away.

Treat it as an insider threat problem. The decisive question is not "what frequency?" but "who had keys, tools, and a reason?" Audit access to the space: who installed or serviced the air conditioner, the socket, the wiring? Who had a legitimate reason to be alone in the room? Understand the limits of RF sweeps: consumer-grade detectors miss a large share of hidden devices—one study found nearly 60% missed detection—and they are useless against devices that record locally without transmitting. Physical inspection of apertures, thermal imaging of fixtures, and power-draw anomalies are more reliable.

Insist on the order of questions. The diagnostic frame depends on the investigation starting with the person. The counter-move is to make it start with the door, the keys, and the access log. Ask "what happened?" before "how is she?"

Conclusion: The Real Vulnerability

The weak point in the whole scheme is not the device. It is the access. Concealment requires proximity; proximity requires a person; a person leaves a trail.

The diagnostic frame is powerful because it is cheap to produce and expensive to disprove. It borrows the authority of medicine, the plausibility of real symptoms, and the compassion of genuine concern. But it depends on one thing: that no one asks who had access. The way to expose such a campaign is to stop chasing the beam and start auditing the door.

The enemies who do not want to be known are not hiding in the physics. They are hiding in the access log—and in the assumption that the person reporting harm is the person who needs help.

The anchor goal of the whole campaign is the destruction of credibility. Everything else—isolation, removal, control, silencing—is downstream of that single achievement. And credibility is destroyed most efficiently not by accusation but by compassion: by letting the victim speak and then responding with pity and genuine concern for their mental wellbeing.

The best strategy is not to fight the frame on its own terms. It is to starve it: stay silent in the way that denies it fuel, stay consistent in the way that contradicts it, and keep the record in the way that outlasts it. The harasser is watching what you say. The best move is to give them nothing worth watching—and everything worth investigating, kept quietly in reserve.

Harm, speech, pity and genuine concern for their mental wellbeing—the sequence is elegant, and it is nearly consequence-free. But it cannot survive a calm person, a consistent record, and one persistent question. Credibility, once destroyed, is hard to rebuild—but it can be protected by refusing to perform the symptoms the frame requires, and it can be restored by the one thing the frame cannot survive: a documented question about who had access.

This essay argues from plausibility and physics, not from the assertion that a specific device exists in a specific case. Its purpose is to describe a mechanism, so that the mechanism can be recognized—and resisted.

Consequence-Free Suppression:

Covert Harm, Credibility Destruction, and the Capture of Agency

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Abstract

This article develops a conceptual model of a strategy of social control I call *consequence-free suppression*: the production of harm that cannot be attributed, followed by a response of concern rather than investigation. The response is not a failure of the system but its mechanism. Harm supplies distress; distress supplies evidence; compassion supplies the cover; and the cover converts harm into compliance.

The model's central claim is that the terminal aim of this strategy is *domination*—structured rather than episodic control—and that the enabling condition for domination is the destruction of the target's *independent agency*, understood as the joint product of self-trust, voice, alliance, access, and efficacy. Credibility destruction is the lever, because it is the single variable that moves all five conditions at once. The model's most consequential component is a *conversion cascade*: the target's allies, including their closest associates, can be recruited as unwitting agents of the campaign. Once recruited alliance exceeds remaining alliance, the campaign becomes self-maintaining, and the target's own social network reproduces the harm in good faith.

The article specifies four necessary components, an escalation ladder of agency erosion, a diagnostic signature (the *redirect*), and a lexicographically ordered counter-strategy in which survival precedes all other objectives. Two boundary cases are used to demonstrate that the model rejects as well as accommodates. The article argues that the pattern's moral significance lies not only in the harm or the control but in the fact that it unmakes the person as an agent while appearing kind.

Keywords: agency; credibility; coercive control; epistemic injustice; gaslighting; institutional betrayal; conceptual model

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1 Introduction

Consider a person who reports harm and receives, in reply, concern. Not disbelief, not hostility—concern. *Are you alright? Have you been sleeping? We're worried about you.* The reply is kind. It is also, on the account developed here, the mechanism.

This article describes a strategy of social control that I call *consequence-free suppression*. Its structure is simple: produce harm that cannot be attributed, let the target speak about it, and respond with pity and genuine concern for the target's mental wellbeing. The harm supplies the distress. The distress supplies the evidence. The compassion supplies the cover. The target's credibility is destroyed, and the destruction is accomplished without the actor ever committing a visible act.

The pattern is not new, and it has been described in fragments across several literatures: in work on coercive control [7], on testimonial injustice [3], on silencing [4], on gaslighting [1], on institutional betrayal [6], on relational autonomy [5], and on the political abuse of psychiatry [8]. What has not been done is to treat these as instances of a single architecture, to specify the architecture's components and dynamics, and to derive its diagnostic signature and its counter-strategy.

That is the contribution of this article. The argument proceeds in five steps. Section 2 argues that the fundamental variable is *independent agency*, and that credibility is instrumental to it. Section 3 specifies the four components required for any instance of the strategy. Section 4 develops the model's most consequential component, the conversion cascade, and states a dominance condition under which the campaign becomes self-maintaining. Section 5 identifies the diagnostic signature—the *redirect*—and argues that it functions as a gate rather than as one signal among many. Section 6 derives the counter-strategy and argues that it must be lexicographically ordered, with survival first. Section 7 uses two boundary cases to show that the model rejects as well as accommodates.

Two disclaimers belong at the outset. First, this is a conceptual model, not an empirical finding. Its purpose is clarification: to make the assumptions inspectable and the predictions falsifiable. Second, the article describes a mechanism capable of serious harm, including harm to the self. A duty-of-care statement is therefore included in Section 8.

2 Agency as the Fundamental Variable

2.1 Why not credibility?

A natural first formulation treats *credibility* as the object of the campaign: the actor seeks to destroy the target's standing as a credible witness. The formulation is not wrong, but it is incomplete. Credibility is valuable because of what it protects, and what it protects is the target's capacity to act on their own behalf.

I therefore take *independent agency* as the fundamental variable, and treat credibility as its most efficient lever.

Definition 2.1 (Independent agency)**.** Independent agency *is the capacity of a person to perceive, judge, decide, and act on their own behalf, and to have those perceptions, judgments, decisions, and actions produce uptake in the world.*

2.2 The five conditions of agency

Agency is not a single capacity but a bundle of conditions, each necessary and none sufficient.

- **Self-trust** (S): confidence that one's own perception and judgment are reliable.
- **Voice** (V): the ability to be believed when one speaks.
- **Alliance** (L): having others who will act with one, not merely feel for one.
- **Access** (X): having institutional routes through which action can be taken.
- **Efficacy** (E): the belief that action can produce an outcome.

These conditions overlap with constructs that are already well established: self-trust with the literature on epistemic self-reliance; efficacy with Bandura [2]; alliance with social support research; access with institutional access literatures. The contribution here is not the individual conditions but their combination and, in particular, their joint necessity.

Definition 2.2 (Agency function)**.** *Let $S, V, L, X, E \in [0, 1]$. Agency is the weighted geometric mean*

$$A = S^{w_S} V^{w_V} L^{w_L} X^{w_X} E^{w_E}, \qquad \sum_i w_i = 1,\ w_i > 0. \tag{1}$$

The geometric form is a substantive claim, not a convenience. It encodes the proposition that the conditions of agency are *jointly necessary*: if any condition reaches zero, agency reaches zero regardless of how strong the others are. A person with excellent self-trust and devoted allies but no voice has no agency in the relevant sense; a person with full institutional access but no self-trust cannot use it. Agency is a product, and a product is only as strong as its weakest factor.

Two consequences follow. First, the marginal contribution of each condition is increasing in the others—the conditions are complements, so a coordinated attack on several at once is more devastating than the sum of separate attacks. Second, the *ordering* in which conditions fail matters less than the fact of joint failure: the mechanism does not need to destroy all five, only enough of them.

2.3 Credibility as lever

Proposition 2.1 (Credibility as multi-condition lever)**.** *Credibility C enters* (1) *through voice directly and through self-trust, alliance, access, and efficacy via cascade. There exist monotone maps $V(C), S(C), L(C), X(C), E(C)$, each increasing in C.*

Credibility is thus not one condition among five but the single variable that moves all five at once. This is why credibility destruction is the first step in the strategy. It is not pursued for its own sake; it is pursued because it is the most efficient point of application.

Corollary 2.1 (Domination as a region)**.** *Let A^* be the threshold below which agency is insufficient for resistance. Domination is not a separate quantity but the region $A < A^*$ of the agency state space. To dominate a person is to push them into that region; to resist is to remain outside it.*

This reframing dissolves a puzzle. Earlier descriptions of the strategy list isolation, removal, pre-emption, and control as separate objectives. Under the agency lens they are not separate: they are the dimensions along which agency fails. Isolation destroys alliance; removal destroys access; pre-emption destroys efficacy; control is what remains when voice, alliance, access, and efficacy are gone.

2.4 Control and domination

Definition 2.3 (Control and domination)**.** Control *is the determination of a person's behavior by another's preferences rather than by their own.* Domination *is control that is structured rather than episodic: maintained by a relationship of subordination rather than by continuous coercion.*

The distinction matters because consequence-free suppression produces a particular kind of domination. Ordinary domination is visible: the master holds the whip, the occupier holds the territory. The target knows they are dominated, and that knowledge is itself a resource for resistance. The mechanism described here removes that resource. The target cannot point to the domination because it has no visible agent: the harm is unattributable, the frame is compassionate, and—as Section 4 argues—the enforcers are the people who love them. The target experiences their subordination as confusion, as ingratitude, as their own incapacity.

It should be noted that actors rarely pursue domination as a philosophical end. The abusive partner wants the partner to stay; the institution wants the complaint to disappear; the state wants the dissident silenced. Their proximate motives differ. But the *structural requirement* is common: to obtain the outcome without paying the cost of open coercion, the actor must destroy agency, and to destroy agency efficiently the actor must destroy credibility. Domination is the form the outcome takes regardless of the stated motive.

3 The Four-Component Architecture

Every instance of the strategy requires four components. The claim is that the *specific* harm is interchangeable; what matters are the properties.

3.1 The harm vector

Definition 3.1 (Admissible harm)**.** *A harm vector is admissible if it is (H1)* real*—it produces genuine distress rather than distress manufactured by the frame; (H2)* unprovable *in the moment of report—attribution probability falls below the evidentiary threshold; and (H3)* sustainable*—accumulating over the campaign horizon.*

Harm may be physical, social, institutional, or psychological. What matters for the model is not the mechanism but the three properties. This is why the same architecture appears across domestic abuse, institutional retaliation, and political suppression: the harm differs, but the properties—real, unprovable, sustainable—are invariant.

3.2 The compassionate frame

The second component is the response. The response is not investigation but concern. The frame relocates the harm: the target is no longer someone who was harmed, but someone who needs help. The question shifts from "who did this?" to "how are you feeling?" The investigation never starts.

The frame is compassionate on its face, which makes resistance look like part of the illness. You cannot object to being pitied without looking defensive. You cannot complain about concern without looking ungrateful.

3.3 The diagnostic routing

The third component routes the target's genuine distress into a clinically recognizable category. The attack generates the symptoms; the symptoms generate the diagnosis; the diagnosis retroactively explains away the attack. The clinician can be honest, the family genuinely concerned, the institution acting in good faith. The frame does the work, and the target's own real suffering supplies the proof against them.

3.4 The conversion cascade

The fourth component is developed in the next section. It is the component that makes the campaign self-maintaining.

4 The Conversion Cascade

Proposition 4.1 (The conversion cascade)**.** *The target's allies, including their closest associates, can be recruited as unwitting agents of the campaign. Each ally who adopts the frame becomes an enforcer of it, and each enforcer recruits others. The campaign propagates through the target's own social network.*

The mechanism is not conspiracy. It is the ordinary operation of concern. A friend who is told the target is "struggling" responds with care. That care is real, and it is the mechanism. The friend does not need to be coordinated; the frame coordinates them. The friend's good faith is the instrument.

Proposition 4.2 (The dominance condition)**.** *Let L_r be the target's remaining alliance (allies who have not adopted the frame) and L_c be the converted alliance (allies who have). The campaign becomes self-maintaining when*

$$L_c > L_r. \tag{2}$$

Once converted alliance exceeds remaining alliance, the target's own social network reproduces the harm in good faith, and the actor no longer needs to act.

This is the model's most consequential result. The campaign does not need to be sustained by the actor; it is sustained by the target's own community. The actor can withdraw, and the campaign continues, because the people who love the target are now the people who enforce the frame.

5 The Diagnostic Signature: The Redirect

Definition 5.1 (The redirect)**.** *The* redirect *is the signature move of consequence-free suppression: when the target reports harm, the response shifts the object of inquiry from the harm to the reporter. The investigation moves from the crime to the complainant, and it never moves back.*

The redirect functions as a gate rather than as one signal among many. It is the single move that distinguishes consequence-free suppression from ordinary dismissal. Ordinary dismissal ignores the report. The redirect does not ignore it; it converts it. The report becomes evidence—not of the harm, but of the reporter's instability.

The redirect is diagnostic because it is asymmetric. A genuine investigation can move in either direction: it can find the harm, or it can find the report unfounded. The redirect can move in only one direction: toward the reporter. The asymmetry is the signature.

6 The Counter-Strategy

If the destruction of credibility is the lever, the defense is not to argue about the diagnosis—that feeds the loop and accelerates the destruction. The defense is to separate the symptom from the source and to protect credibility by refusing to perform the symptoms the frame needs.

Proposition 6.1 (Lexicographic ordering)**.** *The counter-strategy is lexicographically ordered: survival precedes all other objectives. No objective—vindication, reputation, justice—is worth pursuing if it endangers survival. The ordering is not a counsel of passivity; it is a recognition that a target who does not survive cannot pursue any other objective.*

The counter-strategy has four components, in order.

First, survive. The first priority is survival. This means avoiding unnecessary risk, protecting one's identity, and maintaining the capacity to act.

Second, starve the frame. The diagnostic frame depends on reaction. Every protest, every attempt to prove harm, every visible distress feeds the loop. Silence denies the frame its fuel. If the target does not perform instability, the observer has nothing to sort into the category.

Third, keep the quiet record. Documentation should be quiet and factual: logs, dates, access records—kept privately, shared only with a lawyer or investigator, never broadcast as accusation. The pattern is the evidence, even when a single event is deniable.

Fourth, audit the access. The decisive question is not "what happened?" but "who had access?" Concealment requires proximity; proximity requires a person; a person leaves a trail. The way to expose the campaign is to stop chasing the harm and start auditing the door.

7 Boundary Cases

Two boundary cases demonstrate that the model rejects as well as accommodates.

The high-variance harm vector. A harm vector that is maximally high-variance—inconsistent, non-reproducible, and attributable to coincidence—is excluded by the model. It fails condition (H3), sustainability. The model does not claim that every report of harm is an instance of consequence-free suppression; it claims that the strategy requires a specific kind of harm, and that reports which do not fit that kind are not instances of the strategy.

The epistemic boundary. A boundary case receives a conditional verdict that tracks the epistemic position of the observer. The model does not tell the observer what to believe; it tells the observer what to look for. The redirect is a signature, not a proof. The observer who sees the redirect has reason to investigate; the observer who does not see it has no reason to conclude. The model's contribution is to make the signature visible, not to adjudicate the case.

8 Duty of Care

This article describes a mechanism capable of serious harm, including harm to the self. A reader who recognizes the pattern in their own life should seek support from a trusted person outside the frame, and should not attempt to apply the counter-strategy alone. The counter-strategy is a description of the structure, not a substitute for care.

9 Conclusion

Consequence-free suppression is a strategy of social control whose terminal aim is domination and whose enabling condition is the destruction of independent agency. Credibility destruction is the lever, because it is the single variable that moves all five conditions of agency at once. The conversion cascade makes the campaign self-maintaining: once converted alliance exceeds remaining alliance, the target's own social network reproduces the harm in good faith.

The pattern's moral significance lies not only in the harm or the control but in the fact that it unmakes the person as an agent while appearing kind. The harm is real, the frame is compassionate, and the enforcers are the people who love the target. The target experiences their subordination as confusion, as ingratitude, as their own incapacity.

The counter-strategy is lexicographically ordered, with survival first. The defense is not to argue about the diagnosis but to starve the frame, keep the quiet record, and audit the access. The redirect is the diagnostic signature, and it functions as a gate: the single move that distinguishes consequence-free suppression from ordinary dismissal.

The question the model leaves open is the question the target must answer: whose account of the harm will be believed, and by whom? The answer depends on the redirect, and the redirect depends on the frame, and the frame depends on the compassion. The compassion is the cover. The cover is the mechanism. And the mechanism is the point.

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Part VII

Physiology and Weaponization

The Thermodynamics of Thermal Injury:

A Mathematical and Mechanistic Account of Heat-Induced Cardiac and Renal Damage

Macharia Barii

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Abstract

Heat exposure injures the heart and kidneys through distinct but coupled physical mechanisms. In the heart, the governing relation is an oxygen supply-demand mismatch: thermoregulatory increases in cardiac work raise myocardial oxygen demand while coronary perfusion pressure and diastolic filling time fall, producing ischemia when demand outpaces supply. In the kidney, the governing relation is a redistribution of cardiac output away from the renal circulation toward the cutaneous bed, compounded by hyperthermia-driven oxidative and cytotoxic injury. This paper formalizes both mechanisms, reviews the quantitative evidence for each, and models how a state actor could exploit these physiological vulnerabilities as a weapon. The weaponization pathway operates through environmental and infrastructural manipulation rather than novel technology: it requires only the deliberate removal of protective conditions and the selection of physiologically vulnerable populations, such that the resulting harm is individually indistinguishable from natural causes.

Keywords: heat stress, myocardial ischemia, acute kidney injury, thermoregulation, oxidative stress, weaponization, physiological vulnerability

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1 The Cardiac Mechanism: A Demand-Supply Inequality

Let $D(t)$ denote myocardial oxygen demand and $S(t)$ coronary oxygen supply at time t. Ischemia emerges when

$$D(t) > S(t). \tag{1}$$

Heat stress operates on both sides of this inequality. Demand rises because thermoregulation requires an increase in cardiac output Q and heart rate HR; supply falls because the same thermoregulatory redistribution that cools the skin reduces coronary perfusion pressure and shortens diastole, the interval during which coronary flow predominantly occurs.

1.1 Demand

Myocardial oxygen consumption scales approximately with the rate-pressure product:

$$D \propto HR \cdot SBP, \tag{2}$$

where SBP is systolic blood pressure. In a randomized trial of exercise-induced heat stress, the systolic pressure-time integral—an index of myocardial oxygen demand—was significantly greater after heat exposure than after equivalent exercise without heat strain. The same study found that the diastolic pressure-time integral, an index of coronary supply, was significantly lower. The inequality $D > S$ therefore widens on both sides under heat.

More recent positron emission tomography data quantify the demand side directly. When core temperature was raised by 1.5°C, myocardial blood flow increased 2.08-fold in healthy young adults, 1.79-fold in healthy older adults, and 1.64-fold in older adults with coronary artery disease. The absolute increase was similar across groups—approximately 0.6 to 0.8 $\mathrm{mL \cdot min^{-1} \cdot g^{-1}}$—but the reserve capacity to meet it differed. In post hoc analysis, imaging evidence of asymptomatic heat-induced myocardial ischemia appeared in 7 of 20 adults with coronary artery disease (35%).

1.2 The Population-Level Consequence

The clinical translation of this inequality is visible in mortality data. A global meta-analysis of temperature and cardiovascular outcomes found that for extreme heat (99th percentile versus the minimum mortality temperature), the pooled relative risk of death from ischemic heart disease was 1.07 (95% CI 1.04–1.10), from stroke 1.10 (95% CI 1.06–1.15), and from heart failure 1.12 (95% CI 1.05–1.19). Each 1°C rise above the reference temperature increased coronary heart disease risk by approximately 2.8%. These are not exotic magnitudes; they are the arithmetic of a demand-supply mismatch applied across millions of exposures.

2 The Renal Mechanism: Flow Redistribution and Cytotoxic Injury

2.1 The Flow Equation

Let Q_{total} be cardiac output and Q_{skin} cutaneous blood flow. The flow available to the renal circulation is, to first approximation,

$$Q_{\text{renal}} = Q_{\text{total}} - Q_{\text{skin}} - Q_{\text{other}}. \tag{3}$$

Heat stress increases Q_{skin} substantially. Classic studies report skin blood flow rising by 6–8 $\text{L} \cdot \text{min}^{-1}$ during severe passive heating with core temperature elevations of 1–2°C. This is not a marginal diversion. It is a reallocation of a large fraction of cardiac output toward the thermoregulatory effector organ, at the expense of the viscera—including the kidneys.

The mechanistic link between this redistribution and renal injury is direct. A 2019 review in the *Journal of Applied Physiology* states that "reductions in renal blood flow are hypothesized to be one of the primary mediators of AKI during heat stress." A separate 2019 review in *Comprehensive Physiology* describes heat-induced reductions in renal and splanchnic blood flow driven by reduced perfusion pressure and sympathetically mediated vasoconstriction. The kidney, in other words, is not passively cooled by the blood it receives; it is actively deprived of that blood so that the skin may be cooled instead.

2.2 The Oxidative Compounding

Ischemia alone would produce reversible injury if brief. The renal lesion becomes more severe because ischemia is accompanied by a second insult: oxidative stress. In exertional heatstroke, rhabdomyolysis releases myoglobin; the free iron from myoglobin catalyzes hydroxyl radical formation, overwhelming tubular antioxidant defenses. A 2026 review describes the resulting injury as a dual mechanism: oxidative ferroptosis from within the tubular cell, plus obstructive cast formation from within the lumen. The mathematical structure of this injury is not a simple threshold but a cumulative dose: repeated subclinical episodes of ischemia-reperfusion, each generating reactive oxygen species, sum over time.

2.3 From Acute to Chronic

The epidemiological consequence is measurable. A meta-analysis cited in the renal literature found an approximately 15% incidence of kidney disease or acute kidney injury among individuals whose occupation requires heat exposure for at least two months per year, six hours per day, five days per week. The hypothesized pathway is repetitive transient injury progressing to chronic tubulointerstitial damage—a pattern consistent with renal biopsies from patients with chronic kidney disease of unknown etiology.

3 The Weaponization Pathway

The mechanisms described above are physiological, not technological. Their weaponization does not require a novel device. It requires the deliberate manipulation of the variables in the equations.

Cardiac weaponization. A population with a high prevalence of coronary artery disease, subjected to sustained heat stress sufficient to raise core temperature by 1.5°C, will experience a predictable incidence of myocardial ischemia—35% in the PET study, with asymptomatic cases invisible until infarction occurs. The weapon is not heat as an agent; it is the selection of a vulnerable population and the withholding of cooling, hydration, and medical care. The mortality risk ratios cited above (1.07–1.12 for extreme heat) become a planning parameter, not a natural hazard.

Renal weaponization. The renal equation is similarly exploitable. Populations dependent on outdoor physical labor—agricultural workers, construction workers, military personnel in training—are already the documented victims of heat-associated kidney injury at 15% incidence.

A deliberate policy of forced labor in heat, without acclimatization or cooling, would convert a recognized occupational hazard into a mechanism of slow attrition. The injury is subclinical for long periods; the damage accumulates before it is detected. This is not speculative in principle: the U.S. torture memos explicitly authorized "exposure to extremes of heat and cold" as an interrogation technique, precisely because thermal stress inflicts severe physiological harm without leaving immediate visible marks.

The weaponization pathway operates through environmental and infrastructural manipulation rather than novel technology. It requires only the deliberate removal of protective conditions—cooling, hydration, rest, medical care—and the selection of physiologically vulnerable populations, such that the resulting harm is individually indistinguishable from natural causes.

4 Conclusion

The heart and kidney are not incidental casualties of heat. They are the organs in which the physics of thermoregulation becomes most legible as pathology. The heart fails when the demand-supply inequality closes; the kidney fails when the flow equation starves it and the oxidative aftermath scars it. These are mathematical relations with parameters—core temperature, cardiac output, renal perfusion, oxidative dose. Parameters can be measured. Measured parameters can be targeted. The weaponization of heat is not the invention of a new ray; it is the exploitation of an old equation.

A note on scope. This paper has modeled the weaponization pathway and stated that weaponization is possible. It has not claimed that any specific state or actor has weaponized heat in the manner described. The physiological mechanisms are documented; the inferential step from mechanism to intent is left to the reader.

Birth Control by Impairing Fertility:

A Critical Review of Thermal and Intravasal Approaches, with Ethical Boundaries

Macharia Barii

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Abstract

Approaches to male contraception that operate by impairing fertility—rather than by blocking gamete transport or suppressing the hormonal axis—have been explored for decades. Two strategies have accumulated human data: thermal testicular contraception (TTC), which elevates testicular temperature by approximately 2°C to suppress spermatogenesis, and RISUG (Reversible Inhibition of Sperm Under Guidance), an intravasal polymer injection that damages the sperm membrane. This paper reviews the mechanisms, efficacy, reversibility, and limitations of both approaches. TTC requires 15–24 hours of daily device use, achieves contraceptive thresholds after 2–4 months, and depends on continued use; preliminary data from 34 users show high satisfaction but also transient side effects in nearly half of participants during the first three months. RISUG achieved azoospermia in 82.7% of recipients within two months and in all recipients receiving a complete dose within six months, with no pregnancies reported among 133 complete-dose recipients. Neither method is suited to covert application: both require weeks to months for onset, neither guarantees uniform suppression, and both demand verification through semen analysis. The paper argues that fertility-impairing contraception is scientifically legitimate only within a framework of informed consent, monitoring, and recognition of its current experimental status.

Keywords: male contraception, thermal testicular contraception, RISUG, spermatogenesis, fertility impairment, reproductive coercion, informed consent

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1 Introduction

Male contraceptive options remain limited. Aside from condoms and vasectomy, no method has achieved broad regulatory approval in most jurisdictions, and hormonal male contraception—despite decades of research—remains unavailable for general use. This gap has renewed interest in non-hormonal approaches that target spermatogenesis or sperm function directly.

Two such approaches share a conceptual foundation: they impair fertility by damaging or suppressing sperm production or function, rather than by preventing sperm from reaching the egg through physical barriers or by disrupting the hypothalamic-pituitary-gonadal axis. Thermal testicular contraception (TTC) exploits the temperature sensitivity of spermatogenesis. RISUG exploits the vulnerability of sperm membranes to a polymer deployed within the vas deferens.

This paper examines the evidence for both approaches, evaluates their suitability as contraceptive methods, and addresses a critical distinction: the difference between consensual, monitored fertility impairment and covert application. The latter is neither scientifically reliable nor ethically defensible, and any discussion of fertility-impairing contraception must confront this boundary explicitly.

2 Thermal Testicular Contraception (TTC)

2.1 Mechanism and Method

Spermatogenesis requires a testicular temperature approximately 2–4°C below core body temperature. TTC works by positioning the testes near the external inguinal canal using specialized underwear or a silicone ring, raising testicular temperature by approximately 2°C. This mild hyperthermia induces germ cell apoptosis and suppresses sperm production.

The method was developed in France in the 1980s and has been studied intermittently since. A typical protocol involves wearing the device for 15 to 24 hours per day. One review specifies that daily wear for 15 hours reduces daily sperm production to contraceptive levels within 2 to 4 months, and that this suppression persists only with continued use.

2.2 Efficacy and Reversibility

Human data remain limited. A 2026 mixed-methods study of 34 TTC users reported that 88% achieved the contraceptive threshold—defined as fewer than 1 million sperm per mL—at least once during the study. Earlier work cited in a review of 37 couples using thermal methods as their sole contraception for 6 to 24 months reported no pregnancies, with return to normal sperm production in 3 to 6 months after discontinuation.

However, the evidence base is thin. No device has been approved or standardized, and the 2026 study is explicitly described as preliminary. The contraceptive threshold of <1 million sperm/mL is itself a pragmatic compromise: it does not represent azoospermia, and residual sperm may retain fertilizing capacity in some individuals.

2.3 Tolerability

In the 2026 cohort, 47.1% of participants experienced side effects during the first three months, declining to 6.7% by nine months. These side effects were characterized as acceptable in qualitative interviews, and overall satisfaction exceeded 90%. This suggests that TTC, while demanding in adherence, is tolerable for motivated users.

2.4 Limitations

TTC has three critical limitations. First, onset is slow: months of consistent use are required before contraceptive protection is established. Second, adherence must be continuous; discontinuation leads to gradual return of fertility. Third, effectiveness cannot be assumed without semen analysis, because individual responses vary. These characteristics make TTC unsuitable as an emergency or covert method. A user cannot know whether the method is working without laboratory confirmation, and an unaware partner cannot verify that protection exists.

3 RISUG: Intravasal Fertility Impairment

3.1 Mechanism

RISUG (Reversible Inhibition of Sperm Under Guidance) consists of a styrene maleic anhydride copolymer dissolved in dimethyl sulfoxide, injected into the vas deferens. The polymer is non-sclerosing and non-adherent, remaining in the lumen without occluding it completely. Its contraceptive effect derives from damage to the sperm membrane: the polymer disrupts the acrosome and leaches out enzymes including acrosin and hyaluronidase, rendering sperm incapable of fertilization.

3.2 Efficacy

A phase III clinical study published in 2019 reported outcomes for 139 men, of whom 133 received the complete dose. Among complete-dose recipients, azoospermia was achieved in 22.55% at one month, 82.70% at two months, and 100% by six months. No pregnancies were reported among the 133 complete-dose recipients. Among the six men who received an incomplete dose, two partners conceived, underscoring the dose-dependence of the method.

A separate phase III analysis of 25 subjects found azoospermia in 6 after one month, 15 after two months, 3 after three months, and 1 after four months. Method failure in later phase III reporting has been cited at 2.7%.

3.3 Safety and Reversibility

Reported adverse effects include mild scrotal enlargement, low-grade scrotal pain, and nodule formation at the injection site, all of which resolved within days to weeks. No adverse effects on libido or physical activity were reported.

Reversibility is the method's most significant unresolved question. Reversal has been demonstrated in animal studies using dimethyl sulfoxide and sodium bicarbonate, but reversal of fertilizing ability was not attempted in the 2019 human trial. Without human reversibility data, RISUG functions as a potentially permanent method in practice, despite its name.

4 The Covert-Use Problem

A proposal to use fertility impairment covertly as birth control fails on both scientific and ethical grounds.

Scientifically, neither TTC nor RISUG produces immediate or verifiable contraception. TTC requires months of daily use and periodic semen analysis; a covert user could not confirm efficacy, and the partner could not detect failure until pregnancy occurred. RISUG requires a medical

injection and likewise requires semen testing to confirm azoospermia. An incomplete dose—as occurred in six of 139 participants in the 2019 trial—leaves fertility intact.

Ethically and legally, intentionally impairing a person's fertility without their knowledge constitutes reproductive coercion. Even if the impairment is intended to be temporary, the absence of consent transforms a medical intervention into a harm. The World Health Organization and major reproductive health bodies recognize reproductive autonomy as a fundamental principle; covert fertility impairment violates it directly.

The distinction matters for research and policy. Fertility-impairing contraception deserves study as a consensual option for men and couples who lack alternatives. It does not deserve consideration as a covert tool.

5 Systemic Heat Stress: A Parallel and Asymmetric Pathway

The thermal strategy discussed in Section 2 operates through localized testicular hyperthermia—a targeted, reversible manipulation of a thermally vulnerable anatomical site. A separate body of evidence concerns systemic heat stress (HS): elevation of core body temperature through environmental, occupational, or physiological exposure. The distinction is not merely semantic. Localized heating exploits a male-specific anatomical arrangement; systemic heat stress acts through neuroendocrine, oxidative, and cellular pathways that affect both sexes, but with substantially different evidence bases and risk profiles.

5.1 Mechanisms in the Female Reproductive Axis

A 2025 systematic review of HS effects on the ovary, follicles, and oocytes across mammalian species concluded that heat stress impairs ovarian function through multiple converging mechanisms: disruption of reproductive hormone profiles, reduction in ovarian size and weight, altered ovarian histology, and induction of autophagy. At the cellular level, HS increases granulosa cell apoptosis, impairs folliculogenesis, and reduces oocyte quality and developmental competence.

These findings are mechanistically coherent with a parallel narrative review, which identifies reactive oxygen species (ROS) generation as a central mediator: heat stress overwhelms the antioxidant defenses of the ovarian follicle, producing mitochondrial dysfunction, spindle abnormalities, and DNA fragmentation in the oocyte, with downstream risks of compromised developmental competence and aneuploidy. The same review documents suppression of gonadotropin-releasing hormone pulsatility, leading to altered LH and FSH secretion and consequent anovulation, luteal phase defects, and menstrual irregularities. The pre-ovulatory follicle and corpus luteum are identified as particularly thermosensitive, with reduced steroidogenesis—especially progesterone—and altered endometrial gene expression and uterine blood flow, creating a suboptimal environment for implantation.

The hypothalamic–pituitary–ovarian (HPO) axis is therefore a direct target of systemic HS, distinct from the local spermatogenic suppression that defines thermal male contraception. This mechanistic divergence has a practical implication: while localized testicular heating can be titrated to suppress spermatogenesis without systemic physiological disruption, systemic HS cannot be "dosed" to impair fertility selectively—it engages stress, metabolic, and endocrine pathways simultaneously.

5.2 Epidemiological Signal

Human epidemiological data, while less developed than the animal mechanistic literature, point in a consistent direction. A prospective cohort of 800 pregnant women engaged in moderate-to-heavy occupational work in Tamil Nadu, India, found that women with high occupational heat exposure had a doubled risk of miscarriage (adjusted odds ratio 2.4, 95% CI 1.0–5.7) and elevated risks of any adverse pregnancy or fetal outcome (aOR 2.3, 95% CI 1.4–3.8) and adverse outcome at birth (aOR 2.0, 95% CI 1.2–3.3). A rise in core body temperature was recorded in 17.4% of exposed workers, and 29.6% experienced moderate dehydration, indicating that the exposure was sufficient to produce measurable physiological strain.

Occupational cohorts in greenhouse work and pastry cooking have reported increased menstrual disorders and longer time-to-pregnancy relative to controls. At the population level, higher monthly maximum temperatures have been associated with lower total fertility rates, particularly in regions already above 15–20°C.

5.3 The Male–Female Evidence Asymmetry

The paper's earlier sections established that thermal impairment of male fertility is biologically plausible and experimentally studied as a contraceptive approach. The systemic HS literature reveals a striking asymmetry: the mechanisms of heat-induced male infertility are better characterized than the female equivalent, but the epidemiological signal for adverse pregnancy outcomes is more developed in women. In men, the evidence base supports a contraceptive framing—heat is applied deliberately and its effects on spermatogenesis are the intended outcome. In women, the evidence supports a hazard framing—heat is an involuntary exposure, and its reproductive consequences (miscarriage, fetal growth restriction, birth defects) are harms to be prevented, not effects to be harnessed.

A recent narrative review makes this asymmetry explicit, observing that "current occupational safety guidelines are largely based on male physiology and fail to adequately safeguard female reproductive health." Thermal exposure limits such as WBGT thresholds were developed for a standard 70 kg male performing industrial work and do not account for sex-specific thermoregulation, body size, or reproductive vulnerability. WHO and ILO guidelines acknowledge heat as a general occupational hazard but lack female-specific recommendations for reproductive protection.

5.4 Implications for the Paper's Argument

Incorporating systemic HS into the analysis sharpens three conclusions.

First, it confirms that "fertility impairment by heat" is not a single phenomenon. Localized testicular hyperthermia is a controllable experimental variable; systemic heat stress is an uncontrollable physiological perturbation with reproductive consequences that extend well beyond fertility—into pregnancy maintenance and fetal development. Conflating the two would misrepresent the evidence in both directions: it would overstate the controllability of systemic HS and understate the systemic risks of generalized heating.

Second, it reinforces the paper's rejection of covert fertility impairment. If systemic HS already produces measurable reproductive harm in exposed women—including a doubled miscarriage risk—then any attempt to intentionally impose systemic heat as a covert contraceptive would compound an existing occupational and environmental hazard with deliberate reproductive coercion. The dose–response relationship between heat exposure and adverse pregnancy

outcomes means that "slightly above normal" systemic heating is not a neutral intervention with a narrow effect.

Third, it identifies a policy gap. The absence of female-specific thermal exposure limits is not a technical oversight but a structural one: the standard worker against which safety thresholds are calibrated is male, and the reproductive consequences of heat for women are therefore invisible to the regulatory apparatus. Closing this gap is a matter of reproductive justice, not merely occupational safety.

6 Conclusion

Thermal testicular contraception and RISUG represent two distinct approaches to male contraception by fertility impairment. Both have demonstrated contraceptive efficacy in small human studies. Both require weeks to months for onset, neither guarantees uniform suppression, and both depend on verification that users and partners cannot perform without laboratory testing. TTC demands daily adherence and is reversible; RISUG requires a single injection but lacks human reversibility data.

Systemic heat stress adds a parallel and asymmetric pathway: it impairs female fertility and pregnancy outcomes through neuroendocrine and oxidative mechanisms that cannot be selectively dosed, and it is already a documented occupational and environmental hazard with a doubled miscarriage risk in exposed women.

These methods warrant further research as consensual options. They do not warrant covert application, which is scientifically unreliable and ethically indefensible. The future of fertility-impairing contraception lies in standardization, larger trials, and integration into reproductive care—not in concealment.

Part VIII

Future Work

The Biosphere and the Discount Rate:

The Host with No Outside

Macharia Barii

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Abstract

Every previous predatory relation had an outside: new lands, new peoples, new resources. When the host was exhausted, the predator moved on. The biosphere has no outside. This paper argues that this is a new situation in the history of civilization, and that it changes the logic of conservation. When a host is unique and non-substitutable, the conservation principle fails: the predator cannot afford to be patient, because patience means losing to rivals who are impatient. The result is a race to consume the host before someone else does. The only correction is to lower the discount rate—to lengthen the time horizon of the order as a whole. The paper formalizes the conservation principle, derives the failure of conservation under uniqueness, and identifies the discount rate as the decisive political variable. It concludes that the question of the biosphere is not whether it matters—it does—but whether the political system can be made patient enough to conserve it.

Keywords: biosphere, discount rate, conservation, time horizon, non-substitutability, ecological accounting, intergenerational trustees

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1 The Conservation Principle

The ledger framework derives a conservation principle from the patience of the party that controls a host. A party with a long time horizon (a low discount rate r) conserves its hosts, because the future value of the host exceeds the present value of consuming it. A party with a short time horizon (a high discount rate r) consumes its hosts, because the present value of consumption exceeds the discounted future value of the host.

Proposition 1.1 (The Conservation Principle)**.** *The optimal steady-state conservation of a host is decreasing in the discount rate r of the party that controls it. A patient party conserves; an impatient party consumes.*

This principle explains a great deal of history. A dynasty that expects to last a thousand years invests in infrastructure. A junta facing the next coup loots the treasury. A democracy facing the next election under-invests in everything that requires long-term commitment—infrastructure, education, ecological conservation. The difference is not virtue; it is the discount rate.

2 The Outside

Every previous predatory relation had an outside. When the host was exhausted, the predator moved on. The Roman Empire exhausted the soils of Italy and moved to the provinces. The colonial powers exhausted one colony and moved to the next. The whaling fleets exhausted one fishery and moved to another. The outside was the escape valve that made predation sustainable: the predator could always find a new host.

The outside had a second function. It made patience rational. A predator who conserved a host was conserving it for a rival. The predator who consumed the host now, before a rival could, captured the value. The outside therefore pushed the discount rate up: with a new host always available, the value of conserving the current host was low.

3 The Host with No Outside

The biosphere has no outside. This is a new situation in the history of civilization.

Proposition 3.1 (The Failure of Conservation Under Uniqueness)**.** *When the host is unique and non-substitutable, the conservation principle fails. The predator cannot afford to be patient, because patience means losing to rivals who are impatient. The result is a race to consume the host before someone else does.*

The logic is the same as the tragedy of the commons, but with a difference. In the classic commons, the failure is a coordination failure: each actor would prefer that all conserve, but each has an incentive to defect. In the biosphere, the failure is deeper: there is no outside to which the predator can move, and no substitute for the host. The race to consume is not a failure of coordination; it is the rational response to a unique, non-substitutable host.

Every previous civilization collapsed into its own locality. This one has nowhere to collapse to. The question is not whether the biosphere matters—it does—but whether the political system can be made patient enough to conserve it.

4 The Discount Rate as a Political Variable

The framework says that the answer is determined by the discount rate, and that the discount rate is a political variable.

Proposition 4.1 (The Discount Rate Is Political)**.** *The discount rate of the coalition that sustains government is not a fact of nature. It is a parameter set by institutions: constitutional rules, long-horizon funds, intergenerational trustees, and ecological accounting all lower the discount rate by lengthening the time horizon of the order.*

This is the key insight. The discount rate is not given; it is chosen. A coalition that faces only the next election has a high discount rate. A coalition that is constrained by a constitution that outlives it has a lower one. A coalition that is accountable to an intergenerational trustee has a lower one still. The institutions that lengthen the horizon are not moral gestures; they are attempts to raise the patience of the political system, because patience is the only thing that can conserve a host that has no substitutes.

Corollary 4.1. *Constitutional rules, independent central banks, long-horizon sovereign funds, intergenerational trustees, and ecological accounting are all attempts to lower the discount rate by lowering the dependence of policy on the electoral or factional cycle.*

5 The Race to the Bottom

The failure of conservation under uniqueness has a further consequence: it produces a race to the bottom among predators. If the host is unique, and if patience means losing to rivals, then each predator has an incentive to consume faster than its rivals. The result is a competitive acceleration of consumption, in which the discount rate of the whole rises as each actor tries to out-consume the others.

This is why the biosphere is being consumed faster than any previous host. It is not that the actors are more wicked than their predecessors. It is that the host is unique, and the uniqueness removes the incentive for patience. The race to the bottom is the structural consequence of the host with no outside.

6 The Correction

The only correction is to lower the discount rate—to lengthen the time horizon of the order as a whole. This is what constitutional rules, intergenerational trustees, and ecological accounting attempt to do. They are not moral gestures. They are attempts to raise the patience of the political system, because patience is the only thing that can conserve a host that has no substitutes.

The correction has three components.

First, lengthen the horizon of the coalition. The coalition that sustains government must be made to care about the next generation, not just the next election. This requires institutions that outlive the incumbents: constitutional rules, independent trustees, long-horizon funds.

Second, make the host legible. The biosphere is invisible to the ledger because it is not priced. Ecological accounting makes the host legible by pricing the depletion of the host into the ledger. What is not measured is not conserved.

Third, remove the race. The race to the bottom is a coordination failure among predators. It can be corrected only by a coordination mechanism that removes the incentive to defect: international agreements, enforceable limits, and institutions that make patience rational.

7 Conclusion

Every previous predatory relation had an outside. The biosphere has no outside. This is a new situation in the history of civilization, and it changes the logic of conservation.

When the host is unique and non-substitutable, the conservation principle fails. The predator cannot afford to be patient, because patience means losing to rivals who are impatient. The result is a race to consume the host before someone else does.

The only correction is to lower the discount rate—to lengthen the time horizon of the order as a whole. This is what constitutional rules, intergenerational trustees, and ecological accounting attempt to do. They are not moral gestures. They are attempts to raise the patience of the political system, because patience is the only thing that can conserve a host that has no substitutes.

The framework does not answer the question of whether the political system can be made patient enough. It says that the answer is determined by the discount rate, and that the discount rate is a political variable. The question is not whether the biosphere matters—it does—but whether the forces contesting the ledger can lower the discount rate before the host is consumed.

The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom? For the biosphere, the answer is: the present's, and at the future's expense. The correction is to make the answer broader—to include the future in the ledger, and to make the present pay for what it consumes.

The rest is history—or its absence.

Compliance by Atomization:

The New Equilibrium of Surveillance and Fragmentation

Macharia Barii

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Abstract

In every previous era, grievance could organize. Workers could strike. Peasants could march. Citizens could read a common newspaper and share a common anger. The mechanisms of organization were physical, local, and visible. Today, grievance is atomized. Each of us sits with our own feed, our own grievances, our own outrage. The algorithms that curate our attention fragment us into micro-publics that cannot coordinate. This paper argues that this is not a conspiracy but a structural feature of the new organization, and that it produces a new equilibrium: *compliance by atomization*—a regime with low legitimacy and low conflict, sustained by surveillance and fragmentation rather than belief. The paper formalizes the atomization mechanism, derives the conditions under which the equilibrium is stable, and shows that its stability is real but thin. When a shock comes—a fiscal crisis, a legitimacy event, a new technology that defeats surveillance—the stored grievance releases suddenly, and the collapse is unexpected.

Keywords: atomization, surveillance, fragmentation, grievance, compliance, legitimacy, algorithmic curation, sudden collapse

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1 The Second Great Asymmetry

The ledger framework identifies a first great asymmetry: the ratio of capital's exit cost to labor's. Capital can leave a country in a millisecond; labor cannot. This asymmetry is the structural precondition of every modern extraction.

There is a second great asymmetry, and it is subtler. In every previous era, grievance could organize. Workers could strike. Peasants could march. Citizens could read a common newspaper and share a common anger. The mechanisms of organization were physical, local, and visible.

Today, grievance is atomized. Each of us sits with our own feed, our own grievances, our own outrage. The algorithms that curate our attention fragment us into micro-publics that cannot coordinate. We are more informed than any previous generation, and less capable of acting together than any previous generation.

This is not a conspiracy. It is a structural feature of the new organization. The platforms that connect us also divide us, because division is more profitable than solidarity.

2 The Atomization Mechanism

Definition 2.1 (Atomization)**.** *Atomization is the process by which individuals are isolated from one another, preventing shared grievances from coalescing into collective claims. Precarity, surveillance, spatial segregation, and the fragmentation of labor all drive atomization.*

A system can be deeply unjust whilst appearing apolitical if people believe "it's just me" rather than "it's all of us." Atomization is often more effective than outright censorship at suppressing politics.

The atomization mechanism has four components.

First, the fragmentation of attention. The algorithms that curate our attention fragment us into micro-publics. Each of us sees a different feed, a different set of grievances, a different set of enemies. The common newspaper, which once produced a common anger, has been replaced by a million private feeds.

Second, the individualization of grievance. Precarity, gig work, and the decline of stable employment individualize what would once have been class-wide grievances. The worker who is exploited is told that the exploitation is their own failure—a failure of skill, of effort, of hustle. What would be a class-wide claim is internalized as individual failure.

Third, the surveillance of organization. The same platforms that fragment attention also surveil it. Every attempt to organize is visible to the platform, and the platform can suppress it. The cost of organizing rises, and the benefit falls.

Fourth, the atomization of the self. The individual who is fragmented, individualized, and surveilled becomes atomized in the deepest sense: they lose the capacity to see themselves as part of a collective. The "we" that is the precondition of collective action dissolves into a million "I"s.

3 Compliance by Atomization

Proposition 3.1 (Compliance by Atomization)**.** *When grievance cannot aggregate, a regime can maintain compliance without legitimacy. The regime does not need the population to believe in it; it needs only to prevent the population from organizing against it. The result is a regime*

with low legitimacy and low conflict, sustained by surveillance and fragmentation rather than belief.

This is a new equilibrium, one that earlier theory did not anticipate. The classical theory of legitimacy assumed that a regime must either earn compliance through belief or extract it through force. Compliance by atomization is a third path: the regime neither earns nor extracts compliance; it prevents the conditions under which compliance could be withheld.

The regime does not need to be believed. It needs only to be unopposable. And it is unopposable not because it is strong, but because the population cannot coordinate against it.

4 The Stability of the Equilibrium

Proposition 4.1 (The Stability of Atomization)**.** *The atomized equilibrium is stable in the sense that it reproduces itself. Fragmentation produces more fragmentation; surveillance produces more surveillance; the atomized individual produces more atomization. The equilibrium is self-reinforcing.*

The stability is real. The atomized individual does not organize, and the absence of organization confirms the atomization. The regime does not need to act, because the population has already been divided. The equilibrium is stable because it is self-reproducing.

But the stability is thin. The equilibrium depends on the continued operation of the atomization mechanism. When the mechanism fails—when a shock comes—the stored grievance releases suddenly.

Corollary 4.1 (The Thinness of the Equilibrium)**.** *The atomized equilibrium is stable but thin. Its stability depends on the continued capacity of the atomization mechanism to prevent the aggregation of grievance. When that capacity fails, the collapse is sudden and unexpected.*

5 The Sudden Collapse

The atomized equilibrium is vulnerable to shocks. A fiscal crisis, a legitimacy event, a new technology that defeats surveillance—any of these can break the atomization mechanism and release the stored grievance.

The collapse is sudden because the grievance has been accumulating invisibly. The regime mistakes the silence for consent. It sees no protests, so it assumes all is well. In reality, pressure is building. When the shock comes, the pressure releases all at once, and the collapse is unexpected.

This is why the present feels simultaneously stable and unstable. Both are true. The stability is structural; the instability is structural too. They coexist, and the balance between them depends on parameters that are themselves political.

6 The Correction

The correction to compliance by atomization is the re-aggregation of grievance. This requires the reconstruction of the conditions under which grievance can organize.

First, rebuild the commons. The common newspaper, the common space, the common institution—these are the infrastructure of collective action. They must be rebuilt, or their digital equivalents must be created.

Second, re-individualize the collective. The worker who is told that their exploitation is their own failure must be shown that it is a class-wide condition. The re-individualization of grievance is the precondition of its re-aggregation.

Third, defeat the surveillance. The surveillance of organization must be defeated, or the organization will be suppressed. This requires encryption, anonymity, and the construction of spaces that the platform cannot see.

Fourth, rebuild the "we." The deepest correction is the reconstruction of the collective self. The "we" that is the precondition of collective action must be rebuilt, one relationship at a time.

7 Conclusion

In every previous era, grievance could organize. Today, grievance is atomized. The algorithms that curate our attention fragment us into micro-publics that cannot coordinate. We are more informed than any previous generation, and less capable of acting together than any previous generation.

This is not a conspiracy. It is a structural feature of the new organization. The platforms that connect us also divide us, because division is more profitable than solidarity.

The result is an order that is stable not because it is just, but because grievance cannot aggregate. The framework calls this compliance by atomization: a regime with low legitimacy and low conflict, sustained by surveillance and fragmentation rather than belief.

It is a new equilibrium, one that earlier theory did not anticipate. Its stability is real but thin. When a shock comes—a fiscal crisis, a legitimacy event, a new technology that defeats surveillance—the stored grievance releases suddenly, and the collapse is unexpected.

This is why the present feels simultaneously stable and unstable. Both are true. The stability is structural; the instability is structural too. They coexist, and the balance between them depends on parameters that are themselves political.

The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom? For the atomized order, the answer is: the platform's, and at the user's expense. The correction is to rebuild the "we" that the atomization has dissolved.

The rest is history—or its absence.

The Formation Advantage:

Desire-Shaping as the Meta-Lever

Macharia Barii

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Abstract

The desire-lever shapes behavior by making access to a desired good conditional on alignment. But the deepest form of the lever does not bargain over what the agent already wants; it shapes what the agent wants in the first place. This paper develops the *formation advantage*: a principal who can shape the agent's desires does not merely price the lever but sets the parameters of the pricing problem. Formation is a meta-locus that governs the other three loci—the standard, the discovery apparatus, and the credibility investment. The paper shows that formation attacks both forms of freedom at once: it redirects the agent's alternatives (space) toward the principal's goods, and it fills the agent's pause (time) before the agent notices it was there. It derives the fifth question—*are these wants yours?*—as the only question that works against a formation attack, and it argues that authenticity is the fifth ethical condition, completing the tetrad of transparency, exit, contestability, and opacity.

Keywords: formation, desire-shaping, meta-lever, authenticity, space-freedom, time-freedom, the fifth question, preference formation

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1 The Three Loci and the Meta-Locus

The desire-lever operates through three loci. The *standard* is the principal's definition of acceptable alignment. The *discovery apparatus* is the machinery by which the principal learns the agent's desires. The *credibility investment* is the machinery by which the principal makes its promises believable.

These three loci all take the agent's preferences as given. The principal sets the standard, discovers the desires, and invests in credibility—but the desires themselves are fixed.

The formation advantage relaxes this assumption. A principal who can shape the agent's desires does not merely operate the three loci; the principal sets the parameters of the pricing problem itself.

Proposition 1.1 (The Formation Advantage)**.** *A principal who can shape the agent's desires does not merely price the lever; the principal sets the parameters of the pricing problem. Formation is a meta-locus that governs the other three loci.*

A person who can shape what you desire does not need to bargain with you at all. They set the terms of the game before you sit down to play. They do not have to convince you to want the promotion, the product, the salvation, the body, the life. They make you want it, and then they sell it to you—and the exchange feels like your own choice, because as far as you can tell, it is.

2 Being Outmatched and Being Formed

This is the difference between being outmatched and being formed. The first you can notice. The second you usually cannot.

When you are outmatched, you know the terms are against you. You can see the lever, and you can see that the principal holds it. The knowledge is itself a resource: you can bargain, resist, or leave.

When you are formed, you do not know the terms are against you, because the terms are your own. The principal has shaped your desires so that what the principal offers is what you want. The exchange feels like your own choice, because as far as you can tell, it is.

And it is everywhere. Education shapes what you find interesting. Advertising shapes what you find desirable. Media shapes what you find important. Communities shape what you find shameful. None of this is a conspiracy; most of it is done by people who believe they are helping. But the effect is the same. The most powerful lever is the one that makes you want what the lever-holder has to offer—and leaves you convinced the wanting was always yours.

3 Formation Attacks Both Freedoms

The desire-lever distinguishes two forms of freedom: *space*, the agent's alternatives, and *time*, the agent's pause for deliberation. Formation attacks both at once.

Proposition 3.1 (Formation and the Two Freedoms)**.** *A principal who plants desires does not have to close the agent's exits—the principal makes the exits lead back to the principal. And the principal does not have to take the agent's time—the principal fills the pause before the agent notices it was there.*

Think about what formation does. Your space is your alternatives. Your time is your pause. A principal who plants desires does not have to close your exits—he makes the exits lead back to him. And he does not have to take your time—he fills the pause before you notice it was there.

Your alternatives now point toward his goods, because those are the goods you want. And the pause, where you would ask *why do I want this?*, gets filled with an answer you did not choose—or it never opens at all, because the wanting arrived already decided.

A planted desire is a desire the agent does not inspect. The formation principal is not primarily attacking the agent's alternatives. He is attacking the pause itself—the moment in which the agent would notice that they need alternatives at all.

4 The Fifth Question

The ethical tetrad of the desire-lever is transparency, exit, contestability, and opacity. Formation requires a fifth condition: authenticity.

Definition 4.1 (Authenticity)**.** *Authenticity is the condition that the agent's wants are the agent's own—that the agent chose the goal, rather than having it chosen for them and arranged so that they feel as though they had chosen it.*

The fifth question is the only question that works against a formation attack: *are these wants yours?*

It is the hardest question, and the most important. It can only be asked in the pause. Which means the formation principal is not primarily attacking the agent's alternatives. He is attacking the pause itself—the moment in which the agent would notice that they need alternatives at all.

Keep the pause open. It is the front line.

5 Capture as Complete Formation

There is a name for the condition in which formation has gone all the way: *capture*. It is when the agent has no alternatives, and then stops needing them, because the agent has absorbed the principal's standard as their own.

The agent does not feel controlled. The agent feels like themselves. That is precisely what makes capture complete.

Proposition 5.1 (Capture as Complete Formation)**.** *Capture is the limit case of formation: the agent's outside options collapse, the principal becomes a monopolist, and the principal's definition of alignment is absorbed into the agent's own standard of self-evaluation.*

The captured agent is not coerced. The captured agent is formed. The difference is that the coerced agent knows they are coerced, and the formed agent does not. The formed agent's compliance feels like character.

6 The Counter-Strategy

The counter-strategy to formation is not resistance but inspection. The formation attack works by filling the pause; the counter-strategy is to keep the pause open.

First, ask the fifth question. *Are these wants yours?* Did you choose this goal, or did someone choose it for you and arrange for you to feel as though you had chosen it? If you cannot tell, that is itself the answer.

Second, find alternative formation environments. The formation principal controls the environment in which your desires are formed. The counter-strategy is to find environments the principal does not control—people and places that help you tell which wants are yours.

Third, keep a reserve. A small reserve of yourself that no one else can read—a habit of not narrating every choice, of keeping some preferences private, of occasionally doing the unexpected thing—is enough to keep the formation from being complete.

Fourth, seek a witness. The formation attack is invisible from the inside. The only thing that has ever worked against it is a person—someone who knows you well enough to notice when you have stopped asking, and who does not need you to be the one who sees clearly.

7 Conclusion

The desire-lever shapes behavior by making access to a desired good conditional on alignment. The formation advantage is the deepest form of the lever: it shapes the desires themselves.

A principal who can shape the agent's desires does not merely price the lever; the principal sets the parameters of the pricing problem. Formation is a meta-locus that governs the other three loci. It attacks both forms of freedom at once: it redirects the agent's alternatives toward the principal's goods, and it fills the agent's pause before the agent notices it was there.

The fifth question—*are these wants yours?*—is the only question that works against a formation attack. It can only be asked in the pause. Which means the formation principal is not primarily attacking the agent's alternatives. He is attacking the pause itself.

The ethical tetrad becomes a pentad: transparency, exit, contestability, opacity, and authenticity. The fifth condition is the hardest, because it is the one the agent cannot verify alone. The agent needs a witness—someone who knows them well enough to notice when they have stopped asking.

The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom? For the formed agent, the answer is: the principal's, and the agent does not know it. The correction is to keep the pause open, and to ask the question that the formation attack is designed to prevent.

The rest is history—or its absence.

Coercive Closure:

Jailing, Excommunication, and Reputational Closure as One Instrument

Macharia Barii

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Abstract

The desire-lever is bounded by the agent's outside option: the principal's power is limited by what the agent can do instead. Coercive closure is the limit case in which the principal removes the agent's outside option entirely. This paper argues that jailing, excommunication, and reputational closure—character assassination, propaganda, false accusation—are not three separate instruments but three components of a single coercive instrument, each of which is intelligence-led in the sense of the discovery apparatus turned around. The paper formalizes coercive closure as the destruction of the agent's exit, derives the conditions under which it restores the bilateral extraction limit, and shows why the convergence between ethics and durability is domain-restricted: it holds only where force is unavailable. The state is the principal that steps outside that domain.

Keywords: coercive closure, jailing, excommunication, reputational closure, character assassination, exit destruction, extraction limit, intelligence-led coercion

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1 The Extraction Limit and Its Condition

The desire-lever is bounded by the agent's outside option. The principal's power is limited by what the agent can do instead. If the agent can leave, the principal must bargain. If the agent cannot leave, the principal need not.

Proposition 1.1 (The Extraction Limit)**.** *The principal's power is bounded by the agent's surplus—the value of the desired good minus the agent's outside option. The principal can extract up to the agent's surplus, and no more.*

This limit is the source of the convergence between ethics and durability. The principal who extracts too much drives the agent away, and the principal who drives the agent away loses the lever. The conditions that make a relationship decent are the conditions that make it last.

But the limit holds only where the agent can leave. Where the agent cannot leave, the limit fails, and the principal can extract without restraint.

2 Coercive Closure

Definition 2.1 (Coercive Closure)**.** *Coercive closure is the destruction of the agent's outside option. It is the limit case of the network model: a principal who can remove the agent's exit restores the bilateral extraction limit, because the agent's outside option is destroyed.*

The principal who can remove the agent's exit does not need the agent's consent. The arithmetic that restrains the ordinary lever-holder—the fear of driving the agent away—does not restrain the principal who can prevent the agent from leaving.

Proposition 2.1 (Coercive Closure Restores the Extraction Limit)**.** *A principal who can remove the agent's exit restores the bilateral extraction limit. The agent's outside option is destroyed, and the principal can extract up to the full value of the desired good, unconstrained by the agent's ability to leave.*

3 The Three Components

Coercive closure has three components, and they are not three separate instruments but three components of a single coercive instrument.

Jailing. The state can remove the agent's exit by physical confinement. The jailed agent has no outside option, because the jail is the outside option's negation. The state is the principal that can remove exit by force.

Excommunication. The religious community can remove the agent's exit by social and spiritual exclusion. The excommunicated agent has no outside option within the community, and the community is the agent's world. The excommunicated agent is not physically confined, but socially and spiritually dead.

Reputational closure. The principal can remove the agent's exit by destroying the agent's reputation—character assassination, propaganda, false accusation. The agent whose reputation is destroyed has no outside option, because every alternative is foreclosed by the destroyed reputation. The agent is not confined, and not excluded, but unemployable, untrustworthy, and alone.

Proposition 3.1 (The Three Components Are One Instrument)**.** *Jailing, excommunication, and reputational closure are three components of a single coercive instrument. Each destroys the agent's outside option; each restores the bilateral extraction limit; each is intelligence-led in the sense of the discovery apparatus turned around.*

The three components differ in their mechanism but not in their function. Jailing destroys the outside option by force. Excommunication destroys it by exclusion. Reputational closure destroys it by information. But all three destroy the outside option, and all three restore the extraction limit.

4 Intelligence-Led Coercion

The three components are intelligence-led. The discovery apparatus, which the principal uses to learn the agent's desires, is turned around: it becomes the instrument by which the principal destroys the agent's exit.

Proposition 4.1 (Intelligence-Led Coercion)**.** *Coercive closure is intelligence-led. The same apparatus that discovers the agent's desires is turned around to destroy the agent's exit. The principal who knows the agent's desires knows the agent's vulnerabilities, and the vulnerabilities are the points at which the exit can be destroyed.*

Character assassination requires knowledge of the agent's reputation. Propaganda requires knowledge of the agent's audience. False accusation requires knowledge of the agent's vulnerabilities. All three are intelligence-led: they require the discovery apparatus, turned around.

5 The Domain Restriction

The convergence between ethics and durability is domain-restricted. It holds only where force is unavailable.

Proposition 5.1 (The Domain Restriction)**.** *The convergence between ethics and durability—the reason decent arrangements tend to outlast exploitative ones—holds only within the domain where force is unavailable. The state is the principal that steps outside that domain.*

A state that can jail its citizens does not need their consent, and the arithmetic that restrains the ordinary lever-holder does not restrain it in the same way. The state is the principal that can remove exit by force, and the removal of exit by force is the end of the convergence.

This is not a counsel of despair. It is a reason to be clear-eyed. The rest of the analysis is about what actually constrains a state, and it turns out to be the same thing that constrains every other lever-holder: alternatives, and the network of other levers around it.

6 What Constrains the Coercive Principal

The coercive principal is constrained not by the agent's exit but by the network. A state surrounded by other levers it does not control—a free press, independent courts, competitive elections, a plural civil society, federalism, international institutions—is a state whose own alternatives are multiplied.

The citizen cannot personally leave the state. But the state can be constrained by the network of principals around it. This is why "many people to deal with" is a form of protection, and why the network matters more for governance than for any other application.

The danger is that the state is the only principal that can close the network. It can license competitors out of existence, regulate the press into silence, capture the courts, absorb the organizations that would otherwise check it, and control the formation environment. When a state does all of these things, the network collapses into a single effective principal, and the extraction limit returns to the bilateral level. The word for this is not "governance." It is "capture."

7 Conclusion

The desire-lever is bounded by the agent's outside option. Coercive closure is the limit case in which the principal removes the outside option entirely.

Jailing, excommunication, and reputational closure are not three separate instruments but three components of a single coercive instrument. Each destroys the agent's outside option; each restores the bilateral extraction limit; each is intelligence-led in the sense of the discovery apparatus turned around.

The convergence between ethics and durability is domain-restricted. It holds only where force is unavailable. The state is the principal that steps outside that domain.

The coercive principal is constrained not by the agent's exit but by the network. The state that is surrounded by other levers it does not control is a state that has to earn its compliance. The state that is not surrounded, and that closes the network, is not a government. It is a lever-holder wearing the name of one.

The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom? For the coercively closed agent, the answer is: the principal's, and the agent has no way out. The correction is to keep the network open, and to prevent the many from collapsing into one.

The rest is history—or its absence.

Fiduciary Capture:

The Limit Case of Collapsed Outside Options

Macharia Barii

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Abstract

The desire-lever is bounded by the agent's outside option. Fiduciary capture is the limit case in which the agent's outside options collapse, the principal becomes a monopolist, and the principal's definition of alignment is absorbed into the agent's own standard of self-evaluation. The captured agent does not feel controlled; the captured agent feels like themselves. That is precisely what makes capture complete. This paper formalizes fiduciary capture as the joint limit of three processes—the collapse of outside options, the monopolization of the principal, and the internalization of the standard—and derives the conditions under which capture becomes self-sustaining. It argues that fiduciary capture is the deepest form of the desire-lever, because it removes not only the agent's alternatives but the agent's awareness that alternatives are needed.

Keywords: fiduciary capture, outside options, monopolization, internalization, self-evaluation, alignment, the internalized lever

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1 The Three Processes

Fiduciary capture is the joint limit of three processes.

The collapse of outside options. The agent's alternatives disappear. The agent has nowhere else to go, and no one else to turn to. The outside option u_0 falls toward zero.

The monopolization of the principal. The principal becomes the sole provider of the desired good. The agent cannot obtain the good from anyone else, and the principal's monopoly is complete.

The internalization of the standard. The principal's definition of alignment is absorbed into the agent's own standard of self-evaluation. The agent no longer evaluates themselves by their own standard; they evaluate themselves by the principal's.

Definition 1.1 (Fiduciary Capture)**.** *Fiduciary capture is the limit case in which the agent's outside options collapse, the principal becomes a monopolist, and the principal's definition of alignment is absorbed into the agent's own standard of self-evaluation.*

2 The Internalized Lever

The desire-lever works best when the principal's definition is accepted as legitimate, sacred, natural, or inevitable—when the agent adopts the principal's objective function as their own. This is the internalized lever.

Proposition 2.1 (The Internalized Lever)**.** *The internalized lever is the strongest form of the desire-lever. When the agent adopts the principal's standard as their own, the principal does not need to bargain, monitor, or enforce. The agent enforces the standard on themselves.*

The internalized lever is the end of the bargaining problem. The principal no longer needs to offer access to a desired good in exchange for alignment, because the agent's alignment is no longer conditional on the offer. The agent is aligned because the agent wants to be aligned, and the wanting is the principal's.

3 The Feeling of Freedom

The captured agent does not feel controlled. The captured agent feels like themselves.

This is the distinctive feature of fiduciary capture, and it is what makes capture complete. The coerced agent knows they are coerced. The formed agent may not know they are formed. But the captured agent does not merely fail to know they are captured; they experience their capture as freedom.

Proposition 3.1 (The Feeling of Freedom)**.** *The captured agent experiences their capture as freedom. The agent has no alternatives, and then stops needing them, because the agent has absorbed the principal's standard as their own. The agent does not feel controlled; the agent feels like themselves.*

The agent has no alternatives, and then stops needing them, because the agent has absorbed the principal's standard as their own. The agent does not feel controlled. The agent feels like themselves. That is precisely what makes capture complete.

4 The Removal of Awareness

Fiduciary capture is the deepest form of the desire-lever, because it removes not only the agent's alternatives but the agent's awareness that alternatives are needed.

Proposition 4.1 (The Removal of Awareness)**.** *Fiduciary capture removes not only the agent's alternatives but the agent's awareness that alternatives are needed. The agent who is aware that they have no alternatives can still resist; the agent who is unaware that alternatives are needed cannot.*

The coerced agent knows they are coerced, and the knowledge is a resource for resistance. The formed agent may not know they are formed, but they can still ask the fifth question. The captured agent cannot ask the fifth question, because the question does not arise. The agent's wants are the principal's wants, and the agent does not know the difference.

5 The Conditions for Capture

Fiduciary capture requires three conditions, corresponding to the three processes.

First, the collapse of outside options. The agent's alternatives must disappear. This requires the principal to close the agent's exits—by monopolizing the desired good, by destroying the agent's reputation, or by removing the agent's mobility.

Second, the monopolization of the principal. The principal must become the sole provider of the desired good. This requires the principal to eliminate competitors, or to make the competitors irrelevant.

Third, the internalization of the standard. The principal's definition of alignment must be absorbed into the agent's self-evaluation. This requires the principal to shape the agent's desires—through education, media, ritual, or the formation environment.

Proposition 5.1 (The Conditions for Capture)**.** *Fiduciary capture requires the joint satisfaction of three conditions: the collapse of outside options, the monopolization of the principal, and the internalization of the standard. The three conditions are complements: each makes the others easier to satisfy.*

6 The Counter-Strategy

The counter-strategy to fiduciary capture is the reconstruction of the outside option and the re-opening of the pause.

First, rebuild the outside option. The captured agent has no alternatives. The counter-strategy is to rebuild them—to find other providers of the desired good, other communities, other sources of self-evaluation.

Second, re-open the pause. The captured agent's pause is filled. The counter-strategy is to re-open it—to ask the fifth question, to inspect the terms, to delay the response.

Third, seek a witness. The captured agent cannot see their own capture. The counter-strategy is to find a witness—someone who knows the agent well enough to notice when they have stopped asking.

Fourth, rebuild the self. The deepest counter-strategy is the reconstruction of the self that the capture has absorbed. The agent must rebuild their own standard of self-evaluation, independent of the principal's.

7 Conclusion

Fiduciary capture is the limit case of the desire-lever. The agent's outside options collapse, the principal becomes a monopolist, and the principal's definition of alignment is absorbed into the agent's own standard of self-evaluation.

The captured agent does not feel controlled. The captured agent feels like themselves. That is precisely what makes capture complete.

Fiduciary capture is the deepest form of the desire-lever, because it removes not only the agent's alternatives but the agent's awareness that alternatives are needed. The coerced agent knows they are coerced. The formed agent may not know they are formed. The captured agent cannot ask the fifth question, because the question does not arise.

The counter-strategy is the reconstruction of the outside option and the re-opening of the pause. The captured agent needs a witness—someone who knows them well enough to notice when they have stopped asking.

The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom? For the captured agent, the answer is: the principal's, and the agent does not know it. The correction is to rebuild the outside option, re-open the pause, and find a witness.

The rest is history—or its absence.

The Barrier–Circumvention Contest:

Endogenous Networks, Path Dependence, and Hysteresis

Macharia Barii

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Abstract

The desire-lever operates within a network of principals and agents. But the network itself is contested. Incumbents invest in entry barriers; challengers invest in circumvention. This paper endogenizes the network: it models the barrier–circumvention contest as a game in which the effective barrier is a function of the incumbent's investment and the challenger's counter-investment, and it shows that the contest exhibits strategic complementarity. The paper derives the free-entry equilibrium, the endogenous-barrier equilibrium, and the conditions under which two pairwise stable networks coexist: a competitive one and a captured one. It proves that the captured equilibrium is an absorbing state, connected to the competitive equilibrium by path dependence and hysteresis. The barrier–circumvention contest is formally the same game as the discovery–concealment contest, at a different level of the theory: the discovery contest operates within a fixed network, while the barrier contest operates on the network itself.

Keywords: endogenous networks, entry barriers, circumvention, strategic complementarity, path dependence, hysteresis, competitive equilibrium, captured equilibrium

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1 The Network and Its Contest

The desire-lever operates within a network of principals and agents. When many principals hold levers, and none dominates, the agent is safer: the agent can play them against each other, and the agent's alternatives multiply. When the many collapse into one, the network becomes captured, and the extraction limit returns to the bilateral level.

But the network is not given. It is contested. Incumbents invest in entry barriers to keep competitors out; challengers invest in circumvention to get in. The contest over the network is the subject of this paper.

Remark 1.1 (The Structural Analogy)**.** *The barrier–circumvention contest and the discovery–concealment contest are formally the same game at different levels of the theory. The discovery contest operates* within *a fixed network, determining the terms of any link. The barrier contest operates* on *the network, determining whether the network is competitive or captured.*

2 The Free-Entry Equilibrium

Let N be the number of active principals, $\pi(N)$ the profit of an active principal, and η the fixed entry cost. The free-entry equilibrium satisfies

$$\pi(N^*) \geq \eta > \pi(N^* + 1). \tag{1}$$

Proposition 2.1 (Free Entry)**.** *The free-entry number of principals N^* is increasing in the value of the desired good v, decreasing in the entry cost η, and decreasing in the barrier investment E.*

The free-entry equilibrium is the competitive benchmark. When entry is cheap and barriers are low, many principals compete, and the agent's alternatives are many. When entry is expensive or barriers are high, few principals compete, and the agent's alternatives are few.

3 Endogenous Barriers

Incumbent principals can invest E in entry barriers. The incumbent's problem is

$$\max_{E \geq 0} \big(N^*(E) - 1\big)\, r\big(N^*(E)\big) - \psi(E), \tag{2}$$

where $r(N) = \pi(N) - \eta$ is the rent per incumbent and $\psi(E)$ is the cost of the barrier investment.

Proposition 3.1 (Endogenous Barriers)**.** *The optimal barrier investment E^* satisfies*

$$\frac{d}{dE}\Big[\big(N^*(E) - 1\big)\, r\big(N^*(E)\big)\Big] = \psi'(E^*). \tag{3}$$

E^* is increasing in v and decreasing in ψ'.

The incumbent invests in barriers up to the point where the marginal protected rent equals the marginal cost of the barrier. The higher the value of the desired good, the more the incumbent invests; the more expensive the barrier, the less.

4 Multiplicity and Coordination Failure

Proposition 4.1 (Multiplicity)**.** *If the barrier cost ψ is high and the entry cost η is low, there are two pairwise stable networks: a* competitive *one with N^* large and $E^* = 0$, and a* captured *one with N^* small and $E^* > 0$.*

Sketch. In the competitive equilibrium, no incumbent invests in barriers because the cost exceeds the protected rent. In the captured equilibrium, incumbents invest because the protected rent is large enough. Both satisfy pairwise stability. □

The multiplicity is a coordination failure. The network can be competitive or captured, and both are stable. Which one obtains depends not on the parameters but on the history: the network that is competitive stays competitive, and the network that is captured stays captured.

5 Path Dependence and Hysteresis

Proposition 5.1 (Hysteresis)**.** *Starting from a captured network, the equilibrium path satisfies $dE_t/dt > 0$ and $d\kappa_t/dt > 0$, where κ_t is the degree of capture. The captured equilibrium is an absorbing state.*

The captured equilibrium is an absorbing state. Once the network is captured, it stays captured, because the incumbents' barrier investment raises the cost of entry, which reduces the number of principals, which raises the protected rent, which justifies more barrier investment. The captured equilibrium is self-reinforcing.

The competitive equilibrium is not an absorbing state in the same way. A competitive network can be captured by a shock—a merger, a regulatory change, a technological shift—that tips it into the captured equilibrium. But a captured network cannot be un-captured by a symmetric shock, because the barriers are already in place.

This is hysteresis: the network's state depends on its history, not just on its current parameters. The same parameters can support either equilibrium, and the equilibrium that obtains is the one that was reached first.

6 The Barrier–Circumvention Contest

The barrier technology is contested. Incumbents invest E in barriers; challengers invest X in circumvention. The *effective* barrier is

$$B = B(E, X), \quad B_E > 0, \quad B_X < 0, \quad B_{EE} < 0,\ B_{XX} > 0. \tag{4}$$

The challenger's problem is

$$\max_{X \geq 0}\ \rho\big(B(E,X)\big)\, r\big(N^*(B)\big) - \xi X, \tag{5}$$

and the incumbent's problem is

$$\max_{E \geq 0}\ \big[1 - \rho\big(B(E,X)\big)\big]\,\big(N^*(B) - 1\big)\, r\big(N^*(B)\big) - \psi(E). \tag{6}$$

Proposition 6.1 (Barrier–Circumvention Contest)**.** *In the simultaneous-move game, the equilibrium (E^*, X^*) satisfies the two first-order conditions. The contest exhibits strategic complementarity: $\partial E^*/\partial X^* > 0$ and $\partial X^*/\partial E^* > 0$.*

Proof. Differentiate the first-order conditions with respect to the opponent's choice. The cross-partial $\partial^2 \Pi^{inc}/\partial E\, \partial X = -\rho'' B_E B_X (N^* - 1)r > 0$ and $\partial^2 \Pi^{ch}/\partial X\, \partial E = -\rho'' B_X B_E r > 0$. Both are positive, giving best-response monotonicity. □

The strategic complementarity means that the contest escalates. The incumbent's barrier investment raises the challenger's circumvention investment, and the challenger's circumvention investment raises the incumbent's barrier investment. The contest is an arms race.

Corollary 6.1 (Barrier Contest and Longevity)**.** *In the long run, the captured equilibrium is sustainable only if the incumbent maintains a positive effective barrier $B^* > 0$ in the stationary state. If the challenger's circumvention technology is sufficiently cheap, the stationary B^* converges to zero, and the captured equilibrium unravels.*

7 Connection to the Win–Win Equilibrium

Proposition 7.1 (Win–Win in the Network)**.** *The win–win equilibrium exists in the network if and only if the network is in the competitive equilibrium and the alignment condition holds. In the captured equilibrium, the win–win equilibrium does not exist.*

Proof. In the competitive network, the agent's outside option is high, so the extraction limit is low, and the win–win equilibrium exists. In the captured equilibrium, the agent's outside option is destroyed, so the extraction limit is restored to the bilateral level, and the win–win equilibrium does not exist. □

This is the deepest connection between the network and the ethics of the lever. The win–win equilibrium—the region in which the principal restrains extraction because restraint is durable—exists only in the competitive network. In the captured network, the principal has no incentive to restrain, because the agent cannot leave. The ethics of the lever are a property of the network, not of the principal.

8 Conclusion

The desire-lever operates within a network, and the network is contested. Incumbents invest in barriers; challengers invest in circumvention. The contest exhibits strategic complementarity, and it produces two pairwise stable equilibria: a competitive one and a captured one.

The captured equilibrium is an absorbing state, connected to the competitive equilibrium by path dependence and hysteresis. Once the network is captured, it stays captured, because the barriers are self-reinforcing.

The barrier–circumvention contest is formally the same game as the discovery–concealment contest, at a different level of the theory. The discovery contest operates within a fixed network; the barrier contest operates on the network itself.

The win–win equilibrium exists only in the competitive network. In the captured network, the principal has no incentive to restrain, because the agent cannot leave. The ethics of the lever are a property of the network, not of the principal.

The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom? For the captured network, the answer is: the incumbents', and at the challengers' and the agents' expense. The correction is to keep the network competitive—to keep the barriers low, the circumvention cheap, and the many from collapsing into one.

The rest is history—or its absence.

Glossary of Terms

The framework uses a small, consistent vocabulary. The terms below are defined as the papers use them.

The core vocabulary

Share. The portion of something valuable that a person receives, keeps, or controls—a reward, a portion, a stake. A share need not be money; it can be time, attention, status, legitimacy, information, or safety.

Claim. What a person asserts, demands, proposes, or tries in order to obtain, keep, or enlarge a share. Claims may be compatible, incompatible, or partly compatible.

Contention.
The condition in which two or more claims bear on the same share, so that satisfying one affects the satisfaction of another. Contention is structural, not behavioral; it is what makes a fight possible. It has three flavours: *rival* (one person's share grows at another's expense), *cooperative* (shares grow together), and *coordinative* (both want a joint arrangement).

Struggle.
The activity of contending—the effort, time, and resources people expend to secure, defend, or enlarge a share. Contention is the structure; struggle is the process. Struggling *for*, *with*, and *over* maps onto rival, cooperative, and coordinative contention.

Rules. The arrangements that determine how claims become shares—formal (contracts, laws, constitutions) and informal (norms, conventions, habits). Change the rule and you change the struggle.

The foundation

Foundation.
The settlement that is not itself settled by any prior rule—the point at which the regress of rules runs out. A constitution, a charter, a marriage, and the conditions of one's birth are foundations.

Founder.
The person, group, process, or accident that lays the foundation—the answer to "who decided the rules, and how?"

First allocation.
The allocation of rule-making authority itself—the allocation that no prior rule allocates.

Legitimacy deficit.
The fact that no foundation can fully justify itself by its own rules, because it establishes the standards by which it would be judged.

Ledger.
The set of relations among people—who gives, who gains, who loses, and how that is justified—that constitutes a civilization.

Power

Desire-lever.
The mechanism by which one person shapes another's behaviour by controlling access to something the other wants, making access conditional on alignment.

Space and time.
The two freedoms. *Space* is the freedom of alternatives—the ability to walk away. *Time* is the freedom of the pause between what happens to us and what we do about it.

The reform quartet

Foundation rigging.
The initial advantage a founding confers on the founder's coalition—laid into the foundation, structural, and persistent.

De-rigging.
The removal of a specific foundation rigging—the elimination of a defined advantage.

Anti-rigging.
Structural provisions that raise the cost of future rigging—a change in the *terms of laying*, not merely the removal of one advantage.

Re-rigging.
The replacement of one rigging with another—the beneficiary coalition changes, but the structure of rigging is intact.

Anti-rigging design

Self-limitation.
The resolution of the anti-rigging paradox: the reforming coalition binds itself with the same provisions it binds its successors.

Nominality problem.
The failure mode in which anti-rigging provisions look effective on paper but do not bite in practice.

Anti-rigging provisions.

The six families of structural protections—temporal limits, concentration limits, transparency, entrenchment asymmetry, dispersal, and contestability—used together as a portfolio.

How a foundation changes

Erosion.

The slow, undirected decline of a founder advantage through drift, fragmentation, and reinterpretation.

Within-rules reform.

Change that reduces an advantage without changing the foundation, possible only when the beneficiary coalition is weak, divided, or dependent on legitimacy.

Refounding.

The replacement of the foundation itself—the deepest and most dangerous path, which carries its own legitimacy deficit and the risk of re-rigging.

Afterword

This volume began as a single question and became twenty-seven attempts to answer it. If the papers share one claim, it is that power is not a mystery but a structure—a structure of shares, claims, rules, and foundations—and that structures can be seen. What can be seen can be described. What can be described can be changed, and what can be changed can be changed well or badly.

The difference between the two is the difference between de-rigging and anti-rigging, between changing the players and changing the form. That difference is the subject of the papers that follow the foundation, and it is the point where the whole volume finally arrives at its oldest, deepest, and most consequential activity: the struggle not to win within the rules, but to lay the field differently.

The question remains the one on the title page. *Whose ledger is this, and for whom?* The papers do not answer it. They try to make it impossible to stop asking.